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The Holy Bible

Volume IV

Apocrypha

Sola Fide

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Contents

Judith	3
Wisdom of Solomon	35
Tobit	87
Sirach	117
Baruch	249
1 Maccabees	267
2 Maccabees	337
Additions to Esther	385
Additions to Daniel	395
Susanna	397
Bel and the Dragon	403
The Prayer of Azariah and the Song of the Three Young Men	407

Apocrypha

*These are books which are not held equal to Holy Scripture,
and yet are useful and good to read.*

- I Judith
- II Wisdom of Solomon
- III Tobit
- IIII Sirach
- V Baruch
- VI Maccabees (1 & 2)
- VII Additions to Esther
- VIII Additions to Daniel

Martin Luther

M.D.XXXV.

CONTENTS

Preface to the Book of Judith

Martin Luther, 1534

IF one could prove from established and reliable histories that the events in Judith really happened, it would be a noble and fine book, and should properly be in the Bible. Yet it hardly squares with the historical accounts of the Holy Scriptures, especially Jeremiah and Ezra. For these show how Jerusalem and the whole country were destroyed, and were thereafter laboriously rebuilt during the time of the monarchy of the Persians who occupied the land.

Against this the first chapter of Judith claims that King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon was the first one to set about conquering this territory; it creates the impression that these events took place before the captivity of the Jews, and before the rise of the Persian monarchy. Philo, on the contrary, says that they happened after the release and return of the Jews from Babylon under King Ahasuerus, at which time the Jews had rebuilt neither the temple nor Jerusalem, and had no government. Thus as to both time and name, error and doubt are still present, so that I cannot reconcile [the accounts] at all.

Some people think this is not an account of historical events [Geschichte] but rather a beautiful religious fiction [Gedicht] by a holy and ingenious man who wanted to sketch and depict therein the fortunes of the whole Jewish people and the victory God always miraculously granted them over all their enemies. This would be similar to the way Solomon in his Song poetizes and sings of a bride, yet means thereby not some specific person or event but the whole people of Israel. St. John, in his Apocalypse, and Daniel likewise sketch many pictures and beasts; yet these pertain not to specific persons but to the totality of Christian churches and [to the various]

empires. And Christ our Lord himself likes to make use of parables and fictions like this in the gospel. He compares the kingdom of heaven to ten maidens [Matt. 25:1–13], or to a merchant and pearls [Matt. 13:45], a baker woman [Matt. 13:33], a grain of mustard seed [Matt. 13:31–32], or to fishermen and nets [Matt. 13:47–49], or to shepherds and sheep [Matt. 18:12–14], and the like.

Such an interpretation strikes my fancy, and I think that the poet deliberately and painstakingly inserted the errors of time and name in order to remind the reader that the book should be taken and understood as that kind of a sacred, religious, composition.

Now the names fit into this sort of an interpretation extraordinarily well. Judith means Judea, (that is) the Jewish people. She is a chaste and holy widow; that is, God's people is always a forsaken widow who is nevertheless chaste and holy, remaining pure and holy in the Word of God and in the true faith, mortifying herself and praying. Holofernes means worldly leader or governor, a heathen, godless, or un-Christian lord or prince—as all enemies of the Jewish people are. Bethulia (a city nobody knows) means a virgin, indicating that at that time the believing and devout Jews were the pure virgin, free from idolatry and unbelief, as described in Isaiah [37:22] and Jeremiah [14:17; 18:13; 31:4], which is also why they remained unconquerable, though they were in distress.

It may even be that in those days they dramatized literature like this, Just as among us the Passion and other sacred stories are performed. In a common presentation or play they conceivably wanted to teach their people and youth to trust God, to be righteous, and to hope in God for all help and comfort, in every need, against all enemies, etc.

Therefore this is a fine, good, holy, useful book, well worth reading by us Christians. For the words spoken by the persons in it should be understood as though they were uttered in the Holy Spirit by a spiritual, holy poet or prophet who, in presenting such persons in his play, preaches to us through them. Next after Judith, therefore, like a song following a play, belongs the Wisdom of Philo, a work which denounces tyrants and praises the help which God bestows on his

Preface to Judith

people. The song [that follows] may well be called an illustration of this book [of Judith].

Judith

1

Arphaxad Builds Up Ecbatana

IT was the twelfth year of the reign of Nebuchadnezzar, who ruled over the Assyrians in the great city of Nineveh. At the same time, Arphaxad ruled over the Medes in Ecbatana. ²Arphaxad built walls around Ecbatana with huge stones 4-1/2 feet thick and 9 feet long. These walls were 105 feet high and 75 feet thick. ³He also made towers that were 150 feet high and 90 feet wide at the foundation. ⁴He built the gateways of the city 105 feet high and 60 feet wide to allow his armies to march out in force, division by division. ⁵In those days King Nebuchadnezzar fought against King Arphaxad on the great plain near the borders of Ragau. ⁶Nebuchadnezzar was joined by people from the hill country, from along the Euphrates, the Tigris, and the Hydaspes, and from the plain where Arioch ruled over the Elymeans. In this way, many nations joined forces with the Babylonians.

Nebuchadnezzar Calls for Allies

⁷Then Nebuchadnezzar, king of the Assyrians, sent a message to everyone in Persia and to all who lived in the west. The message went to those in Cilicia, Damascus, and the region of Lebanon and the Anti-Lebanon Mountains, and to all the people on the seacoast. ⁸The message also went to the people of Carmel, Gilead, Upper Galilee, the great plain of Esdraelon, ⁹the towns of Samaria, and to everyone who lived west of the Jordan River. This included Jerusalem, Bethany, Chelous, and Kadesh. The message went as far as the border of Egypt to Tahpanhes, Rameses, and the whole land of Goshen. ¹⁰It even went beyond Tanis and Memphis to the entire land of Egypt as far as the border of Ethiopia.

¹¹But everyone throughout the region chose to disregard the summons from Nebuchadnezzar, king of the Assyrians, refusing to join him in war. They were not afraid of him; after all, he was just one man. So they dishonored him by sending back his messengers with a negative response. ¹²Then King Nebuchadnezzar became angry. He swore by his throne and kingdom that he would seek revenge on the whole territory of Cilicia and Damascus and Syria. He vowed to kill all the people of Moab, Ammon, Judea, and Egypt as far as the Mediterranean Sea and the Red Sea.

Nebuchadnezzar Defeats Arphaxad

¹³In the seventeenth year of his reign, Nebuchadnezzar led his forces against King Arphaxad and defeated him in battle, overpowering Arphaxad's entire army, including all his horsemen and chariots. ¹⁴He took possession of all the towns and then conquered Ecbatana, capturing its towers, plundering its marketplaces, and reducing its glory to ruins. ¹⁵He captured Arphaxad in the mountains of Ragau and killed him with spears, thus destroying him once and for all. ¹⁶Then Nebuchadnezzar returned to Nineveh with his entire army, a vast number of troops. There he and his army rested and feasted for 120 days.

2

The Military Plan against the West

N the eighteenth year of Nebuchadnezzar's reign, on a certain day in midspring, word went out from the palace of Nebuchadnezzar, king of the Assyrians, that he would seek revenge on the whole region, just as he had said. ²He called all his advisers and governors and told them about his secret plan. And when he told them that the people throughout the region had refused to help him,

³they decided that everyone who had disobeyed his command should be destroyed.

⁴After the council had finished making its plan, Nebuchadnezzar, king of the Assyrians, gave these orders to Holofernes, his commander who was second in power only to himself: ⁵“This is what the great king, the lord of the whole earth, says: Prepare for battle, and take with you 120,000 brave foot soldiers and 12,000 horsemen. ⁶March out against all the lands to the west, for they disregarded my orders. ⁷Tell them to prepare to submit to my authority, for in my rage I am marching against them. I will cover the whole earth with my armies, and my troops will plunder it. ⁸Their wounded will fill their valleys and ravines. Their dead will be thrown into the rivers, causing them to overflow. ⁹I will lead them captive to the ends of the earth. ¹⁰Go! Seize all their territory for me. All must surrender to you, and you are to hold them for me until I can punish them. ¹¹Show no mercy to those who resist. Slaughter and plunder them throughout the region. ¹²For as I live, and by the power of my kingdom, I have spoken. I will accomplish all this by my own power. ¹³Be careful, Holofernes, not to neglect any of your master’s commands. Carry them out exactly as I have ordered you, and do so immediately.”

Holofernes Prepares for War

¹⁴So Holofernes left the king and called together all the commanders, generals, and officers of the Assyrian army. ¹⁵He arranged the 120,000 select troops by divisions, as the king had ordered him to do, together with 12,000 archers on horseback. ¹⁶He organized them in battle formation. ¹⁷He secured a vast number of camels, donkeys, and mules for carrying baggage, and innumerable sheep, oxen, and goats for food. ¹⁸Everyone received plenty of rations and a large amount of gold and silver from the royal palace.

¹⁹Then Holofernes personally led his army ahead of King Nebuchadnezzar and overran the entire region to the west with chariots and horsemen and select troops. ²⁰After them followed a huge force

of all sorts of people—like a swarm of locusts and the dust of the earth, too many to count.

Holofernes Advances

²¹They marched for three days from Nineveh to the plain of Bectileth, and they camped near Bectileth by the mountain to the north of Upper Cilicia. ²²From there Holofernes took his whole army—the foot soldiers, horsemen, and chariots—and went up to the hill country. ²³He devastated the region of Lydia and carried away all the Rassisites and the Ishmaelites on the border of the desert south of the country of the Chelleans. ²⁴Then he marched along the Euphrates, crossed Mesopotamia, and destroyed all the fortified towns along Abron Brook as far as the sea. ²⁵He seized control of the territory of Cilicia and killed everyone who resisted him. Then he went to the southern borders of Japheth, across from Arabia. ²⁶He surrounded all the Midianites, burned their tents, and plundered their sheepfolds. ²⁷Then he went to the plain of Damascus during the wheat harvest. He burned their fields, destroyed their flocks and herds, plundered their towns, ravaged their lands, and slaughtered all their young men with the sword. ²⁸All the people who lived along the seacoast were terrified—those who lived in Sidon and Tyre and those in Sur, Ocina, and Jamnia. Those who lived in Azotus and Ashkelon were seized with terrible panic.

3

The People Plead for Peace

¹These people sent messengers to Holofernes with this petition for peace: ²“We, the servants of Nebuchadnezzar, the great king, fall humbly before you. Do with us whatever you will. ³See, all we have is at your disposal—our buildings, our

land, our wheat fields, our flocks and herds, and our sheepfolds and their surrounding tents. Do with them as you please.

⁴The people of our towns will all be your slaves. Come and deal with us and all we own as you see fit.”

⁵The messengers went to Holofernes and told him all this.

⁶Then Holofernes went down to the seacoast with his army, stationed garrisons in all the fortified towns, and drafted the best men there as reserve troops. ⁷All the people along the coast and in the surrounding areas welcomed him, wearing garlands, dancing, and playing tambourines. ⁸But Holofernes demolished all their shrines and cut down their sacred groves. For King Nebuchadnezzar had commanded him to destroy all the gods of the land so that he alone might be served as a god in the nations conquered by Holofernes. ⁹Then he came to the plain of Esdraelon, near Dothan, a village facing the great ridge of Judea. ¹⁰He camped between Geba and Scythopolis, and he stayed there for a whole month to collect all the provisions his army needed.

4

Judea Prepares for the Attack

THE Israelites throughout Judea heard that Holofernes, the commander serving Nebuchadnezzar, king of the Assyrians, had plundered all the other nations and destroyed their temples. ²As he approached, they became terrified for Jerusalem and for the Temple of the Lord their God, ³for they had only recently returned from captivity. (All the people of Judea had recently resettled the city and rededicated the sacred vessels and the altar and the Temple, all of which had been defiled.)

⁴So the Israelites in Judea sent word to every district of Samaria and to Kona, Beth-horon, Belmain, Jericho, Choba, Aesora, and the Salem Valley. ⁵They occupied all the high hilltops and fortified the villages

there. They also stored up food to prepare for war, for their fields had recently been harvested. ⁶Joakim, the high priest, was in Jerusalem at the time and wrote to the people of Bethulia and Betomesthaim, towns facing Esdraelon across the plain near Dothan. ⁷He told them to guard the mountain passes, for it was only through these passes that Judea could be invaded. It would be easy to stop any forces trying to enter because the passage was narrow, wide enough for only two soldiers to pass at a time. ⁸The Israelites did as they had been ordered by the high priest Joakim and the high council of all the people of Israel, which was in session at Jerusalem.

⁹All the people cried out earnestly to God and humbled themselves by intense fasting. ¹⁰All the men, their wives, their children, and every resident foreigner (both hired workers and slaves) put on sackcloth to show they were in mourning. They even put sackcloth on their livestock. ¹¹And all the Israelite men, women, and children living in Jerusalem lay face down in front of the Temple, and with ashes on their heads, they spread out their sackcloth before the Lord. ¹²They even draped the altar with sackcloth. They cried out together, earnestly asking the God of Israel not to allow their infants to be carried off, their wives to be taken captive, their towns to be destroyed, and the sanctuary to be desecrated. They knew the Gentiles around them would be overjoyed at their defeat.

¹³The Lord heard their prayers and acknowledged their distress—for the people fasted many days throughout Judea and in Jerusalem before the sanctuary of the Lord Almighty. ¹⁴Joakim the high priest and all the priests who ministered before the Lord wore sackcloth as they offered the people's daily burnt offerings, offerings to fulfill vows, and freewill offerings. ¹⁵With ashes on their turbans, they earnestly called on the Lord, asking him to look kindly on the people of Israel.

5

A Council of War

HOLOFERNES, the commander of the Assyrian army, was told that the people of Israel had prepared for battle by closing the mountain passes, fortifying all the high hilltops, and placing obstructions in the plains. ²Holofernes was very angry at this and called together all the princes of Moab, the commanders of Ammon, and all the governors of the coastlands. ³He asked them, "Tell me, you Canaanites, who are these people that occupy the hill country? What towns do they live in? How large is their army? What is the source of their power and strength? Who is the king that leads their army?" ⁴Why is it that, of all the nations in this western region, they are the only ones who refuse to surrender to me?"

⁵Then Achior, leader of the Ammonites, answered, "My lord, if you wish, I will tell you the truth about these people who live in the hills nearby. I will not lie. ⁶The ancestors of these people were Chaldeans. ⁷For a time they settled in Mesopotamia because they refused to worship the gods their ancestors had worshiped in Chaldea. ⁸Since they had abandoned their ancestors' ways and worshiped the God of heaven, the God they had come to know, their neighbors expelled them from the presence of their gods. So they fled to Mesopotamia, where they lived for a long time. ⁹Then their God commanded them to leave that place and go to the land of Canaan. They settled there and acquired great wealth in gold, silver, and livestock.

¹⁰"When a famine spread over the land of Canaan, they went down to Egypt and lived there as long as there was food. They became such a great multitude that their race could not be counted, ¹¹so the king of Egypt became hostile toward them. He exploited them by making them slaves who produced bricks for him. ¹²They cried out to their God, who punished all of Egypt with incurable plagues. So the Egyptians drove them out of their sight. ¹³Then God dried up the Red Sea before them, ¹⁴and he led them forward to Sinai and Kadesh-barnea. They drove out all the people living in the desert ¹⁵and settled in the land of the Amorites. With great force they destroyed all the inhabitants of Heshbon. Then they crossed over the Jordan River and took control of all the hill country. ¹⁶They drove out the Canaanites,

Perizzites, Jebusites, Shechemites, and all the Gergashites. Then the Israelites lived there a long time.

¹⁷“As long as they did not sin against their God, they prospered, for the God who is with them hates sin. ¹⁸But when they disobeyed him, they were defeated in many battles and were taken captive to foreign lands. The Temple of their God was demolished, and their towns were taken by their enemies. ¹⁹But now they have returned to their God and have come back from the places where they were scattered. Some of them have occupied Jerusalem, the site of their Temple, while others settled in the unoccupied hill country.

²⁰“So now, master and lord, we must find out if these people have sinned against their God. If so, we can go up and defeat them. ²¹But if they are not guilty, my lord, you would do better to leave them alone and move on. For their Lord and God will protect them, and we would become the laughingstock of the whole world.”

²²When Achior had finished his talk, all the people standing around the tent began to disagree with him. Holofernes’ officers, together with the people from the coastal area and from Moab, insisted that Achior should be killed. ²³“Why should we be afraid of the Israelites?” they said. “They are weak and powerless, incapable of withstanding any sort of attack. ²⁴Let’s go ahead! Your great army, master Holofernes, will swallow them up!”

6

Achior Is Released to the Israelites

WHEN the uproar made by the men outside the council died down, Holofernes, commander of the Assyrian army, spoke to Achior in the presence of all the foreigners and Moabites. ²He said, “Achior, who do you think you are—you and the other mercenaries of Ephraim? Who are you to tell us like some prophet not to make war against the people of Israel? Do you think their God will defend them? What god is there except Nebuchadnezzar? He will send his

forces to wipe them from the face of the earth! Their God will not rescue them. ³We, the king's servants, will destroy them as if they were but one man. They could never resist the force of our horsemen. ⁴We will burn them completely. Their mountains will be drunk with their blood, and their plains will be filled with their dead. Not a single trace of them will survive our attack; they will all die. So says King Nebuchadnezzar, lord of the whole earth, for he has spoken, and he makes no empty threats.

⁵"As for you, Achior, you Ammonite mercenary, you have spoken these words rashly. You will not see my face again until I take revenge on these people who came out of Egypt. ⁶When I return, the swords of my soldiers and the spears of my servants will pierce your sides, and you will fall among their wounded. ⁷Now my slaves are going to take you into the hill country and leave you in one of the towns near the mountain passes. ⁸You will not die until you are destroyed along with these people. ⁹If you really believe in your heart that they will not be conquered, don't look so sad! But I have spoken, and none of my words will fail to come true."

¹⁰Then Holofernes commanded his personal slaves to seize Achior and take him away to Bethulia, where they would hand him over to the Israelites. ¹¹So the slaves led him out of the camp into the plain. From there they went up into the hill country and came to the springs below Bethulia. ¹²When the men of the town saw them, they picked up their weapons and ran from the town to the top of the hill. All the slingers prevented Holofernes' slaves from coming up because they kept slinging stones at them. ¹³So the slaves took shelter below the hill. Then they tied Achior, left him lying at the foot of the hill, and returned to their master.

¹⁴The Israelites came down from their town and found Achior. After untying him, they brought him into Bethulia, where he could speak to the leaders of their town. ¹⁵The leaders in those days were Uziah son of Micah (of the tribe of Simeon), Chabris son of Gothoniel, and Charmis son of Melchiel. ¹⁶They called together all the elders of the town, and all the young men and women hurried

to the assembly as well. Achior stood in the middle of all the people, and Uzziah questioned him about what had happened. ¹⁷Achior answered by telling them what had taken place at Holofernes' council. He told them everything he had said to the Assyrian leaders and how Holofernes had bragged about what he would do to the people of Israel.

¹⁸Then all the people fell down and worshiped God. They cried out, ¹⁹"O Lord God of heaven, see their pride, and be merciful to our humble race. Show your kindness to those who are dedicated to you."

²⁰Then they reassured Achior and praised him warmly. ²¹Uzziah took him from the assembly to his own house and gave a banquet for the elders. All that night they called on the God of Israel for help.

7

The Campaign against Israel Begins

HE next day Holofernes ordered his whole army and all the reserve troops who had joined him to break camp and march against Bethulia. He told them to take over the mountain passes as the first step in their attack on the Israelites. ²The army began to march that very day; it numbered at 148,000 foot soldiers and 12,000 horsemen, not counting the baggage carts and the soldiers handling the supplies. ³They set up camp in the valley near Bethulia beside the spring. They covered the whole land from Dothan to Balbaim and from Bethulia to Cyamon, which faces Esdraelon. ⁴When the Israelites saw this huge army, they were terrified and said to each other, "They will strip the whole land clean. The mountains, valleys, and hills cannot bear their weight." ⁵Yet they all took up their weapons and lit fires on their towers, where they remained on guard all night.

⁶On the second day Holofernes led all his horsemen out in full view of the Israelites in Bethulia. ⁷He scouted out the slopes leading up to the town and located the springs that supplied their water. So he took

control of these springs and set guards of soldiers over them. Then he returned to his army.

⁸Then all the leaders of the Edomites and the Moabites and the commanders of the coastal area came to him and said, ⁹“Listen to what we have to say, our master, and your army will suffer no casualties.

¹⁰These Israelites do not have to rely on their spears, for they live in safety in the high mountains. ¹¹Therefore, master, you do not have to fight against them in the normal way, and you will not lose a single man of your army. ¹²Simply stay in your camp and keep all your forces with you. Let your men keep control of the spring of water at the foot of the mountain, ¹³for this is where all the people of Bethulia get their water. Eventually their thirst will force them to surrender their town. Meanwhile, we and our people will go up to the tops of the nearest mountains. We will camp there to keep watch and to prevent anyone from leaving the town. ¹⁴All the men, women, and children will waste away from thirst, and you won’t even need to attack them. Their bodies will be scattered about in the streets outside their houses. ¹⁵Thus, you will pay them back for their defiance and for refusing to receive you peaceably.”

¹⁶This suggestion pleased Holofernes and all his officers, and he gave orders to do as they had said. ¹⁷So the army of the Ammonites moved forward along with five thousand Assyrians. They set up camp in the valley and seized the Israelites’ water sources and springs. ¹⁸Meanwhile, the Edomites and Ammonites went up and camped in the hill country opposite Dothan. They sent some of their men southeast toward Acraba, near Chusi, which is beside Mochmur Brook. The rest of the Assyrian army camped in the plain. Their tents and supply wagons spread out in great numbers, and they covered the entire area.

¹⁹The Israelites lost their courage and cried out to the Lord their God for help. All their enemies had surrounded them, and there was no way of escape. ²⁰The whole Assyrian army, including their foot soldiers, chariots, and horsemen, surrounded them for thirty-four days. Eventually, all the water jars of every house in Bethulia became empty. ²¹Their cisterns were going dry, and no one had enough water

to drink, for their water was rationed. ²²The children wasted away, and the women and young men, faint from thirst, were collapsing in the streets of the town and in the gateways. No one had any strength left.

²³Then all the people—including the young men, the women, and the children—gathered around Uzziah and the rulers of the town. They shouted at the elders, ²⁴“Let God judge between you and us! We are suffering because you wouldn’t make peace with the Assyrians. ²⁵Now we have no one to help us. God has handed us over to them, thirsty and helpless. ²⁶Call them immediately, and surrender the whole town as a prize to the army of Holofernes, ²⁷for it would be better for us to be captured by them. We will be forced to become their slaves, but at least our lives will be spared. And we won’t have to see our infants dying before our eyes or see our wives and children taking their last breath. ²⁸We call on heaven and earth and God to be our witnesses. The Lord of our ancestors is punishing us for our sins and the sins of our ancestors. Do what we have asked for today!” ²⁹Then the entire assembly began to weep, and they cried out to the Lord God with a loud voice.

³⁰But Uzziah said to them, “Take heart, my brothers and sisters. Let’s hold out for five more days. By then the Lord our God will show us his mercy again, for he will not completely forsake us. ³¹But if no help comes during that time, I will do as you say.” ³²Then he dismissed the people to their various quarters. The men returned to their stations on the walls and towers of the town. The women and children went home. And everyone in the town was miserable and discouraged.

8

Judith



ow Judith heard about what had happened. She was the daughter of Merari son of Ox, son of Joseph, son of Oziel,

son of Elkiah, son of Ananias, son of Gideon, son of Raphain, son of Ahitub, son of Elijah, son of Hilkiah, son of Eliab, son of Nathanael, son of Salamiel, son of Sarasadai, son of Israel. ²Her husband, Manasseh, who was from the same tribe and family, had died several years earlier during the barley harvest. ³As he supervised the workers who were binding sheaves of grain in the field, he was overcome by the burning heat and was confined to his bed. He died in Bethulia, his hometown, and was buried with his ancestors in the field between Dothan and Balamon. ⁴Judith had remained a widow for three years and four months. ⁵She stayed at home, where she set up a room for herself on the roof of her house. She wore sackcloth around her waist and dressed in widow's clothing. ⁶She fasted every day except on the day before the Sabbath, the Sabbath itself, the day before the new moon, the festival of the new moon, and all the joyful festivals of Israel. ⁷She was a beautiful woman, very lovely in appearance. Her husband, Manasseh, had left her gold and silver, male and female servants, herds, and cultivated land, and she managed the entire estate. ⁸No one spoke a bad word about her, for she was devout and feared God.

Judith Consults the Elders

⁹Judith heard how the people, who were fainting because they had no water, had spoken against Uzziah, the ruler. And she heard all that Uzziah had promised them, even that he had sworn to surrender the town to the Assyrians after five days. ¹⁰So she sent her maid, who was in charge of all she owned, to summon Uzziah and Chabris and Charmis, the elders of the town.

¹¹When the elders came to Judith, she said, "Listen to me, rulers of the people of Bethulia! What you have said to the people today is wrong. You have bound yourselves by an oath to God, promising to surrender the town to our enemies unless the Lord helps us within a certain number of days. ¹²Who are you to test God? Who are you to set yourselves above him? ¹³You are testing the Lord Almighty, but

you will never learn anything! ¹⁴If you cannot discover the depths of the human heart or understand the thoughts of the human mind, how can you search out God, who made these things? How can you grasp his mind or comprehend his thoughts? No, my brothers, do not make the Lord our God angry. ¹⁵For if he doesn't choose to help us within these five days, he still has the power to protect us for as long as he pleases. Or he could decide to destroy us in the presence of our enemies. ¹⁶Do not try to control the plans of the Lord our God, for God is not like a human being, to be manipulated. He is not like a mere mortal, who can be persuaded. ¹⁷Therefore, while we wait for him to rescue us, let us call on him for help. He will hear us, if it pleases him.

¹⁸"In these days there are no tribes, families, clans, or towns among us that worship gods they themselves have made, as was done before. ¹⁹That was why God allowed our ancestors to be killed, plundered, and humiliated by our enemies. ²⁰But now we worship no other gods but him, and so we hope that he will not abandon us or any of our people. ²¹For if we are captured, all Judea will be captured, and our Temple will be plundered. God will make us pay for its desecration with our very lives. ²²Our relatives will be slaughtered, our land will be taken over, and our inheritance will be destroyed—and all this in the presence of the Gentiles, to whom we will be slaves. We will be disgraced before these masters. ²³For our slavery will not bring us into their favor; rather, the Lord our God will make our slavery shameful.

²⁴"Therefore, fellow Israelites, let us be an example to our relatives, for their lives depend on us. And so does the Temple—even the holy places and the altar. ²⁵In spite of everything, we should thank the Lord our God, who is testing us, just as he tested our ancestors. ²⁶Remember how he tested Abraham and Isaac. And remember what happened to Jacob in Syrian Mesopotamia while he was taking care of the sheep of Laban, his mother's brother. ²⁷The Lord tried them with fire to test their hearts. But he is not punishing us. He punishes those who are close to him in order to warn them."

²⁸Then Uzziah said to her, “Everything you have said was spoken with a good heart, and there is no one who can disagree with your words. ²⁹Today is not the first time you have shown your wisdom, for the people have recognized your understanding and integrity from the time you were a small girl. ³⁰But the people were so thirsty that they forced us to make this promise, and they made us take an oath that cannot be broken. ³¹Now, since you are a devout woman, pray for us, that the Lord may send rain to fill our cisterns. Then we will no longer die of thirst.”

³²Then Judith said to them, “Listen to me. I am about to do something that will be remembered by all our descendants. ³³Tonight, stand by the gate, where I will leave with my maid. Within five days—the period after which you have promised to surrender the town to our enemies—the Lord will rescue Israel through me. ³⁴But don’t try to find out what I am doing, for I will not tell you until I have done it.”

³⁵Uzziah and the rulers said to her, “Go in peace. May the Lord God go before you and take revenge on our enemies.” ³⁶Then they left her room and returned to their quarters.

9

Judith’s Prayer

THEN Judith fell face down on the ground, put ashes on her head, and removed her clothing, leaving only the sackcloth she was wearing. At the very time the evening incense was being offered in the Temple of God in Jerusalem, Judith cried out to the Lord with a loud voice. She said, ²“O Lord God of my ancestor Simeon, you gave Simeon a sword to take revenge on the foreigners who had defiled a virgin by stripping off her clothes, exposing her thighs to put her to shame, and raping her. You said, ‘Such a thing must not be done.’ Yet they did it. ³So you allowed their rulers to be killed and their bed to be stained with blood, for it was covered with the shame of their deceitful

deed. You struck down slaves along with princes and killed even the princes on their thrones. ⁴You let their wives be captured and their daughters be taken into captivity, and you gave all their possessions to be divided among your beloved children. Your children burned with zeal for you and abhorred the stain on their sister, so they called on you for help. Listen to me and answer me, O God, my God, for I am a widow. ⁵You made the things of the past, and you designed everything that now exists and everything that is to come. What you planned has all happened. ⁶Everything you decided on has taken place just as you said it would. For all your ways are prepared in advance, and you make your judgments with knowledge of what will happen in the future.

⁷“Here now are the Assyrians, a great force, who take pride in their horses and riders. They boast in the strength of their foot soldiers and trust in shield and spear, bow and sling. They do not know that you are the Lord who crushes armies. ⁸Your name is the Lord. Break their strength by your might. Subdue their power in your anger. For they intend to defile your sanctuary, to pollute the Temple, where your glorious name resides, and to break off the horns of your altar with their powerful swords. ⁹Look at their pride. Send your fury on their heads. Give strength to a widow’s hand to do what I plan. ¹⁰When I trick them with my words, strike down the slave with the ruler and the ruler with his servant. Break their pride by the hand of a woman.

¹¹“For your strength does not depend on numbers nor your might on the powerful. But you are the God of the humble, helper of the oppressed, supporter of the weak, protector of the forsaken, deliverer of those without hope. ¹²Please, please, O God of my ancestor, God of Israel’s heritage, Lord of heaven and earth, Creator of the seas, King of your whole creation—hear my prayer! ¹³Help my deceitful tongue to wound and bruise those who have planned cruel things against your covenant, against your holy dwelling place on top of Mount Zion, and against this land that your children possess. ¹⁴Show your whole nation and every tribe that you are God, the God of all power and might. You are the only one who protects the people of Israel!”

10

Judith Goes to See Holofernes

HEN Judith finished pleading to the God of Israel, ²she got up from where she was lying face down before the Lord. She called her maid and went down into her house, where she lived on Sabbaths and festival days. ³Then she took off her sackcloth and the clothes that showed she was a widow in mourning. She took a bath, anointed herself with the finest lotion, braided her hair, put a tiara on her head, and dressed in her most beautiful clothing—things she had often worn when her husband, Manasseh, was still alive. ⁴Then she put sandals on her feet and put on anklets, bracelets, rings, and earrings. She made herself very beautiful to catch the attention of any man who might see her.

⁵She gave her maid a wineskin filled with wine and a flask of oil to carry. She also filled a bag with roasted grain, dried fig cakes, and fine bread, and she filled a sack with her dishes and gave them to the maid to carry. ⁶Then they went to the town gate of Bethulia, where Uzziah and the elders of the town, Chabris and Charmis, were waiting. ⁷They were astonished when they saw her so transformed, and they greatly admired her beauty. They said to her, ⁸“May the God of our ancestors bring you favor and fulfill your plans, bringing glory to the Israelites and exaltation to Jerusalem.”

Judith bowed down before God. Then she said to them, ⁹“Order the town gate to be opened, and I will go out and do what you have just said.” So they ordered the young men to open the gate for her. ¹⁰Then Judith went out, accompanied by her maid. The men of the town watched her while she went down the mountain and passed through the valley. Then they lost sight of her.

¹¹As Judith and her maid went straight through the valley, an Assyrian patrol met her ¹²and took her into custody. They asked her, “To what people do you belong? Where are you coming from? Where are you going?”

Judith answered, “I am a daughter of the Hebrews, but I am fleeing from them because I know you will soon defeat them. ¹³I want to see your commander, Holofernes, so I can tell him their secrets and show him a way to take the hill country without losing a single life.”

¹⁴When the men heard her words and saw her face—for she was incredibly beautiful—they said to her, ¹⁵“You have saved your life by choosing to surrender to our lord. Go to his tent immediately. Some of us will escort you to him. ¹⁶Don’t be afraid when you tell him what you just told us, for he will treat you well.” ¹⁷Then they chose a hundred men to accompany her and her maid, and they brought them to the tent of Holofernes.

¹⁸The whole camp was very excited, for news of her arrival spread from tent to tent. They came and gathered around her as she stood outside the tent of Holofernes, waiting to be invited in. ¹⁹They were amazed at her beauty and admired the Israelites, judging them by her. They said to one another, “Who can look down on the Jews when they have such beautiful women? We must destroy them all, for any that escape could captivate the whole world.”

²⁰Then Holofernes’ guards and servants came out and led her into the tent. ²¹Holofernes was resting on his bed under a purple canopy that was decorated with gold, emeralds, and other precious stones. ²²When they told him about her, he came to the front of the tent, accompanied by servants with silver lamps. ²³And when Holofernes and his servants saw Judith, they were all amazed at the beauty of her face. She showed honor by bowing low before him, but his slaves lifted her to her feet.

11

Judith’s First Meeting with Holofernes



THEN Holofernes said to Judith, “Take courage and don’t be afraid. I have never hurt anyone who was willing to serve Nebuchadnezzar, king of all the earth. ²If your people from the hill

country had not resisted me, I would never have attacked them. They have brought this on themselves. ³But tell me why you fled from them and came over to us. In any event, you have come to safety. Take courage! You will live tonight and ever after. ⁴No one will hurt you. In fact, everyone will treat you well, just as they treat all the servants of my lord, King Nebuchadnezzar.”

⁵Judith replied, “I am your servant. Please let me speak to you, and I will not lie to you. ⁶If you follow my advice, God will accomplish great things through you, and you will achieve your goals. ⁷For I swear this by Nebuchadnezzar, king of all the earth, and by his great power, which he has given you to bring order to every living being. And because of you, not only people serve him, but even the wild animals, the livestock, and the birds live under Nebuchadnezzar’s rule. ⁸We have all heard of your wisdom and skill, and everyone throughout the whole world knows that you alone are the most capable man in the whole kingdom, the most knowledgeable and brilliant in military strategy.

⁹“We have heard about what Achior said at your council meeting, for the people of Bethulia spared him, and he told them what he told you. ¹⁰Lord and master, do not disregard what he said, for it is true. Indeed, our nation cannot be punished, nor can the sword conquer the people if they have not sinned against their God.

¹¹“But as it is now, my lord will not be defeated by them. Death will surely fall on them, for they have been overtaken by sin and provoked the anger of their God. ¹²Since their food supply is depleted and their water is almost gone, they have planned to kill their livestock and eat all the parts that God has forbidden them to eat. ¹³And they have decided to eat the first part of the grain harvest and the tithes of the wine and oil, which they had dedicated and set aside for the priests in Jerusalem who minister in the presence of our God. It is not lawful for any of the people to even touch these things. ¹⁴But the elders of our town have sent men to Jerusalem (where they have been doing the same thing) to get permission from the high council of elders there.

¹⁵When they get this permission and act upon it, on that very day they will be handed over to you to be destroyed.

¹⁶“When I, your slave, learned all this, I fled from them. God has sent me to accomplish with you things that will astonish everyone in the world who hears about them. ¹⁷I revere and serve the God of heaven night and day. So, my lord, I would like to remain with you, but every night I must go out into the valley and pray to God. He will let me know when my people have committed their sins. ¹⁸Then I will come and tell you so that you may go out with your whole army, and not one of the Israelites will be able to stand against you. ¹⁹Then I will guide you through Judea until you reach Jerusalem, where you will be enthroned. You will round up the people like sheep without a shepherd, and no dog will so much as bark at you. I was sent to tell you all this, which has been shown to me before it even happens.”

²⁰Judith’s words pleased Holofernes and all his servants. They were amazed at her wisdom and said, ²¹“No other woman on earth looks so beautiful or speaks so wisely!” ²²Then Holofernes said to her, “God has done well to send you ahead of the others. This strengthens our hands to bring destruction on those who have insulted my lord. ²³You are as wise as you are beautiful. If you do as you have said, your God will be my God, and you will live in the palace of King Nebuchadnezzar and be famous throughout the whole world.”

12

Judith Resides as Holofernes’ Guest



OLOFERNES commanded his servants to bring Judith inside the tent, where his silver dinnerware was set on a table with some of his own delicacies and his own wine. ²But Judith said, “I cannot eat and drink these things without sinning. But I have enough to eat from the supply I brought with me.”

³Holofernes said to her, “If your supply runs out, where can we get you more? For none of your people are here.”

⁴Judith replied, "As surely as you live, my lord, I will not use up my supplies before the Lord uses me to carry out what he has planned."

⁵Then the servants of Holofernes took her to her own tent. She slept until midnight and then got up about two o'clock in the morning. ⁶She sent a message to Holofernes asking permission to be allowed to go out and pray. ⁷Holofernes commanded his personal bodyguards not to stop her. She was at the camp three days, and each night she went out to the valley of Bethulia and bathed at the spring. ⁸After bathing, she asked the Lord, the God of Israel, to show her how to achieve victory for his people. ⁹When she had purified herself, she returned and stayed in the tent all day until she ate her evening meal.

Judith at Holofernes' Banquet

¹⁰On the fourth day Holofernes held a private banquet for his personal staff. He did not invite any of his officers. ¹¹He said to Bagoas, the eunuch in charge of his personal affairs, "Persuade the Hebrew woman to join us, for I want her to eat and drink with us. ¹²It would be a shame to let such a beautiful woman go without sleeping with her. If we fail to seduce her, she will laugh at us."

¹³So Bagoas went out to see Judith and said, "Would this lovely woman come to my lord as his guest of honor? Please come and enjoy our wine, and you will be treated like one of the Assyrian women who serve in the palace of Nebuchadnezzar."

¹⁴Judith replied, "Who am I to refuse my lord? I will do whatever he wants me to do, and it will be a joy to me until my dying day." ¹⁵So she dressed herself in all her beautiful clothing and feminine finery. Her maid went ahead and spread before Holofernes the lambskins Bagoas had provided for Judith's bed and dining couch.

¹⁶When Judith went in and lay down, Holofernes' heart burned with passion, for he had been waiting for a chance to seduce her ever since he first saw her. ¹⁷So Holofernes said to her, "Please, enjoy yourself! Have a drink!"

¹⁸Judith said, "I will gladly drink, my lord, because today is the best day of my life." ¹⁹Then she took the food and drink her maid had prepared and ate and drank with him. ²⁰Holofernes was so pleased with her that he drank a great quantity of wine, much more than he had ever drunk before.

13

Judith Kills Holofernes

HEN evening came, Holofernes' slaves left quickly. Bagoas closed the tent from the outside and sent the attendants away. They went to their beds, for they were all weary from the long banquet. ²Judith was left alone in the tent with Holofernes, who had collapsed on his bed in a drunken stupor. ³Judith told her maid to stand outside Holofernes' sleeping quarters and wait for her to come out, as she had done on the other days, for Judith said she would be going out for her prayers. (She had told Bagoas the same thing.) ⁴So now everyone had left, and she was alone in the tent.

Then Judith, standing beside Holofernes' bed, said in her heart, "O Lord, God of all power, bless what I am about to do for the glory of Jerusalem. ⁵Now is the time to help your people and to carry out my plan to destroy the enemies who have attacked us."

⁶She went up to the bedpost near Holofernes' head and took down his sword that hung there. ⁷She came close to his bed, took hold of his hair, and said, "Make me strong today, Lord God of Israel!" ⁸Then she struck his neck twice with all her might and cut off his head. ⁹Next she rolled his body off the bed and pulled the canopy down from the posts. Then she quickly went out and gave Holofernes' head to her maid, ¹⁰who put it in her food bag. Then the two of them left camp together, as they usually did when they went to pray.

As soon as they passed through the camp, they circled around the valley, went up the mountain toward Bethulia, and then headed for its gates. ¹¹From a distance Judith called out to the guards at the gates,

“Please, open the gate! Open! God, our God, is still with us. He has shown his power in Israel and his strength against our enemies on this very day!”

¹²When the people of the town heard her voice, they hurried down to the town gate and summoned the elders of the town. ¹³The leaders and the rest of the people all ran to the gate, for it seemed unbelievable that she had returned. They opened the gate and welcomed the two women. Then they lit a fire for light and gathered around them.

¹⁴With a loud voice, Judith said to them, “Praise God! Praise him! Praise God, who has not withdrawn his mercy from the people of Israel. He has helped me destroy our enemies this very night!” ¹⁵Then she pulled the head out of the bag and showed it to them. “Look,” she said. “This is the head of Holofernes, the commander of the Assyrian army. Here is the canopy beneath which he lay drunk. The Lord has struck him down by the hand of a woman!” ¹⁶The Lord protected me in this mission, and as the Lord lives, I swear that it was my beauty that seduced him to his destruction. But he committed no sin with me so as to disgrace and shame me.”

¹⁷All the people were completely amazed. They bowed down and worshiped God, saying with one voice, “We bless you, our God, for on this day you have humiliated the enemies of your people.”

¹⁸Then Uzziah said to Judith, “Daughter, may you be blessed by the Most High God above all women on earth. Praise to the Lord God, who created the heavens and the earth, who has guided you to cut off the head of the leader of our enemies. ¹⁹Those who acknowledge the power of God will forever find hope in him. ²⁰May God give you honor forever, and may he reward you with blessings, for you did not think about your own life when our nation was brought to its knees. You prevented our ruin by walking in the straight path of our God.”

And all the people said, “Amen! Amen!”

14

Judith's Plan



THEN Judith said to them, “Listen to me, brothers and sisters. Take this head and hang it on the battlements of your wall. ²When morning comes and the sun is up, every able-bodied man should go out of the town with his weapons. Appoint a leader over them, as if you were going down to the plain to attack the Assyrian scouts—only don’t really go. ³The scouts will grab their weapons and run into the camp and wake up the officers. They will all rush to the tent of Holofernes, but when they cannot find him, they will panic and flee before you. ⁴Then you and all who live within the borders of Israel will chase them and cut them down in their tracks. ⁵But before you do all this, bring Achior the Ammonite to identify this man who despised the people of Israel and who thought he was sending Achior to his death by sending him to us.”

⁶So they called Achior, who was staying in the home of Uzziah. When he came and saw one of the men holding Holofernes’ head, he fell to the ground in a faint. ⁷When they revived him, he threw himself at Judith’s feet and honored her. He said, “May you be blessed by every family of Judah! In every nation, those who hear your name will be afraid. ⁸How in the world did you do this?”

So Judith, surrounded by all the people, told him everything she had done, from the day she left until that moment. ⁹When she finished, the people cheered, rejoicing throughout the town. ¹⁰When Achior saw all that the God of Israel had done, he became a firm believer in God. So he was circumcised and joined the people of Israel, remaining so to this day.

Holofernes Is Discovered Dead

¹¹As soon as it was dawn, the people of Bethulia hung Holofernes’ head on the wall. Then they all took their weapons and went in companies to the mountain passes. ¹²When the Assyrians saw them, they sent word to their commanders, who reported the news to the generals and captains and all their other officers. ¹³The officers went to Holofernes’ tent and said to the man in charge of Holofernes’

personal affairs, “Wake up our lord, for those slaves are so bold they are attacking us—but we will destroy them!”

¹⁴Bagoas went inside and knocked at the inner entrance of the tent, for he thought Holofernes was sleeping with Judith. ¹⁵But when no one answered, he opened it and went into the bedchamber and found Holofernes’ dead body lying on the floor with his head cut off. ¹⁶Bagoas cried out in anguish, wept, moaned, shouted, and tore his clothes. ¹⁷Then he ran to the tent where Judith had stayed. When he saw that she was gone, he ran out to the people and shouted, ¹⁸“Those slaves have tricked us! A single Hebrew woman has disgraced the whole house of King Nebuchadnezzar. Look, Holofernes is lying dead on the ground, and his head is missing!”

¹⁹When the leaders of the Assyrian army heard this, they tore their clothing in terror and distress, and their loud cries and shouts rang throughout the camp.

15

The Assyrians Flee

WHEN the men in the tents heard about it, they were astonished at what had happened. ²Panic-stricken, they didn’t wait for each other but rushed out and fled across the plain and through the hill country on any available road or path. ³Those who were camped in the hills around Bethulia also fled. Then all the Israelite soldiers charged after them.

⁴Uzziah sent messengers to Betomasthaim, Bebai, Choba, Kola, and all the territory of Israel to tell what had happened and to urge everyone to pursue and destroy the enemy. ⁵When the Israelites heard it, they joined together to fight the enemy, cutting them down all the way to Choba. Those in Jerusalem and in all the hill country also came, for they were told what had happened in the enemy camp. The men of Gilead and Galilee repeatedly attacked the enemy from the flank and slaughtered them, pursuing them even to the borders of

Damascus. ⁶The people of Bethulia plundered the Assyrian camp and carried off great riches. ⁷And when the other Israelites returned from the slaughter, they took what remained. There was such a huge amount of plunder that even the villages and towns in the hill country and in the plain received much of it.

Victory Celebration

⁸Then Joakim the high priest and the high council of the Israelites in Jerusalem came to see the good things that the Lord had done for Israel. They also wanted to see Judith and congratulate her. ⁹When they met her, they all blessed her and said to her, “You are the glory of Jerusalem; all Israel boasts about you! You are the great pride of our nation! ¹⁰You have done all this with your own hand. You have done a great thing for Israel, and God is well pleased with it. May the Almighty Lord bless you forever!” And all the people said, “Amen.”

¹¹The people plundered the Assyrian camp for thirty days. They gave Holofernes’ tent and all his silver dinnerware, his beds, his bowls, and his furniture to Judith. She loaded her mules, hitched up her carts, and piled up all the plunder. ¹²All the women of Israel hurried to see her and bless her. They danced in her honor, and Judith gave them ivy-covered wands. ¹³Then the women crowned themselves with olive wreaths. Judith led all the women in a dance procession, and the men of Israel followed, carrying their weapons, wearing garlands, and singing hymns. ¹⁴With all Israel surrounding her, Judith sang a song of thanksgiving. And all the people joined in her song of praise.

16

A Song of Praise



THIS is Judith’s song:

Sing to my God with tambourines.

Sing to my Lord with cymbals.

Lift up to him a psalm of praise.

Exalt him and call upon his name.

²For the Lord is a God who crushes warfare.

He set up his camp in the midst of his people;
he rescued me from the hands of my oppressors.

³Assyria came down from the mountains of the north.

They came with many thousands of warriors.

Their soldiers filled the valleys.

Their horsemen covered the hills.

⁴They boasted that they would set my land on fire,

kill my young men with the sword,

throw my infants to the ground,

seize my children as prizes of war,

and take my virgins as captives.

⁵But the Lord Almighty has defeated them

by the hand of a woman.

⁶Their mighty leader was not struck down by young men,

nor did the sons of the Titans bring him down,

nor did tall giants put him away.

It was Judith, daughter of Merari,

who disarmed him with her beauty.

⁷She put away her widow's clothing

to rescue the oppressed in Israel.

She put on sweet perfume

⁸and fastened her hair with a tiara.

She put on a linen gown to seduce him,

⁹and a glimpse of her sandal aroused him.

Her beauty captivated his soul,

but the sword severed his neck!

¹⁰The Persians trembled at her boldness,
the Medes were stunned by her daring.

¹¹Then my oppressed people shouted a war cry.
My weak people cried out, and the enemy trembled;
they raised their voices, and the enemy turned back.

¹²Sons of slave girls pierced the enemy
and wounded them like deserters.
They perished before the army of my Lord.

¹³I will sing a new song to my God:
O Lord, you are great and glorious,
wonderfully strong, invincible.

¹⁴May all your creatures serve you,
for when you spoke, they came into being.

You sent your breath, and it formed them;
no one can resist your voice.

¹⁵The mountains and oceans will shake in your presence,
and rocks will melt like wax before you,
but to those who fear you,
you show mercy.

¹⁶Sweet-smelling sacrifices are a small thing to you.
The fat of whole burnt offerings means little to you.
But those who fear the Lord are great forever.

¹⁷Destruction is certain for the nations that rise up against my
people!

The Lord Almighty will punish them in the day of judgment.
He will send fire and worms into their flesh,

and they will cry in pain forever.

¹⁸Eventually the entire group arrived at Jerusalem, where they worshiped God. As soon as the people were purified, they offered burnt offerings, freewill offerings, and gifts. ¹⁹Judith dedicated to God all the possessions of Holofernes she had been given, and she gave the canopy from his sleeping quarters as an offering to fulfill a vow. ²⁰For three months the people enjoyed the festivities in Jerusalem before the Temple. And Judith was with them the whole time.

Conclusion

²¹After these events, the people all went home. Judith returned to Bethulia and lived on her estate, and she was esteemed throughout the country for the rest of her life. ²²Many men wanted to marry her, but she never gave herself to another man after the death of her husband, Manasseh. ²³She became more and more famous through the years. She grew old in her husband's house, reaching the age of 105. She set her maid free, and then she died in Bethulia. She was buried in a cave beside her husband, Manasseh, ²⁴and all Israel mourned for seven days. Before she died she distributed her property to all of her relatives and to Manasseh's relatives.

²⁵No one troubled the Israelites during Judith's lifetime or for a long time afterward.

Preface to the Book of Wisdom of Solomon

Martin Luther, 1534

BECAUSE the present meeting of the Diet at Spires has separated us, so that we who had intended to translate the prophets completely could not all get together—and because, hindered by an unexpected weakness, I was unfit to attend to these and other matters, yet did not want to sit here altogether idle—I have in the meanwhile picked up this little block of wood, the book of Wisdom, and begun whittling away. With the help of my good friends I have translated it and, insofar as God has granted it, we have brought it out of its Latin and Greek obscurity into the German daylight. Even though others have translated it before, I think their German will just have to stand comparison with ours; indeed, it may even need ours.]

For a long time this book has stood in the cross fire of controversy as to whether or not it should be included among the sacred Scriptures of the Old Testament, especially in view of the fact that the author suggests in chapter 9[:7] that throughout the book it is King Solomon speaking—he whose wisdom is also extolled in the Book of Kings [I Kings 4, 10].

The ancient church fathers, however, excluded it outright from the sacred Scriptures. They believed it was made to appear like the work of King Solomon, so that the name and fame of such a renowned king would gain for the book greater attention and reputation among the mighty men on earth, for whom it was mainly written. Perhaps it would long since have disappeared had its author—if he were a man of small reputation—let it come out under his own name.

They contend, however, that Philo is the author of this book. Undoubtedly he was one of the most learned and wisest men the Jewish

people have had since the prophets, as he demonstrated in other books and deeds of his.

For during the reign of the emperor, Caligula, when the Jews were most disgracefully maligned in blasphemous pamphlets and abusive speeches by Apion and others in Alexandria, and then were most poisonously denounced and accused before the emperor, it was this same Philo whom the Jewish people sent to the emperor to defend their cause and plead their case. When the emperor was so embittered against the Jews that he turned them away and would not even hear them, then Philo—a man of courage and confidence—spoke up and said to his fellow Jews, “Well, then, dear brethren, do not be afraid but take heart; just because human help fails us, God’s help will surely be with us!”

In my estimation, this book must have come out of such a situation or cause. When the case and rights of Philo and the Jews could no longer gain a hearing before the emperor, Philo turned to God and threatened the mighty and the evil-tongued with God’s judgment. This is also why the author speaks so vehemently in chapters 1[:6–11] and 2[:10–20] against the poisonous and evil tongues who on account of the truth persecute and destroy the righteous and innocent, and then goes on to cite the great example of the divine judgment which God meted out to Pharaoh and the Egyptians for the sake of the children of Israel [10:15–19; 18:5–19; 19:1–16]. He does this with such incisiveness and forcefulness as though he were eagerly seeking to make every word strike the emperor, the Romans, and the poisonous tongues of the Greeks who were raving against the Jews. Through powerful examples he would frighten off [the opponents] and comfort the Jews.

[Finally, when one considers the times, history, and writings of Philo and compares this book with them, then it appears so intensely Jewish, and corresponds so fully, that the holy fathers were not without considerable justification when they held Philo to be its author.]

Afterward, however, it came to be regarded by many as a genuine book of sacred Scripture. This has been particularly true in the Roman

Church, which has esteemed it so highly that there is hardly another book of Scripture about which so much fuss has been made. Perhaps it is because in this book tyrants are explicitly attacked and condemned so sharply, while saints and martyrs are so superbly consoled. In Rome, where Christians were persecuted and martyred more than anywhere else in the world, this book has been stressed most of all, as the one that perfectly fit the case with its threats against the tyrants and comfort for the saints. Of course there were many passages they did not understand, but simply dragged in by the hair, as has often happened also to the whole of sacred Scripture, and still happens daily.

Be that as it may, there are many good things in this book, and it is well worth reading. Especially the great lords, who take it out on their subjects and who, on account of God's Word, rage against the innocent, should read this book. For [the author] addresses himself to them in chapter 6[:1–2] and affirms that the book is written for them, saying, "To you, O tyrants, my words are directed," etc. [6:9]. And he testifies very well that the worldly overlords have their power from God and are really God's agents [6:3], yet warns them against using such a divinely entrusted office tyrannically [6:4–6].

This book is timely for our day, because tyrants are now cocksurely abusing their authority against him from whom they have it. And they are living just as disgracefully in their idolatry and un-Christian holiness as the Romans and heathen, whom Philo here describes, [lived] in their own idolatry. So in every respect it really fits our present times.

It is called the Wisdom of Solomon because (as has been pointed out) it was brought forth under his name and character; and it exalts wisdom quite royally, namely, for what it is, what it can accomplish, and from whence it comes [6:22]. It pleases me beyond measure that the author here extols the Word of God so highly, and ascribes to the Word all the wonders God has performed, both on enemies and in his saints.

From this it can be clearly seen that what the author here calls wisdom is not the clever or lofty thoughts of pagan teachers and human reason, but the holy and divine Word. Mark well that whatever praise and glory you hear ascribed herein to wisdom is said of nothing other than the Word of God. For even [the author] himself says, in chapter 16[:12], that the children of Israel were not sustained by manna, nor saved by the bronze serpent, but by the Word of God. just as in Matthew 4[:4] Christ says, “Man shall not live by bread alone,” etc. This is why [the author] teaches that wisdom comes from nowhere else than from God, and brings many illustrations from Scripture. So he ascribes to wisdom what Scripture ascribes to the Word of God.

Because one commonly understands the word “wisdom” in a sense different from that in which it is used in Scripture, I have spoken all the more readily about this matter. When one hears mention of the word, one usually jumps at conclusions and imagines that the reference is to nothing but thoughts lying hidden in the hearts of wise people; at the same time one does not regard the external Word or Scripture as wisdom, even though all human thoughts without the Word of God are lies and false dreams. To refer to this book as the Wisdom of Solomon is as much as to call it: A Book of Solomon about the Word of God. So the spirit of wisdom is nothing other than faith, our understanding of that same Word; this, however, the Holy Spirit imparts. Such faith or spirit can do all things, and does do all things, as this book glories in chapter 7[:27].

Finally, this book is a proper exposition and illustration of the first commandment. For here you see that the author throughout is teaching you to fear and trust God; he terrifies with examples of divine wrath those who are not afraid and who despise God, and he comforts with examples of divine grace those who believe and trust him. All of this is simply a correct understanding of the first commandment.

From this one can also see that all wisdom wells up and flows forth from the first commandment, as from a central spring. Indeed this same commandment is the true sun by which all wise men see what they see. For whoever fears and believes God is full of wisdom, master

of all the world, mighty over all words and deeds, judge of all such teaching and living as are valid and worthful in the sight of God. Again, whoever does not have the first commandment, and neither fears nor trusts God, he is full of foolishness; he can do nothing and is nothing. This is the foremost reason why it is well to read this book: that one may learn to fear and trust God. To that end may he graciously help us. Amen.

Wisdom of Solomon

1

Wisdom Forsakes the Wicked



OVE justice, you rulers of the earth.

Think of the Lord in the right way,
and seek him with a sincere heart,

²for he is found by those who trust him,
and he shows himself to those who have faith in him.

³Dishonest thinking separates people from God.
When his power is put to the test,
it exposes fools for what they are.

⁴Wisdom will not enter an evil person,
nor will it dwell in a person enslaved by sin.

⁵Someone with a disciplined, holy spirit will flee from deceit,
abandon foolish thoughts,
and withdraw when sin intrudes.

⁶Wisdom is a spirit that is kind to humanity,
but it holds blasphemers accountable for what they say.
God knows their innermost being;
he sees what is truly in their hearts
and listens to them speak.

⁷The Spirit of the Lord fills the whole world;
he holds all things together
and knows every word that is spoken.

⁸Therefore, those who speak unjustly cannot escape notice.
Justice will certainly punish them.

⁹The thoughts of the ungodly will be carefully examined;
their words will be reported to the Lord,
and he will convict them of their sins.

¹⁰His jealous ear hears all things;
he does not ignore the sound of complaining.

¹¹So be sure you don't engage in pointless grumbling,
and keep your tongue from finding fault.

Even what you say in private has consequences,
and a lying tongue destroys the soul.

¹²Do not court death by living a life of error;
do not destroy yourself by your own actions.

¹³God did not make death,
and he takes no pleasure in the destruction of the living.

¹⁴He created all things so that they could exist,
and everything he created is inclined toward wellness.
There is no destructive poison in them.

The grave has no power on earth,
¹⁵for righteousness is immortal.

¹⁶But the wicked invite death by their deeds and words.
They consider death a friend, so they long for him.

They have made a covenant with him
because they belong together.

2

The Wicked Say Life Is for Pleasure



THE wicked have reached this irrational conclusion:

“Our life is short and sad.

There is no remedy for death;

no one has returned from the grave.

²We are born by chance,

and when we die, it is as though we never existed.

The breath in our nostrils is but a puff of smoke,

and our reason is merely a spark kept alive by our beating hearts.

³When that spark is extinguished, it will leave the body in ashes;
our spirit will dissipate like a vapor.

⁴In time even our name will be forgotten,

and no one will remember anything we have done.

Our life will pass away

like the last wisp of a cloud;

it will dissipate like mist

that is driven away by sunlight

and overcome by its heat.

⁵For our days are but the passing of a shadow,

and there is no return from death.

Our fate is sealed,

and no one can come back.

⁶“Come, then, let’s enjoy the good things around us
and take pleasure in creation with youthful zeal.

⁷Let’s take our fill of costly wines and perfumes;

let’s take time to enjoy the spring flowers.

⁸Let’s crown ourselves with rosebuds before they wilt;

⁹let’s stop in every meadow for joyous play.

Let’s leave signs of our enjoyment everywhere,

for this life is what we have inherited.

¹⁰“Let’s oppress the righteous poor man

and not spare the widow.

Let’s dishonor the aged, whose hair is gray.

- ¹¹Let's consider our might to be right,
for the weak prove to be useless.
- ¹²Let's lie in wait for righteous people,
for they are an embarrassment to us.
They oppose our actions;
they reproach us for breaking the law of Moses
and rebelling against our upbringing.
- ¹³They claim to know God
and call themselves servants of God.
- ¹⁴They tell us our thoughts are sinful;
the very sight of these people bothers us.
- ¹⁵They are not like other people;
their ways are very different.
- ¹⁶They regard us as insignificant
and avoid our ways, calling them unclean.
They say that the final destiny of the righteous is blessed,
and they boast that God is their Father.
- ¹⁷Let's see then if their words are true;
let's watch what happens to them in the end.
- ¹⁸If the righteous are the children of God,
God will defend them
and rescue them from their enemies' control.
- ¹⁹Let's insult and torture them;
then we will find out how meek and patient they are.
- ²⁰Let's condemn them to a most shameful death,
for they say God will protect them."
- ²¹They reasoned this way, but they were deceived,
for their own evil blinded them.
- ²²They did not know the secret plan of God.
They never expected that a holy life would have its rewards.

- ²³For God created people to be immortal;
he made us in his own eternal image.
²⁴But because of the envy of the Devil,
death came into the world,
and all who belong to him experience it.

3

The Destiny of the Righteous



- UT the souls of the righteous are in the hand of God,
and no torment will ever touch them.
²In the eyes of the foolish, the righteous appear to die;
their passing is considered a misfortune.
³They seem to be on their way to destruction,
but they are really at peace.
⁴And though they appear to suffer punishment,
immortality has made their hope complete.
⁵The righteous may suffer a little in this life,
but they will be well rewarded,
for God has tested them
and found them worthy to join him.
⁶He has tried them like gold purified by fire
and has accepted them as he accepts a whole burnt offering.
⁷In their time of judgment, the righteous will shine;
they will destroy their enemies.
⁸They will govern nations and rule over people,
and the Lord will reign over them forever.
⁹Those who trust in the Lord will understand truth,
and the faithful will live with him in love.
For he shows grace and mercy to his chosen ones.

The Destiny of the Wicked

- ¹⁰But the wicked will be punished as their thoughts deserve,
for they neglected justice and rebelled against the Lord.
- ¹¹Those who reject wisdom and instruction are miserable;
their hope is in vain,
their labors bear no fruit,
and their work is pointless.
- ¹²Their wives are foolish,
their children are depraved,
and their offspring are cursed.

The Rewards of Righteousness

- ¹³God blesses the childless woman who remains pure,
who has not entered into a sinful sexual relationship.
She will be rewarded when God comes to judge people.
- ¹⁴God also blesses the eunuch whose hands have done no wrong,
who has no wicked thoughts against the Lord.
Special favor will be given to him for his faithfulness,
and he will be given a place of honor in the Lord's Temple.
- ¹⁵For everyone knows that good labor yields good fruit,
and wisdom is a strong and nourishing root.
- ¹⁶But the children of adulterers will not reach maturity;
the offspring of a sinful relationship will disappear.
- ¹⁷Even if they live long, they will not be esteemed;
they will receive no honor in their old age.
- ¹⁸And if they die young, they will have no hope
and no consolation on the day of judgment,
¹⁹for harsh is the end of a wicked generation.



It is better to be childless
than to lack virtue.

For virtuous people will live on forever
since they are honored by God and by people.

²When virtue is present, people imitate it,
and when it is absent, they long for it.

Forever it marches, crowned in triumph,
honorably winning lasting rewards.

³The numerous offspring of the ungodly will not thrive;
their illegitimate seedlings will not take deep root
or gain a firm hold.

⁴They may flourish for a time,
but they will be shaken by the wind because of their shallow
roots
and uprooted by the force of the storm.

⁵The young branches will be broken off,
and their fruit will be useless,
not ripe enough to eat and good for nothing.

⁶For children who are born of sinful relationships
will be evidence of their parents' wickedness when judgment
comes.

⁷But the righteous, though they may die young,
will be at rest.

⁸Honor is not gained merely by a long life,
nor is it measured by a person's age;

⁹but understanding comes with gray hair,
and a blameless life brings the honor of ripe old age.

¹⁰Once such a man pleased God and was loved by him.
While living among sinners, he was taken from the earth.

¹¹He was taken away so evil could not undermine his judgment

nor deceit seduce his soul.

¹²For fascination with wickedness obscures what is truly good,
and unrestrained desire perverts the innocent mind.

¹³He was made perfect in his few short years,
as though he had lived a long life.

¹⁴Since his soul pleased the Lord,
the Lord quickly took him from the wickedness around him.

¹⁵Yet the people saw this and did not understand it;
they did not take these things to heart:

that God shows grace and mercy to his chosen ones
and that he watches over his holy ones.

Terror for the Wicked

¹⁶The righteous who have died
condemn the wicked who are living,
and the youth who is made perfect in a short life
condemns the long life of the unjust.

¹⁷The unjust will see the end of the wise,
but they will not understand what the Lord has designed for
them
and why he has taken them to safety.

¹⁸The unjust will see them and despise them,
but the Lord will laugh at the unjust.

¹⁹They will become dishonored corpses;
they will be a reproach among the dead forever.

He will throw them down speechless
and will shake them from their foundations.

They will be completely abandoned and left to suffer grief.
Even the memory of them will perish.

- ²⁰They will be filled with dread when their sins are recounted,
and their crimes will convict them.

5



- WHEN the righteous will stand up with great confidence
to confront those who have persecuted them
and ridiculed their actions.
- ²Those who see the righteous will tremble with terrible fear
and will be surprised and amazed at their salvation.
- ³They will speak to each other with words of repentance.
They will groan in anguish and say,
- ⁴“These are the people we once derided!
We were fools to reproach them.
We thought they were crazy;
we thought they died without honor.
- ⁵Look, now they are regarded as children of God.
They are listed among the saints.
- ⁶We were the ones who strayed from the truth.
The light of righteousness has not shined on us,
and the sun has not risen upon us.
- ⁷We took all the paths of wickedness and destruction
and walked through the wilderness,
but we did not find the way of the Lord.
- ⁸“But how has our pride helped us?
What has our boasting about riches gained us?
- ⁹All those things have passed away like a shadow
and like a fleeting rumor.
- ¹⁰They have vanished like a ship passing through the waves,
leaving no trace of its passage,
no track of its path in the waves.

- ¹¹They are like a bird flying through the air,
leaving no evidence of its passage—
only the sound of wings beating the light air,
parting the air by the force of its flight.
It moves its wings and passes through,
yet it leaves no trace of its path.
- ¹²They are like an arrow shot at a target.
The air divides and comes together again,
so that no one knows its route.
- ¹³So it is with us; we die almost as soon as we are born.
And we have left nothing of virtue behind,
for we were consumed by our wickedness.”
- ¹⁴The hope of the wicked is like thistledown blown by the wind
or like foam blown by a storm.
It is like smoke dissipated by the wind.
It is soon forgotten like the memory of a one-day guest.
- ¹⁵But the righteous will live forever,
and their reward is in the Lord’s keeping.
The Most High takes care of them.
- ¹⁶Therefore, they will receive a glorious crown,
a beautiful diadem from the Lord.
For he will cover them with his right hand,
and he will shield them with his arm.
- ¹⁷The Lord will use his zeal as armor
and all creation as a weapon against his enemies.
- ¹⁸He will put on righteousness as body armor,
and he will wear impartial justice as a helmet.
- ¹⁹He will take holiness for an invincible shield,
²⁰and he will sharpen his stern wrath as a sword.
All creation will join his fight against his frantic enemies.
- ²¹Shafts of lightning will strike with pinpoint accuracy,
shooting from the clouds like arrows from a fully drawn bow.

²²Hailstones of wrath will be catapulted upon the enemy.
The sea will rage against them,
and the rivers will flood them in a torrent.
²³A mighty wind will blow over them,
and like a whirlwind it will winnow them.
So lawlessness will destroy the earth,
and wickedness will overthrow rulers.

6

Kings Should Seek Wisdom



EAR, then, you kings, and understand;
learn, you who judge everyone on earth.
²Listen, you who rule over many people
and govern numerous nations.
³Your authority was given to you by the Lord,
and your power comes from the Most High.
He will examine your works
and scrutinize your plans.
⁴You are the servants of his kingdom,
but you have not judged justly.
You have not upheld the law of Moses
or lived according to the will of God.
⁵He will come against you terribly and quickly,
because severe judgment falls on those with great authority.
⁶To the lowly, mercy may be granted;
but those who are great will be greatly tested.
⁷For the Lord will not stand in awe of anyone,
nor will he step aside for greatness.
He made both the small and the great,
and he regards them all the same.

- ⁸But greater scrutiny awaits the powerful.
⁹So my words are directed to you, O kings,
in order that you may learn wisdom and not depart from it.
¹⁰For those who have treated the sacred with holiness
will be considered holy,
and those who have learned these things
will know how to defend themselves.
¹¹Therefore, be eager to hear my words;
long for them, and you will be instructed.

The Way to Wisdom

- ¹²Wisdom is glorious and never fades away.
She is easily seen by those who love her;
she is found by those who seek her.
¹³She is quick to show herself to all who desire her.
¹⁴Those who rise early to seek her will not find it difficult,
for they will find her sitting at the gate.
¹⁵Meditating upon wisdom brings perfect understanding,
and those who watch for her will soon be free from care.
¹⁶For she goes about seeking those who are worthy of her;
she graciously shows herself to them in their daily activities
and meets them in every thought they have.
- ¹⁷The beginning of wisdom is a sincere desire for instruction,
and concern for instruction shows a love of wisdom.
¹⁸To love wisdom is to keep her laws,
and obeying her laws guarantees immortality.
¹⁹Immortality brings one near to God;
²⁰so the desire for wisdom is the way to acquire a kingdom.
²¹So if you kings desire thrones and scepters,

honor wisdom, and you will reign forever.

Wisdom's Riches

²²Now I will tell what wisdom is
and how she came to be.

I will hide no secrets from you
but will trace her steps from the beginning.
I will bring knowledge of her to light
and not bypass the truth.

²³I will not allow myself to be consumed with envy,
for envy has nothing in common with wisdom.

²⁴A multitude of wise counselors brings salvation to the world,
and a wise king brings stability to his people.

²⁵Therefore, be instructed by my words,
and you will profit from them.

7



, too, am mortal, like everyone else.

I am a descendant of the first man formed from the earth;
in my mother's womb I was fashioned into a body.

²For nine months I developed,
having come from the seed of man and the pleasure of marriage.

³When I was born, I breathed the air we all breathe
and was laid upon the earth that bears us all.
The first sound I uttered was a cry, as is true with everyone else.

⁴Snugly wrapped in strips of cloth, I was nursed with care.

⁵And no king had a beginning that was any different.

- ⁶For all people have one entrance into life,
and all have a common exit.
- ⁷So I prayed, and I was given understanding;
I pleaded, and the spirit of wisdom came upon me.
- ⁸I preferred wisdom to power and kingship;
riches were as nothing compared to her.
- ⁹I did not compare her to any precious stone,
for gold is but a little sand in comparison to her,
and silver is as clay.
- ¹⁰I loved her more than health and beauty;
I preferred her even to light,
for her light cannot be extinguished.
- ¹¹All good things came to me along with her;
innumerable riches accompanied her.
- ¹²I rejoiced in all these things, because wisdom brought them to
me,
though I did not know that wisdom was the mother of them
all.
- ¹³I learned diligently, and I teach others freely.
I do not hide wisdom's riches,
¹⁴for they are an infinite treasure to people.
- Those who use wisdom's riches become friends of God
and are commended for the benefits of learning.
- ¹⁵May God grant me the ability to speak wisely
and to think thoughts worthy of all I have learned.
He is the guide of wisdom
and the director of the wise.
- ¹⁶We and our words are in his hands
along with all knowledge and skills.
- ¹⁷For he has given me true knowledge of what exists.
I know how the world and the elements work.
- ¹⁸I know all the ages from beginning to end,

- the movements of the sun and the changes of seasons.
¹⁹I know the cycles of the year and the various constellations,
²⁰the nature of animals and the instincts of wild beasts.
I know the power of spirits and the way people think,
the varieties of plants, and the roots that are beneficial.
²¹I know what is hidden and what is visible,
for wisdom, the designer of all things, taught me.

The Nature of Wisdom

- ²²Wisdom's spirit is intelligent, holy, unique,
many-faceted, subtle, active,
clear, undefiled, certain,
sweet, benevolent, sharp,
irresistible, ²³helpful, kind,
firm, sure, and secure.
Wisdom's spirit is all-powerful and oversees all things.
It permeates every intelligent, pure, and perceptive spirit.
²⁴Wisdom is more active than motion itself.
She pervades and permeates everything by her purity.
²⁵For she is a breath of God's power,
a pure revelation of the glory of the Almighty.
Therefore, nothing that is defiled can reach her.
²⁶For she is the reflection of eternal light,
the spotless mirror of God's power,
and the image of his goodness.
²⁷She is only one, but she can do all things.
She herself remains the same, but she renews all things.
In every generation she gives herself to holy souls,
making them prophets and friends of God.
²⁸For God loves none as much as those who dwell with wisdom.
²⁹She is more beautiful than the sun,

more wonderful than all the constellations of stars.
She is superior even to the sun's light,
³⁰for daylight is followed by night,
but no evil can overcome wisdom.

8

The Rewards of Wisdom



WISDOM reaches from one end of the earth to the other
and governs all things well.

²I have loved her and sought her from my youth.
I have desired to take her for my bride,
for I am enamored with her beauty.

³She enhances her noble birth by living with God,
and the Lord of all loves her.

⁴For she has received the knowledge of God;
she is his helper in all he does.

⁵If you desire riches in life,
what is richer than wisdom, who is the cause of all things?

⁶If understanding is effective,
what about wisdom, who designed all things?

⁷And if a person loves righteousness,
wisdom's labors have great virtue,
for she teaches self-control, prudence, justice, and courage—
the most valuable attributes in life.

⁸And if a person desires much knowledge,
wisdom knows the past and foresees the future.
She knows the subtleties of speech and the solutions of riddles.
She foreknows signs and wonders
and the outcome of times and ages yet to come.

⁹So I determined to take wisdom to live with me,

- knowing that she would give me good instruction
and comfort me in my cares and grief.
- ¹⁰Because of her, the multitudes honor me,
and the elders esteem me, though I am young.
- ¹¹I will be found wise in judgment,
and I will be admired by the mighty.
- ¹²They will wait for me when I am silent,
and they will pay attention when I speak.
And if I talk at length,
they will not interrupt me.
- ¹³Because of wisdom I will be immortal;
I will leave an everlasting memory to those who come after
me.
- ¹⁴I will rule the people,
and nations will be subject to me.
- ¹⁵Tyrants will quake when they hear my name;
my people will find that I am good and valiant in war.
- ¹⁶When I go into my home, I will find rest with wisdom,
for companionship with her has no bitterness.
To live with her is to live without pain in joy and gladness.

A Prayer for Wisdom

- ¹⁷I pondered these things and weighed them in my mind—
that associating with wisdom brings immortality,
¹⁸that her friendship is pure delight,
that her activities bring great wealth,
that her companionship brings understanding,
and that a person gains respect by sharing her words.
Then I went about seeking how I might get wisdom for myself.
- ¹⁹I was born a gifted child,
and I was naturally good.

²⁰Better yet, since I was good,
I was given an undefiled body.

²¹But I knew I could not possess wisdom unless God gave her to
me.

It was a sign of intelligence that I knew who had given me
wisdom.

So I went to the Lord and pleaded with him.

With my whole heart I said:

9



God of my ancestors and Lord of mercy,
you have made all things by your word.

²In your wisdom you formed people
to be masters over the creatures you made,
³to rule the world in holiness and justice,
and to pronounce judgment with a righteous heart.

⁴Give me the wisdom that sits by your throne,
and do not exclude me from being one of your servants.

⁵For I am your servant and the son of your servant girl,
a weak man with a short life
and little understanding of justice and laws.

⁶Even if there were a perfect human being,
without wisdom he would be regarded as nothing.

⁷You have chosen me to be king of your people
and judge over your sons and daughters.

⁸You told me to build a Temple on your holy mountain
and an altar in the city of your dwelling place—
a copy of the holy Tabernacle you prepared from the begin-
ning.

⁹Wisdom, who resides with you, knows your works;
she was present when you made the world.
She knows what is pleasant in your sight

- and what is right according to your commandments.
- ¹⁰Send her out from your holy heaven
and from the throne of your glory
so that she may work with me
and teach me what is pleasing to you.
- ¹¹For wisdom knows and understands all things;
she will guide me wisely in my actions
and guard me with her glory.
- ¹²Then my works will be acceptable,
and I will govern your people justly.
I will be worthy of the throne of my father.
- ¹³For what human being can know the counsel of God?
Who can discern the will of the Lord?
- ¹⁴The thoughts of mortals are fallible,
and our plans are uncertain.
- ¹⁵The mortal body weighs down the soul.
This earthly tent burdens the active mind.
- ¹⁶We can scarcely guess at what is on earth;
we struggle to understand what is within our reach.
So who can search out the things in heaven?
- ¹⁷Who could have known your plan
if you had not given wisdom
and sent your Holy Spirit from above?
- ¹⁸Through them, people on earth were guided on the right path.
The people were taught the things that please you,
and they were saved by wisdom.”

10

The Deeds of Wisdom throughout History



WISDOM protected Adam, the first father of the world,

when he alone had been created.

Wisdom freed him from his sin

²and gave him power to be master over all things.

³But when Cain, an unrighteous man, abandoned wisdom in his anger,

he was destroyed because he murdered his brother in a fit of rage.

⁴When water flooded the earth because of Cain's sin, wisdom saved it again,

steering Noah, a righteous man, by a mere piece of wood.

⁵When the nations were thrown into confusion for planning wicked things together,

wisdom recognized Abraham, a righteous man.

She protected him from sin before God

and gave him strength to be willing to sacrifice his son, whom he loved.

⁶She delivered Lot, a righteous man,

when the wicked were being destroyed.

He escaped the fire that destroyed Sodom and Gomorrah.

⁷Evidence of their wickedness still remains:

a smoking, desolate land,

trees bearing fruit that never ripens,

and a pillar of salt—a monument to Lot's unbelieving wife.

⁸By forsaking wisdom,

the people of those cities failed to recognize good things.

But they also left us a memorial to their foolish actions, so that their failures would always be remembered.

⁹Yet wisdom rescued those who served her.

- ¹⁰When Jacob, a righteous man, fled from his brother's anger,
Wisdom guided him well.
She showed him the kingdom of God
and gave him knowledge of holy things.
She made him successful in his work
and blessed him for his efforts.
- ¹¹While others tried to defraud him,
wisdom stood by him and made him wealthy.
- ¹²She kept him safe from his enemies
and defended him from those who wanted to ambush him.
In his difficult fight she gave him victory,
so that he might know that godliness is more powerful than
anything.
- ¹³Wisdom did not forsake Joseph, a righteous man, when he was
sold
but delivered him from sin.
- ¹⁴She went with him down into the dungeon
and did not abandon him in prison.
In time, she made him the ruler of a kingdom
and gave him authority over those who oppressed him.
Then she exposed his accusers as liars
and gave him everlasting honor.

Wisdom Rescued the Israelites

- ¹⁵Wisdom rescued the Israelites, a holy and blameless people,
from the nations that oppressed them.
- ¹⁶She entered the soul of Moses, a servant of the Lord,
and resisted dreaded kings with wonders and signs.
- ¹⁷She rewarded the holy people for their work

and guided them on an amazing journey.
She was a shelter for them by day
and a starry beacon in the night.
¹⁸She brought them through the Red Sea
and led them through deep waters.
¹⁹But she drowned their enemies
and cast them up from the watery depths.
²⁰Therefore the righteous plundered the wicked.
They sang hymns to your holy name, O Lord,
and together they praised your victorious hand.
²¹For wisdom opened the mouths of the mute
and made the tongues of infants eloquent.

11

The Lord Provided for His People



WISDOM gave his people success under the leadership of Moses,
a holy prophet.
²They traveled through uninhabited desert
and pitched their tents in the frontier.
³They withstood attacks by their enemies
and defended themselves against their adversaries.
⁴When they were thirsty, they called upon you, Lord,
and you gave them water from the sheer rock.
Refreshment for their thirst came from hard stone.
⁵The very things that punished their enemies
became a benefit to the Israelites when they needed help.
⁶Their enemies had only an ever-flowing river polluted with
blood—
⁷their punishment for ordering that the infants be killed.

But you gave the Israelites abundant water from an unexpected source.

⁸So the thirst of the Israelites

reminded them how you had once punished their enemies.

⁹For when they were tested, though only by merciful discipline, they learned how the ungodly were judged in anger and tormented.

¹⁰For you tested the Israelites as a father warns his children, but you examined and condemned the others like a stern king.

The Wicked Were Punished

¹¹For whether they were at home or abroad, the ungodly were equally distressed.

¹²They were doubly grieved and groaned at the memory of what had happened.

¹³For when the ungodly heard that their punishments benefited the righteous, they recognized that the Lord had caused these things to happen.

¹⁴They had scorned and rejected Moses, whom they had cast out as a child much earlier and left to die. But in the end they were amazed at him, for they were thirsty in a different way than the righteous.

¹⁵But the foolish and evil thoughts of the ungodly deceived them to worship irrational serpents and worthless animals.

In return, you sent hordes of irrational animals to punish them.

¹⁶This was done to teach them that people are punished by the very sins they commit.

- ¹⁷For your almighty hand,
 which created the world out of formless matter,
was able to send upon the ungodly
 many bears or fierce lions,
¹⁸or newly created, unknown beasts filled with rage,
 breathing out fiery breath,
 belching forth acrid smoke,
 and flashing terrible sparks from their eyes.
¹⁹Not only could these savage beasts destroy people,
 but the very sight of them could scare people to death.
²⁰Even besides these animals, people could be killed by a single
 breath of the Lord,
 when they are pursued by justice and scattered by the breath
 of your power.
But you have arranged all things by measure, number, and weight.
²¹For you are always able to display your great power.
 Who can resist your mighty arm?
²²For the whole world before you is as the smallest grain that tips
 the scales,
 or as a drop of morning dew that lies upon the ground.

The Mercy of the Lord

- ²³But you have mercy on all, because you can do all things;
 you overlook people's sins so that they might repent.
²⁴For you love everything that exists.
 You hate none of the things you have made,
 for you would not have made anything you hated.
²⁵And how could anything last if you had not wanted it?
 How could it endure if you had not called it into being?
²⁶But you spare all things because they are yours,
 O Lord, who loves everything that lives.

12



OR your immortal spirit is in everything.
Therefore, little by little you correct those who disobey,
and you warn them about the way they are sinning.
You do this so they will be freed from their wickedness
and trust in you, O Lord.

- ³Those Canaanites who lived long ago in your holy land
⁴were hated by you because of their detestable practices,
their sorceries, and their wicked rituals.
⁵They mercilessly slaughtered their own children
and feasted on sacrifices of human flesh and blood during their
pagan rituals.
⁶You told our ancestors to destroy
those parents who sacrificed innocent lives,
⁷for you wanted the land most dear to you
to receive a worthy colony of God's servants.
⁸Yet you spared even these Canaanites, since they were merely
human beings,
but you sent hornets as forerunners of your army,
to destroy them little by little.
⁹You could have handed over the wicked to the righteous by means
of war
or destroyed them in one fell swoop by fearsome animals or
your stern word.
¹⁰But you judged them little by little to give them a chance to
repent,
although you knew that they were evil by nature
and that their way of thinking would never change.
¹¹The Canaanites were a cursed race from the beginning.
It was your kindness, not fear of anyone, that you did not
punish them for their sins.

The Justice of the Lord

¹²For who will say to you: “What have you done?”

Or who will challenge your judgment?

Who will accuse you for destroying the nations you have made?

Or who will face you to avenge the death of the unrighteous?

¹³For there is no other God but you, and you care for all,
proving that you have not judged unjustly.

¹⁴No king or ruler can confront you
about those you have punished.

¹⁵You are righteous, and you rule over all things righteously.
You consider it uncharacteristic of your power
to condemn anyone who does not deserve to be punished.

¹⁶Your strength is the source of righteousness;
because you rule over all, you are gracious to all.

¹⁷You show your strength when people doubt your absolute
power,
and you rebuke those who do believe in your power but are
arrogant.

¹⁸Although you are sovereign in strength, you judge mildly,
and you govern us leniently,
for your power is at hand when you choose to use it.

¹⁹In this way you have taught your people
that the righteous must be kind.

You have given your children good reason for hope
because you make room for repentance of sins.

²⁰After showing great care and leniency, you finally punished
your servants’ enemies, who deserved to die.

You had given them time and opportunity to repent of their
wickedness.

²¹So you have judged your own children even more strictly,

for you swore oaths and covenants of good promises to their ancestors.

²²Therefore, while you merely discipline us,
you punish our enemies ten thousand times more,
so that when we judge others, we may keep your goodness in
mind,
and when we are judged, we may hope for mercy.

²³So those who foolishly live unrighteous lives
are tormented by you through their own sins.

²⁴For the Egyptians strayed far down the path of error
and worshiped the most despised animals;
they were deceived like foolish children.

²⁵Therefore, as with senseless children,
you punished them in a way that made them look ridiculous.

²⁶But those who do not heed gentle warnings
experience the just punishment of God.

²⁷The Egyptians became angry because they suffered
and were punished by the very animals they considered gods.
So they realized and confessed that the One they had formerly
rejected was the true God.
For this reason they had been completely condemned.

13

The Foolishness of Nature Worship



ALL people who were unaware of God were foolish by nature.
Despite the good things they could see, they were unable to
perceive the God who is,

nor did they recognize the craftsman, though they observe
his works.

²But they imagined that fire or wind or swift air
or the movement of the stars or rushing water
or the heavenly lights are the gods that rule the world.

³If mere beauty caused people to believe these things were gods,
let them know how much more beautiful is their Lord,
for the author of all beauty created these things.

⁴Or if people were amazed by their power and energy,
let them learn from these things how much more powerful is
the One who made them.

⁵For the Creator can be seen and understood
through the greatness and beauty of creation.

⁶But yet such people should not be blamed very harshly,
for perhaps they went astray while seeking God and desiring
to find him.

⁷For they are familiar with his works and search diligently,
but they fall victim to mere appearances, for the things they
see are beautiful.

⁸But even so, they are not to be excused.

⁹For if they know so much
that they can speculate about the world,
how have they been so slow to find the Lord of creation?

The Foolishness of Idolatry

¹⁰But those who set their hopes on dead things are miserable.
They worship “gods” made by human beings—
works of gold and silver skillfully shaped to resemble animals,
or useless stone, the work of someone long ago.

¹¹A skilled woodcarver cuts down a suitable tree
and deftly strips off all the bark.

Then with admirable precision

he forms a bowl that is useful in daily life.

¹²He burns the fallen chips from his work

to heat his food so that he can eat his fill.

¹³But one stick is left over, seemingly good for nothing,

since it is crooked and full of knots.

This he carefully carves in his spare time.

With leisurely skill he fashions it;

he gives it the shape of a human

¹⁴or of some worthless animal.

He coats it with crimson paint and colors it red,

covering every blemish with paint.

¹⁵Then he makes a special place to put it

and sets it in a wall, fastening it with iron.

¹⁶He must take care of it so it doesn't fall

because he knows it cannot help itself;

it is only an image and needs his help.

¹⁷But then he prays to it about his possessions, his marriage, or

his children;

he is not ashamed to speak to a lifeless object.

For health, he appeals to a thing that has no strength;

¹⁸for life, he prays to a thing that is dead;

for help, he calls upon a thing that is completely helpless;

for a successful journey, he petitions a thing that cannot take
a single step;

¹⁹for money, work, and success in business

he asks for strength from a thing that is unable to help itself.

14

Trust in God, Not Idols



GAIN, a person preparing to set sail on a voyage over raging waves

calls upon a piece of wood more fragile than the ship that carries him.

²For it was the desire for profit that planned the vessel,
and wisdom was the craftsmen who built it.

³But it is steered by your providence, O Father,
for you have made a path for it even in the sea,
and a safe way over the waves.

⁴This shows that you can save people from every danger,
so that even an inexperienced person can make a sea voyage.

⁵For you want people to use the objects produced through your wisdom.

So people trust their lives even to the smallest piece of wood;
they pass over the waves on a raft and arrive safely on land.

⁶Even from the beginning, when the proud giants were being destroyed,

Noah, the hope of the world, took refuge on a raft,
and you led him to produce a new human race.

⁷For blessed is the wooden object by which righteousness comes.

⁸But the idol that is made by hands is cursed,
and so is the one who made it.

The person is cursed because he made the idol,
and the perishable idol is cursed because it is called a god.

⁹For equally hateful to God are the wicked and their wicked deeds.

¹⁰Both the thing that was made and the one who made it will be punished.

- ¹¹Therefore, pagan idols will be condemned
because they have become a terrible sin, even though they
belong to God's creation.
They are snares for human souls,
and a trap for the feet of the foolish.

The Origin of Idolatry

- ¹²Immorality came about when idols were first made,
and life was corrupted by their invention.
¹³They did not exist from the beginning,
nor will they last forever.
¹⁴Futile thinking brought them into the world,
and swift destruction is planned for them.
- ¹⁵For a father, mourning the untimely death of his child,
made an image of the child who had been suddenly snatched
from him.
He then worshiped as a god the image of a corpse
and devised secret rites and initiations for his household.
¹⁶The wicked custom became established over time and was re-
garded as a law.
Carved images of tyrants were worshiped at their command.
¹⁷Some people could not honor the rulers in person since they
lived far away.
So they imagined what the rulers looked like
and made a visible image of the king they wished to honor.
They did this to flatter the king as though he were present.
- ¹⁸Then even those who did not know the king

were spurred on to worship him—all because of the artisan's ambition.

- ¹⁹For he, perhaps wishing to please his ruler,
labored with all his skill to make the likeness even more beautiful than the actual person.
- ²⁰Then the masses, carried away by the beauty of the work,
decided to worship the one they had honored as a mere mortal
just a short time before.
- ²¹And this became a trap for people;
in their bondage to misfortune or tyranny,
they gave objects of stone or wood the name “God”—
a name that is not to be shared with others.

The Evils of Idolatry

- ²²It was not enough for them to hold misconceptions about God.
They also live in great conflict due to ignorance,
and they call such evils peace.
- ²³For they kill children in their initiation rituals and celebrate
secret mysteries;
they hold frenzied orgies with strange practices.
- ²⁴They keep neither their own lives nor their marriages pure,
for they treacherously kill each other or harm each other by
adultery.
- ²⁵Everything is chaos—
blood and murder, theft and deceit,
corruption, unfaithfulness, riots, lying,
- ²⁶confusion over what is good, neglect of favors,
corruption of souls, sexual perversion,
disorder in marriages, adultery, and shameless living.
- ²⁷For the worship of nameless idols is the source and cause and
result of every evil.

- ²⁸The worshipers become intoxicated with festivity,
or they prophesy lies, live wicked lives, or readily break oaths.
- ²⁹Because they trust in lifeless idols,
they swear falsely and expect to suffer no harm for it.
- ³⁰But for two things they will be justly punished:
because they misunderstood God when they worshiped idols,
and because they made false oaths since they despised what is
holy.
- ³¹For the wicked and their sins are pursued
not by the power of the things by which people swear
but by the just punishment of sinners.

15

Worship of the True God

- UT you, our God, are kind and true—
a patient and merciful ruler over all things.
- ²Even if we sin, we are still yours and acknowledge your power.
But we will not sin, because we know that you acknowledge
us as your own.
- ³For perfect righteousness comes from knowing you,
and knowledge of your power is the root of immortality.
- ⁴The evil intent of human art has not deceived us,
nor has the fruitless work of painters—
a statue stained with various colors.
- ⁵The appearance of such works excites fools
and causes them to desire the lifeless form of a dead image.
- ⁶Those who make or desire or worship such idols
love evil things and deserve no better hope
than that offered by the idols.

More Examples of Foolish Idolatry

- ⁷The potter works the soft clay
and laboriously shapes each piece of pottery for our use.
From the same clay he makes some pots for clean uses
and some for unclean uses.
They are all made alike,
and the potter decides how each will be used.
- ⁸He then wastes his time by making a useless god from the same
clay,
though he himself, only a short time before, was also made
from earth.
After a little while he will return to the earth from which he
came,
when he is asked to return the life that was lent to him.
- ⁹But he is not concerned that he will die one day or that his life is
short.
Instead, he competes with the goldsmiths and silversmiths
and imitates the bronzeworkers.
He takes pride in fashioning counterfeit gods.
- ¹⁰His heart is ashes, his hope is worth less than dirt,
and his life is of less value than clay.
- ¹¹For he did not know the One who formed him,
who infused him with an active soul
and breathed into him a living spirit.
- ¹²He considered our existence to be a meaningless game
and life merely a festival for making profit.
He says people must make money however they can—even by
evil means.
- ¹³Yet this man, above all others, knows that he sins
when he makes fragile pots and carved images from earthly
clay.

- ¹⁴But those who are most foolish and more miserable than infants
are the enemies who oppress your people.
- ¹⁵They thought all their pagan idols were gods,
though these idols have no eyes for seeing,
nor noses for breathing,
nor ears for hearing,
nor fingers for grasping.
Even their feet are useless for walking.
- ¹⁶They were made by a human being;
they were formed by someone whose own life is borrowed.
People cannot make true gods that are like themselves,
¹⁷for people are mortal and can form only dead things with
their wicked hands.
- They are better than the objects they worship,
for they, at least, are alive; the idols will never live.

The Plagues of Small Animals

- ¹⁸These people worship even the most detestable creatures,
which are worse than all others because they lack intelligence.
- ¹⁹In comparison to other animals, they are not beautiful or desirable.
- They were excluded both from the praise and blessing of God.

16



HEREFORE the Egyptians were rightly punished by such creatures;

they were tormented by a great number of animals.

- ²But instead of punishing your people in this way, you showed them kindness.

You sent a delicacy to satisfy their hungry appetites—
quail for them to eat.

³You did this so that when the Egyptians wanted food,
they would think of the repulsive creatures you sent
and would lose their appetites.

But your people, after going hungry for a short time, would eat
delicacies.

⁴The Egyptian oppressors had to be made permanently needy,
but your people only had to see their enemies being tormented.

⁵When your people were attacked by raging wild animals
and were being destroyed by the bites of writhing serpents,
you did not stay angry until they were completely destroyed.

⁶They were troubled for a short time as a warning,
but they received a symbol of deliverance to remind them of
your law's commandment.

⁷Anyone who turned toward it was healed, not by the visible
object,
but by you, the Savior of all.

⁸And by this you showed our enemies
that you are the one who rescues from every evil.

⁹They were killed by the bites of locusts and flies,
for there was no remedy to save them;
they deserved to be punished by such things.

¹⁰But not even the fangs of venomous serpents overcame your
children,
for your mercy came to their aid and healed them.

¹¹They were bitten to remind them of your words,
and then they were quickly rescued
so that they would not completely forget
and become unresponsive to your kindness.

- ¹²For neither herb nor ointment healed them;
it is your word, O Lord, that heals all things.
- ¹³You have power over life and death.
You take people down to the gates of death and bring them
back again.
- ¹⁴A person who maliciously kills another
cannot bring back the departed spirit
or release the soul that has been captured by death.
- ¹⁵It is impossible to escape your hand.
- ¹⁶The wicked Egyptians who refused to acknowledge you
were flogged by your strong arm.
They were pursued by extraordinary rains, hail, and relentless
storms
and completely consumed by fire.
- ¹⁷Most incredible of all was that the fire was even more effective
in water, which normally extinguishes everything,
for the universe fights for the righteous.
- ¹⁸At one point the fire died down
so that the creatures sent against the wicked would not be
burned.
Then the people could see and understand
that they were pursued by God's judgment.
- ¹⁹And at another point, the fire burned in the rain even hotter
than it is naturally able,
in order to destroy the crops of a wicked land.

Rewards for True Worship

- ²⁰Instead of these punishments, you fed your people with manna,
the food of angels.

Without their help you prepared bread from heaven for your people,
and everything it contained was delicious and tasty to everyone.

²¹The food you gave your children showed your sweetness toward them.

The bread satisfied everyone who ate it
and changed to suit each person's taste.

²²Snow and ice resisted fire without melting,
so your people would see that their enemies' crops
were being destroyed by the fire that burned in the hail
and flashed in the rain.

²³But this same fire forgot the limits of its own power
in order that the righteous might be nourished.

²⁴For creation serves you, the Creator,
and strives to punish the wicked,
but it relaxes for the benefit of those who trust in you.

²⁵Therefore, even creation changed into all sorts of forms
and was obedient to your generosity, which nourished all people
according to their needs and desires.

²⁶This happened, O Lord, so that your beloved children might learn
that it is not by crops that people are nourished
but by your word, which sustains those who trust in you.

²⁷The manna that was not destroyed by fire
melted after being warmed by a passing ray from the sun.

²⁸So the people learned that they must rise before dawn to give
you thanks
and pray to you at daybreak.

²⁹For the hope of the ungrateful will melt away like a winter frost
and drain away like waste water.

17

The Plague of Darkness



OUR judgments are great and difficult to describe;
so the unlearned have gone astray.

²The wicked Egyptians thought they held the holy nation in
their power,
but they themselves were captives of darkness and prisoners
of unending night.

They were confined under their own roofs and exiled from
eternal providence.

³While they thought their secret sins were concealed
behind a dark curtain of forgetfulness,
they were scattered and terrified;
they were frightened by apparitions.

⁴Not even the most secluded room they hid in protected them
from fear.

Terrifying noises echoed around them
and somber, gloomy-faced phantoms appeared to them.

⁵No fire, no matter how intense, could give them light,
and the bright glow of the stars
were unable to illuminate that gloomy night.

⁶Nothing gave the Egyptians light
except a spontaneous, dreadful flash.
In their fear, they thought they saw things
even worse than the things they had imagined.

⁷The tricks of their magic art were humbled,
and the wisdom they boasted about was scornfully rebuked.

⁸Those who promised to drive away the fears and troubles of a
sick soul

were now sick themselves with ludicrous fear.

⁹No terrible thing actually attacked them,

but they were frightened by hissing serpents and wild animals
passing by.

¹⁰The Egyptians died of fright

as they futilely tried even to ignore the very air around them.

¹¹For wickedness is cowardly and condemns itself

because a troubled conscience always assumes the worst.

¹²Fear is nothing but the surrender of assistance from reason.

¹³And after hope has been defeated within,

people imagine the cause of their torment to be worse than it
actually is.

¹⁴That terrifying night was really powerless,

since it came from the powerless place of the dead,

but the Egyptians all slept in terror.

¹⁵They were chased by monstrous apparitions,

yet they were also paralyzed by their fainting souls,

for sudden and unexpected fear overwhelmed them.

¹⁶People everywhere fell down

and were shut up in a prison without bars.

¹⁷Whether they were farmers or shepherds

or people working in the desert,

they were suddenly snatched up and suffered an inescapable fate.

They were all bound together with a chain of darkness.

¹⁸Whether it was the whistling wind,

or the melodious sound of birds in the trees,

or the steady noise of rushing water,

¹⁹or the mighty crash of rocks hurled down,

or the sound of animals running along unseen,

or the roar of the most savage beasts,

or an echo rebounding from a mountain hollow—

the noise paralyzed them with fear.

²⁰The rest of the world was illumined with bright light,

and people went about their work unhindered.

²¹But a dark night descended upon the Egyptians alone,

an image of another darkness that would one day come upon them.

Yet more heavy than this darkness was the burden they were to themselves.

18

The Pillar of Light



OUR holy ones, however, saw a bright light;
the Egyptians heard their voices but could not see them.

They realized that your holy ones were happy because they did not suffer the same things.

²They were thankful that your people did not repay them for past injuries.

They asked forgiveness for past conflicts.

³Therefore, you sent a flaming pillar of fire
to guide your people on an unknown journey.

It acted as a harmless sun for their celebrated wandering.

⁴The Egyptians deserved to be deprived of light and imprisoned
in darkness,

for they had imprisoned your children,
through whom the unfading light of the law would be given
to the world.

The Plague upon the Firstborn

⁵When the Egyptians decided to kill the infants of your holy ones,
one child, Moses, was abandoned and then rescued.

You punished them by taking away many of their children.

Then you destroyed them all at once in a mighty flood.

⁶You had warned our ancestors ahead of time about that night,
so they might rejoice and know that your promise could be
trusted.

⁷Your people expected to see
the salvation of the righteous and the destruction of their
enemies.

⁸You used this event to punish our adversaries
and also call us to yourself and bring us glory.

⁹For during this time, the holy children of good people secretly
offered sacrifices
and unanimously agreed upon this divine institution of
Passover.

In this way they would share in good things and dangers alike
while already singing the praises of the ancestors.

¹⁰But the discordant cry of their enemies echoed back,
and a mournful lament for their children sounded throughout
the land.

¹¹The slave suffered the same punishment as the master,
and commoners experienced the same loss as the king.

¹²By the death of the firstborn, they all
had countless dead.

There were not enough living to bury the dead,
for in one moment their most favored children were destroyed.

¹³Earlier, they would not have believed this could happen,
for they trusted in their magic arts.

But when their firstborn were destroyed,
they acknowledged your people to be God's child.

¹⁴While all things were wrapped in utter silence
and the night was halfway through its swift course,

¹⁵your almighty word leaped down from your royal throne in
heaven

and entered the doomed land like a fierce warrior.

¹⁶Carrying the sharp sword of your unchanging command,

it stood and spread death everywhere.

While standing on earth it reached to heaven.

¹⁷ Apparitions in horrible dreams terrified the people,
and unexpected fears came over them.

¹⁸ As people everywhere were hurled to the ground half dead,
they testified as to the reason they were dying.

¹⁹ For their nightmares had forewarned them about this,
so that they would not die without knowing why they suffered.

God Punished His People

²⁰ But even the righteous experienced death.

In the desert you struck the people with a plague.

But your wrath did not continue long,

²¹ for Aaron, a blameless man, hurried to the people's defense.

Bringing forth the shield of his ministry—

prayer and incense that satisfies you—

he withstood your wrath and put an end to the disaster.

This showed that he was your servant.

²² He overcame the destruction,

but not by physical strength or force of arms;

with a word he subdued the one who punished them,

invoking the oaths and covenants given to our ancestors.

²³ After the dead had fallen on one another in heaps,

Aaron intervened and stopped the wrath,

cutting off its access to the living.

²⁴ On his long robe the whole world was depicted,

and the glories of the ancestors were engraved on the four rows
of stones on his ephod.

Your majesty was written on the diadem, the turban on his head.

²⁵ To these the destroyer yielded for he feared them.

This single test of wrath was enough.

19

God Destroyed the Egyptians

BUT the wicked Egyptians were assailed with merciless wrath
to the very end,

for God knew in advance what they would do.

²He knew that they would let your people leave
and anxiously send them on their way,
but he also knew they would change their minds and pursue
your people.

³While the Egyptians were still mourning
and lamenting at the graves of their dead,
they reached another foolish decision
and pursued the very ones they had urged to leave.

⁴Their well-deserved fate led them to this end,
causing them to forget all that had happened
so they would complete their torments with one final punish-
ment.

⁵Then your people could experience an amazing journey,
but the Egyptians would meet an extraordinary death.

Nature Obeyed God's Commands

⁶All creation had its very nature recreated
in obedience to your commands,
so that your servants might be protected from harm.

⁷A cloud overshadowed their camp,
and dry land appeared where water had stood before.

This provided a clear path through the Red Sea—
a grassy plain instead of raging waves.

- ⁸The whole nation passed through under your protection
after they had witnessed amazing miracles.
- ⁹They ranged like horses and skipped like lambs,
praising you, O Lord, who had delivered them.
- ¹⁰They still remembered what had happened while they were
living in Egypt as foreigners—
how the ground brought forth flies instead of animals
and the river teemed with vast numbers of frogs instead of
fish.
- ¹¹Later they saw a new kind of bird
when their cravings led them to ask for delicacies.
- ¹²To satisfy their desires, quail came to them from the sea.
- ¹³Punishments came upon the sinners,
but not without prior signs from crashing thunder.
They suffered justly because of their wicked deeds,
for they had shown more hatred of strangers than even the
residents of Sodom had shown.
- ¹⁴The residents of Sodom refused to welcome strangers when
they arrived,
but the Egyptians made slaves of guests who had served them
well.
- ¹⁵And besides this, while the residents of Sodom will receive some
sort of punishment
for being hostile toward strangers,
- ¹⁶the Egyptians were worse, for first they welcomed the strangers
with a celebration,
but then they enslaved the very people they had first received
with joy.
They harshly afflicted them even though they shared the same
rights.
- ¹⁷The Egyptians were struck with blindness,
like those at the door of Lot, the righteous man.

They were surrounded by deep darkness
and groped to find the door to their own house.

¹⁸For the elements changed places with each other,
just as on a harp the tune is varied by rearranging the notes,
yet each note keeps its same sound.

This may be clearly deduced by looking at what happened.

¹⁹Land animals were turned into water creatures,
and creatures that swim walked on land.

²⁰Fire kept its normal power even in water,
and water forgot its fire-quenching nature.

²¹But the flames did not consume the flesh
of perishable animals that walked through the fire.

Nor did the flames melt the manna—that heavenly food that
melts as easily as ice.

²²For in all things, O Lord, you have exalted and glorified your
people.

You have never failed to help them at any time or place.

Preface to the Book of Tobit

Martin Luther, 1534



HAT was said about the book of Judith may also be said about this book of Tobit. If the events really happened, then it is a fine and holy history. But if they are all made up, then it is indeed a very beautiful, wholesome, and useful fiction or drama by a gifted poet. It may even be assumed that beautiful compositions and plays like this were common among the Jews. On their festivals and sabbaths they steeped themselves in them; and through them, especially in times of peace and good government, they liked to instill God's Word and work into their young people. For they had outstanding people—prophets, bards, poets, and the like—who in all sorts of ways diligently set forth the Word of God.

It may even be that the Greeks picked up from the Jews their art of presenting comedies and tragedies, as well as a lot of other wisdom and worship, etc. For Judith presents a good, serious, heroic tragedy, and Tobit presents a fine, delightful, devout comedy. The book of Judith shows how a land and people may often fare miserably, and how the tyrants who rave proudly in the beginning end in disgraceful ruin. Similarly, the book of Tobit shows how things may go badly with a pious peasant or townsman, and there may be much suffering in married life, yet God always graciously helps and finally crowns the outcome with joy, in order that married folk should learn to have patience and, in a genuine fear of God and firm faith, put up gladly with all sorts of hardships because they have hope.

Now the Greek version almost looks as though it had been a play. For Tobit [1:1–3:6] speaks of everything in the first person, just as characters in a drama customarily do. Afterward some writer came along and cast the drama in the form of a regular discourse. The

names also bear this out very well. For Tobit signifies a righteous man; and he begets another “Tobit.” He has to live in peril and anxiety because of both the tyrants and his own neighbors. In addition (that no misfortune should be alone), he becomes blind. Finally, he falls out with his dear wife Anna, sends their son away, and life becomes miserable. But Tobit remains steadfast in faith, patience, and good works. Anna signifies amiable, that is, a dear housewife who lives in love and friendship with her husband. The demon Asmodeus signifies destroyer or spoiler, that is, the domestic demon who obstructs and spoils everything, so that one can no longer get along with the children or the rest of the household. Sarah means a champion or victor, one who wins, comes out on top, triumphs. The archangel Raphael, i.e., physician or healer, is here also and calls himself Azarias, i.e., helper or aid, son of the great Azarias, in other words an aid, emissary, or messenger of the Most High God. For God helps keep the home, and stands by married folk; else they would never have a chance against Asmodeus.

Therefore this book is useful and good for us Christians to read. It is the work of a fine Hebrew author who deals not with trivial but important issues, and whose writing and concerns are extraordinarily Christian. It is appropriate that the book of Jesus Sirach should follow a work such as this. For this next book is for the common man and housefather a true teacher and comforter in all things. And Tobit is an illustration of just such a book.

Tobit

1

 HIS is the story of Tobit son of Tobiel, son of Hananiel, son of Aduel, son of Gabael. He belonged to the family of Asiel of the tribe of Naphtali. ²During the reign of Shalmaneser, king of Assyria, Tobit was taken into captivity from Thisbe, which is south of Kedesh Naphtali in Upper Galilee, above Asher toward the west, and north of Phogor.

Tobit's Youth

³I, Tobit, have tried to live a life of truth and justice. I performed many good deeds not only for my relatives but also for other captives who were with me in the city of Nineveh in Assyria. ⁴When I was a young man in my own country of Israel, the entire tribe of my ancestor Naphtali deserted the king who sat on the throne of David. They also deserted Jerusalem, the city where the Temple, God's dwelling place, was built and dedicated as a holy place for all generations forever. All the tribes of Israel had been instructed to offer their sacrifices in Jerusalem. ⁵Instead, my relatives and the entire tribe of Naphtali offered sacrifices on all the mountains of Galilee to the calf that King Jeroboam of Israel had made in Dan.

⁶So I alone went to Jerusalem for the frequent festivals, as all Israel was commanded to do. I would bring with me the first crops of the harvest, the firstborn of my flocks, the first wool from the sheep, and a tenth of my income. ⁷I would give these to the priests, Aaron's descendants, as a sacrifice. In addition, I would give tithes of grain, wine, olive oil, pomegranates, figs, and other fruits to the Levites who were on duty in Jerusalem. Also, I would save a second tithe for six years and would distribute it in Jerusalem. ⁸Then every third year I would give a third tithe to orphans, widows, and those who had converted to Judaism, and we would eat a feast as required by the law of Moses. We also followed the instructions given by my father's

mother, Deborah, who raised me after my father, Tobiel, died and left me an orphan.

⁹When I came of age, I married Anna, a relative of mine, and we had a son, whom I named Tobiah.

Captivity in Nineveh

¹⁰After I was taken captive to Nineveh in Assyria, all my relatives and people ate Gentile food, ¹¹but I refused to eat any such food. ¹²And because I obeyed God with all my heart, ¹³the Most High brought me to the attention of King Shalmaneser, who made me his purchasing agent. ¹⁴As long as the king lived, I went frequently to Media to buy supplies. One time I left 750 pounds of silver in the care of my relative Gabael, the brother of Gabri. ¹⁵When Shalmaneser died and his son Sennacherib became king, the roads to Media were difficult to travel.

¹⁶During the reign of Shalmaneser, I was able to do many good deeds for my relatives and my people. ¹⁷I shared my food with the hungry and clothed the naked. Whenever I saw the dead body of one of my people thrown outside the walls of Nineveh, I would bury it. ¹⁸One time Sennacherib had to retreat from Judea because the King of heaven was punishing him for speaking blasphemous things. In his anger Sennacherib put to death many of the captives from Judea, but I stole the bodies and buried them secretly. When Sennacherib looked for the bodies, he could not find them. ¹⁹One day someone from Nineveh told the king what I was doing. When I realized that the king knew all about me and wanted to put me to death, I became afraid and fled for my life. ²⁰All my property was taken from me and put in the royal treasury. All that was left to me was my wife, Anna, and my son, Tobiah.

²¹But less than forty days later the king was murdered by two of his sons, who escaped into the mountains of Ararat. He was succeeded by his son Esarhaddon, who appointed my nephew Ahikar (my brother Hanael's son) to be his chief accountant and administra-

tor. ²² Ahikar put in a good word for me, and I was able to return to Nineveh. (Ahikar had been Sennacherib's chief cup-bearer, guardian of the king's seal, administrator, and treasurer. When Esarhaddon became king, he reappointed Ahikar to office. As I said, Ahikar was my nephew, and so he was a close relative.)

2

So when Esarhaddon became king, I returned home to live with my wife, Anna, and my son, Tobiah. It was Pentecost, the Festival of Harvest, and a fine dinner was prepared for me. ²When I saw all the food laid out on the table, I said to Tobiah, "My dear son, go and find a poor, sincere worshiper from among the Israelite captives here in Nineveh. Bring him home to share this dinner, and we will wait until you come back."

³Tobiah had hardly left when he returned. "Father!" he exclaimed. "What is it, my son?" I replied.

Tobiah said, "One of our people has been strangled, and his body was dumped in the marketplace!"

⁴I hurried from the table without touching my food and found the body. I carried it back from the public square and put it in an outbuilding until I could bury it after sunset. ⁵Then I returned to my own house, washed myself, and ate my meal in sorrow. ⁶As I ate, I thought of the prophecy of Amos against Bethel:

*"I will turn your celebrations into times of mourning,
and your songs of joy will be turned to weeping."*

Then I wept.

Tobit Becomes Blind

⁷At sunset I dug a grave and buried the dead man. ⁸But my neighbors ridiculed me: “Will he never learn? He had to run away the last time he did such a thing, and here he is burying the dead again!”

⁹That same night I washed myself and went to bed along the inside wall of the courtyard. Because it was a hot night, I left my face uncovered. ¹⁰I did not know there were sparrows on the wall until their droppings fell into my eyes, causing cataracts. I went to the doctors to be healed, but the more they treated me with ointments, the worse my vision became. Finally, I was totally blind. I remained blind for four years. During this time my relatives grieved for me, and my nephew Ahikar took care of me for two years until he went to Elymais in Persia.

¹¹My wife, Anna, supported us by making cloth. ¹²Each time she delivered to her employers what she had made, they paid her. On a certain day in late winter, she finished a piece of work and took it to her employers. When they paid her in full for the cloth, they also gave her a young goat from their herd. ¹³As soon as she returned home, the goat began to bleat. I called out to her, “Where did you get that goat? You didn’t steal it, did you? Give it back to its owners, for we cannot eat stolen food.”

¹⁴She replied, “It was given to me as a bonus over and above what I earned.” But I did not believe her. I became angry and told her to take the goat back. She answered, “And you’re supposed to be a man of charity and righteous deeds! Now your true character is coming out!”

3

Tobit Prays for Death



was struck with grief over my actions. I groaned and wept, and in my sadness I began to pray.

²“You are just, O Lord,
and all your deeds are right.
Your ways are merciful and true.
You judge the world.
³Remember me, Lord,
and look upon me with kindness.
Do not punish me for my sins,
both known and unknown,
or for the sins of my ancestors.
They sinned against you
⁴and disobeyed your commandments.
So you gave us up to be plundered, captured, and killed.
We became a laughingstock and an object of scorn and derision
when you scattered us among the nations.
⁵I admit the justice of your many judgments;
you are completely right to punish my sins
and the sins of my ancestors.
For we have not kept your commandments,
and we have not walked in your way of truth.
⁶Now deal with me as you please.
Command that my spirit be taken from me
so that I may die and become dust.
It is better that I should die than live,
because I have had to endure undeserved insults and lies,
and I am overwhelmed with grief.
O Lord, command that I be freed of this misery
so that I can go to my everlasting home.
O Lord, do not turn your face from me.
It is better for me to die
than to experience so much anguish in my life
and to hear insults.”

Sarah Falsely Accused

⁷On the very same day, at Ecbatana in Media, Sarah, the daughter of Raguel, was insulted by one of her father's servant girls. ⁸Sarah had been married to seven husbands, each of whom had been killed by the evil demon Asmodeus before any of the marriages had been consummated. The servant said to her, "You are the one who kills your husbands. You have already had seven husbands and no children from any of them. ⁹Why do you punish us? Because your husbands died? Go with them! We never want to see a son or daughter of yours!"

Sarah Asks for Death

¹⁰Sarah was in deep anguish because of these insults. She went upstairs in tears, intending to hang herself. But she thought about it again and said, "People would reproach my father and say, 'Your only beloved daughter killed herself because of her troubles.' And I would bring my father in his old age down to his grave in sorrow. It is better for me not to hang myself but to pray to the Lord to let me die. Then I won't have to hear these insults anymore." ¹¹So she spread out her hands at the window and prayed:

"I praise you, God of mercy.

I praise your name forever.

May all your creation praise you forever.

¹²To you, O Lord, I turn my face
and lift my eyes.

¹³Command that I be allowed to die,
never more to hear insults.

¹⁴You know, O Master, that I am innocent
of any impurity with a man.

¹⁵I have disgraced neither my name

nor the name of my father in this land of captivity.
I am my father's only child;
there is no one else to be his heir.
My father has no relatives
I can marry.
Seven husbands of mine have already died—
so why should I live?
But if you do not want to take my life, O Lord,
at least hear me concerning these insults.”

Answers to Prayer

¹⁶At that very moment, the prayers of both Sarah and Tobit were heard in the glorious presence of God. ¹⁷Raphael was sent to answer their prayers for healing. He was going to heal Tobit's eyes so that he might once again see God's light. He also would arrange the marriage of Sarah, the daughter of Raguel, to Tobiah son of Tobit and would free Sarah from the demon Asmodeus. For Tobiah, more than anyone else who wanted her, was entitled to marry her. Tobit returned from the courtyard into his house at the same moment that Sarah came down from the upper room.

4

Tobit Instructs Tobiah his Son



THAT same day Tobit remembered the money he had entrusted to Gabael's care at Rages in Media. ²He said to himself, “Since I have prayed for death, why shouldn't I tell my son, Tobiah, about this money before I die?”

³So Tobit called for Tobiah and said to him, “My son, give me a proper burial when I die. Honor your mother and care for her as long as she lives. Do what will please her and do nothing to make her sad.

⁴Remember, my dear son, that she went through many dangers for you while you were still in her womb. When she dies, bury her beside me in the same plot.

⁵“Remember the Lord every day of your life. Never sin deliberately or break his commandments. As long as you live, do what is right and never take part in wrongdoing. ⁶For those who live in the truth will succeed in all they do. To those who live righteous lives, ⁷give generously from your possessions. But don’t give a gift grudgingly. If you do not ignore the poor, God will not ignore you. ⁸Let your giving be in proportion to your possessions. If you have great wealth, give a generous amount. If you have few possessions, give from that little. ⁹In this way you will store up a great treasure for a time of need. ¹⁰For giving to people in need frees people from death and keeps them from going down into darkness. ¹¹Giving to charity is a pleasing sacrifice to the Most High.

¹²“My dear son, be on your guard against all sexual immorality. It is important that you take a wife from your own tribe. Do not marry a foreign woman, for we are descendants of the prophets. My son, remember the example of Noah, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, our ancestors who took wives from among their relatives. They were blessed by the lives of their children, whose descendants will inherit their land. ¹³Be like them, my son; love your relatives. Do not proudly think you are better than your relatives, and do not hesitate to take a wife from your own tribe. Pride is the source of ruin and confusion. Idleness will result in famine.

¹⁴“Pay your workers each day; don’t make them wait until the next day to receive their wages. If you serve God, you will be rewarded. Watch yourself, my son, in everything you do, and be disciplined in all your conduct. ¹⁵Don’t do to others what you would hate to have them do to you. Don’t drink too much wine or let drunkenness become a way of life. ¹⁶Give food to the hungry and clothing to the poor. Don’t hesitate to give away your surplus to people in need. ¹⁷Place bread on the tombs of the just, but give nothing to sinners.

¹⁸“Seek the counsel of every wise person, and do not reject useful advice. ¹⁹Bless the Lord God at every opportunity. Ask him to keep you on a straight path so that you will be successful in everything you do. The nations don’t understand these things. It is the Lord who gives them good counsel, but if the Lord decides otherwise, he can bring them down to the grave. So now remember these commands, my son, and never let them be erased from your heart.

²⁰“Now, my son, I want to tell you that I have left 750 pounds of silver in the care of Gabael son of Gabri at Rages in Media. ²¹Do not be anxious, my son, that we have become poor. You will have great wealth if you fear God, run from every sin, and do what is right in the sight of the Lord your God.”

5

Raphael the Angel



THEN Tobiah said to his father, “I will do everything you have told me. ²But how will I get your money from him, since I do not know him and he does not know me? What proof should I give him of my identity to convince him to give me the money? I do not even know the roads to Media.”

³Tobit told him, “He and I made two copies of a written agreement. We tore one of them in half, and each of us kept one of the halves. I put the other copy with the money. Twenty years have passed since I deposited that money. So find a reliable man to accompany you, my son. We will pay him for his time when you get back. Now go and reclaim this money from Gabael.”

⁴Tobiah went out to find someone who knew the roads to Media and would accompany him there. He found Raphael standing outside, but Tobiah did not know that he was an angel of God. ⁵Tobiah asked him, “Who are you, young man?”

He replied, “I am an Israelite, one of your relatives, and I am looking for work.”

Tobiah asked him, "Do you know the way to Media?"

⁶"Yes," Raphael answered. "I have gone there often and know all the roads. I used to stay with our relative Gabael in Rages. We will first have to travel to Ecbatana, which is on the plain east of here. Then it is two more long days to get to Rages, which is in the mountains."

⁷Tobiah said to him, "Wait for me, young man, while I go in and tell my father. I need someone to accompany me to Rages, and I will pay you to guide me."

⁸Raphael replied, "I am at your service, but don't be too long."

⁹Tobiah went in and told his father, "I have found a fellow Israelite who will go with me."

Tobit said, "Bring him to me, my son, so that I can find out about his family and tribe and decide if he should be trusted to go with you."

Tobiah went out and said to Raphael, "My father would like to meet you."

¹⁰When Raphael came in, Tobit immediately greeted him. Raphael replied, "And may all be well with you."

Tobit responded, "What! How can anything be well with me? I am blind and can no longer enjoy the sunlight. I might as well be dead, for everything is dark. Even though I'm still alive, I'm no better than a corpse. I hear voices, but I cannot even see who is speaking."

"Be brave," Raphael encouraged him. "God will heal you soon. Be confident."

Then Tobit said, "My son, Tobiah, wants to go to Media. Can you accompany him and guide him there? I will pay you, my brother."

"Yes, I can go with him," Raphael responded. "I know all the roads. I have often been to Media, crossing the plains and the mountains, so that I know every road."

¹¹Tobit inquired, "Tell me, brother, to what tribe and family do you belong?"

¹²"Why do you need to know my tribe?" replied Raphael.

Tobit said, "I really want to know who your family is and what your name is."

¹³Raphael answered, “I am Azariah, son of the great Hananiah, one of your relatives.”

¹⁴Tobit said, “Welcome, my brother. Do not be insulted because I wanted to know your tribe and family. You are a relative of mine, of good and noble stock. I knew Hananiah and Nathan, the two sons of the great Shemeliah. They used to make the pilgrimage to Jerusalem with me, and we would worship together. They did not turn away from keeping the law of Moses. Your relatives are good people, and you come from a good family. Again, welcome!” ¹⁵He added, “I will pay you a silver coin for each day of your trip as well as all your expenses. ¹⁶I will also pay you a bonus if you both return safely.”

Raphael replied, “I will go with him. Don’t worry. We will return as healthy as we are now because the route is safe.”

¹⁷Tobit said, “May God bless you, brother.” Then he called Tobiah and said to him, “My son, prepare whatever is necessary for the trip. May God in heaven protect both of you as you travel and bring you back to me safely. May his angel guard your way.”

Before setting out on the journey, Tobiah kissed his father and mother. Then Tobit said, “Have a safe journey.”

¹⁸Tobiah’s mother began to weep. She said to Tobit, “Why have you sent my son away? Isn’t he the one we depend on? ¹⁹Why do you want more money if it costs us the life of our son? ²⁰Can’t we be satisfied with the life the Lord has given us?”

²¹Tobit said to her, “Don’t worry. Our child is leaving in good health, and he will return the same way. You will see for yourself that he will be safe. Say no more. Do not fear for them, dear wife. ²²A good angel will go with him. His mission will be successful, and he will return in good health.”

²³So she stopped weeping.

6

The Journey to Rages

THE young man and the angel left together, ²and Tobiah's dog followed them. They traveled until dusk and then spent the night beside the Tigris River.

³When Tobiah went down to wash his feet in the river, a large fish jumped from the water and tried to swallow his foot. As Tobiah cried out, ⁴the angel shouted, "Catch the fish and hang on to it!" Tobiah grabbed the fish and pulled it up on the bank. ⁵Then the angel told him, "Cut open the fish, and save its heart, liver, and gall. Throw away the intestines. The heart, liver, and gall make good medicines." ⁶Tobiah did as the angel told him. Then he roasted the fish, ate some of it, and preserved the rest of it with salt.

The two traveled on together until they were near Media. ⁷Then the young man asked the angel, "Brother Azariah, what medicine can be made from the fish's heart, liver, and even the gall?"

⁸He replied, "If you burn the heart and liver and blow the smoke on a man or woman who is tormented by a demon or an evil spirit, the spirit will leave and never return. ⁹As for the gall, you can use it to anoint the eyes of a person who has cataracts. Then, if you blow on the eyes, they will be healed."

¹⁰When they had entered Media and were getting close to Ecbatana, ¹¹Raphael spoke to the young man and said, "Brother Tobiah."

"Yes, what is it?" he replied.

Raphael said, "Tonight we must stay with your relative, Raguel. He has a daughter named Sarah. ¹²He has no male heir, and Sarah is his only daughter. Since you are the only eligible relative, you have the right to marry her and gain her inheritance. The young woman is sensible, courageous, and very beautiful, and her father is a good man." ¹³He continued: "You have the legal right to marry her. So, listen to me, brother. I will speak to the young woman's father tonight so that you can take her as your bride. When we return from Rages, we will celebrate the marriage. Raguel cannot keep her from you or promise her to another man, for that would be punishable by death according to the law of Moses. Raguel knows that you—above all others—are entitled to marry his daughter. So listen to me, brother.

This very night we will arrange for you to marry her. And when we return from Rages, we will take her back with us to your house.”

¹⁴But Tobiah said to Raphael, “Brother Azariah, I have heard that this woman has already been married seven times and that each husband died on his wedding night in the bridal chamber when he approached her. I have heard that it was a demon that killed them. ¹⁵The demon doesn’t harm her, but it kills anyone who wants to come near her. So I am afraid. I am my father’s only son, and my death would bring my mother and father to their graves. Then there would be no son to bury them.”

¹⁶Raphael said to him, “Remember your father’s command to take a wife from your own tribe. Now listen to me, brother, and say no more about this demon. Take her as your wife. I know that she will marry you tonight. ¹⁷When you enter the bridal chamber, take the fish’s liver and heart and lay them on the burning incense. The demon will smell the smoke and flee, never to return. ¹⁸Then, when you are about to go to bed with her, both of you must first stand up and pray. Ask the Lord of heaven to give you mercy and deliverance. Don’t be afraid. Sarah was set apart for you from all eternity. You will rescue her and she will go with you. I have no doubt that you will have children by her, and they will be very dear to you. So don’t worry!”

¹⁹When Tobiah heard Raphael’s words and realized that Sarah was his relative on his father’s side of the family, he fell deeply in love with her and his heart was set on her.

7

Meeting Raguel



WHEN they reached Ecbatana, Tobiah said to Raphael, “Brother Azariah, take me straight to our brother Raguel.” So they arrived at Raguel’s house, where they found him seated by the courtyard door. They greeted Raguel, and he replied, “Greetings to you also, brothers. Welcome, and good health to you.” Then Raguel brought

them into the house ²and said to his wife, Edna, "This young man looks a lot like my relative Tobit!" ³Then Edna asked them, "Where are you from, brothers?"

They answered, "We belong to the descendants of Naphtali who are exiled in Nineveh."

⁴She asked them, "Do you know our relative Tobit?"

"We certainly do!"

Then she asked them, "Is he in good health?"

⁵They answered, "He is alive and well." Then Tobiah added, "He is my father!"

⁶Raguel jumped up, kissed him, and wept. ⁷Then he said, "Bless you, child. You are the son of a good and noble man. What an unfortunate calamity that such a righteous and charitable man became blind!" He embraced Tobiah and wept. ⁸His wife, Edna, also wept for Tobit, and even their daughter, Sarah, began to weep. ⁹They showed the visitors a warm welcome by preparing a young ram from the flock for a meal.

Marriage Arrangements

When they had washed and sat down to eat, Tobiah said to Raphael, "Brother Azariah, how about asking Raguel if I can marry my relative Sarah?"

¹⁰Raguel overheard the question, so he said to the young man, "Eat, drink, and be happy. No man is more entitled to my daughter than you. Indeed, I have no right to give her to anyone else since you are my closest relative. But, my son, let me explain the true situation to you.

¹¹I have given her to seven husbands from our family, and each of them died on his wedding night when he approached her. But don't be discouraged, my son. Eat and drink, for the Lord will make it work out for both of you."

But Tobiah said, "I will not eat or drink until we make a binding agreement."

So Raguel said, “I will do this. She is yours according to the law of Moses, and it has been decreed from heaven that she be given to you. Take her, for you belong to each other. She is yours forever. May the Lord of heaven guide you, my son, and bless you both this night. May he grant you mercy and peace.”

¹²Then Raguel called for his daughter, Sarah. When she came, he took her by the hand and gave away the bride to Tobiah, saying, “Here she is. Take her to be your wife according to the law of Moses. Take her to your father safely. And may the God of heaven prosper your journey with peace.”

¹³Then Raguel called the young woman’s mother and told her to bring him a scroll. On it he wrote out the marriage contract, stating that he was giving Sarah to Tobiah as his wife according to the law of Moses. ¹⁴Then they began to eat and drink.

¹⁵Then Raguel said to Edna, “Dear wife, prepare the bedroom, and take our daughter there.” ¹⁶So Edna went and made the bed as she was told. She took Sarah there and began to weep for her. Then she wiped away her tears and said, ¹⁷“Be brave, daughter. May the Lord of heaven grant you joy in the place of your sorrow. Be brave, my child.” Then she left.

8

Tobiah Repels the Demon

A^{FTER} they had feasted, Tobiah wanted to go to bed with his bride. So the young woman’s parents took him to the bedroom. ²Remembering Raphael’s words, Tobiah took the fish’s liver and heart out of his bag, and he put them on burning incense. ³The odor of the fish repelled the demon, and it fled through the air to Upper Egypt. (But Raphael followed him there and completely subdued him.)

⁴When the parents had left and shut the bedroom door, Tobiah got up from the bed and said to Sarah, “Stand up, dear wife. We

must pray to our Lord and ask him to grant us mercy and deliverance.
⁵So she got up, and they began to pray, asking God for deliverance.
Tobiah said,

“We praise you, God of our ancestors.
May your name be praised in all generations forever.
Let the heavens and all creation praise you forever.
⁶You made Adam, and then you made his wife, Eve,
as his helper and support.
And the entire human race has come from them.
You said, ‘It is not good for the man to be alone.
I will make a companion who will help him.’
⁷I do not take this woman as my wife
for any lustful reason,
but to show my fidelity.
Grant us your mercy,
and may she and I grow old together.”

⁸They both said, “Amen, Amen.” ⁹Then they went to bed and slept together.

But during the night Raguel arose and called his servants to help him dig a grave. ¹⁰He said, “Perhaps the man will die, so we will bury him before we are criticized and ridiculed.” ¹¹When they had dug the grave, Raguel went back to his wife at the house and said to her, ¹²“Send one of your servant girls to see if Tobiah is still alive. If he is dead, we can bury him before it is daylight so that no one will know.”

¹³So they sent one of the servants, who took a lighted lamp into the bedroom. She found them safe and sound, sleeping together. ¹⁴So the servant came out and told the parents, “He is alive. Nothing is wrong.”

¹⁵Then they blessed the God of heaven. Raguel said,

“We praise you, O God, with pure blessings.

May you be praised forever!

¹⁶May you be praised because you have given me joy.

It has not turned out as I had expected,
but you have shown us your great mercy.

¹⁷We praise you for having mercy
on these two children.

O Master, give them mercy and safety.

May their lives be filled with joy and mercy.”

¹⁸Then Raguel commanded his servants to fill up the grave before dawn.

The Wedding Feast

¹⁹Raguel asked his wife to prepare many loaves of bread. He also slaughtered two cows and four young rams in preparation for a feast.

²⁰And he said to Tobiah, “You must stay here with me for fourteen days, eating and drinking and cheering up my daughter, for she has been depressed. ²¹Take half of what I own, and return safely to your father. The other half will be yours when my wife and I die. Be encouraged, my son. I am your father and Edna is your mother, and all of us—including your wife—belong to you forever. Be encouraged, my son.”

9

Raphael Gets the Money from Gabael



THEN Tobiah said to Raphael, ²⁴“Brother Azariah, take four household servants and two camels with you, and go to Rages. Go to Gabael, give him this portion of the written agreement, and get the money from him. Invite him to return with you to my wedding

feast. ³You know that my father is counting the days until we return, and if I stay one day more than necessary, he will be very worried. ⁴You know that Raguel made an oath, obligating me to stay; I cannot violate his oath.”

⁵So Raphael took the four servants and two camels and went to Rages in Media, where he stayed overnight with Gabael. Raphael gave him Tobit’s portion of the written agreement. Then Raphael told Gabael that Tobit’s son, Tobiah, had married, and he invited Gabael to the wedding feast. So Gabael got up and counted out the money bags, each properly sealed, and loaded them on to camels.

⁶In the morning they both got up early and went to the wedding celebration. When they came to Raguel’s house, they found Tobiah sitting at the table. He stood up and greeted Gabael. Then Gabael began to weep, and he blessed Tobiah with these words: “You are the good and honorable son of a good and honorable man, who also is just and charitable. May the Lord grant the blessings of heaven to you and your wife and to your wife’s father and mother. Praise God, for I see that Tobiah looks a lot like my relative Tobit.”

10

Tobit and Anna Worry about Tobiah

OBIT had calculated the number of days it would take Tobiah to reach Rages and return again. He counted the days, and when his son did not return, ²he said, “What can be detaining him? Do you think Gabael has died and there is no one to give Tobiah the money?”

³Tobit began to worry. ⁴His wife, Anna, said, “My child has died and is no longer alive.” She began to weep and mourn for her son: ⁵“How terrible! Oh, my son, you are the light of my eyes. Why did I let you take that journey?”

⁶But Tobit said to her, “Be quiet and stop worrying, my dear wife. Our son is safe. Probably something unexpected has happened. The

man we sent with him is a trustworthy relative. Don't grieve for Tobiah. He will be here soon."

⁷She answered him, "You be quiet! Stop trying to deceive me. My child has died." Every day she would rush out and look down the road Tobiah had taken. No one could persuade her to do otherwise. When the sun set, she would go inside to mourn and weep all night long, never getting any sleep.

Tobiah and Sarah Head Home

When the fourteen days of wedding festivities (which Raguel had sworn to give his daughter) had ended, Tobiah said to Raguel, "Send me back. I know my father and mother think they will never see me again. I beg you, father, let me return to my own father, for you know that he is old and blind."

⁸But Raguel said, "Don't go; stay with me, my son. I will send messengers to your father to tell him about you."

⁹But Tobiah responded, "No! I beg you to send me back to my father!"

¹⁰So Raguel let Tobiah leave with his wife, Sarah. He also gave Tobiah half of all his property: his male and female servants, cattle and sheep, donkeys and camels, clothing, money, and utensils. ¹¹As he sent them off, he embraced Tobiah and said to him, "Farewell, my son. Travel safely. May the Lord of heaven give you and your wife many good things. May my eyes see my grandchildren before I die."

¹²Then he kissed his daughter, Sarah, and said to her, "My daughter, honor your father-in-law and mother-in-law because now they are your parents, just as we are. Go in peace, Daughter. As long as I live, may I hear that you are doing well." And then he let them go.

¹³Then Edna said to Tobiah, "My child and my beloved brother, may the Lord of heaven bring you home safely. And may I live long enough to see my grandchildren. In the sight of the Lord, I entrust my daughter, Sarah, to you. Don't ever do anything to make her sad. Go in peace, my son. From now on I am your mother and Sarah is your

beloved wife. May we all have prosperous lives.” Then she tenderly kissed them both and sent them on their way.

¹⁴And Tobiah left Raguel with great joy, praising the Lord of heaven and earth, the King of all, because he had given him a successful journey. Before leaving, he told Raguel and Edna, “May I fulfill the Lord’s command to honor you all the days of my life.”

11

The Journey Home



WHEN they came to Kaserin, which is near Nineveh, Raphael said to Tobiah, ²“You know that your father is old and blind. ³Therefore, let us go ahead of your wife to get the house ready before the others arrive.” ⁴So they went on ahead, and Tobiah’s dog followed them. As they traveled together, Raphael reminded Tobiah, “Make sure you’re ready to use the gall of the fish.”

⁵Anna sat looking down the road for her son, as she had been doing every day. ⁶When she saw them coming, she said to her husband, “Look, your son is coming, along with the man who went with him!”

⁷(Raphael had said to Tobiah, “I know that your father’s eyes will be healed. ⁸Anoint his eyes with the fish gall you carry. This will cause the cataracts to fall off, and your father will regain his sight and see the light.”)

⁹Anna ran to her son, embraced him, and said, “Now that I have seen you, my child, I can die in peace.” And she wept.

¹⁰Despite his blindness, Tobit stood up and, hurrying to meet his son, stumbled through the courtyard door. Tobiah approached him ¹¹with the fish gall in his hand. He took hold of his father, blew into his eyes, and said, “Don’t be afraid, Father.” ¹²Then Tobiah took the medicine and put it on his father’s eyes, ¹³causing him some pain. Using both of his hands, Tobiah pulled the cataracts from Tobit’s eyes. Embracing Tobiah, ¹⁴Tobit wept and said, “I can see you, my son; you are the light of my eyes!” Then he said,

“Praise God.

Bless his great name.

Bless all his holy angels.

May his great name be over us,

and blessed be all his angels

for all eternity.

¹⁵Though he afflicted me,
now I see Tobiah, my son.”

So Tobit went inside, rejoicing and praising God as loudly as he could.

Tobiah told his father about the success of his journey—how he had gotten the money and married Sarah, the daughter of Raguel. Then he said that Sarah was at that very moment approaching the gate of Nineveh.

¹⁶Then Tobit, rejoicing and praising God, went out to meet his daughter-in-law at the gate of Nineveh. The people of Nineveh were amazed to see him walking along, fully restored and with no one leading him by the hand. ¹⁷Tobiah told them all that God had been merciful to his father and restored his sight. When Tobit met Sarah, the wife of his son, Tobiah, he blessed her by saying, “Come in, my daughter. Praise God, who has brought you to us, my daughter. Blessed be your father’s household, and blessed be my son, Tobiah, and you, my daughter. Come into your home now. May you have health, blessings, and joy.”

On that day there was rejoicing among all the Jews in Nineveh. ¹⁸Ahikar and his nephew Nadab came to join in the celebration with Tobit.

12

Raphael's Wages

WHEN the wedding festivities ended, Tobit said to Tobiah, “My son, take care of paying the wages of the man who traveled with you, and give him a bonus as well.”

²Tobiah replied, “How much should I pay him, Father? How about half of the possessions I brought back with me? ³He brought me back safely to you, he healed my wife, he brought the money back with me, and he healed you. How much extra shall I give him as a bonus?”

⁴Tobit said, “My son, he deserves to receive half of all he has brought back.”

⁵So Tobiah said to Raphael, “For your wages, accept half of everything you brought back. Now go in peace.”

⁶Then Raphael took the two men aside privately and said, “Praise God, and tell everyone about the good things he has done for you. Sing praises to his name. Honor God by telling everyone his words. Don’t hold back from telling about him. ⁷While it is good to hide the secret of a king, it is also good to reveal and praise the works of God.

“Do good so that evil will not overtake you. ⁸Prayer made with true sincerity is good, and charitable acts done with justice are better than wealth gotten by unjust means. It is better to give to the poor than to store up treasures of gold. ⁹For charitable giving saves us from death and cleanses us from sin. Those who give charitably will be satisfied.

¹⁰Those who do evil and commit sin are their own worst enemies.

Raphael Reveals His Identity

¹¹“Now I will tell you the truth, hiding nothing from you. I already hinted at it when I said, ‘While it is good to hide the secret of a king, it is also good to reveal and praise the works of God.’ ¹²When you prayed, Tobit, and when Sarah prayed, it was I who brought your prayer into the presence of the glorious Lord. And I was there whenever you

buried the dead. ¹³When you left your dinner to bury a dead man, I was sent to test you. ¹⁴At the same time, God sent me to heal you and your daughter-in-law. ¹⁵I am Raphael, one of the seven angels who stand ready and enter the glorious presence of the Lord.”

¹⁶Tobit and Tobiah were greatly shaken. They fell with their faces to the ground. ¹⁷But Raphael said to them, “Do not be afraid; peace be with you. Praise God forever. ¹⁸When I was with you, I was there by the will of God. Praise him each and every day. Sing his praises. ¹⁹(By the way, if you thought I ate and drank with you, it was only imaginary—a vision.) ²⁰Praise the Lord of the earth, and publicly acknowledge God. See, I am ascending to the one who sent me. Write down all the things that have happened to you.” Then he ascended to heaven.

²¹They stood up and saw him no more. ²²Then they kept blessing God and singing his praises, and they openly acknowledged God for the wonderful things that happened when God’s angel appeared to them.

13

Tobit’s Praise



THEN Tobit said:

“Praise God, who lives forever,
for his kingdom lasts for all ages.

²He both punishes and shows mercy.

He takes people to the place of the dead beneath the earth
and raises them up from great destruction.

There is nothing that can escape his hand.

³Praise him before the Gentiles, children of Israel.

He has scattered you among them,

⁴yet he has shown you his greatness even there.

Exalt him in the presence of every living being,

because he is our Lord and our God.
He is our Father and our God forever.
⁵Although he punished you for your sins,
he will also show you his mercy—
you who have been scattered among the nations.
⁶If you turn to him with all your heart and all your soul
to practice truth in his presence,
then he will turn to you
and will no longer hide his face from you.
⁷Now see what he has done for you,
and confess him with a loud voice.
Praise the King of justice,
and exalt his kingdom forever.
In the land of my exile I confess him
and show his power and majesty to a nation of sinners.
Turn around, sinners, and practice justice before him.
Perhaps he will show you his mercy.
As for me, I will exalt my God,
and my soul rejoices in the King of heaven.
⁸Let everyone speak of his majesty
and acknowledge him in Jerusalem.
⁹O Jerusalem, the holy city,
the Lord punished you for your children's actions.
But he will again have mercy on the children of righteousness.
¹⁰Acknowledge the Lord, for he is good.
Bless the eternal King
so that his dwelling place may be rebuilt in you with joy.
May he cheer all the exiles among you
and love all who are in misery
throughout all generations forever.
¹¹A bright light will shine to the ends of the earth.
Many nations will come to you from far away.
People from the most remote places on earth will come to you,
the holy city,

bringing gifts in their hands for the King of heaven.
Generation after generation will be glad in your midst,
and the name of the chosen city will live forever.

¹²All who speak harshly against you will be cursed,
as will all who overtake you and pull down your walls.

Those who overthrow your towers and set your houses on fire
will also be cursed.

But all who respect you will be blessed forever.

¹³Go and rejoice for the children of the righteous,
for they will be gathered together
and will praise the eternal Lord.

¹⁴Blessed are all who love you
and who rejoice to see you prosper.

Blessed are all who grieve with you in your afflictions,
for they will rejoice with you when they see your eternal glory.

¹⁵O my soul, praise the Lord, the great King,

¹⁶for Jerusalem will be built as his eternal house.

I will be happy if some of my descendants
live to see your glory, O Jerusalem,
and acknowledge the King of heaven.

The gates of Jerusalem will be built with sapphire and emerald,
and all the surrounding walls with precious stones.

The towers of Jerusalem will be built with gold,
and their fortifications with pure gold.

¹⁷The main streets of Jerusalem will be paved
with rubies and precious stones of Ophir.

¹⁸The gates of Jerusalem will sing hymns of joy,
and all the houses will shout, 'Hallelujah! Praise the God of
Israel!'

In you, O Jerusalem, his holy name will be praised forever and
ever."

14



o ended Tobit's praise.

Tobit's Final Words

²Tobit died in peace at the age of 112 years and was buried with honor in Nineveh. He was 62 years old when he went blind. After he was healed, he lived in prosperity, giving money to the poor, continually praising God and acknowledging his majesty.

³When Tobit was on his deathbed, he sent for his son, Tobiah, and gave him this command: "My son, take your children, ⁴and go to Media. For I believe the message that God has spoken by Nahum concerning Nineveh's destruction. All the things Nahum said will come upon Assyria and Nineveh. Everything that was spoken by the prophets God sent to Israel will happen. None of their words will fail; all will come true at the right time. So it will be safer in Media than in Assyria and Babylon, for I know and believe that whatever God has said will happen. Not a single word of the prophets' messages will fail. All of our fellow Israelites will be scattered from the good land, Israel, and taken into captivity. The whole land of Israel will become desolate, including Samaria and Jerusalem. And the Temple of God will be burned to the ground for a while.

⁵"But God will again have mercy on them and will bring his people back to the land of Israel. They will rebuild the Temple of God, though it won't be like the first one. This will be the situation until the time comes for God's promise to be fulfilled. Then the people of Israel will return from captivity to Jerusalem and rebuild it with splendor. And the Temple of God will be built in it, even as the prophets of Israel said. ⁶Then all the nations of the earth will turn from their ways and will truly worship God. All of them will abandon their idols, which led them into error, ⁷and they will praise the eternal God in righteousness. All the Israelites who are rescued in those days and who truly acknowledge God will go to Jerusalem. They will live safely forever in the land of Abraham, which will be handed over to

them. Those who truly love God will rejoice, and those who practice sin and injustice will disappear from the earth.

8-⁹“And now, my children, I give you these commands: Serve God sincerely, and do what is pleasing to him. Command your children to do what is right and to give charitably. They must remember God, blessing his name at all times in truth and with all their strength. Now, my son, leave Nineveh; do not stay here. ¹⁰As soon as your mother dies and you have buried her beside me in the tomb, leave this city without delay. For I see that there is great injustice here; this city is full of treacherous and shameless people.

“My son, look at what Nadab did to Ahikar, who had raised him. Wasn’t Ahikar forced to hide underground? But God personally repaid Nadab for his shameful treatment of Ahikar. Ahikar eventually returned to the light of day, but Nadab has gone into eternal darkness for trying to kill Ahikar. Because of his charitable acts, Ahikar escaped the deathly trap Nadab set for him. But Nadab fell into it himself—to his own destruction. ¹¹So now, my children, see what happens to those who are charitable. And see what happens to those who are unjust—they die!

“But now it is getting hard for me to breathe.”

So they laid Tobit on his bed, and he died. Then they gave him a funeral with great honor.

¹²When Tobiah’s mother died, Tobiah buried her beside his father. Then he and his wife returned to Media and lived in Ecbatana with Raguel, his father-in-law. ¹³Respecting the old age of his parents-in-law, he took care of them until they died. He buried them in Ecbatana of Media, and he inherited the property and possessions of Raguel, along with that of his father, Tobit.

¹⁴Then Tobiah died and was buried with honor at the age of 117. ¹⁵But before he died, he not only heard about the destruction of Nineveh but witnessed it as well. He saw its captives being taken to Media by King Cyaxares. Tobiah praised God for all that he had done to the people of Nineveh and Assyria. Before he died, he rejoiced over

the destruction of Nineveh, and he praised the Lord God who lives forever and ever.

Preface to the Book of Sirach

Martin Luther, 1534

THIS This book has heretofore carried the Latin title, Ecclesiasticus, which has been understood in German to mean “spiritual discipline.” Through reading, singing, and preaching it has been extensively used and inculcated in the churches, yet with little understanding or profit except to exalt the estate of the clergy and the pomp of the churches.

Its real name is otherwise Jesus Sirach, after its author as its own prologue and the Greek [50:27] indicate. This is how the books of Moses, Joshua, Isaiah, and all the prophets are named, after their authors. Yet the ancient fathers did not include this one among the books of sacred Scripture, but simply regarded it as the fine work of a wise man. And we shall let it go at that.

Since [the translator] admits in the prologue that he came to Egypt in the reign of King Euergetes and that he there completed this book (which his grandfather had originally begun), it seems to us that he has compiled the best from as many books as he could find. After all, there was a valuable library in Egypt which had been founded by the father of Euergetes, King Philadelphus. Moreover in those days both books and learned men were held in high esteem; and, having come from all over, especially from Greece, they constituted one great school of learning [in Alexandria]. There, too, the Jews had built a temple and instituted divine worship.

That the book must be a compilation is suggested also by the fact that in it one part is not fitted neatly to the next, as in the work of a single author. Instead it draws on many books and authors and mixes them together, much as a bee sucks juices out of all sorts of flowers and mixes them. Moreover, as one may deduce from Philo, it appears

that Jesus Sirach was descended from the royal line of David, and was either a nephew or grandson of Amos Sirach, the foremost prince in the house of Judah, living some two centuries before the birth of Christ, about the time of the Maccabees.

This is a useful book for the ordinary man. The author concentrates all his effort on helping a citizen or housefather to be Godfearing, devout, and wise; and on showing what the relationship of such a man should be to God, the Word of God, priests, parents, wife, children, his own body, his servants, possessions, neighbors, friends, enemies, government, and anyone else. So one might well call this a book on home discipline or on the virtues of a pious householder. This indeed is the proper “spiritual discipline,” and should be recognized as such.

Should anyone like to know what labor it cost us to translate this book, let him compare our German with all the other versions, be they Greek, Latin, or German, old or new—the product will bear sufficient testimony concerning those who produced it. In all languages so many wiseacres have gone at this book that—quite apart from its inherent lack of order from the very outset—one should not be surprised if it turned out completely unrecognizable, unintelligible, and in every respect worthless. But we have put it together again like a torn, trampled, and scattered letter, and washed off the mud; we have brought it into shape as anyone can see for himself. God be praised and thanked. Amen. Christians will not criticize us for this, but the world will; in keeping with its virtues, it will manage to thank us as it has always done.

Sirach *(Ecclesiasticus)*

Translator's Prologue

HE knowledge of many great things has been given to us through the Law, the Prophets, and the other books that followed them. In light of these books, Israel should be commended for its learning and wisdom. But those who read the Scriptures must do more than simply understand them for themselves. Since they love learning, they must also be able to teach outsiders through speaking and writing. My grandfather Jeshua was a great student of the Law, the Prophets, and the other books of our ancestors. He decided to write something himself pertaining to instruction and wisdom so that those who want to learn may make progress in living according to the law of Moses.

I urge you, therefore, to come with a charitable attitude and to read with attention. Pardon us if, despite our careful work, we seem to have mistranslated anything, for the Hebrew words lose some of their meaning when they are translated into another language. And this is not the only book in which that happens; the translation of the Law, the Prophets, and the other books differs considerably when compared to the original text.

I came to Egypt in the thirty-eighth year of the reign of Ptolemy Physcon and stayed for some time. There I came across this book of great learning and wisdom. I felt it was important that I devote myself to translating it, so I worked day and night to complete it. Now it is published for the benefit of those living abroad who want to learn how to conduct themselves in accordance with the law of Moses.

1

In Praise of Wisdom



ALL wisdom comes from the Lord,
and wisdom is with him for eternity.

²Who has numbered the sands of the sea,
the drops of rain, and the days of eternity?

³Who has measured the height of heaven,
the width of the earth, and the depth of the abyss?

⁴Wisdom was created before all things;
prudent understanding is from eternity.

⁶To whom has the root of wisdom been revealed,
and who has known all that she does?

⁸There is but one who is wise and greatly to be feared—
he sits upon his throne.

⁹Yes, it is the Lord who created wisdom.
He saw her and measured her.

He poured her out upon all his works;

¹⁰to each living creature he gave a certain amount.
He has lavished her on those who love him.

Fear of the Lord

¹¹Fear of the Lord brings honor, glory,
gladness, and a crown of joy.

¹²Fear of the Lord delights the heart
and gives gladness, joy, and long life.

¹³Those who fear the Lord will have a happy end;
even on the day of death they will be blessed.

¹⁴Fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom;
she is instilled in the faithful even in the womb.

¹⁵She has made an everlasting home among the human race,
and she will faithfully stay with our descendants.

¹⁶Fear of the Lord is the fullness of wisdom;
she deeply satisfies people with her fruits.

- ¹⁷She fills their houses with good things
and their storehouses with her harvest.
¹⁸Fear of the Lord is a crown of wisdom,
making peace and health to flourish.
¹⁹Knowledge and discernment shower down from wisdom;
she brings glory to those who cling to her.
²⁰Fear of the Lord is the root of wisdom,
and long life stems from her.

- ²²Unjust anger can never be excused,
for anger tips the scales to a person's own destruction.
²³Patient people endure for a time,
and joy is later restored to them.
²⁴They hold back their words until the right time;
then everyone praises their good works.
²⁵The treasuries of wisdom hold wise sayings,
but godly living is detestable to a sinner.
²⁶If you desire wisdom, keep the commandments,
and the Lord will freely give her to you.
²⁷For fear of the Lord is wisdom and instruction,
and he applauds faithfulness and humility.

- ²⁸Don't refuse to fear the Lord,
and don't come to him unless you are sincere.

- ²⁹Don't be a hypocrite before others;
be careful of what you say.

- ³⁰Don't exalt yourself, or you might fall
and disgrace yourself.

The Lord will expose your secrets
and humble you before the whole community
because you did not come to him in the fear of the Lord,
and your heart was full of deceit.

2

Coping with Troubles



My child, when you come to serve the Lord,
expect to encounter troubles.

²Firmly resolve to go in the right direction,
and don't flinch in the face of adversity.

³Cling to the Lord and do not leave him
so that your last days may be prosperous.

⁴Accept whatever comes your way,
and be patient in times of humiliation.

⁵For gold is tested in the fire,
and worthy souls in the furnace of humiliation.

⁶Trust in the Lord, and he will help you.
Follow a straight path, and hope in him.

⁷You who fear the Lord, wait for his mercy;
don't turn away from him, or you may fall.

⁸You who fear the Lord, trust in him,
and you will not lose your reward.

⁹You who fear the Lord, hope for good things
and for lasting joy and mercy.

¹⁰Look at the generations of old and consider:
Has anyone trusted in the Lord and been disappointed?
Has anyone stood firm in the fear of him and been forsaken?
Has anyone called upon him and been ignored by him?

¹¹For the Lord is compassionate and merciful;
he forgives sins and saves in times of distress.

¹²How terrible it will be for the fearful and cowardly

and for the sinner who leads a double life!

¹³How terrible it will be for the fainthearted who have no trust,
for they will not be protected!

¹⁴How terrible it will be for you who have lost your nerve!
What will you do when the Lord brings about justice?

¹⁵Those who fear the Lord do not disobey his words,
and those who love him keep his ways.

¹⁶Those who fear the Lord try to please him,
and those who love him are filled with his law.

¹⁷Those who fear the Lord prepare their hearts
and humble themselves in his presence.

¹⁸Let us fall into the hands of the Lord
rather than into the hands of people,
for his mercy is equal to his majesty.

3

Children and Parents



CHILDREN, listen to me, for I am your father;
do what I tell you, so that you may be kept safe.

²The Lord has given the father a place of honor before his children

and has confirmed the mother's authority over her children.

³Those who honor their father will have their sins forgiven,
⁴and those who respect their mother store up treasure.

⁵Those who honor their father will have joy in their own children,
and their prayers will be heard.

⁶Those who respect their father will enjoy a long life,
and those who comfort their mother obey the Lord.

⁷They submit to their parents as a servant would to his master.

⁸Honor your father by word and deed
so that you may receive his blessing.

⁹A father's blessing strengthens the homes of his children,
but a mother's curse tears out their foundations.

¹⁰Don't seek to glorify yourself by dishonoring your father,
for his shame is no glory to you.

¹¹For people are glorified when their father is glorified,
and it is disgraceful for children not to honor their mother.

¹²My child, help your father in his old age,
and do not cause him grief during his life.

¹³Even if his mind fails, have patience with him,
and do not despise him when you are in your prime.

¹⁴For kindness to a father will not be forgotten
and will be recorded in your favor against your sins.

¹⁵When you are in trouble, your kindness will be remembered;
your sins will melt away like frost in the sunshine.

¹⁶Those who forsake their father are like blasphemers,
and those who anger their mother are cursed by the Lord.

Humility

¹⁷My child, do your work with humility,
and God's people will love you.

¹⁸The greater you are, the more you should humble yourself;
then you will find favor with the Lord.

²⁰The Lord is great and powerful,
but he is honored by the humble.

- ²¹Don't try to understand things that are too difficult for you
or search into things beyond your ability.
- ²²Focus instead on what God has given you,
for what is hidden is not your concern.
- ²³Don't meddle in matters that are beyond you,
for even what you see is more than you can grasp.
- ²⁴For many have been deceived by their own reasoning,
and false assumptions have impaired their judgment.
- ²⁶A stubborn heart will come to a bad end,
and those who love danger will perish in it.
- ²⁷A stubborn heart will be weighed down with sorrows,
and the sinner heaps up sin upon sin.
- ²⁸There is no cure when disaster falls upon the proud,
for an evil plant has taken root in them.
- ²⁹Sensible people will reflect on proverbs,
and an attentive listener delights the wise teacher.

Kindness to the Poor

- ³⁰Just as water quenches a flaming fire,
helping the poor atones for sins.
- ³¹Those who repay favors are thinking ahead,
for they will be supported when they fall.

4



- y child, don't cheat the poor out of their livelihood,
and don't hold back from helping the destitute.
- ²Don't aggravate the hungry,
and don't provoke the needy.
- ³Don't cause more troubles for the desperate,

- and don't delay in giving to those in need.
- ⁴Don't ignore the pleas of those in distress,
and don't turn your face away from the poor.
- ⁵Don't turn your eyes away from the needy,
and give no one a reason to curse you.
- ⁶For if people curse you out of bitterness,
their Creator will hear them.
- ⁷Make yourself welcome in your congregation;
show respect to the great.
- ⁸Listen to the poor,
and return their greetings courteously.
- ⁹Rescue the oppressed from the oppressor,
and don't be fainthearted when giving a verdict.
- ¹⁰Be a father to the fatherless,
and act as a husband to their mother.
- You will be like an obedient son of the Most High,
and he will love you more than your own mother does.

The Rewards of Wisdom

- ¹¹Wisdom exalts her children
and helps those who seek her.
- ¹²Anyone who loves her loves life;
those who look for her early in the morning will be filled with
joy.
- ¹³Anyone who holds tight to her will inherit honor;
the Lord blesses every place she enters.
- ¹⁴Those who serve her are really serving the Holy One;
the Lord loves those who love her.
- ¹⁵Those who obey her will judge the nations,

- and those who listen to her will remain secure.
- ¹⁶If they trust in wisdom, they will inherit her,
and their descendants will also possess her.
- ¹⁷At first she will lead people down winding trails,
causing them fear and apprehension.
She will discipline them and test them
until they come to trust her.
- ¹⁸Then she will immediately return to them and give them joy;
she will reveal her secrets to them.
- ¹⁹But if they go astray, wisdom will forsake them
and hand them over to destruction.

Wisdom in Speech

- ²⁰Be on guard all the time, and watch out for evil,
but don't be overly modest about yourself.
- ²¹For one kind of modesty leads to sin,
but another kind leads to honor and favor.
- ²²Don't favor others so much that you harm yourself
or defer to others to the point that you cause your own down-
fall.
- ²³Don't hesitate to speak at the proper moment.
And don't hide your wisdom.
- ²⁴For wisdom is revealed by what you say,
and instruction by the words you speak.
- ²⁵Never contradict the truth;
instead, be ashamed of your own ignorance.
- ²⁶Don't be ashamed to confess your sins,
and don't fight against the current of a river.
- ²⁷Don't let a fool tell you what to do,
but don't show favor to the powerful.
- ²⁸Fight for truth even to the point of death,

and the Lord God will fight for you.

Guarding against Overconfidence

- ²⁹Don't be hasty in your speech
or slow and lazy in your actions.
³⁰Don't be like a lion in your home
or suspicious of your servants.
³¹Don't open your hands to receive from others
and then close them when it is time to give.

5

- ON'T put your confidence in wealth
or say, "I have enough—I'm set for life."
²Don't follow your inclinations and strength
and pursue all the desires of your heart.
³Don't say, "No one is more powerful than I am,"
for the Lord will surely punish you.
⁴Don't say, "I have sinned, yet nothing has happened to me,"
for the Lord is simply being patient with you.
⁵Don't be so sure your sin is forgiven
that you continue to heap up sin upon sin.
⁶Don't say, "The mercy of the Lord is great,
so I can keep sinning and receive forgiveness."
For the Lord shows both mercy and anger,
and he will become angry with sinners.
⁷Don't wait to return to the Lord;
don't put it off one day longer.
For the Lord's anger will come suddenly upon you,
and in the time of punishment you will be destroyed.

⁸Don't take comfort in ill-gotten wealth,
for it will not help you on the day of disaster.

Sincerity in Speech

⁹Don't winnow in every wind
or follow every path.

¹⁰Stand firm for what you know,
and be a person of your word.

¹¹Be quick to hear
and slow to answer.

¹²If you know what to say, answer your neighbors' questions;
but if you don't, keep quiet.

¹³What you say brings either honor or dishonor,
and the tongue may bring about a person's downfall.

¹⁴Don't gain a reputation as a slanderer,
and don't try to trap people by what you say.

For shame awaits the thief,
and condemnation will come to those who speak out of both
sides of their mouth.

¹⁵Be careful not to offend others in matters great or small,
and don't be an enemy instead of a friend.

6



OR a bad name will bring reproach and shame,
as happens to every double-tongued sinner.

²Don't let passion completely overtake you,
or it will tear you apart like an angry bull.

³It will eat your leaves and destroy your fruit
so that you are left as a withered tree.

⁴Those who are filled with evil passion are destroyed by it,
causing their enemies to laugh at them.

Regarding Friendship

⁵A gentle word wins friends,
and gracious speech prompts kindness.

⁶Have many friends,
but let only one in a thousand be your adviser.

⁷When you are looking to gain friends, test them first,
and do not trust them too quickly.

⁸Some friends are loyal only when it suits them,
and they will not stand with you when trouble comes.

⁹Some friends become your enemies
and shame you by publicizing your quarrel.

¹⁰Other friends will dine at your table
but will not stand with you when trouble comes.

¹¹When things are going well for you, they make themselves your
equal,
bossing your servants around.

¹²But when times are tough, they turn against you
and hide themselves from you.

¹³Avoid your enemies,
and be on guard even with your friends.

¹⁴A faithful friend is a strong refuge,
and anyone who has found one has found a treasure.

¹⁵Faithful friends are priceless;
their worth can't be measured.

- ¹⁶A faithful friend is a lifesaving remedy,
and those who fear the Lord will find one.
¹⁷Those who fear the Lord will make good friends,
for they will find friends among others of like mind.

Seeking Wisdom

- ¹⁸My child, receive instruction in your youth,
and you will still possess her when your hair turns gray.
¹⁹Come to wisdom as one who plows and plants;
then wait for her good harvest.
You will labor a little as you cultivate her soil,
but you will soon eat of her harvest.
²⁰Wisdom seems harsh to the unlearned!
The foolish will not put up with her.
²¹She will weigh them down as a heavy stone,
and they will quickly abandon her.
²²For wisdom is true to her name,
and she is not attained by many.
- ²³Listen, my child, and take my advice;
do not discard my instruction.
²⁴Put your feet into wisdom's fetters
and your neck into her collar.
²⁵Bow down your shoulders and carry her,
and do not resent her bonds.
²⁶Come to her with all your being,
and keep her ways with all your power.
²⁷Search intently for her, and she will reveal herself to you;
when you have taken hold of her, do not let her go.
²⁸In the end you will find rest in her,

and she will become your joy.

²⁹Then her fetters will give you a strong defense,
and her collar will be your robe of glory.

³⁰Her yoke will be a gold ornament,
and her bonds a royal purple cord.

³¹You will wear her like a robe of glory
and put her on your head like a crown of joy.

³²My child, if you will listen to me, you will learn;
if you will apply yourself, you will be intelligent.

³³If you love to listen, you will gain knowledge;
if you pay attention, you will become wise.

³⁴Stand in the company of wise elders;
find out who is wise and stay close to them.

³⁵Be ready to listen to every godly conversation,
and let no wise sayings be missed.

³⁶If you find an intelligent man, get up early each day to visit him;
let your feet wear out his doorstep.

³⁷Let your thoughts dwell on the laws of the Lord,
and meditate continually on his commandments.

He will affirm your thinking,
and the wisdom you desire will be granted.

7

Proverbs for Life



Do no evil, and no evil will happen to you;

²avoid wickedness, and it will stay away from you.

³My child, don't plant in the field of injustice;
otherwise you will harvest its crop sevenfold.

⁴Don't ask the Lord for a high position,
or the king for the seat of honor.

⁵Don't try to justify yourself before the Lord
or try to appear wise before the king.

⁶Don't seek to be made a judge,
for you may not be able to root out injustice,
or you may be partial to the powerful.
Then you would lose your integrity.

⁷Don't commit an injustice against the community;
don't disgrace yourself before the people.

⁸Don't plan to repeat a sin,
for you will be punished even for one sin.

⁹Don't say, "God will respect my many offerings;
the Most High God will accept what I offer."

¹⁰Don't grow weary of praying,
and don't neglect to give to the poor.

¹¹Don't ridicule someone who is bitter about something,
for the same God who humbles a person can also exalt him.

¹²Don't make up lies about your brother
or about your friend.

¹³Refuse to tell any lie,
for it is a habit that does no good.

¹⁴Don't talk on and on before the elders
or repeat yourself in prayer.

¹⁵Don't despise hard work or farm work,
which was ordained by the Most High.

¹⁶Don't join the ranks of sinners;
remember, punishment will soon follow.

¹⁷Humble yourself as much as you can,
for the ungodly will be punished by fire and worms.

Regarding Relationships

- ¹⁸Don't betray a friend for money
or despise a true brother for all the gold of Ophir.
- ¹⁹Don't leave a wise and good wife,
for her gracious presence is worth more than gold.
- ²⁰Don't hurt servants who work faithfully
or hired laborers who are devoted to their work.
- ²¹Love wise servants as you love yourself;
don't deny them their freedom.
- ²²Do you have livestock? Look after them,
and if they are profitable, keep them.
- ²³Do you have children? Instruct them,
and make them obedient from childhood.
- ²⁴Do you have daughters? Be concerned for their chastity,
and don't be too indulgent with them.
- ²⁵Giving your daughter in marriage is the culmination of a great
task;
but be sure to give her to a sensible man.
- ²⁶If you have a wife who pleases you, don't divorce her;
but if you don't love her, don't trust her.
- ²⁷Honor your father with your whole heart,
and don't forget the pain your mother endured to give you
birth.
- ²⁸Remember that you owe your very life to them;
how can you repay them for all they have done?
- ²⁹Fear the Lord with all your soul,

and revere his priests.

³⁰Love your Creator with all your strength,
and don't forsake his servants.

³¹Fear the Lord and honor the priest.

As it is commanded, give the priest his portion:
firstfruits, guilt offerings, shoulder offerings,
sanctification sacrifices, and firstfruits of the holy things.

³²Stretch out your hand to help the poor,
so your blessing may be complete.

³³Be generous to all the living,
and honor even the dead.

³⁴Don't turn away from those who weep;
share the grief of those who mourn.

³⁵Don't hesitate to visit the sick,
because you will be loved for doing such things.

³⁶If you always live in light of your approaching death,
you will never sin.

8

=More Proverbs for Life=

¹Don't fight against the powerful,
or you might fall into their hands.

²Don't quarrel with the rich;
their resources may outweigh yours.

For gold has destroyed many
and corrupted the hearts of kings.

³Don't argue with loudmouths;
don't heap fuel on their fire.

⁴Don't make fun of an ignorant man,

- for he may insult your ancestors.
- ⁵Don't criticize a repentant sinner;
remember, we are all guilty.
- ⁶Don't despise anyone who is old,
for some of us are also growing old.
- ⁷Don't rejoice at anyone's death;
remember, we all have to die.
- ⁸Don't despise the counsel of the wise,
but strive to learn their proverbs.
From them you can gain instruction
and learn how to serve the great.
- ⁹Don't ignore what elderly people have to say,
for they themselves learned from their parents.
From them you can learn how to understand
and give a timely answer.
- ¹⁰Don't kindle the coals of sinners,
or you may be burned in the fire of their sins.
- ¹¹Don't let insolent people provoke you,
or they will trap you in your own words.
- ¹²Don't lend to a person who is stronger than you—
but if you do lend something, count it as lost.
- ¹³Don't give a guarantee beyond your means;
and if you put up bond money for someone, presume you
will have to pay it.
- ¹⁴Don't file suit against a judge;
the ruling will favor him because of his position.
- ¹⁵Don't go on a journey with irresponsible people,
for their mischief will become your burden.

- They will do what they wish,
and you will be ruined by their foolishness.
- ¹⁶Don't quarrel with those who have short tempers,
and don't go with them into the desert,
for bloodshed is nothing to them,
and they will strike you down when no one is near to help
you.
- ¹⁷Don't discuss your plans with fools,
for they can't keep anything secret.
- ¹⁸Be careful what you do around strangers,
for you do not know what they will tell.
- ¹⁹Don't open your heart to just anyone,
and don't accept favors from such a person.

9

Regarding Women

- ON'T be jealous of the wife you love
or teach her wicked ways she can use to repay you.
- ²Don't give yourself to a woman,
for she may dominate you completely.
- ³Don't go near a promiscuous woman,
or you will fall into her snares.
- ⁴Don't spend time with a dancing girl,
or you will succumb to her charms.
- ⁵Don't stare at a young girl,
or you might sleep with her and have to pay a penalty.
- ⁶Don't sleep with prostitutes,
or you might lose your inheritance.
- ⁷Don't look around the streets of a city
or wander up and down in its deserted places.

- ⁸Turn your eyes away from a shapely woman,
and don't stare at beauty that belongs to another.
For many have been seduced by a woman's beauty,
and passion then becomes a roaring fire.
⁹Don't have dinner with another man's wife
or spend time with her drinking wine,
for you might fall in love with her
and come to ruin because of your passion.

Keeping Good Company

- ¹⁰Don't forsake old friends,
for new ones will not compare to them.
A new friend is like new wine;
when it has aged, you drink it with pleasure.
¹¹Don't envy the success of sinners,
for you don't know what is in store for them.
¹²Don't seek after the pleasures of the ungodly;
remember, they will eventually be punished before they die.
- ¹³Keep far from those who have the power to kill,
and you will have no worry about death.
But if you must approach them, be careful not to offend them,
or they may kill you.
Realize that you are stepping among traps
and walking along the edge of a cliff.
- ¹⁴Know your neighbor as well as you can,
and consult with the wise.
¹⁵Look for intelligent people to talk with;

always discuss the law of the Most High.

¹⁶Choose the righteous to be your dinner companions,
and let your boasting be in the fear of the Lord.

¹⁷A work is praised for the skill of the artisan,
and a leader is praised for the wisdom of his speech.

¹⁸Loudmouths are feared in their city,
and those who speak recklessly are hated.

10

Regarding Government



wise ruler educates his people,
and the administration of a prudent ruler is well ordered.

²The judge of the people sets the example, and all his officials
follow his lead.

The mayor of a city sets the tone, and the people follow.

³An unlearned king will be the ruin of his people,
but a city prospers through its leaders' knowledge.

⁴The Lord is in charge of the whole earth.

He establishes the right leader at the right time.

⁵The Lord is in charge of human success,
and he is the one who honors the legislator.

The Evils of Pride

⁶Don't get angry at your neighbor for every little injury,
and don't behave rashly.

⁷Pride is hateful to the Lord and humanity,
and injustice is outrageous to both.

- ⁸Control of a kingdom passes from one group of people to another
because of injustice, arrogance, and greed.
- ⁹How can we—dust and ashes—be proud?
Even during life a person's body decays.
- ¹⁰A long sickness baffles the physician;
a king today is a corpse tomorrow.
- ¹¹When people die,
they inherit maggots, wild animals, and worms.
- ¹²Pride begins when a person abandons the Lord
and turns away from his Maker.
- ¹³Pride begins with sin;
those who remain proud are abominable.
For this reason the Lord brings them unexpected disasters,
which completely destroy them.
- ¹⁴The Lord overturns the thrones of princes
and sets up the meek in their place.
- ¹⁵The Lord plucks up the roots of proud nations
and plants the humble in their place.
- ¹⁶The Lord overthrows the nations
and destroys them to their very foundations.
- ¹⁷He removes some of them and destroys them.
He erases their memory from the earth.

Those Worthy of Honor

- ¹⁸Pride was not created for mortals,
or furious anger for those born of women.
- ¹⁹Who is worthy of honor?
The human race.
Who is worthy of honor?
Those who fear the Lord.

Who is not worthy of honor?

The human race.

Who is not worthy of honor?

Those who break the commandments.

²⁰Among family members, their leader is worthy of honor,
but with the Lord, anyone who fears him is worthy of honor.

²²The rich, the noble, the poor—
let them pride themselves in fearing the Lord.

²³It is not right to despise an intelligent person who is poor,
and it is not good to honor a sinful person.

²⁴The prince, the judge, and the ruler are honored,
yet there is none greater than the person who fears the Lord.

²⁵Those who are free will serve a wise slave,
and the intelligent will not protest.

²⁶Don't show off your wisdom when doing your work
or boast in the time of need.

²⁷Better are those who work and have plenty
than those who brag but need bread.

²⁸My child, think well of yourself but with modesty;
be honest in assessing your worth.

²⁹Who can acquit those who condemn themselves?
And who can honor those who devalue their own lives?

³⁰The poor are honored for their understanding,
and the rich are honored for their wealth.

³¹If a person is honored in poverty,
how much more in wealth!

If a person is dishonored in wealth,
how much more in poverty!

11

Appearances Are Deceiving



THE wisdom of the humble raises their heads high
and causes them to sit among the great.

²Don't praise people for their good looks
or despise them for their appearance.

³The bee is small among flying creatures,
but what it produces is the sweetest.

⁴Don't boast about your fine clothes,
or become proud when you are honored;
for the works of the Lord are wonderful,
and his works are hidden from people.

⁵Many kings have been deposed,
and an unlikely person has been given the crown.

⁶Many rulers have been completely disgraced,
and the prominent have been placed at the mercy of others.

Acting with Caution

⁷Don't place blame before you investigate;
when you have finished your inquiry, then criticize.

⁸Listen before you answer,
and don't interrupt others while they are talking.

⁹Don't get involved in a matter that doesn't concern you
or sit with sinners involved in a dispute.

¹⁰My child, don't take on too many responsibilities;
if you get overcommitted, you will still be held accountable.

- In all your hurrying, you will not catch up,
and you will not escape by running away.
- ¹¹Some people labor and struggle and rush,
only to fall farther behind.
- ¹²Others are slow and need help.
They lack strength and are plagued by poverty.
Yet the Lord looks upon them with kindness;
he lifts them from their lowly condition.
- ¹³He gives them honor—
to the amazement of most everyone.
- ¹⁴Good and bad, life and death, poverty and riches—
all are from the Lord.
- ¹⁷The gift of the Lord remains with the devout,
and the Lord's favor brings lasting success.
- ¹⁸People become rich by living frugally,
and this is their reward:
- ¹⁹They say, "I have found rest,
and now I will enjoy my possessions."
But they do not know how much time is left
until they die and leave all their wealth to others.
- ²⁰Stand by your contracts and fulfill them.
Grow old in your work.
- ²¹Don't be amazed at what sinners do.
Trust in the Lord, and stick to your job.
In the Lord's sight it is easy
to make a poor person suddenly rich.
- ²²The Lord rewards the devout by blessing them,
and his blessing flourishes fruit quickly.
- ²³Don't say, "What do I need,
and how will I benefit from this?"

- ²⁴Don't say, "I am self-sufficient;
what could possibly go wrong?"
- ²⁵In times of prosperity we forget adversity,
and in times of adversity we forget prosperity.
- ²⁶It is easy for the Lord on the day of death
to reward a person's conduct.
- ²⁷An hour's misery makes a person forget past delights.
The last hour of life reveals a person's deeds.
- ²⁸Don't call anyone blessed before that person dies,
for people are known by their children.
- ²⁹Don't bring just anyone into your home,
for the deceitful have many tricks.
- ³⁰The proud act like decoy partridges in a cage.
Like spies, they look for what could make you fall.
- ³¹They lie in wait, turning good into evil,
and find fault with what is praiseworthy.
- ³²A blazing fire comes from one spark,
and a sinner looks for a chance to shed blood.
- ³³Beware of scoundrels and their evil schemes,
for they could ruin your reputation forever.
- ³⁴If you receive strangers into your home,
they will cause trouble and make you a stranger in your own
home.

12

Rules for Doing Good



If you do good to others, give thought to the people you select;
then your good deeds will be appreciated.

- ²Do good to the devout, and you will be rewarded—
if not by them, then certainly by the Most High.
- ³No good comes to those who continue to do evil
or to those who do not give to the poor.
- ⁴Give to the godly but not to the sinner.
- ⁵Do good to the humble, but do not give to the ungodly.
Keep your bread, and don't give it to the ungodly,
for they might grow stronger than you because of it.
Then you will receive twice as much evil
for all the good you have done to them.
- ⁶The Most High hates sinners
and will punish the ungodly.
- ⁷Give to the good,
but don't help the sinner.
- ⁸A friend will not ask for favors when you are doing well,
but an enemy won't stay away when you are in trouble.
- ⁹When people are prosperous, their enemies act like friends,
but when trouble comes, even one's friends disappear.

Guarding against Enemies

- ¹⁰Never trust your enemies,
for they will turn wicked as surely as copper tarnishes.
- ¹¹Even if they humble themselves and come begging,
be on guard—beware of them.
Treat them carefully, as though you were polishing a metal mirror
to be sure it doesn't tarnish.
- ¹²Don't give your enemies a position next to you,
or they may overthrow you and take your place.
Don't seat them at your right hand,
or they may try to take your seat.
And then you will see that I was right

and be stung by what I told you.

¹³Who feels sorry for snake charmers when they are bitten?

Or for those who go near savage beasts?

¹⁴So it is with those who keep bad company
and participate in their sins.

¹⁵Sinners will stand by you for a while,
but if you slip, they will abandon you.

¹⁶Enemies speak sweetly with their lips,
but in their hearts they plot to throw you into a pit.

Enemies weep with their eyes,
but they will use every opportunity to cause as much blood-
shed as they can.

¹⁷If trouble comes, enemies will be there ahead of you.
They will pretend to help you, but they will trip you up.

¹⁸They will shake their heads and clap their hands to mock you,
and they will whisper about you,
showing their true feelings toward you.

13

The Rich and the Poor



As those who touch pitch get dirty,
so those who associate with the proud will become proud.

²Don't try to carry a burden too heavy for you
or associate with someone mightier or richer than you.

How can you put a clay jar next to an iron kettle?

If they knock against one another, the jar will be smashed.

³If rich people do wrong, they blame others,
but if poor people are wronged, they must apologize over and
over.

- ⁴Rich people will exploit you if you have anything to give,
but they will abandon you if you have nothing.
- ⁵If you have anything, the rich will live with you
and consume your goods without remorse.
- ⁶If they need you, they will deceive you.
They will smile at you and encourage you.
They will speak gently to you,
asking, "What do you need?"
- ⁷The rich will shame you by their fine meals
until you are drained two or three times by returning the favor.
Finally, they will laugh at you.
Afterward when they see you,
they will avoid you and deride you.
- ⁸Beware that you are not deceived
and humiliated by your stupidity.
- ⁹If you are invited to dinner by the influential, be reluctant to
accept;
then they will be even more insistent.
- ¹⁰Don't push yourself forward, or you might be pushed back;
but don't stand aloof, or you may be forgotten.
- ¹¹Don't speak to the influential as equals
or believe their many words,
for they will test you with their long discourses
and probe you with their smiles.
- ¹²Those who betray your confidence are cruel.
They will not hesitate to harm or imprison you.
- ¹³Keep quiet and be very careful,
for you are flirting with disaster.
- ¹⁵Every creature loves its own kind,
so every person should love his neighbor.
- ¹⁶Every creature associates with those like itself,
and people are drawn to others like themselves.

- ¹⁷What does a wolf have in common with a lamb?
So it is with the sinner and the godly.
- ¹⁸What peace can there be between a hyena and a dog?
Or what peace can there be between the rich and the poor?
- ¹⁹The wild donkey is a lion's prey in the wilderness;
so also the poor are devoured by the rich.
- ²⁰Humility is an abomination to the proud,
just as the poor are abhorred by the rich.
- ²¹When the rich fail, their friends support them;
but when the poor fall, their friends push them away.
- ²²When the rich falter, many come to their aid;
when they speak inappropriately, they are justified by others.
But if the poor slip, they are criticized.
They may speak wisely, but no one listens.
- ²³The rich speak, and everyone stops talking;
their speech is praised to the heavens.
The poor person speaks, and people ask, "Who is this?"
If the poor stumble, they are pushed down.
- ²⁴Riches are good for those without sin,
and poverty is evil only to the ungodly.

True Happiness

- ²⁵The heart changes one's countenance—
for better or for worse.
- ²⁶The sign of a good heart is a happy face,
but composing proverbs is painful work.

14



BLESSED are those who have not erred in their speech
and who are not plagued by remorse for sin.

²Blessed are those who are not wracked by guilt
and who have not given up hope.

³Riches are not appropriate for those who think small.
What use is money to a miser?

⁴By depriving himself, he is only storing up for others,
and they will enjoy a life of luxury with his possessions.

⁵If people are stingy toward themselves, to whom will they be
generous?

They don't even enjoy their own wealth.

⁶No one is worse than those who are stingy with themselves;
they punish themselves by their own stinginess.

⁷If they do good, it is by mistake;
in the end they show that they are mean.

⁸Misers are wicked;
they turn away from people and disregard them.

⁹Greedy people are never satisfied with their share;
their souls will shrivel up from greed.

¹⁰Misers are reluctant to share food,
and even their own meals are meager.

¹¹My child, be good to yourself with what you have,
and give worthy offerings to the Lord.

¹²Remember that death advances steadily
and that the decree of the grave has not been shown to you.

¹³Be good to your friends while you are still alive;
reach out and give to them as much as you can.

¹⁴Don't forget to enjoy the good things each day brings,
and don't let your part of a good gift pass you by.

¹⁵When you die, others will receive your hard-earned possessions;

everything you worked for will be randomly distributed to others.

¹⁶Give, take, and be good to yourself,
for you cannot find luxury in the place of the dead.

¹⁷Like a garment, all living beings grow old,
for the age-old decree is: "You will die."

¹⁸The generations of flesh and blood
are like the many leaves of a growing tree.

The tree sheds some leaves and puts forth new ones.

So also one generation dies and another is born.

¹⁹All things made by people decay and disappear,
and those who made them will eventually pass away with them.

The Pursuit of Wisdom

²⁰Blessed are those who meditate on wisdom
and reflect on knowledge.

²¹They consider wisdom's ways
and ponder her secrets.

²²They pursue her like a hunter
and wait to ambush her along her paths.

²³They look for her through her windows
and listen for her at her doors.

²⁴They camp near her house
and fasten their tent pegs to her wall.

²⁵They pitch their tent near her;
in this way they find a good place to live.

²⁶They place their children under her shelter
and camp under her branches.

²⁷She protects them from the heat,
and they live amidst her glory.

15

The Blessings of Wisdom



- WHOEVER fears God will do these things;
whoever follows the law of Moses will gain wisdom.
- ²Like a mother, she will come to meet him;
like a young bride, she will welcome him.
- ³She will feed him with the bread of understanding
and give him the water of wisdom to drink.
- ⁴He will lean on her and not fall;
he will depend on her and not be humiliated.
- ⁵She will exalt him above his neighbors
and make him eloquent among the congregation.
- ⁶He will be crowned with joy and gladness
and inherit an everlasting name.
- ⁷The foolish will not obtain wisdom,
nor will sinners ever see her.
- ⁸Wisdom will have nothing to do with arrogance,
and liars never give thought to her.
- ⁹Praise from sinners is out of place,
for it has not been given to them by the Lord.
- ¹⁰For praise must flow from wisdom,
and the Lord must prompt it.

Freedom to Choose

- ¹¹Don't say, "It is the Lord's fault that I sinned,"
for he does not do what he hates.
- ¹²Don't say, "It was the Lord who led me astray,"
for he does not need sinful people.

- ¹³The Lord hates every kind of detestable sin,
and those who fear him will not love it either.
- ¹⁴In the beginning he made people
and allowed them to do whatever they planned.
- ¹⁵If you choose, you can obey the commandments;
you have the freedom to act faithfully.
- ¹⁶He has set before you fire and water;
reach out and select whichever one you choose.
- ¹⁷Before each person are life and death;
you will receive whichever one you choose.
- ¹⁸For the wisdom of the Lord is great;
he is powerful and sees all things.
- ¹⁹The Lord watches over those who fear him,
and he knows everything we do.
- ²⁰He has not commanded anyone to be wicked;
he has given no one permission to sin.

16

Ungodly Children



- Do not desire to have many children if they are worthless;
do not delight in godless offspring.
- ²No matter how many children you have, don't rejoice over
them
unless they are godly.
- ³Don't count on them living a long time
or take confidence in how many there are.
For one can be better than a thousand,
and it is better to die childless than to have ungodly children.
- ⁴One intelligent person can cause a city to become populated,
but a clan of rebels causes it to become deserted.

The Lord Punishes Sinners

- ⁵My eyes have seen many things like this,
and my ears have heard things even more astounding.
- ⁶A fire was kindled in Korah's group of sinners,
and the Lord's wrath blazed up within the disobedient nation.
- ⁷The Lord did not forgive the ancient giants,
who used their strength to rebel.
- ⁸He did not spare Lot's neighbors;
he detested them for their pride.
- ⁹The Lord showed no pity for the doomed nation of Canaanites,
who were uprooted for their sins.
- ¹⁰Nor did he have pity on the 600,000 Israelite foot soldiers
that gathered together in their stubbornness.
- ¹¹Even if there had been only one stubborn person,
it would have been amazing if he had escaped unpunished.
- For the Lord possesses both mercy and wrath;
he forgives a great deal, but he also pours out wrath.
- ¹²His mercy is great, but so is his punishment.
He judges people according to their deeds.
- ¹³He does not let sinners escape with their plunder
or allow the patience of the godly to go unrewarded.
- ¹⁴He credits every act of mercy in a person's favor,
and all are treated as their deeds deserve.
- ¹⁷Don't say, "I am hidden from the Lord.
Who will remember me from on high?
No one will notice me in such a large crowd.
What do I amount to in such an immense creation?
- ¹⁸Look! The very highest heavens,
the watery depths, and the earth tremble at the Lord's coming.
- ¹⁹The mountains and the foundations of the earth

- tremble and shake when he looks at them.
- ²⁰But no mind thinks about these things,
for who can comprehend his ways?
- ²¹Just as the wind of a storm cannot be seen,
so most of the Lord's works are hidden.
- ²²Who will announce his acts of justice?
Or who will wait for them to happen?
It will be a long time before he carries out what he has decreed."
- ²³This is how people who lack understanding think.
They are foolish, senseless, and misguided.

The Lord Created with Order

- ²⁴Listen to me, my child, and gain knowledge.
Focus your thoughts on my words.
- ²⁵I will measure out my learning
and declare knowledge accurately.
- ²⁶When the Lord created his works in the beginning
and determined the natural laws of creation,
- ²⁷he arranged things in a certain order forever
and assigned their dominion for all generations.
They do not grow hungry or weary,
nor do they shirk their duties.
- ²⁸They do not crowd each other,
and they never disobey his word.
- ²⁹After this the Lord looked at the earth
and filled it with his good things.
- ³⁰He covered its surface with all kinds of living things,
and to the earth they must return.

17



HE Lord created human beings from the earth,
and he makes them return to it.

²He gave them a certain number of days to live
but also granted them authority over everything on earth.

³He gave them strength like his own
and created them in his own image.

⁴He put the fear of them in all living creatures
and gave them dominion over animals and birds.

⁶The Lord gave people discretion, a tongue, eyes,
ears, and a mind for thinking.

⁷He filled them with knowledge and understanding
and showed them the difference between good and evil.

⁸He kept his eye on their hearts
to show them the greatness of his works.

¹⁰People will praise the holy name of the Lord
as they proclaim the glory of his works.

¹¹He gave them knowledge
and the law of life for an inheritance.

¹²He made an everlasting covenant with them
and showed them his decrees.

¹³Their eyes saw his glorious majesty,
and their ears heard his glorious voice.

¹⁴The Lord said to them, "Beware of all evil."
And he gave all of them a commandment about their neighbors.

¹⁵Their ways are always known to him;
they are not hidden from his eyes.

¹⁷Over each nation he appointed a ruler.
But Israel is the Lord's own possession.

¹⁹To him, all their actions are as plain as the sun,
and his eyes continually watch how they live.

²⁰Their evil deeds are not hidden from him;

the Lord sees all their sins.

²²Gifts to the needy are like a signet ring to the Lord,
and kind acts are the apple of his eye.

²³Afterward he will rise up and repay the wicked;
he will bring his retribution down on their heads.

²⁴But to those who repent he grants a return to his favor,
and he encourages those who have lost hope.

A Call to Repentance

²⁵Return to the Lord, and forsake your sins.

Pray in his presence, and stop offending him.

²⁶Return to the Most High, and turn away from evil;
completely detest what he hates.

²⁷Who will praise the Most High from the place of the dead?
Will they replace the living who give thanks?

²⁸Once people die, they can no longer give thanks,
but those who are alive and well can sing praises to the Lord.

²⁹How great is the mercy of the Lord
and his forgiveness for those who return to him!

³⁰Human beings cannot do everything,
for they are not immortal.

³¹There is nothing brighter than the sun, is there? Yet even it can
be eclipsed.

In the same way, human beings falter by devising evil.

³²The sun watches over the powers of the heavens,
but all humans are merely dust and ashes.

18

The Greatness of God



HE who lives forever created all the universe.

²The Lord alone is just.

⁴He has given no one the power to fully proclaim his works.

Who can search out his mighty deeds?

⁵Who can measure his majestic power?

And who is able to tell about his mercy?

⁶None of these things can be diminished or enlarged.

No one can search out the wonders of the Lord.

⁷When people finish recounting them, they are still at the beginning;

when they stop, they are still puzzled.

⁸What are mere mortals, and what is their purpose?

What is good in them, and what is evil?

⁹The lifespan of a person

is a hundred years at most.

¹⁰Like a drop of water from the sea or a grain of sand,

so are these few years compared to eternity.

¹¹For this reason the Lord is patient with them

and pours out his mercy on them.

¹²He recognizes how harsh their end is,

so he grants them forgiveness all the more.

¹³Human compassion extends to one's neighbor,

but the Lord's mercy reaches every living thing.

He trains, corrects, and teaches them;

he brings them back as a shepherd does with his flock.

¹⁴He has compassion on all who accept his guidance

and who are eager to obey his laws.

Using Caution and Good Judgment

¹⁵My child, don't scold while doing good deeds

or ruin your generous deeds by speaking harshly.

- ¹⁶Doesn't the dew relieve the scorching heat?
So also a word is better than a gift.
- ¹⁷Certainly a word is worth more than a good gift, isn't it?
A gracious person gives both.
- ¹⁸A fool is ungracious and offensive.
The gift of a stingy person is an eyesore.
- ¹⁹Learn before you speak.
Take care of your health before you get sick.
- ²⁰Examine yourself before judgment comes,
and you will receive forgiveness in the time of reckoning.
- ²¹Humble yourself before you get sick,
and when you sin, repent.
- ²²Don't let anything keep you from fulfilling a vow promptly,
and don't go to your grave before you have fulfilled your vow.
- ²³Before you make a vow, prepare yourself,
and don't be like a person who tries the Lord's patience.
- ²⁴Think about the wrath that awaits you at death
and the time of vengeance when the Lord turns away his face.
- ²⁵Remember times of hunger during times of plenty,
and remember times of poverty and need when you are
wealthy.
- ²⁶From dawn to dusk conditions change,
and the Lord watches all things move swiftly.
- ²⁷Wise people are cautious in everything
and take care not to participate in the sins that surround them.
- ²⁸Every sensible person recognizes wisdom
and praises the one who finds her.
- ²⁹Those who are skilled with words become wise
and pour out fitting proverbs.

Self-Control

- ³⁰Don't be ruled by your passions;
restrain your desires.
- ³¹If you give in to your passions,
they will make a mockery of you before your enemies.
- ³²Don't indulge in great luxury,
for you may go broke from the cost.
- ³³Do not make yourself poor by feasting with borrowed money
when you have nothing in your pocket.

19



- drunken worker will not become rich,
and those who don't take care of the little they have will fail
little by little.
- ²Wine and women corrupt intelligent men,
and the man who frequents prostitutes is reckless.
- ³Rottenness and worms will consume him,
and the reckless person will be snatched away.

Caution in Speech

- ⁴One who trusts others too easily has a shallow mind,
and those who sin hurt themselves.
- ⁵Those who take pleasure in evil will be condemned.
- ⁶Those who hate gossip are guarding against evil.
- ⁷Do not repeat what you hear,
and you will never let anything slip.
- ⁸Do not tell it to friend or foe;

- do not disclose it, unless keeping it a secret would be a sin.
- ⁹For someone may watch you and hear you,
and over time they will come to hate you.
- ¹⁰Have you heard something? Let it die with you.
Be strong! It will not make you burst!
- ¹¹When something is told to fools, they suffer agony
like a woman in labor with a child.
- ¹²Like an arrow stuck in someone's thigh,
so is gossip in the heart of a fool.
- ¹³If you hear a rumor, question your friends about it.
They may have not done anything.
Or if they did, question them so that they may not do it again.
- ¹⁴Question your neighbors, for they may not have said anything;
but if they have, question them so that they may not repeat it.
- ¹⁵Question your friends about any rumor,
for it may only be slander against them.
Do not believe everything you hear.
- ¹⁶A person may make a slip in speech without intending it.
For who has never sinned by something they have said?
- ¹⁷Question your neighbors before you threaten them,
and let the law of the Most High take its course.

Wisdom Is Better Than Craftiness

- ²⁰All wisdom comes from fearing the Lord
and always involves practicing the law of Moses.
- ²²Knowledge about wickedness is not wisdom,
and there is no prudence in the advice of sinners.
- ²³Certain kinds of cleverness are detestable,
and some people are fools simply because they lack wisdom.

- ²⁴But better are those who lack wisdom and yet fear God
than those who are brilliant and yet disobey the law of Moses.
- ²⁵Some cleverness is keen but unjust,
while on the other hand some people pervert the system to get
justice.
- ²⁶There are villains who appear stooped over in grief,
while inwardly they are full of deceit.
- ²⁷They cover their faces and pretend not to hear,
but once no one is looking, they will take advantage of you.
- ²⁸Though their lack of strength may keep them from sinning,
if they find an opportunity to do evil, they will do it.
- ²⁹People are known by their appearance,
and sensible people can be recognized at first sight.
- ³⁰The way they dress, laugh heartily,
and walk tells you what kind of people they are.

20

The Wise Know When to Keep Silent



- C**ERTAIN kinds of rebuke are out of place,
and a wise person knows when to keep quiet.
- ²But how much better it is to rebuke someone
than to stay angry with that person.
- ³The person who admits a mistake
will avoid being disgraced.
- ⁴Like a eunuch lusting after a girl,
so is the person who does what is right only under compulsion.
- ⁵Some people are thought to be wise because they remain silent,
while others are despised because they are talkative.
- ⁶Some people keep quiet because they have no answer,
while others keep quiet because they know when to speak.

⁷A wise person keeps quiet until the right opportunity,
but an arrogant fool is completely unaware of the right moment.

⁸Whoever talks too much is hated,
and those who act as if they are important are detested.

Some Paradoxes of Life

⁹Sometimes hard times can bring good fortune,
while a windfall may turn into a loss.

¹⁰Some gifts are not profitable
and others must be paid back double.

¹¹There are losses because of honor,
and some people of lowly status have gained prestige.

¹²Some people buy much for little,
but then they pay for it seven times over.

¹³The wise gain favor with their words,
but fools waste their compliments to others.

¹⁴Gifts from fools will do you no good,
for they are looking to be repaid sevenfold.

¹⁵Fools give little and berate much.
They announce things like the town crier.

Today they lend, and tomorrow they ask for it back;
such people are detestable.

¹⁶The fool says, "I have no friends,
and no one thanks me for my good deeds.

¹⁷The very people I feed speak maliciously about me."
How often—and by how many—will such a person be
laughed at!

Shameful Speech

¹⁸A slip on the pavement is better than a slip of the tongue.

That is how fast the wicked will fall.

¹⁹An ill-mannered person is like an indiscreet story
that is continually repeated by fools.

²⁰A proverb told by a fool will be rejected
because he does not tell it at the right moment.

²¹Poverty may prevent some people from sinning;
when they try to sleep, they will not be restless with remorse.

²²People can be destroyed because they are modest
or because they look foolish.

²³A person may be shamed into making promises to a friend
and thereby gains an enemy for no good reason.

²⁴A lie is an ugly stain on a person,
and the foolish will constantly talk about it.

²⁵A thief is better than a constant liar,
but both are headed for destruction.

²⁶Lying leads to disgrace,
and such shame stays with a person constantly.

Displaying Wisdom

²⁷Wise people gain prestige by their words,
and sensible people please the powerful.

²⁸Those who till their land will harvest a good crop,
and those who please the powerful make up for injustice.

- ²⁹Favors and gifts blind the eyes of the wise;
like a muzzle over their mouths, they keep them from criticizing.
- ³⁰What profit is there in wisdom that is hidden
and in treasure that no one has discovered?
- ³¹Better are those who hide their foolishness
than those who hide their wisdom.

21

Warnings against Sin



- My child, have you sinned? Don't sin anymore.
But ask forgiveness for your past sins.
- ²Flee from sin as from a snake,
for if you come near sin, it will bite you.
Its teeth are the teeth of a lion,
which can destroy human lives.
- ³All lawlessness is like a two-edged sword;
the wound it inflicts will never heal.
- ⁴Terror and arrogance will cause riches to waste away.
In this way the household of the proud will be reduced to nothing.
- ⁵The prayer of the poor will be heard by the Lord,
and his judgment comes quickly.
- ⁶Those who hate correction follow in the footsteps of sinners,
but those who fear the Lord repent in their heart.
- ⁷The eloquent are heard by everyone,
but the sensible person notices when such people slip.

- ⁸To build a house with borrowed money
is like gathering stones for your own tomb.
⁹A band of wicked people is like a bundle of fibers;
they are destined to be thrown into a blazing fire.
¹⁰The way of sinners is paved with smooth stones,
but eventually it leads to death.

The Wise and the Foolish

- ¹¹Those who observe the law will control their thinking.
The fear of the Lord results in wisdom.
¹²Those who are not clever cannot be taught,
but a certain kind of cleverness makes a person bitter.
¹³The knowledge of the wise will swell like a flood,
and their advice is like a living spring.
¹⁴The mind of a fool is like a broken jar;
it cannot hold any knowledge.
- ¹⁵When intelligent people hear a wise saying,
they applaud it and add to it.
When fools hear it, they sneer at it
and throw it away.
¹⁶The talk of a fool is like a burden on a journey,
but it is delightful to hear the intelligent speak.
¹⁷The words of a sensible person are sought after in the congregation,
and they will ponder the words in their minds.
- ¹⁸Like a house that lies in ruins, so is wisdom to a fool,
and to the ignorant, knowledge is merely babbling speech.

¹⁹To a senseless person, education is like fetters on the feet
and shackles on the right hand.

²⁰Fools laugh loudly,
but the clever smile quietly.

²¹To the sensible person, education is like a gold ornament
or a bracelet on the right arm.

²²A fool rushes into a house,
but an experienced person waits respectfully outside.

²³An ill-mannered person peers into a house from the doorway,
but one who is well-taught waits outside.

²⁴It is bad manners for a person to listen outside someone's door.
The discreet would be upset by such a disgrace.

²⁵Babblers merely repeat what others have said,
but the wise carefully measure their words.

²⁶Fools blurt out whatever they are thinking,
but the wise think before they speak.

²⁷When the ungodly curse their adversaries,
they are cursing themselves.

²⁸Gossips degrade themselves
and gain the hatred of the whole neighborhood.

22

Foolishness Brings Grief



LAZY people are like filthy stones.

Everyone jeers at their disgrace.

²Lazy people are like a lump of dung;

everyone who picks it up will shake it from his hand.

³A father is disgraced by an undisciplined son,
and the birth of a daughter means loss.

⁴A sensible daughter is sure to find a husband,
but a shameful daughter is a grief to her father.

⁵A brazen daughter makes both her father and her husband
ashamed,
and she is despised by both.

⁶Untimely speech is like music during a time of mourning,
but punishment and discipline are always wise.

⁹Teaching a fool is like gluing broken pottery back together
or like rousing a sleeper from deep slumber.

¹⁰Whoever tells a story to a fool
might as well be speaking to someone who is asleep.
At the end of the story, the fool will say, "What was that?"

¹¹Weep for the dead, for they left the light behind;
and weep for fools, for they have left intelligence behind.
Do not weep as much for the dead, for they are at rest.
But the life of the fool is worse than death.

¹²Mourning for the dead lasts seven days,
but for fools and the ungodly it lasts a lifetime.

¹³Do not talk much with a fool
or visit those who lack common sense.
Keep away from them, or you will have trouble
and be spattered when they shake themselves off.
Avoid such people, and you will find rest.
You will not be exhausted by their foolishness.

¹⁴What is heavier than lead?

The same one who is called "Fool."

¹⁵Sand, salt, and a piece of iron
are less of a burden than a stupid person.

¹⁶A wooden beam firmly secured in the frame of a building
will not be loosed by an earthquake.

In the same way, a mind made up after thoughtful reflection
will not be shaken during a time of crisis.

¹⁷A mind solidified with intelligent thought
is like stucco decoration on a smooth wall.

¹⁸A fence set on a high place
will not stand against the force of the wind.

Likewise, a timid mind with the resolve of a fool
will not stand firm in the face of fear.

Preserving Friendships

¹⁹Prick an eye and tears will come;
prick the heart and feelings pour forth.

²⁰One who throws stones at birds scares them off,
and one who insults a friend destroys a friendship.

²¹But even if you have drawn a sword on a friend,
do not despair; there is a way back.

²²If you have said something to a friend,
don't worry; you can still be reconciled.

Only insults, arrogance, disclosing of secrets,
or a treacherous blow will cause a friend to flee from you.

²³Gain your neighbors' trust when they are poor
so that you may rejoice with them when they are prosperous.

In the time of trouble continue to be faithful to them
so that they may share with you when they receive an inheritance.

²⁴As fumes and smoke precede a fire in a furnace,
so also insults precede bloodshed.

²⁵I am not ashamed to give shelter to friends,
nor will I hide from them.

²⁶But if any harm should come to me because of them,
everyone who hears of it will watch out for them.

Guarding against Sin

²⁷Who will set up a guard over my mouth
and a tight seal on my lips
to keep them from becoming my downfall
and my tongue from destroying me?

23



Lord, Father, and Ruler of my life,
do not abandon me to their schemes
or allow me to fall because of them.

²Who will punish my thoughts to correct them
and discipline my mind with wisdom
so that I am not left unpunished for my errors
and my sins are not overlooked?

³Otherwise my mistakes may increase
and my sins may multiply,
and I may fall before my enemies,
allowing them to rejoice over me.

⁴O Lord, Father and God of my life,

- do not let me become proud,
 ⁵and take away all my evil desires.
⁶Do not let gluttony or lust consume me,
 and do not abandon me to shameless passions.

Controlling the Tongue

- ⁷My child, listen to instruction concerning the things you say.
 The one who obeys it will never be tripped up.
⁸Sinners are ensnared by their own words;
 scoffers and the proud fall by what they say.
⁹Don't make a habit of swearing an oath after everything you say
 or of using the name of the Holy One.
¹⁰Just as a slave who is constantly monitored
 is always bruised,
so everyone who takes God's name in vain
 will not be free from sin.
¹¹Those who constantly swear oaths are sinful;
 their households will continually be punished.
If they go back on their oaths, their sin will not be overlooked.
 If they disregard their oaths, their guilt is doubled.
If they swear an oath that is not true, they will not be acquitted.
 Their house will be filled with troubles.
¹²There is also a manner of speaking that equals death.
 May it never be found among Jacob's descendants!
The godly will steer clear of such conduct
 and will not wallow in sin.
¹³Don't get used to speaking lewd vulgarities,
 for this is sinful speech.
¹⁴Remember who your father and mother are
 when you sit among the great.
Otherwise you may forget who you are in their presence

and behave like a fool.
Then you will wish you had never been born,
and you will curse the day of your birth.
¹⁵Those who are accustomed to vulgarity
will never correct the habit as long as they live.

Regarding Sexual Sins

¹⁶There are two kinds of people who pile up sins
and a third who brings wrath upon themselves.
¹⁷Hot passion that burns fire
cannot be quenched until it burns itself out.
Those who have sexual relations with their own family members
will not give up until they are devoured by fire.
To the sexually immoral all that they devour is sweet;
they will not be weary of sinning until they die.
¹⁸The man who is unfaithful in marriage
says to himself, "Who can see me?
Darkness covers me, and the walls hide me.
No one sees me, so why should I fear?
The Most High will not remember my sins."
¹⁹But his fears concern only human eyes.
He does not realize that the eyes of the Lord
are ten thousand times more intense than the sun.
They perceive every aspect of human behavior
and see into the most hidden places.
²⁰For all things were known to the Lord before they were created,
and he has known them since they were finished.
²¹This unfaithful man will be punished in the streets of the city,
and when he least suspects it, he will be captured.

- ²²The same thing will happen to every woman who leaves her husband
and presents him with an heir by another man.
- ²³First of all, she has disobeyed the law of the Most High.
Second, she has sinned against her husband.
Third, she has committed the sin of adultery
and has given birth to children by another man.
- ²⁴This woman will be brought before the congregation,
and her punishment will be inherited by her children.
- ²⁵Her children will not become firmly rooted,
and her branches will not bear fruit.
- ²⁶People will curse the very memory of her,
and her disgrace will never be removed.
- ²⁷Those who live on after her will realize
that there is nothing better than to fear the Lord
and nothing sweeter than to obey his commandments.

24

The Praise of Wisdom



- WISDOM praises herself
and proclaims her glory in the midst of her people.
- ²In the assembly of the Most High she speaks,
and before his heavenly armies she declares her glory.
- ³"I came forth when the Most High spoke,
and I covered the earth like a mist.
- ⁴I lived in the highest places,
and my throne was in a pillar of clouds.
- ⁵I alone have traveled across the heavens
and have walked on the bottom of the watery depths.
- ⁶Over the waves of the sea, over the whole earth,

and over every people and nation I have held power.

⁷Among all these I looked for a place to rest.

I wondered, 'In whose territory should I settle?'

⁸"Then the Creator of all things gave me a command.

My Creator chose the place for me to live.

He said, 'Live among Jacob's descendants,

and make Israel the permanent home of your family.'

⁹Before the dawn of time and creation, the Lord created me,

and I will never cease to exist.

¹⁰In the holy Tabernacle I ministered before him,

and so I was established in the Temple on Mount Zion.

¹¹Therefore, the Lord gave me a resting place in the beloved city.

In Jerusalem I held authority.

¹²I took root among an honored people

and in the portion of the Lord, his special possession.

¹³"I grew tall like a cedar in Lebanon

and like a cypress on Mount Hermon.

¹⁴I grew tall like a palm tree in En-gedi

and like a rosebush in Jericho.

Like a beautiful olive tree in a field

or a plane tree beside water, I grew tall.

¹⁵I gave off a pleasant aroma like cinnamon and camel's thorn.

I yielded a fragrance like the finest myrrh.

My aroma was like galbanum, mollusk scent, and resin droplets

and like the incense of the Tabernacle.

¹⁶I stretch out my branches like a tree

and my branches are splendid and graceful.

¹⁷Like a vine I put forth pleasant buds,

and my blossoms become splendid and abundant fruit.

- ¹⁹“Come to me, all you who desire me,
and eat as many of my fruits as you wish.
²⁰For remembering me is sweeter than honey,
and possessing me is sweeter than the honeycomb.
²¹Those who eat me will hunger for more,
and those who drink me will thirst for more.
²²Those who obey me will not be ashamed,
and those who work with me will not sin.”

Wisdom Flows from the Law

- ²³All this is the Book of the Covenant of the Most High God,
the law that Moses commanded us
as an inheritance for the congregations of Israel.
²⁵Wisdom overflows like the Pishon River
and like the Tigris during the season of the first crops.
²⁶Like the Euphrates, it runs over with understanding,
and like the Jordan at harvesttime.
²⁷Like the Nile, it pours out knowledge.
It is like the Gihon at the time of the grape harvest.
²⁸The first man did not know wisdom fully,
nor will the last one understand.
²⁹For her thoughts are more vast than the sea,
and her counsel deeper than the great abyss.
- ³⁰As for me, I was like a canal from a river,
and an irrigation ditch into a garden.
³¹I said, “I will water my garden
and irrigate my flower beds.”
Then my canal became a river,
and my river became a sea.

- ³²I will make teaching shine like the dawn,
and it will be clearly visible from far away.
³³Once again I will pour out teaching like prophecy
and leave it for all future generations.
³⁴Take note that I have not labored for myself alone
but for all who seek wisdom.

25

Reasons for Happiness



- HERE are three things that please me,
for they are delightful to God and to all people:
harmony between brothers and sisters, friendship among neighbors,
and a wife and husband who live well together.
²There are three kinds of people I hate,
and I am disgusted by the way they live:
a poor person who boasts, a rich person who lies,
and an old fool who commits adultery.
³If you have gathered nothing in your youth,
how will you get anything in your old age?
⁴How beautiful it is to see sound judgment coming from gray-haired people
and good advice from the aged!
⁵How beautiful it is to see wisdom coming from the aged
and understanding and advice from the honorable!
⁶The crown of the aged is their ample experience,
and they take pride in their fear of the Lord.

- ⁷I can think of nine people whom I would call blessed

- and a tenth, whom I will speak of:
a man who can rejoice in his children
and one who lives to see the downfall of his enemies.
- ⁸Blessed is the man who lives with a sensible wife.
Blessed is the one who does not sin by what he says
and the one who has not served a person who is inferior to
himself.
- ⁹Blessed is the one who finds a friend
and the one who has good listeners as his audience.
- ¹⁰How great is the one who finds wisdom!
But no one is superior to the person who fears the Lord.
- ¹¹Fear of the Lord surpasses all things.
Those who have it are beyond compare.

Warnings against Wicked Women

- ¹³No wound is worse than a wound of the heart!
No wickedness is worse than the wickedness of a woman!
- ¹⁴No affliction is worse than the affliction from those who hate
you!
And no vengeance is worse than the vengeance of your ene-
mies!
- ¹⁵No poison is worse than that of a snake,
and no anger worse than a woman's anger.
- ¹⁶I would rather live with a lion and a dragon
than live with an evil woman.
- ¹⁷A woman's wickedness changes her appearance
and darkens her face like that of a bear.
- ¹⁸When her husband sits down to eat with neighbors,
he cannot restrain his bitter sighs.

- ¹⁹Any evil is insignificant compared to that of a woman.
May the fate of sinners overtake her!
- ²⁰Just as climbing a sandy hill is difficult for the aged,
so is a talkative wife to a quiet man.
- ²¹Don't be taken in by a woman's beauty,
and don't desire her for her possessions.
- ²²There is anger, shamefulness, and great disgrace
when a wife must support her husband.
- ²³Depression, sadness,
and a wounded heart are caused by an evil wife.
Feeble hands and weak knees
are caused by the wife who does not make her husband happy.
- ²⁴Sin came about because of a woman,
and because of her we all die.
- ²⁵Don't allow a cistern to leak water
or an evil wife to speak arrogantly.
- ²⁶If she does not follow your instructions,
send her away from you.

26

The Blessings of a Good Wife



- B**LESSED is the husband of a good wife,
for his lifespan will be doubled.
- ²A virtuous wife brings joy to her husband,
and he will live out his years in peace.
- ³A good wife is a great blessing;
she will be one of the blessings given to the man who fears the
Lord.
- ⁴Whether rich or poor, his heart is content,
and his face is always cheerful.

- ⁵Three things frighten my heart,
and a fourth makes me afraid:
slander in a city, the gathering of a mob,
and false accusation—all these are worse than death.
- ⁶But there is grief and heartache when a wife is jealous over another woman,
and her tongue-lashing will let everyone know about it.
- ⁷A bad wife chafes like a poorly fitted yoke;
trying to control her is like grasping a scorpion.
- ⁸A drunken wife makes her husband very angry,
for she cannot hide her shameful behavior.
- ⁹An unfaithful wife is revealed by her bold stare,
and her glances give her away.
- ¹⁰Keep a strict watch over a strong-willed daughter,
or else, when she gets a chance, she will take advantage of it.
- ¹¹Watch out for her immodest glances,
and do not be surprised if she disobeys you.
- ¹²Like a thirsty traveler who is eager
to drink from any water nearby,
she will sleep with anyone
and open her quiver to any arrow.
- ¹³A wife's charm pleases her husband,
and her skill puts meat on his bones.
- ¹⁴A silent wife is a gift from the Lord,
and nothing is worth more than her good character.
- ¹⁵A modest wife becomes ever more pleasing,
and no price can be placed on her faithfulness.
- ¹⁶Like the sun rising in the Lord's heavens,
so is the beauty of a good wife in her well-kept home.
- ¹⁷Like the shining lamp on the holy lampstand,

- so is a beautiful face on a graceful figure.
¹⁸Like golden pillars on silver bases,
so are shapely legs and steady feet.
-

The most reliable Greek manuscripts do not include Sirach 26:19-27.

Warnings against Ungodly Women

- ¹⁹My child, be careful not to ruin yourself in the prime of your life,
and do not spend your strength on women you don't even know.
²⁰With regard to women, look for a fertile field within the whole plain,
and plant it with your own seed, trusting in your fine stock.
²¹Your offspring will grow strong,
and they will become great, since they know they come from a good family.
²²People regard a prostitute as spittle,
and a married woman as a tower of death for her lovers.
²³The wicked man inherits an ungodly wife,
while the man who fears the Lord receives a devout wife.
²⁴A shameless woman constantly acts disgracefully,
but a humble daughter will act modestly even around her husband.
²⁵People regard a stubborn wife as a dog,
but a wife who possesses modesty fears the Lord.
²⁶Everyone regards as wise a wife who honors her husband,

but everyone will think she is ungodly if she pridefully dishonors him.

Blessed is the husband of a good wife,
for his lifespan will be doubled.

²⁷ A loud, talkative wife is like a trumpet sounding the charge,
and everyone like this experiences all the upheavals of war.

Miscellaneous Instruction

²⁸ Two things grieve my heart,
and a third arouses my anger:
a warrior in poverty, an intelligent person who is despised,
and someone who turns from righteousness to sin.
The Lord will prepare this last person for a violent death.

²⁹ It is difficult for a merchant to keep from doing wrong
and for a shopkeeper to keep from sinning.

27



ANY sin for profit,
and those who seek riches will look the other way.

² As a stake is driven between stones,
so also is sin wedged between selling and buying.

³ Unless people continually fear the Lord,
their house will quickly collapse.

⁴ When a sieve is shaken, the chaff remains;
likewise, a person's faults are revealed when he speaks.

- ⁵Just as a furnace tests the potter's vessels,
so also people are tested by their speech.
- ⁶As the fruit of a tree shows the quality of its cultivation,
so also people's speech shows their true character.
- ⁷Do not praise people before they speak,
for this is how they are tested.
- ⁸If you pursue justice, you will obtain it
and wear it as a splendid robe.
- ⁹Just as birds roost with their own kind,
so honesty is repaid to those who practice it.
- ¹⁰The lion lies in wait for prey,
and so do sins for those who practice evil.

Wise Conversation

- ¹¹The godly always speak wisely,
but a fool is as changeable as the moon.
- ¹²Don't spend much time with foolish people,
but stay among those who are thoughtful.
- ¹³Fools always say offensive things,
and they laugh at sinful practices.
- ¹⁴Their swearing makes your hair stand on end,
and their quarrels make people hold their ears.
- ¹⁵The quarrels of the proud lead to bloodshed,
and their insults are grievous to hear.
- ¹⁶Whoever betrays secrets destroys trust
and will never find a close friend.
- ¹⁷Love your friend and maintain his trust.

- But if you betray his secrets, stay away from him.
- ¹⁸For as a person destroys an enemy,
so you have destroyed friendship with your neighbor.
- ¹⁹And as you let a bird escape from your hand,
so you have let your friend go and will not recapture him.
- ²⁰Do not chase after him, for he is gone.
He has escaped like a gazelle from a snare.
- ²¹A wound can be bandaged,
and insults can be forgiven,
but those who betray secrets have no hope.

Regarding Those Who Plot Evil

- ²²Those who slyly wink are planning mischief,
and those who know them will keep their distance.
- ²³In your presence they are sweet tongued,
and they admire your words.
But later they will change their story
and use your own words to condemn you.
- ²⁴I have hated many things, but I hate them the most.
The Lord even hates such people, too.
- ²⁵To throw a stone straight up is to throw it on your own head,
and backstabbing will wound many.
- ²⁶Those who dig a pit will fall into it,
and those who set a snare will be caught in it.
- ²⁷Those who do evil will be crushed by it
and not know where it came from.
- ²⁸Mockery and insults come from the proud,
yet vengeance lies in wait for them like a lion.
- ²⁹Those who rejoice in the fall of the godly will be caught in a
snare,
and pain will overwhelm them before they die.

Anger and Forgiveness

³⁰ Anger and fury are also detestable,
but the sinner is a master at both of them.

28



HOSE who seek revenge will experience vengeance from the Lord,

who keeps a strict account of their sins.

² Forgive those neighbors who have wronged you,
and then your sins will be forgiven when you pray.

³ If people harbor anger against each other,
how can they expect healing from the Lord?

⁴ If they do not show mercy toward people like themselves,
how can they seek pardon for their own sins?

⁵ If mere human beings harbor anger,
who will make an atoning sacrifice for their sins?

⁶ Think of your approaching death,
and choose not to act as an enemy.

Think of your mortality and death,
and be faithful to the commandments.

⁷ Think of the commandments,
and don't be angry with your neighbor.

Think of the covenant of the Most High,
and overlook the faults of others.

Quarrels and Slander

⁸ Refrain from quarreling, and you will sin less,

- for a hot-tempered person provokes arguments.
- ⁹A sinner causes trouble among friends
and plants discord among those who are at peace.
- ¹⁰The more the fuel, the greater the fire;
the stronger the stubbornness, the more the quarreling;
and the greater the wealth, the hotter the anger.
- ¹¹A quarrel that begins easily kindles a fire,
and a hasty dispute sheds blood.
- ¹²If you blow on a spark, it flares up,
and if you spit upon it, it will be quenched;
yet both come from your mouth.
- ¹³May the gossips and the double-tongued be cursed,
for they have troubled many who were at peace.
- ¹⁴The slanderer has upset many
and scattered them from nation to nation.
Slander has destroyed strong cities
and overthrown the houses of the great.
- ¹⁵Slander has driven virtuous women from their homes
and deprived them of the rewards for their work.
- ¹⁶Those who listen to slander will never find rest,
nor will they relax in peace.
- ¹⁷The lash of a whip makes a bruise,
but a lash of the tongue breaks bones.
- ¹⁸Many have been killed by the sword,
but even more have been destroyed by the tongue.
- ¹⁹Happy are those who are protected from the tongue,
who have not experienced its anger,
who have not been burdened with its yoke
and bound with its chains.
- ²⁰For its yoke is a yoke of iron,
and its chains are chains of bronze.
- ²¹The death that the tongue brings is evil,

and the grave is preferable to it.

²²The tongue has no power over the godly;
they will not be burned by its flame.

²³Those who forsake the Lord will fall into its power.
Its fire will burn among them and not be quenched.

This fire will be sent upon them as a lion;
like a leopard it will tear them apart.

²⁴Just as you hedge your property with thorns
and lock up your silver and gold,

²⁵so also make a door and bolt for your mouth
and a scale to carefully measure your words.

²⁶Take care not to slip with your tongue
and fall victim to those waiting to catch you.

29

Lending and Borrowing



HOSE who show mercy lend to their neighbors.

By giving them help, they are obeying the commandments.

²Lend to your neighbors in their time of need,
and pay your neighbor when your loan is due.

³Keep your word and be honest with them,
and you will always find what you need.

⁴Many look upon a loan as a windfall
and give trouble to those who help them.

⁵They kiss someone's hand until they get a loan from them,
and they make themselves appear humble as they speak of
their neighbor's wealth.

But when the time comes to repay, they put it off
by repaying with only empty promises
and complaining about the lack of time.

⁶And if they are able to pay, the lender will hardly get back half
and will consider himself fortunate to get that much.

They will repay the creditor with insults and curses
and with dishonor rather than praise.

⁷Many have refused to lend, not out of their own meanness,
but simply because they are afraid of being defrauded without
reason.

⁸Nevertheless, be patient with those in poverty,
and do not keep them waiting for your gifts of charity.

⁹Help the poor in obedience to the commandment,
and do not send the needy away empty-handed.

¹⁰Lose your money for the sake of your brother or your friend.
Don't let it rust away under a stone.

¹¹Store up your treasure according to the commandments of the
Most High,
and it will bring you more profit than gold.

¹²Store up gifts for charity in your treasury,
and they will bring you help in every disaster.

¹³Such gifts are better than a strong shield and a sturdy spear.
They will fight for you against your enemy.

¹⁴A good person will cosign a loan for his neighbor,
but a shameless person will let his neighbor down.

¹⁵Never forget the kindness of your guarantor,
for he has given his life for you.

¹⁶The sinner wastes the property of his guarantor,
and the ungrateful person abandons his rescuer.

¹⁷Cosigning for others has ruined many wealthy people
and tossed them about like waves of the sea.

¹⁸It has driven the powerful into exile,
and they have wandered in foreign lands.

- ¹⁹Sinners fall into trouble by cosigning.
Their pursuit for profit leads to lawsuits.
²⁰Assist your neighbor as best you can,
but be careful that you don't fall yourself.

Contentment

- ²¹The essentials for life are water, bread, and clothing,
and a house for privacy.
²²Better is the life of the poor under their own simple roof
than lavish banquets among strangers.
²³Be content with little or plenty;
then you will not be known for living on others' hospitality.
²⁴It is a miserable life to go from house to house,
for as a guest, you can't say anything.
²⁵You must act as a host and provide drinks without being
thanked,
and you even hear rude words like:
²⁶"Come here, stranger, and set the table.
Let me eat whatever you have."
²⁷"You must leave now. An honored guest is coming.
My brother has come to visit, and I need the guest room."
²⁸Two things are upsetting to a conscientious person:
to be scolded about lodging and to be reproached by creditors.

30

Regarding Children



HOEVER loves his son will frequently discipline him

so that he may rejoice in the way his son turns out.

²Whoever disciplines his son will benefit from him
and boast about him to people he knows.

³Whoever educates his son will make his enemy jealous
and glory in him among his friends.

⁴When the father dies, it will be as if he were not dead;
for he has left behind a man like himself.

⁵While the father lived, he rejoiced at the sight of his son;
and when he died, he had no regrets.

⁶He has left behind an avenger against his enemies
and one to repay kindness to his friends.

⁷Whoever spoils his son will bandage his every wound
and be heartbroken at every cry.

⁸A horse that is not broken becomes stubborn,
and a child left to himself becomes headstrong.

⁹Pamper a child, and he will be a terror for you;
join in with his games, and he will cause you grief.

¹⁰Do not laugh with him, or you will be sorry
and gnash your teeth in anguish in the end.

¹¹Give him no freedom while he is young,
and don't overlook his mistakes.

¹²Break him in while he is young,
and punish him while he is a child.

Otherwise he will grow stubborn and disobey you,
and your heart will grieve over him.

¹³Discipline your son and be hard on him
so that he will not offend you by acting shamelessly.

Health and Cheerfulness

- ¹⁴Better to be a poor person who is healthy and physically fit
than a rich person who is sick.
- ¹⁵Health and strength are better than gold,
and a sound body is better than immense riches.
- ¹⁶No treasure is greater than a healthy body,
and no pleasure is greater than a joyful heart.
- ¹⁷Death is better than a miserable life,
and eternal sleep than continual sickness.
- ¹⁸Good things lavished upon someone who will not eat
are like offerings of food placed upon a grave.
- ¹⁹What good does an offering do for an idol?
For the idol can neither eat nor smell.
It is the same for a person who is being punished by the Lord.
- ²⁰He sees the food and groans
like a eunuch groans when embracing a young woman.
- ²¹Don't let yourself become sad,
and don't intentionally make yourself upset.
- ²²A joyful heart is life itself,
and rejoicing lengthens a person's life.
- ²³Indulge yourself and take it easy;
drive sadness far away from you.
For sadness has destroyed many,
and there is no benefit from it.
- ²⁴Envy and anger shorten a person's life,
and anxiety brings on premature old age.
- ²⁵Those who are cheerful while feasting
will benefit from their food.

31

Proper Attitudes toward Wealth



- LOSING sleep over wealth wears out the body,
and anxiety about it drives away rest.
- ²Sleepless worry prevents a person from resting,
and a severe illness steals away sleep.
- ³The rich struggle to amass a fortune,
and when they relax, they enjoy luxury.
- ⁴The poor struggle to barely make a living,
and if they ever rest, they become poor.
- ⁵Those who love gold will not be regarded as righteous,
and those who pursue wealth will be led astray by it.
- ⁶Many have come to ruin because of gold
and come face to face with destruction.
- ⁷Gold causes those who are devoted to it to stumble;
every fool gets tripped up by it.
- ⁸Blessed are the rich who are found blameless
and do not chase after gold.
- ⁹Who are they? We want to praise them,
for they have achieved wonderful things among their people.
- ¹⁰Who have been tested in this way and found perfect?
Let them boast about it.
- Who could have sinned and chose not to do so?
Who could have done evil but did not do it?
- ¹¹They will be made secure in their wealth,
and the congregation will praise their acts of charity.

Practicing Temperance

¹²Are you seated at a grand table?

Don't show that you are greedy,
and don't say, "There is so much here to eat!"

¹³Remember that a greedy eye is evil.

Is anything in creation more greedy than the eye?
That is why it cries so easily.

¹⁴Don't reach for everything you see,
and don't crowd the one sitting next to you at a meal.

¹⁵Be considerate of your neighbors' feelings by thinking about
how you would feel,
and be thoughtful in everything.

¹⁶Show your good upbringing as you eat what is set before you.
Don't gorge yourself, or you will offend someone.

¹⁷Be the first to stop eating, as good manners demand,
and don't be a glutton, or you will offend someone.

¹⁸And if you are sitting with many people,
don't be the first to reach for the food.

¹⁹Well-disciplined people are more than satisfied with only a little
food.

They have no trouble breathing when they lie in bed.

²⁰Moderate eating ensures sound sleep.

Those who practice it rise early and feel well.
But sleeplessness, nausea, and colic
cause distress for the glutton.

²¹If you eat too much,
go vomit, and you will be relieved.

²²Listen to me, my child, and don't ignore me,
and in the end you will find my words to be true.
Practice moderation in all you do,
and you will never get sick.

²³People bless those who are generous with food,
and their testimony to such generosity can be trusted.

²⁴But the whole city complains about those who are stingy with food,
and their testimony to such selfishness is accurate.

²⁵Do not try to prove your strength by drinking wine,
for wine has destroyed many.

²⁶As fire tests metal,
so wine tests people's hearts when braggarts begin to argue.

²⁷Wine gives a person life
if it is drunk in moderation.

What is life without wine?

It was created to make people happy.

²⁸Wine drunk with moderation at appropriate times
gives joy to the heart and soul.

²⁹Wine drunk to excess produces bitter attitudes,
quarrels, and brawls.

³⁰Drunkenness fuels the anger of a fool to his own harm,
sapping his strength and causing wounds.

³¹Don't correct your neighbor at a banquet,
and don't mock him when he is enjoying himself.

Don't say anything nasty to him
or pressure him for anything.

32

Proper Conduct at a Banquet



If they make you the master of ceremonies for a banquet, don't become proud.

Act simply as one of the crowd.

²Take care of them first, and then sit down;

when you have fulfilled all your duties, take your seat.
Then you can celebrate with them
and receive a wreath for your fine leadership.

³You who are older should speak, for this is fitting.
But speak accurately, and don't interrupt the music.

⁴If entertainment is going on, don't keep talking.
Don't show off your wisdom at the wrong time.

⁵A concert of music at a banquet
is like a ruby set in gold.

⁶Melodious music with good wine
is like an emerald seal set in gold.

⁷You who are young should only speak when necessary.
But never speak more than twice, and only when asked.

⁸Be brief; say much in only a few words.
Act like a person who can hold his tongue, even though he
knows the answer.

⁹When you are around prestigious people, don't act like their
equal.
Don't chatter on while another is speaking.

¹⁰Lightning comes before thunder,
and approval goes before a modest person.

¹¹Leave the banquet in good time, and don't be the last to leave.
Go straight home; don't linger on at the banquet.

¹²Enjoy yourself at the banquet to your heart's content,
but don't sin by speaking arrogantly.

¹³Above all, bless your Maker,
who causes you to experience his good gifts.

Obeying the Lord and His Law

- ¹⁴The one who fears the Lord will accept his discipline,
and those who rise early to seek him will find favor.
- ¹⁵The one who seeks the law will be filled with it,
but the hypocrite will stumble over it.
- ¹⁶Those who fear the Lord will think correctly;
their good deeds will shine forth like a fire.
- ¹⁷Sinners will ignore correction
and find a way to justify what they want to do.
- ¹⁸A sensible person will not neglect a thoughtful suggestion,
but not even fear will change the mind of an arrogant and
proud person.
- ¹⁹Never do anything without getting advice;
then when you do something, don't change your mind.
- ²⁰Don't travel on a hazardous path,
and don't stumble over its stones.
- ²¹Don't be careless even on a smooth road;
²²watch where you are going.
- ²³Be careful in everything you do,
for this is how a person keeps the commandments.
- ²⁴The one who believes the law is careful to obey the command-
ments,
and the one who trusts in the Lord will never fare for the
worse.

33

NOTHING bad will happen to those who fear the Lord;
he will rescue them from trials again and again.

²The wise do not hate the law,
but those who are insincere about it are tossed about like a boat
in a storm.

³A sensible person trusts in the law,
for it is as dependable as a divine oracle.

⁴Carefully prepare what you will say,
and people will listen to you.
Make use of your learning as you give your answer.

⁵The heart of a fool turns like a wheel of a cart,
and his thoughts spin like an axle.

⁶Mocking friends are like stallions;
they neigh no matter who is on their back.

Creation Was Established by the Lord's Wisdom

⁷Why is one day more important than another
when every day receives its light from the sun?

⁸By the Lord's wisdom they are different;
he established the various seasons and festivals.

⁹The Lord made some days important and holy,
and some of them he made ordinary.

¹⁰And all humans come from the ground,
the dust from which Adam was created.

¹¹With perfect knowledge the Lord distinguished people from
each other
and assigned them their various ways of life.

¹²Some people he has blessed and exalted;
some he has made holy and drawn to himself;
and some he has cursed and humbled,
removing them from the place they once lived.

¹³As the potter's clay is in his hand
to be shaped as he pleases,
so all people are in the hand of their Maker,
and they will be given whatever he decides.

¹⁴Good is the opposite of evil, and life is the opposite of death.
In the same way, sinners are the opposite of the godly.

¹⁵Look at everything the Most High has made;
they come in pairs, one opposite the other.

The Author Comments on His Work

¹⁶I, Sirach, kept watch at the end
like one who gleanes what the grape gatherers have left behind.

¹⁷By God's blessing I arrived before the other gleaners,
and I filled my winepress as full as any of the grape pickers' presses.

¹⁸Notice that I have not labored only for myself
but for all who seek learning.

¹⁹Listen to me, you who hold prestige among the people,
and pay attention, you leaders of the congregation.

Managing a Household Wisely

²⁰Don't give to your son or wife, brother or friend
power over yourself as long as you live.

Don't give your property to someone else,
for you might change your mind and have to ask for it back.

²¹As long as you live and have breath in you,
don't let anyone take over your position.

²²It is better for your children to ask from you
than for you to depend on your children.

²³Maintain the upper hand in all you do,
and never allow your honor to be stained.

²⁴When you come to the end of your life,
then, at the hour of your death, distribute your inheritance.

²⁵Fodder, the stick, and burdens are for a donkey;
bread, discipline, and work are for a slave.

²⁶Keep your slaves busy at work, and you will find rest.
Allow them to be idle, and they will seek freedom.

²⁷The yoke and the harness make an ox obey,
and torture and pain are for a wicked slave.

²⁸Put him to work so that he will not be idle,

²⁹for idleness trains a person to be very evil.

³⁰Put him to work, as is fitting for him,
and if he does not obey, make his fetters heavy.
But don't be too demanding of anyone,
and do nothing unjust.

³¹If you have only one slave, treat him like yourself,
for you have bought him at a high price.

If you have only one slave, treat him like a brother,
for you need him as much as you need your own life.

³²If you mistreat him, and he runs away,

³³where will you go to find him?

34

Regarding Dreams



AIN and false hopes are for the senseless,
and dreams lend wings to fools.

²The person who believes in dreams
is like one who grabs at shadows
and chases after the wind.

³What is seen in a dream is simply a reflection,
a face looking at itself in a mirror.

⁴Nothing clean can come from something unclean, can it?
In the same way, truth cannot come from something false.

⁵Divinations, omens, and dreams are unreal.
The mind has fantasies just like a woman in labor hopes for
something.

⁶Unless they are sent as visions from the Most High,
pay no attention to them.

⁷For dreams have deceived many,
and those who have trusted in them have been disappointed.

⁸The law is perfect without such deceptions as dreams.
Wisdom is complete when it is spoken by the faithful.

Experience and Travel Bring Knowledge

⁹A person who has traveled much will know many things,
and a person of experience knows what he is talking about.

¹⁰A person with little experience knows little,
but a person grows more resourceful as he travels.

¹¹I have seen many things by traveling
and learned more than I could ever say.

- ¹²I have often been in mortal danger
but have escaped because of my many experiences.

Fear of the Lord Brings Blessing

- ¹³Those who fear the Lord will live,
for their hope is in him who has saved them.
- ¹⁴Those who fear the Lord will not be timid.
They will not be afraid for the Lord is their hope.
- ¹⁵Blessed are those who fear the Lord.
Just think whom they look to for support!
- ¹⁶The Lord watches over those who love him.
He is their mighty shield and strong support,
a shelter from the scorching wind and midday sun,
a safeguard against stumbling, and a help against falling.
- ¹⁷He revives the soul and makes the eyes sparkle;
he gives health and life and blessing.

Insincere Worship

- ¹⁸The sacrifice of something wrongfully obtained is blemished,
and the gifts of the lawless are not acceptable.
- ¹⁹The Most High does not accept the gifts of the wicked
or forgive their sins for a multitude of sacrifices.
- ²⁰Those who offer a sacrifice seized from the poor
are like those who slaughter a son before his father's eyes.
- ²¹Bread is life for the needy and the poor.
Whoever deprives them of it is a murderer.
- ²²Those who take away a person's livelihood are murderers.
Those who deprive an employee of wages shed blood.

- ²³When one builds up and another tears down,
what do they gain except hard work?
- ²⁴When one prays for something and another curses it,
which request will the Lord honor?
- ²⁵If a person touches a corpse, washes, and then touches it again,
what good did washing do?
- ²⁶In the same way, if people fast over their sins
and then commit them again,
who will listen to their prayers?
- What good does their act of humility do?

35

Sincere Worship



KEEPING the law is the same as making many offerings.

Heeding the commandments is like making a peace offering.

- ²To repay a kind deed is to offer fine flour,
and to give charitable gifts is to sacrifice an offering of thanksgiving.
- ³To avoid wickedness is to please the Lord,
and to abandon injustice is to make an atoning sacrifice.
- ⁴But do not come before the Lord without anything to offer,
for making these offerings fulfills the Lord's commandment.
- ⁵The offering of the righteous enriches the altar;
its pleasing aroma rises to the Most High.
- ⁶The sacrifice of the righteous is acceptable;
the Lord will never forget it.
- ⁷Be generous when you worship the Lord.
Do not hold back the firstfruits of your labor.
- ⁸Be cheerful as you give each gift,
and be joyful as you dedicate your tithes.

- ⁹Give to the Most High as he has given to you
and as generously as you can afford.
¹⁰For the Lord always repays,
and he will repay you seven times over.

The Lord Repays Injustice

- ¹¹Do not offer him a bribe, for he will not accept it.
Do not rely on a wrongly obtained sacrifice.
¹²For the Lord is the judge,
and he does not show favoritism.
¹³The Lord is not prejudiced against the poor,
and he will listen to the prayer of the one who is wronged.
¹⁴He will not ignore the requests of the orphan
or the widow when she pours out her complaint.
¹⁵Look how the widow's tears run down her cheek
as she cries out against the one who causes them to fall!
¹⁶Those who serve the Lord in a way that pleases him will be
accepted,
and their prayers will reach even to the clouds.
¹⁷The prayer of the humble penetrates the clouds,
and they will not rest until the prayer has been answered.
¹⁸They will not stop until the Most High responds,
enforcing justice for the righteous and executing judgment.
¹⁹The Lord will not delay;
he will not be patient.
²⁰He will crush the loins of the unmerciful
and take vengeance on the nations.
²¹He will destroy all of the arrogant
and shatter the power of the wicked.
²²He will repay all people as their deeds deserve
and judge their actions by their intentions.

- ²³He will rule in favor of his people
and cause them to rejoice in his mercy.
²⁴His mercy is as welcome in a time of distress
as clouds of rain in a time of drought.

36

A Prayer for Israel



- AVE mercy upon us, O Lord, the God of all.
Make all the nations fear you.
²Punish the foreign nations,
and let them see your power.
³Use them to show your glory to us,
just as you have used us to show your holiness to them.
⁴Let them know, as we have known,
that there is no God besides you, O Lord.
⁵Give new signs and work other miracles,
showing the glory of your hand and right arm.
⁶Stir up your anger and pour out your wrath.
Destroy the adversary and crush the enemy.
⁷Remember the time appointed for this, and make it come
quickly.
Let people recount your mighty deeds.
⁸Let those who escape be consumed in fiery wrath,
and let those who oppress your people be destroyed.
⁹Crush the heads of hostile rulers
who say, "We are the only ones who matter."
¹⁰Gather all the tribes of Jacob,
and give them their inheritance as you did at the beginning.
¹¹Show mercy to the people called by your name,
on Israel, whom you have made your firstborn.

- ¹²Have pity on the city of your sanctuary,
Jerusalem, the place where you reside.
¹³Fill Zion with praise for your wonderful deeds,
and fill your Temple with your glory.
¹⁴Acknowledge those you created in the beginning,
and fulfill the prophecies spoken in your name.
¹⁵Reward those who wait for you,
and show that your prophets can be trusted.
¹⁶Respond to the prayers of your servants, O Lord,
in the manner that Aaron blessed your people.
¹⁷Then everyone on earth will know
that you are the Lord, the eternal God.”

The Need for Discretion

- ¹⁸The stomach will accept any food,
yet one food is better than another.
¹⁹As the palate recognizes the type of wild animal by the flavor of
the meat,
so the intelligent mind discerns lies.
²⁰Those with perverse minds will cause grief,
but a person with experience will pay them back.
²¹A woman will accept any man as a husband,
but a man will prefer one girl over another.
²²A woman’s beauty lights up a man’s face,
and there is nothing he desires more.
²³If her words convey kindness and humility,
her husband is the happiest of men.
²⁴He who finds a good wife finds his best possession.
She is a helper fit for him and a pillar of support.
²⁵Where there is no fence,
the property will be plundered;

where there is no wife,
a man will become a wandering fugitive.
²⁶Who would trust a fleet-footed bandit
that goes from city to city?
²⁷So it is with the man who has no home
and who lodges wherever the night finds him.

37



VERY friend says, "I, too, am your friend."

But some are friends in name only.

²When a close friend turns into an enemy,
it is as sad as someone's death.

³O evil inclination, why were you created?
You cover the earth with deceitfulness.

⁴Some companions rejoice with a friend when times are joyful,
but they turn against him when times are hard.

⁵Some companions help a friend for their stomachs' sake,
but then in battle they carry his shield.

⁶Do not forget a close friend,
and do not overlook him when you distribute your wealth.

Being Cautious of Advice

⁷All counselors think their own advice is good,
but some are only looking out for themselves.

⁸So be careful about those who offer you advice.
First find out what they want
because they might be thinking of their own interests.

They may set you up for a fall
⁹and tell you, "Your way is good,"

- and then stand aside to see what happens to you.
- ¹⁰Don't seek advice from anyone who is suspicious of you
or reveal your intentions to those who envy you.
- ¹¹Don't consult with a woman about her rival;
or with a coward concerning war;
or with a merchant about commerce;
or with a buyer about selling;
or with a stingy person about generosity;
or with the merciless about kindness;
or with a lazy person about work;
or with a seasonal worker about staying on to finish a task;
or with an idle servant about a big job.
Pay no attention to the advice they give.
- ¹²But spend time with a godly person,
whom you know obeys the commandments.
Make sure he thinks like you do
and that he will sympathize with you if you fail.
- ¹³Follow the advice of your own heart,
for it is devoted to you more than anyone is.
- ¹⁴Sometimes our own mind does a better job of keeping us in-
formed
than seven watchmen sitting in a watchtower.
- ¹⁵But above all these things pray to the Most High
that he may direct you along the path of truth.

True Wisdom Yields Good Results

- ¹⁶Let discussion precede every undertaking
and counsel precede every action.
- ¹⁷The mind is the root of all behavior.
Out of it come four branches:
- ¹⁸good and evil, life and death.

- And the tongue continually rules them.
- ¹⁹Some people are good at teaching others
yet are of no use to themselves.
- ²⁰Others are very eloquent, but if detested,
they will starve to death.
- ²¹Charm was not given to them from the Lord,
for they are lacking in all wisdom.
- ²²Those who use wisdom to better themselves
will produce results that are praiseworthy.
- ²³But the wise instruct their own people,
producing results that will last.
- ²⁴The wise will be highly praised,
and all who see them will call them blessed.
- ²⁵The length of a person's life is limited,
but the number of Israel's days is infinite.
- ²⁶The wise will inherit honor among their people,
and their name will live forever.
- ²⁷My child, test yourself all your life;
learn what is bad for you, and do not give in to it.
- ²⁸For not everything is good for everyone,
nor is everything enjoyable to everyone.
- ²⁹Don't be greedy for luxury,
and don't be a glutton.
- ³⁰For overeating causes sickness,
and gluttony leads to nausea.
- ³¹Many have died of gluttony,
but avoiding it will prolong your life.



HONOR physicians for their services,
for the Lord has created them.

²Their skill with healing comes from the Most High,
and they are rewarded by kings.

³The skill of physicians makes them distinguished,
and they are admired by the great.

⁴The Lord has created medicines from the earth,
and the sensible will not despise them.

⁵Wasn't bitter water made sweet by a tree
so that its power might be known?

⁶The Lord has given skill to people
so that he might be honored through his marvelous works.

⁷By these works the physician cures and removes pain,
and from them the pharmacist makes medicine.

⁸There is no end to God's works,
and he spreads health all over the earth.

⁹My child, when you are sick, do not wait;
pray to the Lord, and he will heal you.

¹⁰Renounce your errors, amend your ways,
and cleanse your heart from all sin.

¹¹Offer a sweet-smelling sacrifice and a memorial of fine flour,
and pour oil on your offering—as much as you can afford.

¹²Then let the physician take his place, for the Lord created him.
Don't let him leave you, for you need him.

¹³A time will come when you must commit yourself to physicians.
Then they will pray to the Lord,

¹⁴asking for success in diagnosis
and in healing so that your life will be saved.

¹⁵Those who sin against their Maker
will not listen to the physician.

Mourning for the Dead

- ¹⁶My child, shed tears for the dead
and lament for them to show your great sorrow.
Prepare the body with proper ceremony,
and provide for a decent burial.
- ¹⁷Weep bitterly and wail fervently;
make your mourning worthy of the deceased.
- Mourn for at least one or two days to avoid criticism,
and then let yourself be comforted during your grief.
- ¹⁸For grief can lead to death,
and a heavy heart saps a person's strength.
- ¹⁹When a person is buried, the time of mourning is over,
but a life of poverty continues to weigh down the heart.
- ²⁰Do not be consumed with grieving for others.
Drive grief from you, and think about your own approaching death.
- ²¹Do not forget that there is no returning from death.
Grieving does the dead no good and harms the one who grieves.
- ²²Remember this fate, for yours is the same;
yesterday it was for that person, and today it is for you.
- ²³When the dead are at rest, let the memory of them also end.
Take comfort that their spirit has departed.

The Worker Has Little Time for Wisdom

- ²⁴The scribe possesses wisdom because he possesses leisure time.
Only those who have few responsibilities can become wise.
- ²⁵How can a person become wise who directs the plow
or who glories in the goad,

who drives oxen or keeps busy with work
or whose conversation is always about bulls?

²⁶His mind is fixed on plowing furrows,
and his concerns are about giving his cows fodder.

²⁷It is the same for every craftsman and designer,
who labors night and day.

So also for those who cut engraved seals.

Each is diligent to make the image unique.
Their minds are fixed on making a lifelike image,
they are concerned about completing the task.

²⁸It is also the same for the blacksmith who sits by the anvil,
concentrating on his ironwork.

The heat from the fire melts his flesh
as he works with the heat of the furnace.

The noise of the hammer rings in his ears,
and he keeps his eyes on the pattern of the object.

His mind is fixed on finishing his work,
and he is concerned about giving it a perfect finish.

²⁹It is also the same for the potter, who sits at his work,
turning the wheel with his feet.

He always takes great care with his work
and makes many vessels.

³⁰He fashions the clay with his hands
and kneads it beneath his feet.

His mind is fixed on finishing the glazing,
and he is concerned about keeping the furnace clean.

³¹All these people rely on their hands,
and all are skilled in their own craft.

³²Without them a city could not be inhabited,
for people could not live or walk in it.

³³Yet they are not chosen for the council of the people
or hold high rank in the congregation.

They do not occupy the judge's seat,
nor do they understand the laws of the courts.
They cannot explain moral or legal principles,
and they are not familiar with proverbs.
³⁴But they sustain the structure of society,
and their concern is for the practice of their craft.

39

The Student of the Law Gains Wisdom



How different it is for the one who devotes himself
to studying the law of the Most High.
He seeks out the wisdom of all the ancients
and is occupied with the prophets' writings.
²He is careful to remember the sayings of the famous,
and he can perceive the subtle truths of parables.
³He searches out the hidden meanings of proverbs
and is very familiar with the secrets of parables.
⁴His services are employed by the great,
and he appears before the rulers.
He travels in foreign countries
and witnesses good and evil among humanity.
⁵He determines to rise early
to seek the Lord who made him
and to pray to the Most High.
He opens his mouth in prayer
and asks forgiveness for his sins.

⁶If it pleases the great Lord,
such a person will be filled with the spirit of understanding.

- He will pour forth his own words of wisdom
and give thanks to the Lord in prayer.
- ⁷The Lord will direct his counsel and his knowledge
as he meditates on the Lord's mysteries.
- ⁸He will display the wisdom he has gained
and glory in the law of the Lord's covenant.
- ⁹Many will praise his understanding,
and he will never be forgotten.
- People will always remember him,
and his name will be honored for all generations.
- ¹⁰Nations will declare his wisdom,
and the congregation will proclaim his praise.
- ¹¹If he lives long, he will leave a name that surpasses a thousand;
if he dies, he has lived a full life.

A Hymn of Praise to the Lord

- ¹²I, Sirach, have yet more on my mind to express,
for I am as full as the full moon.
- ¹³Listen to me, my faithful children, and blossom
like a rose planted by a stream.
- ¹⁴Give off fragrance like frankincense,
and bloom like a lily.
- Spread fragrance, and sing a hymn of praise;
bless the Lord for all his works.
- ¹⁵Give glory to his name;
give praise and thanks to the Lord.
- As you sing and play harps,
thank him with these words:
- ¹⁶"All the works of the Lord are very good,

- and everything he commands is done at the appointed time.
- ¹⁷You must not say, ‘What is this?’ or ‘Why is that?’ —
for all such questions will be answered at the appointed time.
At the Lord’s word the waters stood in a heap,
and reservoirs of water were created.
- ¹⁸When he commands, his will is carried out entirely,
and no one can hold back his saving power.
- ¹⁹He sees what everyone does,
and nothing can be hidden from his eyes.
- ²⁰He sees everything throughout all eternity,
and nothing is too amazing for him.
- ²¹You must not say, ‘What is this?’ or ‘Why is that?’ —
for everything has been created for a purpose.

- ²²“The Lord’s blessing overflows like a river
and soaks the earth like a flood.
- ²³His anger drives out the nations
just as he turned irrigated land into a salty desert.
- ²⁴To the faithful, his journey is smooth,
but for sinners, the way is full of obstacles.
- ²⁵From the beginning, good things were created for good people,
while bad things were created for sinners.
- ²⁶The basic necessities of life
are water, fire, iron, salt,
flour, milk, honey,
juice from the grape, olive oil, and clothing.
- ²⁷All these things are good for the godly,
but they turn out bad for sinners.

- ²⁸“Some winds are created for vengeance,
and in their fury they can inflict terrible punishment.
On the day of judgment they will pour out their force

and give vent to the anger of their Maker.

²⁹Fire, hail, famine, and disease—

all these were created for punishment.

³⁰So also the fangs of wild animals, scorpions, and serpents,

and the sword that punishes the ungodly by destroying them.

³¹These things delight in doing the Lord's bidding,

and they are always ready to serve him on earth.

When the time comes, they never disobey him."

³²I, Sirach, have been sure of all this from the beginning;

I have meditated on these things and put them in writing.

³³All the works of the Lord are good,

and he will fully supply every need in due time.

³⁴No one can say, "This is not as good as that,"

for all things will prove good at their proper time.

³⁵So now sing praise with all your heart and voice,

and bless the name of the Lord.

40

Hardships of Life



ARD work was created for everyone,

and a heavy yoke has been laid on the children of Adam—
from the day they emerge from their mother's womb
to the day they return to the mother of all.

²They are filled with thoughts and fears of the heart
and anxiety over the day they will die.

³From the one who sits on a glorious throne
to the one who lies humbled in dust and ashes,

⁴from the one who wears a purple robe and a crown

- to the one who is dressed in sackcloth,
there is anger, envy, trouble, unrest,
fear of death, fury, and quarreling.
⁵And when such people rest in bed,
their sleep causes them confusion.
⁶They get little or no rest,
and they are as troubled in sleep as they are in the daytime.
They are troubled by their dreams,
imagining that they were escaping from battle.
⁷The instant they reach safety, they wake up
and are astonished that there is nothing to fear.
⁸For all creatures, both human and animal—
but seven times more for sinners—
⁹come death and bloodshed, quarrels and war,
disasters and famine, havoc and plague.
¹⁰All these were created for the wicked,
and because of them the flood came.
¹¹All that is from the earth returns to the earth,
and all that is from water returns to the sea.

Goodness Outlasts Evil

- ¹²All bribery and injustice will be blotted out,
but faithfulness will last forever.
¹³The riches of the unjust will dry up like a seasonal brook
and fade away like a clap of thunder in a storm.
¹⁴A generous person will rejoice,
but lawbreakers will be completely ruined.
¹⁵The children of sinners put forth few branches.
They are withered roots on sheer rock.
¹⁶The reeds growing along any riverbank
wither before any grass.

- ¹⁷But kindness is like a garden of blessings,
and acts of charity last forever.

Joys of Life

- ¹⁸Wealth and wages can make life sweet,
but finding treasure is better than either.
- ¹⁹A person's name is established through children and through
building a city,
but a blameless wife will be counted better than either.
- ²⁰Wine and music cheer the heart,
but the love of wisdom is better than either.
- ²¹The flute and the harp make a sweet melody,
but a pleasant voice is better than either.
- ²²The eye seeks grace and beauty,
but green, sprouting grain is better than either.
- ²³A friend or companion is always welcome,
but a wife with her husband is better than either.
- ²⁴Family and friends are for times of trouble,
but acts of charity rescue better than either.
- ²⁵Gold and silver give a person security,
but good advice is more valued than either.
- ²⁶Wealth and strength make a person confident,
but the fear of the Lord is better than either.
- Those who fear the Lord lack nothing;
they do not need to look for help.
- ²⁷The fear of the Lord is like a garden of blessing;
it covers a person better than any glory.
- ²⁸My child, do not live like a beggar,
for it is better to die than to beg.

- ²⁹When people must depend on another for food,
their existence is hardly to be called living.
People lose self-respect by living off another person's food.
An intelligent, learned person guards against this.
- ³⁰For the shameless, begging is sweet in the mouth,
but it burns them within like a fire.

41

Welcoming Death



- death, how bitter is the reminder of you
to people who enjoy their possessions—
to those who are prosperous in everything and have no worries
and who are still able to enjoy food.
- ²O death, how welcome your sentence is
to those who are needy and losing strength!
For they are worn out by old age and endless anxiety
and have become grumpy and impatient.
- ³Do not fear the sentence of death.
Remember those who went before you and those who will
come after you.
- ⁴This sentence is from the Lord to everyone.
So why object to the will of the Most High?
Whether your life lasts ten or a hundred or a thousand years,
no one will ask about it in the place of the dead.

The Wicked and the Righteous

- ⁵The children of sinners are detestable,

- and they are found among the ungodly.
- ⁶The inheritance of sinners' children will perish,
and perpetual shame will plague their offspring.
- ⁷Children will blame their ungodly father,
for they endure shame because of him.
- ⁸How terrible it will be for you ungodly,
for you have abandoned the law of the Most High God.
- ⁹When you were born, you were born under a curse;
when you die, a curse will be your inheritance.
- ¹⁰All things from the earth return to the earth;
so the ungodly pass from curse to destruction.
- ¹¹Physical death brings grief,
but sinners and their bad reputation will also be forgotten.
- ¹²Be careful of your reputation, for it will live on after you.
It will last longer than a thousand treasures of gold.
- ¹³The actual life span of a good person is limited,
but a good reputation lasts forever.

Things That Warrant Shame

- ¹⁴My children, be true to your upbringing and be at peace,
for hidden wisdom is as useless as a treasure that lies undiscovered.
- ¹⁵Better are those who hide their foolishness
than those who hide their wisdom.
- ¹⁶Therefore, show respect for what I say,
for it is not always appropriate to be ashamed,
nor is everything regarded with the same respect by everyone.

- ¹⁷Be ashamed of sexual immorality before your father or mother
and of a lie before a prince or ruler;
¹⁸of a crime before a judge or official;
of sin before the congregation and community;
¹⁹of dishonest dealings before a partner or friend;
and of theft in your neighborhood.
²⁰Be ashamed of breaking an oath or covenant
and of reclining at meals;
²¹of receiving or giving ungraciously;
of ignoring those who greet you;
²²of looking at a prostitute;
of rejecting a request from your relative;
²³of taking away someone's inheritance or gift;
and of gazing at another man's wife.
²⁴Be ashamed of making advances toward a man's servant girl;
don't go near her bed.
²⁵Be ashamed of reprimanding friends,
and do not insult someone after you give them a gift.
²⁶Be ashamed of repeating what you have heard
and of betraying confidences.
²⁷Then you will display a proper sense of shame
and be well liked by everyone.

42

Things That Do Not Warrant Shame



- ON'T sin to maintain your dignity,
and don't be ashamed of any of the following:
²of the law of the Most High and of his covenant;
of rendering judgment that acquits the ungodly;
³of sharing expenses with partners and fellow travelers;

- of dividing a friend's inheritance;
⁴of using accurate scales and weights;
of gaining much or little profit;
⁵of making profit from trade;
of frequently disciplining your children;
and of lashing a wicked slave until he bleeds.
⁶Bolting the door is wise when you have an untrustworthy wife.
Where there are many hands, lock everything up.
⁷Keep careful records of your deposits,
and put in writing any donations you give or receive.
⁸Do not be ashamed to correct the ignorant and foolish
or the aged who are found guilty before the young.
Then you will show that you are well instructed,
and you will gain everyone's approval.

Regarding Daughters

- ⁹A daughter causes her father unspoken anxiety,
and worry over her robs him of sleep.
When she is young, he worries that she may not find a husband.
When she is married, he worries that her husband may be
displeased with her.
¹⁰While she is a virgin, her father worries that she may be seduced
and become pregnant while living in his house.
When she has a husband, her father worries that she may be un-
faithful
or, though she is married, that she may be childless.
¹¹Keep strict watch over a headstrong daughter,
or else she might make you a laughingstock to your enemies.
You would become the talk of the town and a reproach among
the people,
and she would make you ashamed to appear in public.

- ¹²Don't let her display her beauty to any man,
and don't let her socialize with married women.
- ¹³For as from clothes comes the moth,
so from a woman comes a woman's wickedness.
- ¹⁴The wickedness of a man is better than the goodness of a
woman.
A woman brings shame and disgrace.

The Works of the Lord

- ¹⁵I will now recall the works of the Lord
and declare what I have seen.
His works were made by the word of the Lord.
- ¹⁶The sun shines down on all things,
and the work of the Lord is full of his glory.
- ¹⁷Not even the holy ones were empowered by the Lord
to declare all his wonderful works.
The Lord Almighty has established these works
so that the universe may stand firm in his glory.
- ¹⁸He searches out the watery depths and the human heart,
and he understands their innermost secrets.
For the Most High knows all that there is to know.
He perceives the signs of the times.
- ¹⁹He discloses the past and the future
and reveals the traces of hidden things.
- ²⁰No thought escapes his notice,
and nothing is hidden from him.
- ²¹He has set in order the glorious works of his wisdom,
and he is the same for all eternity.
Nothing can be added to him or subtracted from him,
and he has no need of any counselor.
- ²²How desirable are all the Lord's works,

- and even the smallest spark deserves attention.
- ²³ All these things live and remain forever,
and they obey him regarding every need.
- ²⁴ All things come in pairs, one opposite the other,
and he has made nothing incomplete.
- ²⁵ Each adds to the good things of another.
Who could ever see enough of his glory?

43



- THE clear firmament of the sky is the pride of the higher realms.
The beauty of heaven is glorious to see.
- ² The rising sun testifies
that it is a wonderful work of the Most High.
- ³ At noon it parches the land.
Who can endure its burning heat?
- ⁴ A person must tend a furnace to get any heat,
but the sun burns three times as hot when it shines upon the
mountains.
It breathes out fiery vapors,
and its bright rays blind the eyes.
- ⁵ Great is the Lord who made it,
and at his command the sun speeds along its course.
- ⁶ He created the moon to mark the seasons.
It acts as an eternal sign to regulate the times.
- ⁷ The moon sets apart the days for festivals.
It is a light that wanes as it completes its course.
- ⁸ The month is named after the moon.
It is marvelous as it changes in its phases.
It is a beacon to the stars in the sky,
shining in the heavenly firmament.

- ⁹The glory of the stars makes the heavens beautiful;
they are a sparkling array in the heights of the Lord.
- ¹⁰They stand in their appointed places, just as the Holy One has
ordered them,
and they are never lax on their watch.
- ¹¹Look at the rainbow, and praise him who made it;
it is very beautiful in its brightness.
- ¹²It spans the heavens with its glorious arc.
The hands of the Most High have bent it like a bow.
- ¹³By his command he sends snowstorms
and shoots out lightning to execute judgment.
- ¹⁴The storehouses of heaven are opened at his command as well,
and the clouds fly out like birds.
- ¹⁵By his greatness he gives the clouds their strength,
and the hailstones are formed.
- ¹⁶At his sight the mountains shake,
and at his will the south wind blows.
- ¹⁷The noise of his thunder causes the earth to recoil,
and the northern storm and the whirlwind to blow.
He makes the snow fall like birds fluttering down;
it settles like a swarm of locusts.
- ¹⁸The eye admires the beauty of snow's whiteness,
and the mind is amazed as it falls.
- ¹⁹The Most High pours frost upon the earth like salt,
and icicles become sharp thorns.
- ²⁰The cold north wind blows,
and ice forms on the water.
It freezes over every pool of water
and clothes it like armor.
- ²¹The Most High levels the mountains, burns up the wilderness,
and shrivels the grass like fire.
- ²²Then a cloud soon heals everything,

and the falling dew brings relief from the heat.

²³By his design the Most High calmed the watery depths
and planted islands in it.

²⁴When those who sail on the sea tell of its dangers,
we are amazed at what we hear.

²⁵The sea contains strange and amazing creatures,
all kinds of living things and great sea monsters.

²⁶It is by the Most High that each messenger reaches his destination,
and by his word all things hold together.

²⁷We could say more but could never say enough.
But the sum of our words is, "He is all."

²⁸Where can we find the ability to praise him?
For he is greater than all his works.

²⁹The Lord is awesome and very great,
and his power is amazing.

³⁰Glorify the Lord as much as you can,
yet he will far exceed your praise.

When you exalt him, put forth all your strength.

Don't become weary, for you can never praise him enough.

³¹Who has seen him and can describe him?
Who can praise him for who he really is?

³²Many things greater than these lie hidden from us,
for we have seen but a few of his works.

³³The Lord has made all things,
and to the godly he has given wisdom.

In Praise of the Earliest Ancestors



- LET us now praise famous men,
our ancestors in their successive generations.
- ²The Lord has created great glory,
his majesty from the beginning.
- ³There were those who ruled in their kingdoms;
they were renowned for their valor.
- Others were intelligent advisers
or those who spoke prophecies.
- ⁴Some led the people by advising them
and by knowing the writings of the people.
They gave wise instruction.
- ⁵Some composed musical tunes
or wrote poetic lyrics.
- ⁶Others were rich and powerful,
living peacefully in their homes.
- ⁷All these men gained glory in their generations;
they were the pride of their times.
- ⁸Some of them have left behind a famous name,
so that others tell of their praises.
- ⁹But others are not remembered at all;
they have completely perished as if they had never existed.
They have become as if they had never been born,
and their children are forgotten as well.
- ¹⁰But these were godly men,
whose righteous deeds have not been forgotten.
- ¹¹Their wealth will remain in the family,
and their inheritance will pass to their descendants.
- ¹²Their children have kept the covenants,
and their grandchildren also, for their sake.

¹³Their line of descendants will continue forever,
and their glory will not diminish.

¹⁴Their bodies are buried in peace,
but their name lives on from generation to generation.

¹⁵The people tell about their wisdom,
and the congregation declares their praise.

¹⁶Enoch pleased the Lord and was taken up to heaven
as an example of repentance to all generations.

¹⁷Noah was found perfect and righteous.
In the time of wrath he was chosen to begin a new human
race.

Therefore, a remnant was left on earth
after the flood came.

¹⁸Everlasting covenants were made with him
that all flesh should never again be destroyed by a flood.

In Praise of the Patriarchs

¹⁹Abraham was the great father of many nations,
and there has never been anyone equal to him in honor.

²⁰He obeyed the law of the Most High
and entered into a covenant with him.

He ratified the covenant by undergoing circumcision,
and when he was tested he was found faithful.

²¹Therefore, the Lord promised him with an oath
that the nations would be blessed through his descendants.

He promised to make them as numerous as the dust of the earth,
to exalt them like the stars.

He promised to give them an inheritance from sea to sea
and from the Euphrates River to the ends of the earth.

²²He gave Isaac the same assurance
for the sake of his father, Abraham.

The Lord caused Jacob to receive
the blessing of all people and the covenant.

²³He confirmed Jacob's position by blessing him,
and he gave him his inheritance.

He divided his portions
and distributed them among twelve tribes.

45

In Praise of Moses



FROM Jacob's descendants the Lord brought forth a godly man,
who gained everyone's favor.

This man was Moses, who was beloved by God and people
and blessed whenever people remember him.

²The Lord made Moses' glory equal to that of the holy ones.
He made him great, terrifying his enemies.

³With his words Moses put a stop to the miracles of others,
and the Lord glorified him in the sight of kings.

The Lord gave Moses commandments for his people
and revealed to him his glory.

⁴Because of Moses' faithfulness and meekness, the Lord set him
apart as holy,
choosing him from among all people.

⁵The Lord allowed him to hear his voice
and led him into the dark cloud.

He gave him the commandments face to face,
the law of life and knowledge,

so that he might teach Jacob the covenant
and Israel his decrees.

In Praise of Aaron

⁶The Lord exalted Aaron, a holy man like Moses.

Moses was Aaron's brother and came from the tribe of Levi.

⁷The Lord made an everlasting covenant with Aaron,
and he made him and his descendants priests over the people.
He honored and adorned him,
giving him a glorious robe.

⁸He clothed him with majestic attire
and established him with the symbols of authority—
the linen undergarments, the long robe, and the ephod.

⁹The Lord encircled Aaron's attire with pomegranates,
along with many gold bells.

These would sound with every step,
ringing throughout the Temple
as a reminder to his people.

¹⁰He gave Aaron a sacred garment of gold, blue, and purple,
the work of an embroiderer.

The Lord gave him the oracle of judgment, Urim and Thummim,
¹¹with twisted scarlet, the work of an artisan.

He gave Aaron precious stones engraved like signets
and set in gold, the work of a jeweler.

These stones contained inscriptions
that denoted each of the tribes of Israel.

¹²The Lord also gave Aaron a gold crown to put over his turban.
It was engraved like a signet with the word Holiness.

The crown was an ornament of honor, the work of an expert
and a richly adorned delight to the eyes.

¹³Before Aaron's time none of these beautiful things existed,

and no stranger was ever clothed with them.

Only Aaron's sons and his descendants would ever be allowed to wear them.

¹⁴ Aaron's sacrifices were to be completely consumed with fire, twice every day forever.

¹⁵ Moses ordained Aaron and anointed him with holy oil.

This was an everlasting covenant for him and for his descendants as long as the heavens endure.

He was supposed to serve the Lord as priest and bless his people in the name of the Lord.

¹⁶ The Lord chose Aaron out of all the living to offer sacrifice to the Lord.

He chose him to offer incense and a pleasing aroma as a memorial offering

to make atonement for his people.

¹⁷ The Lord entrusted Aaron with his commandments and with the authority of law and judgment.

He instructed Aaron to teach Jacob his decrees and enlighten Israel concerning his law.

¹⁸ Strangers conspired against Aaron and envied him in the wilderness.

Dathan and Abiram and their followers, along with the company of Korah, acted in anger against him.

¹⁹ The Lord saw their actions and was displeased, so he destroyed them in anger.

He performed wonders against them and consumed them in flaming fire.

²⁰ He increased Aaron's glory and gave him an inheritance.

He prescribed that Aaron should receive the best of the firstfruits so that he would have plenty of bread.

²¹ For the priests eat the sacrifices of the Lord, which he gave to Aaron and his descendants.

- ²²But Aaron did not receive any of the land as an inheritance.
He was allotted no portion among the people,
for the Lord himself was his portion and inheritance.

In Praise of Phinehas

- ²³Phinehas son of Eleazar ranks third in glory
because of his zeal in fearing the Lord.
He stood firm when the people turned away.
He acted with noble courage
and made atonement for Israel.
- ²⁴Therefore, the Lord made a covenant of peace with him.
He made him the leader of the sanctuary and of his people,
and Phinehas and his descendants were given
the honor of the priesthood forever.
- ²⁵In the covenant that was given to David,
who was the son of Jesse and a descendant of Judah,
royalty passed only from son to son.
In the same way, Aaron's priestly inheritance was for his descendants alone.

- ²⁶May the Lord grant you wisdom of mind
to judge his people with justice
so that their prosperity may never fade
and their glory may endure for all generations.

In Praise of Joshua



OSHUA was mighty in war.

He succeeded Moses as a prophet
and was worthy of his name,
for he was a great savior of the Lord's chosen ones.

Joshua took vengeance on the enemies who rose up against
them

so that he might give Israel its inheritance.

²How glorious he was when he raised his arm
and brandished his sword against the cities!

³Before Joshua's time, who ever stood so firmly?
He fought the Lord's battles.

⁴Wasn't he the one through whom the sun stood still
and one day became as long as two?

⁵He called upon the Most High, the Mighty One,
when enemies assaulted him on every side.

The great Lord answered him
by sending a terrible storm of hailstones.

⁶Joshua overwhelmed that nation in battle.

He destroyed his adversaries as they were going down the pass
so that the nations might know the Lord's power
and that he was fighting as the Lord watched over him.

Joshua was a devoted follower of the Mighty One,
⁷and he showed his allegiance in the days of Moses.

Joshua and Caleb son of Jephunneh
opposed the congregation,
kept them from sinning,
and halted their wicked complaining.

⁸These two alone were spared
out of six hundred thousand infantry.

They led the people into their inheritance,
the land flowing with milk and honey.

⁹The Lord gave strength to Caleb,
and he remained strong even in his old age.
He went up into the hill country,

and his descendants obtained it for an inheritance.

- ¹⁰He did this so the Israelites might see
that it is good to follow the Lord.

In Praise of the Judges and Samuel

- ¹¹Let us also consider all the judges with their respective names,
whose hearts did not fall into idolatry
or turn away from the Lord.

May their memory be blessed!

- ¹²May their bones, wherever they lie, give life to others,
and may their honored names
continue to live on in their children.

- ¹³Samuel was beloved by his Lord,
and this prophet of the Lord established the kingdom
and anointed leaders over his people.

- ¹⁴By the law of the Lord he judged the people,
and the Lord watched over Israel.

- ¹⁵His faithfulness proved that he was a prophet,
and his messages showed that he was a trustworthy seer.

- ¹⁶He called upon the Lord, the Mighty One,
when his enemies were attacking him on every side,
and he offered a young lamb as a sacrifice.

- ¹⁷Then the Lord thundered from heaven
and made his voice heard with a great noise.

- ¹⁸Samuel conquered the leaders of Tyre
and all the rulers of the Philistines.

- ¹⁹Before he died he proclaimed
before the Lord and his anointed:

“I have not taken anything from anyone,

not even a pair of shoes.”
And no one accused him.
²⁰Even after Samuel died, he prophesied,
revealing to the king that he, too, would die.
Samuel spoke from the grave
to prophesy and blot out the wickedness of the people.

47

In Praise of Nathan and David



THEN Nathan came along
to prophesy in the days of David.
²As the fat is set aside in preparing a peace offering,
so David was set apart from the Israelites.
³He played with lions, as though they were young goats,
and with bears, as though they were lambs of the flock.
⁴When David was young, did he not kill a giant
and get rid of his people's shame?
He hurled a stone from his sling
and struck down that boastful Goliath.
⁵David called upon the Lord Most High,
who strengthened his right hand
to kill the mighty warrior
and exalt the power of his nation.
⁶They glorified him for the tens of thousands he had conquered
and praised him for the blessings received from the Lord.
When a glorious crown was given to him,
⁷David annihilated his enemies on every side.
He crushed the Philistines, his adversaries,
and destroyed their power even to this day.
⁸In all that he did David gave thanks,

giving glory to the Holy One, the Most High.
He sang praises with all his heart
because he loved his Maker.
⁹David stationed singers before the altar
to make sweet melody.
¹⁰He gave fitting dignity to the festivals
and established their appointed days throughout the year.
Everyone praised the Lord's holy name,
and the sanctuary resounded from the break of dawn.
¹¹The Lord removed David's sins
and exalted his power forever.
The Lord made a covenant with him that made him king,
and he gave him a throne of glory in Israel.

In Praise of Solomon

¹²After David, a wise son came along
who lived in security because of David.
¹³Solomon reigned in an age of peace
because God allowed no border disputes to happen.
God did this so that Solomon might build a Temple to his name
and prepare an eternal sanctuary.
¹⁴O Solomon, how wise you were when you were young!
You overflowed like the Nile with understanding.
¹⁵Your understanding spread throughout the earth;
you filled it with riddles and proverbs.
¹⁶Your fame spread to distant islands,
and you were loved for your peaceful reign.
¹⁷Your answers astounded the nations,
as did your songs, proverbs, and stories.
¹⁸In the name of the Lord God,
who is known as the God of Israel,

you gathered gold like tin

and amassed silver like lead.

¹⁹But you brought in women to sleep with

and let others rule over you by means of your body.

²⁰You stained your honor

and defiled your posterity.

You brought God's wrath on your children,

who had to suffer for your foolishness.

²¹You caused the kingdom to be divided.

Out of Ephraim a rebellious kingdom came into power.

²²But the Lord will never cease to be merciful

or cause any of his works to be destroyed.

He will never cause his chosen one's descendants to be eliminated

or destroy the family line of him who loved the Lord.

So he provided Jacob with a remnant

and gave David a root from his family.

²³Solomon died

and left behind a son.

This son was foolish in many ways and lacked sense.

His name was Rehoboam, and his policies caused the people
to rebel.

Jeroboam son of Nebat caused Israel to sin

and led Ephraim down the path of sin.

²⁴Their sins piled up more and more

until they were exiled from their land.

²⁵For they explored every kind of evil

until vengeance overtook them.



- WHEN Elijah the prophet arose like a fire,
and his word burned like a torch.
- ²He brought a famine upon Israel,
and he reduced them to a small number by his zeal.
- ³By the word of the Lord he held back the rain
and three times brought down fire from heaven.
- ⁴How glorious your amazing deeds made you, Elijah!
Who else can boast such deeds?
- ⁵You raised a corpse from death
and the grave by the word of the Most High.
- ⁶You brought down kings to destruction
as well as the famous from their sickbeds.
- ⁷You heard rebuke at Mount Sinai
and judgments of vengeance at Mount Horeb.
- ⁸You anointed kings to mete out retribution
and prophets to succeed you.
- ⁹You were taken up in a whirlwind of fire,
in a chariot with fiery horses.
- ¹⁰The Scriptures say that you are to come at the appointed time
to calm the anger of the Lord before it furiously breaks out.
He will turn the hearts of parents to their children
and restore the tribes of Jacob.
- ¹¹Blessed are they who saw you
and were honored with your love.
For now we also will certainly live.

In Praise of Elisha

- ¹²When Elijah was enveloped in the whirlwind,
Elisha was filled with his spirit.
- Throughout his life, Elisha never feared any ruler,
and no one could even intimidate him.

¹³Nothing was too difficult for him,
and his body retained prophetic power even after death.

¹⁴During his lifetime, Elisha performed wonders,
and after death he performed amazing deeds.

¹⁵Despite all this the people did not repent.

They did not abandon their sins
until they were carried from their land as captives
and scattered throughout the whole world.

Only a small number of people were left,
but one of them was a ruler from David's royal line.

¹⁶Some of them did what was right,
but others heaped up sins.

In Praise of Hezekiah

¹⁷Hezekiah fortified his city
and brought water within its walls.

He tunneled through solid rock with iron tools
and made cisterns to collect the water.

¹⁸During Hezekiah's reign Sennacherib invaded the country.
He sent his commander and then left.

He threatened Jerusalem
and arrogantly made great boasts.

¹⁹The hearts of the people were shaken, and their hands trembled.
They were in anguish like women in labor.

²⁰But they called upon the Lord, who is merciful,
spreading out their hands toward him in prayer.

The Holy One quickly heard them from heaven
and rescued them through Isaiah.

²¹The Lord attacked the army of the Assyrians,

and his angel destroyed them.

²²For Hezekiah did what pleased the Lord
and walked faithfully in the ways of his ancestor David.

Hezekiah had been commanded to do this by Isaiah,
the great and trustworthy prophet.

²³During Isaiah's time the sun went backward,
and he lengthened the king's life.

²⁴Empowered by the Spirit, he saw the future
and comforted the mourners of Jerusalem.

²⁵He showed what would happen until the end of time
and revealed hidden events before they even occurred.

49

In Praise of Josiah



HE memories of Josiah are like blended incense
made by the skill of a perfumer.

The remembrance of him is as sweet as honey in every mouth
and like music at a banquet.

²He did the right thing by reforming the people
and removing wicked and loathsome practices.

³He kept his heart directed toward the Lord,
and in lawless times he promoted godliness.

In Praise of Other Leaders

⁴Except for David, Hezekiah, and Josiah,
all the kings were very sinful.
All of them abandoned the law of the Most High,

so the royal line of Judah came to an end.

⁵They gave their power to others
and their glory to a foreign nation.

⁶These nations burned Jerusalem, the chosen city of the sanctuary.

They made its streets desolate,
just as Jeremiah prophesied.

⁷For they had mistreated Jeremiah,
who was set apart to be a prophet while still in his mother's
womb.

He was sent to uproot, to ruin, and to destroy,
but also to build and to plant.

⁸Ezekiel saw the vision of glory,
which the Lord showed him above the chariot of the cherubim.

⁹For the Lord remembered his enemies and sent a storm,
and he helped those who followed in the right path.

¹⁰May the bones of the twelve prophets
give life to others wherever they lie.

For they encouraged the people of Israel
and rescued them with confident hope.

¹¹How will we praise Zerubbabel?

He was like a signet ring on the right hand,

¹²and so was Jeshua son of Jehozadak.

In their days they built the house,
raising up a Temple holy to the Lord
and destined for everlasting glory.

¹³Nehemiah is often remembered
because he raised up our fallen walls,
put gates and bars in place,

and rebuilt our ruined houses.

- ¹⁴No one on earth has ever been created who was comparable to
Enoch,
for he was taken up from the earth.
- ¹⁵Nor has anyone like Joseph ever been born.
He was a leader of his brothers and the support of his people.
Even his bones were cared for.
- ¹⁶Shem and Seth were honored among people,
but Adam stands above every other created living being.

50

In Praise of Simon the High Priest



- S**IMON the high priest, the son of Onias,
was the leader of his brothers and the pride of his people.
During his lifetime he repaired the Lord's house;
in his day he fortified the Temple.
- ²He laid the foundations for the high double walls,
the high retaining walls of the Temple area.
- ³During Simon's time a water cistern was dug,
a reservoir as broad as the sea.
- ⁴He devised a plan to save his people from destruction
and fortified the city against siege.
- ⁵How glorious Simon was when the people would surround him
as he came out of the veiled sanctuary.
- ⁶He shone like the morning star among the clouds,
like the moon at its fullest.
- ⁷He was like the sun when it shines on the Temple of the Most
High,

- like the rainbow gleaming in beautiful clouds.
⁸He was like roses in the springtime,
like lilies by a spring of water,
like a green shoot on Mount Lebanon on a summer day.
⁹Simon was like fire and incense in the censer,
like a vessel of hammered gold
adorned with every kind of precious stone.
¹⁰He was like an olive tree weighed down with fruit,
like a cypress tree reaching up to the clouds.
¹¹When he put on his glorious robe
and dressed himself in all his splendor,
he made the court of the sanctuary glorious
as he went up to the holy altar.
- ¹²When he received the sacrifices from the priests
and stood by the hearth of the altar,
he was surrounded by brothers as with a garland,
and he was like a young cedar on Mount Lebanon
surrounded by palm trees.
¹³All the sons of Aaron in their glory
held offerings for the Lord in their hands
as they stood before the entire congregation of Israel.
¹⁴When Simon finished the service at the altar,
he would arrange the offering to the Most High, the Almighty.
¹⁵Simon would reach out to receive the cup
and pour out a drink offering of wine.
He would pour it out at the foot of the altar,
a pleasing aroma to the Most High, the King of all.
¹⁶Then the sons of Aaron would shout
and blow their trumpets of hammered metal.
They made a mighty fanfare
as a reminder to those in the presence of the Most High.
¹⁷Then all the people would quickly

fall with their faces to the ground
and worship their Lord,
the Almighty, God Most High.

¹⁸Then the singers would praise him with their voices,
making a sweet, resounding melody throughout the Temple.

¹⁹The people of the Lord Most High would offer
their prayers to the Merciful One.

This was done until the order of the worship of the Lord was
completed,
and they finished his ritual.

²⁰Then Simon would come down and raise his hands
over the entire congregation of Israelites.
He would pronounce the blessing of the Lord
and glorify his name.

²¹The people would bow down again to worship
and receive the blessing from the Most High.

A Blessing and a Curse

²²Now bless the God of all,
who works great wonders everywhere,
who has caused us to grow from the day we were born,
and who deals with us according to his mercy.

²³May he grant us joyfulness of heart,
and may there be peace in our time
in Israel, just as there was long ago.

²⁴May he confirm his mercy toward us
by rescuing us in our time.

- ²⁵There are two nations my soul abhors
and the third is not even a nation:
²⁶those who live in Edom and Philistia
and those foolish Samaritans who live in Shechem.

Postscript

- ²⁷I, Jeshua son of Eleazar
son of Sirach of Jerusalem (whose mind overflowed with wisdom),
have written instruction in understanding and knowledge in
this book.
²⁸Blessed are those who ponder these things,
and those who take them to heart will become wise.
²⁹For if they put them into practice, they will be equal to any task,
for the fear of the Lord guides their steps.

51

A Prayer of Jeshua Son of Sirach



give thanks to you, O Lord and King,
and I praise you, O God my Savior.
I give thanks to your name,
²for you have been my protector and helper.
You have rescued me from destruction,
from the traps set for me by slanderers,
by those who make up lies.
In the sight of my enemies
³you have been my helper and rescued me.

In keeping with your abundant kindness and great name,
you rescued me from gnashing teeth about to devour me,
from the hands of those wanting to kill me,
and from my many troubles.

⁴You rescued me from the choking flames that surrounded me,
from the fire that I had not kindled,
⁵from deep in the belly of Hades,
and from a filthy tongue and lying words,
for wicked people have slandered me before the king.

⁶My soul was approaching death;
my life was on the brink of the grave.

⁷My enemies surrounded me on every side,
and there was no one to help me.

I looked for someone to assist me,
but there was no one.

⁸Then I remembered your mercy, O Lord,
and your deeds from long ago.

You rescue those who wait for you
and save them from their enemies.

⁹I called out in prayer from the earth.
I pleaded to be rescued from death.

¹⁰I cried, "Lord, you are my Father.
Don't abandon me in the times of trouble,
when there is no help against the proud.

¹¹I will praise your name continually
and sing hymns of thanksgiving."

My prayer was heard.

¹²You saved me from destruction
and rescued me in the time of trouble.

Therefore, I give you thanks and praise,
and I bless the name of the Lord.

Hebrew manuscripts of Sirach include the following hymn between verses 12 and 13.

A Hymn of Thanksgiving to the Lord

Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the God of praises;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the guardian of Israel;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to him who formed all things;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the Redeemer of Israel;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to him who gathers those dispersed from Israel;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to him who rebuilt his city and his Temple;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to him who increases the power of David's family;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to him who has chosen the sons of Zadok to be priests;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the shield of Abraham;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the rock of Isaac;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the Mighty One of Jacob;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to him who has chosen Zion;
his mercy endures forever.
Give thanks to the greatest King of kings;

his mercy endures forever.
He has increased the power of his people.
Praise for all his loyal ones—
for the children of Israel, the people close to him.
Praise the Lord!

The Author's Search for Wisdom

¹³When I was still young, before I had traveled much,
I openly sought wisdom in my prayer.

¹⁴At the Temple I prayed to receive her,
and I will seek her to the end.

¹⁵My heart delighted in wisdom
from the time she first blossomed to the time she ripened into
fruit.

My feet followed the right path.
I followed wisdom from the time I was young.

¹⁶I made some effort to listen and received wisdom.
I found a great deal of instruction.

¹⁷I have advanced in wisdom;
I give glory to the Lord, who gives me wisdom.

¹⁸For I have determined to live according to wisdom.
I was zealous for the good
and will never be disappointed.

¹⁹My soul has fought to possess wisdom,
and I tried to strictly control my conduct.

- I spread out my hands to the heavens
and was grieved over my ignorance of her.
- ²⁰I directed my soul toward wisdom,
and I found her as I lived purely.
Through wisdom I gained understanding right from the start;
therefore, I will not be forsaken.
- ²¹My heart was stirred to seek her;
therefore, I have gained a valuable prize.
- ²²The Lord has rewarded me with things to say,
so I will praise him by speaking.
- ²³Draw near to me, you unlearned,
and live in the house of instruction.
- ²⁴Why do you complain of lacking these things,
and why do you let yourselves be so thirsty?
- ²⁵I have declared,
“Buy wisdom for yourselves without money.”
- ²⁶Submit your neck to wisdom’s yoke,
and let your soul receive instruction,
for it is easily found.
- ²⁷See with your own eyes how I have not worked hard
and have found great peace in my life.
- ²⁸Acquire instruction with a large sum of silver,
and you will use it to gain a great deal of gold.
- ²⁹May your soul rejoice in the Lord’s mercy,
and may you never be ashamed to praise him.
- ³⁰Do your work before the assigned time,

and the Lord will reward you in his time.

Preface to the Book of Baruch

Martin Luther, 1534



HOEVER the good Baruch may be, this book is very skimpy. It is hardly credible that the servant of St. Jeremiah, whose name is also Baruch (and to whom this letter is attributed), should not be richer and loftier in spirit than this Baruch. Furthermore, the book's chronology does not agree with the [accepted] histories. Thus I very nearly let it go with the third and fourth books of Esdras, books which we did not wish to translate into German because they contain nothing that one could not find better in Aesop or in still slighter works. As to the Fourth Book of Esdras, St. Jerome says it contains vain fancies; nor did Lyra want to comment on it. Besides, it does not exist in Greek.

Whoever is so inclined may and should translate them; only let him not include them among these [recognized] books. Baruch, however, we shall let run with the pack because he writes so vigorously against idolatry and sets forth the law of Moses.

Baruch

1

Baruch and the Jews in Babylon

THESE are the words that Baruch son of Neriah, son of Mahseiah, son of Zedekiah, son of Hasadiah, son of Hilkiah, wrote in Babylon. ²He wrote it on the seventh day of the month during the fifth year after the Babylonians captured Jerusalem and destroyed it by fire. ³Baruch read this book to Jehoiachin son of Jehoiakim, the king of Judah, and to all the people who came to hear it. ⁴He also read it to the nobles, the princes of Judah, the elders, and everyone else, from the least to the greatest, who lived in Babylon by the Sud River.

⁵When the people heard what Baruch wrote, they wept, fasted, and prayed to the Lord. ⁶Then they collected all the money they could afford to give ⁷and sent it to Jerusalem to the high priest, Jehoiakim son of Hilkiah, son of Shallum, and to the other priests, and to all the Jews who were still with them in Jerusalem.

⁸At about this time in early summer, Baruch recovered the silver utensils that had been looted from the Temple, in order to return them to the land of Judah. Zedekiah son of Josiah, the king of Judah, had made these silver utensils ⁹after Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, had deported Jehoiachin, the princes, the skilled workers, the nobles, and other people from Jerusalem and had taken them as captives to Babylon.

¹⁰They sent this message to the people in Jerusalem:

“We are sending you money to buy incense, burnt offerings, sin offerings, and grain offerings to be offered on the altar of the Lord our God. ¹¹Pray for the health of King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon and for his son Belshazzar so that their days on earth may last as long as heaven itself lasts. ¹²And pray that

the Lord will give us strength and wisdom as we live under the protective shadow of King Nebuchadnezzar and his son Belshazzar. May we serve them for a long time and win their favor. ¹³Also, pray to the Lord our God for us, for we have sinned against him, and even to this day the anger of the Lord has not turned away from us. ¹⁴Finally, we send you this book to read aloud as your confession in the Lord's Temple during the special feasts and sacred festivals.

Instruction for Confession of Sins

¹⁵“This is what you will say: Lord, you are in the right, and our faces are covered with shame. This is true of us all, including the people of Judah and Jerusalem, ¹⁶our kings, our rulers, our priests, our prophets, and our ancestors. ¹⁷We have sinned before the Lord. ¹⁸We have not obeyed him, nor have we listened to the voice of the Lord our God, nor kept the commandments that the Lord gave us. ¹⁹From the day the Lord brought our ancestors out of Egypt until today, we have disobeyed the Lord our God. We have acted thoughtlessly and have not listened to his voice. ²⁰So to this day we have experienced many disasters as well as the curses spoken by the Lord when his servant Moses brought our ancestors out of Egypt into a land flowing with milk and honey. ²¹Despite all the warnings of the prophets he sent us, we have not listened to the voice of the Lord our God. ²²We have each followed the inclinations of our own wicked heart, serving other gods and doing evil in the sight of the Lord our God.

2

¹“As a result, the Lord has carried out his threat on our kings, our rulers, and each person of Israel and Judah. ²As it is written in the law of Moses, the atrocities we experienced in Jerusalem have never before been witnessed under heaven. ³Some people even ate the flesh of their own sons and daughters. ⁴God allowed us to be captured by the kingdoms around us. Our land became a desert, and we were scorned by the surrounding nations where the Lord has scattered us. ⁵Instead of being exalted, we were humiliated because we sinned against the Lord our God by not obeying what he said.

⁶“Even now the Lord our God is in the right, and our faces are covered with shame, just like our ancestors. ⁷All the disasters that the Lord threatened have happened to us. ⁸Yet we have not renounced our wicked thoughts to win back the favor of the Lord our God. ⁹The Lord has kept the disasters ready for just the right moment and then allowed them to fall on us. But we deserved them, for the Lord is just in all that he has commanded us to do. ¹⁰We have not listened to his voice, nor have we obeyed the commandments he gave us.

Prayer for Restoration

¹¹“O Lord God of Israel, you brought your people out of Egypt with amazing power, miraculous signs and wonders, and overwhelming terror. Because of this, you have brought lasting honor to your name. ¹²Now we acknowledge that we have sinned by being ungodly and doing wrong; we have disobeyed all your commands, O Lord our God. ¹³But please let your anger turn away from us, for we are but a small group among the nations where you have scattered us. ¹⁴Hear our

prayers and petitions, O Lord. Deliver us for your own sake, and grant us favor with those who have taken us as captives. ¹⁵Then the whole world will know that you are the Lord our God, for Israel and his descendants bear your name. ¹⁶Look down upon us from your holy dwelling place, O Lord; think of us and hear us. ¹⁷Open your eyes and look at us. Those who are dead, whose spirits have been taken from their bodies, cannot give glory and recognition to the Lord. ¹⁸But the person who is deeply sorrowful, who walks bowed down, who is feeble and has failing eyes, and who has spiritual hunger—such a person gives glory to the Lord and acknowledges his righteousness.

¹⁹“It is not because of the merits of our ancestors or kings that we pour out our prayers and beg your mercy, O Lord our God, ²⁰for you have punished us because of your anger and indignation with us. You revealed this through your servants the prophets, who told us, ²¹“This message is from the Lord: If you work hard and serve the king of Babylon, you will remain in the land I promised to your ancestors. ²²But if you do not listen to the voice of the Lord and do not serve the king of Babylon, ²³I will remove all happy and joyful voices from the towns of Judah and from those surrounding Jerusalem. I will silence the voice of the bridegroom and the bride, and the land will become a desert with no people living in it.’

²⁴“But we did not listen to your command that we should serve the king of Babylon. As a result, you carried out what you had threatened through your servants the prophets. The bones of our rulers and our ancestors have been scattered from their tombs, as you said. ²⁵Indeed, they have been thrown out into the heat of the day and the frost of the night. People have died in severe pain by famine, by sword, and by plague. ²⁶Because of the wickedness of the people of Israel and Judah, you have humbled your Temple and left it as it is today.

²⁷“And yet, O Lord our God, you have dealt with us according to your kindness and great mercy. ²⁸Everything has happened exactly as you warned us when you commanded your servant Moses to write your law in the presence of the people of Israel. ²⁹This law says, ‘If you do not obey my voice, this great multitude will be turned into a very small number among the nations where I will scatter them. ³⁰But I know they will not listen to me, for they are stubborn. In their exile they will finally come to their senses, ³¹and then they will realize that I am the Lord their God. I will give them an understanding heart and an attentive ear. ³²Then they will praise me in the land of their captivity and will recall my name. ³³Remembering the sins of their ancestors, they will turn away from their own wickedness and stubborn ways. ³⁴Then I will bring them back again to the land that I promised to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, and they will rule over it. Their numbers will not grow smaller, for I will increase their population. ³⁵I will make an everlasting covenant with them to be their God, and they will be my people. I will never again remove my people Israel out of the land that I have given them.’

3

Prayer for Restoration Continues

¹“And now, O Lord Almighty, God of Israel, our souls are in pain. With troubled spirits, we cry out to you. ²Listen, O Lord, and have mercy on us who have sinned against you. ³You will reign forever, but we will remain dead forever. ⁴O Lord Almighty, God of Israel, hear the prayer of those who have died in Israel and of their children, who have sinned against you. They failed to listen to the voice of the Lord their

God, and so disaster fell upon us. ⁵Do not dwell on the sins of our ancestors, but for now think only of your power and your name. ⁶You are the Lord our God, and we will praise you, O Lord. ⁷For you have caused us to fear you so that we will call upon your name. We praise you in our captivity, for we have turned from the evil of our ancestors, who sinned against you. ⁸Look at us today in our land of exile, where you have scattered us to be reproached, cursed, and punished for all the sins of our ancestors who deserted you, O Lord our God.”

In Praise of Wisdom

- ⁹Listen, O Israel, to the commandments of life;
pay attention, that you may learn wisdom.
- ¹⁰How did it happen, O Israel,
that you are in the land of your enemies,
that you have grown old in a foreign country?
- ¹¹You are defiled with the dead;
you are counted among those who have gone to the grave.
- ¹²It is because you have abandoned the fountain of wisdom.
- ¹³If you had walked in the way of God,
you would have lived in peace forever.
- ¹⁴Learn where understanding resides,
where to find strength and insight.
Then you will know where to find a long life—
and life itself.
You will know what makes the eyes shine
and where to find peace.
- ¹⁵Who has discovered wisdom’s dwelling place?
Who has gone into the place where wisdom is stored?

¹⁶Where are the leaders of the nations?

Where are those who rule over the animals on earth

¹⁷and entertain themselves with birds?

Where are those who hoard silver and gold?

They place their trust in such things,

yet they have no end to their wants.

¹⁸Where are the careful craftsmen of silver?

There is no trace of their works.

¹⁹They have vanished into the place of the dead,

and others have risen up in their place.

²⁰Generations have seen the light of day

and inhabited the earth,

but they have not learned the way to knowledge.

²¹They do not know the path,

so their children have strayed from the truth.

²²Wisdom has not been heard of in Canaan;

neither has she been seen in Teman.

²³The descendants of Hagar search after worldly wisdom,

as do the merchants of Merran and Teman,

the storytellers, and the philosophers.

None have found the way to wisdom;

neither have they discovered her paths.

²⁴O Israel, how great is the world God created;

how vast is his domain!

²⁵It is great and has no end;

it is high and immeasurable.

²⁶In it were born giants,

men renowned from the beginning,

great in stature, expert in war.

²⁷Yet God did not choose them,

- neither did they find the paths of knowledge.
²⁸And because they did not have wisdom,
they perished through their own foolishness.
- ²⁹Who has gone up into heaven and seized wisdom?
Who has brought her down from the clouds?
³⁰Who has sailed across the sea and found her?
Who could buy her for gold?
³¹No one can know the way to wisdom
nor search out the paths she takes.
³²But God, who knows all, knows her;
he has mastered her by his own intelligence.
God is the one who constructed the earth for all time
and filled it with four-footed animals.
³³He sends forth the light, and it speeds away.
He recalls it, and it obeys trembling.
³⁴The stars shine joyfully in their appointed places.
³⁵When he calls to them, they reply: "Here we are!"
And they cheerfully shine for their Creator.
³⁶This is our God,
and no one else can be compared to him.
³⁷He who holds all knowledge
has given her to his servant Jacob
and to Israel, whom he loved.
³⁸Then wisdom came to earth
and lived among people.

4



ISDOM is the book of God's commandments,
the law that endures forever.

Those who keep her will live;

those who forsake her will die.

²Come back, O Jacob, and take hold of wisdom;
walk in the light of her brightness.

³Do not give your honor to another,
nor your privileges to a foreign people.

⁴We rejoice, O Israel,
because we know what pleases God.

Jerusalem Consols the Exiled People

⁵Take courage, my people,
who keep Israel's name alive.

⁶It was not for your destruction
that you were sold to the Gentiles.

It was because you provoked God
that you were handed over to your enemies.

⁷You angered your Creator
by sacrificing to demons rather than to God.

⁸You have forgotten the eternal God, who brought you up,
and you have grieved Jerusalem, the city that reared you.

⁹For Jerusalem saw the wrath of God that came upon you,
and she said, "Listen, all you who live near Zion.

God has brought great sorrow upon me,
¹⁰for I have seen my sons and daughters being taken captive.
The Eternal One allowed them to suffer this.

¹¹I nourished them with joy,
but I sent them away weeping and mourning.

¹²Let no one rejoice over me, a widow
forsaken by many.

I was left alone because of the sins of my children,
for they abandoned the law of God.

¹³They have not heeded his laws

- or followed his commandments
or taken the paths of justice that God showed them.
- ¹⁴Let those who live near Zion come
and remember the captivity of my sons and daughters,
which the Eternal One allowed them to suffer.
- ¹⁵For he brought a distant nation against them,
a wicked nation that spoke a strange language.
They had no respect for the aged
and no pity on children.
- ¹⁶They carried away the widow's beloved sons
and deprived her of her daughters.
- ¹⁷"But as for my part, what help can I give you?
- ¹⁸Only he who allowed you to suffer these disasters
can deliver you from your enemies.
- ¹⁹Go your way, my children, go your way,
for I am left alone.
- ²⁰I have taken off the robe of peace
and put on the sackcloth of one crying out to God.
I will cry to the Eternal One all my days.
- ²¹"Take courage, my children, and cry out to God.
He will deliver you from the oppression of your enemies.
- ²²For I have put my hope in the Eternal One to save you.
Joy has come upon me from the Holy One
because of the mercy that will soon come to you
from your everlasting Savior.
- ²³Although I sent you away with mourning and weeping,
God will bring you back to me
with joy and gladness forever.
- ²⁴For as those who live near Zion have seen your captivity,
so will they soon see God's deliverance.

It will come to you with great glory

and with the splendor of the Eternal One.

²⁵My children, endure patiently the punishment
that has come upon you from God.

Although your enemies persecute you,
you will soon see their destruction,
and you will conquer them.

²⁶My tender children have walked rough paths,
for they were taken away like a flock seized by raiders.

²⁷“Take courage, my children, and cry out to God,
for he who brought this upon you will remember you.

²⁸Just you chose to stray from God,
you can seek him again with ten times the zeal.

²⁹For he who allowed you to suffer these disasters
will bring you everlasting joy through salvation.”

Consolation for Jerusalem

³⁰Take courage, O Jerusalem,
for he who named you will comfort you.

³¹Misery will come to those who have harmed you
and to those who rejoiced at your fall.

³²Misery will come to the cities that enslaved your children,
to those who took your sons and daughters.

³³Just as they rejoiced at your fall
and were made happy by your ruin,
so will they grieve when they themselves are made desolate.

³⁴I will rob them of their pride in their great numbers,
and their arrogance will be turned to grief.

³⁵Fire from the Eternal One will fall on them for many days,

and for a long time their city will be inhabited only by demons.

- ³⁶Look to the east, O Jerusalem,
and see the joy that is coming from God.
³⁷Look! The children you sent away are now returning,
coming from the east to the west.
They are coming at the command of the Holy One,
rejoicing in the glory of God.

5



- Jerusalem, take off the garment of your sadness and pain.
Put on forever the beautiful glory that comes from God.
²Wrap the cloak of God's righteousness around you,
and crown yourself with glory from the Eternal One.
³For God will reveal your splendor
to everyone under heaven.
⁴God will give you a name that will last forever:
"The Peace of Justice, and the Glory of Godliness."

- ⁵Arise, Jerusalem! Go to a high point
and look toward the east.
See your children gathered together from west and east
by the command of the Holy One.
Rejoice that God has remembered them.
⁶Although they left you on foot,
led away by their enemies,
God will bring them back to you,
carried in glory as on a royal throne.
⁷For God has ordered the leveling of every high mountain
and of the everlasting hills.

The valleys will be filled up to make the ground level
so that Israel may walk safely in God's glory.

⁸The forests and every fragrant tree
will give Israel shade at God's command.

⁹For God will lead Israel with joy,
in the light of his glory,
with his mercy and righteousness.

6

The Letter of Jeremiah



THIS is a copy of the letter that Jeremiah sent to those who were to be taken to Babylon as captives by the king of the Babylonians. Jeremiah gave them the message that God had given him.

“Because of the sins you have committed before God, you will be taken as captives to Babylon by Nebuchadnezzar, king of Babylon. ²You will have to spend many years in Babylon—as much as seven generations. After that captivity, I, the Lord, will bring you home in peace. ³In Babylon you will see gods of silver, gold, and wood—gods that are carried about on people's shoulders and that cause other nations to fear. ⁴Be careful that you do not imitate these pagan acts, and do not become fearful of pagan gods. ⁵When you see crowds carrying the images in a procession and worshipping them, you must say in your hearts, ‘O Lord, we must worship you alone.’ ⁶For my angel is with you, and he will watch over your lives.

⁷“The pagan gods are overlaid with gold and silver, and their tongues are polished by woodcarvers, but they are fake and cannot speak. ⁸The people make gold crowns for their gods

as if they were dressing up a girl who loves fancy clothing. ⁹Sometimes the priests steal the gold and silver for themselves ¹⁰or give it to the temple prostitutes. They put clothes on these gods of gold, silver, and wood as if they were human. ¹¹Yet these gods, dressed in purple robes, cannot protect themselves from tarnish or decay. ¹²Even the temple dust needs to be cleaned from their faces. ¹³One god holds a scepter, like a district judge, yet it is powerless to condemn an offender to death. ¹⁴Another holds a sword or an ax in its hand but cannot protect itself from war or thieves. Therefore, it is evident that they are not gods, so do not fear them.

¹⁵“Just as a pot becomes worthless when it is broken, ¹⁶so these gods are worthless as they sit in their temples. Their eyes are full of dust kicked up by the feet of those who enter the temple. ¹⁷A person who is awaiting execution for offending the king must be securely locked up. In the same way, the priests must secure their temples with bars and locks, lest their gods be taken by thieves. ¹⁸The priests light more lamps than they themselves would ever need, but their gods cannot see the light. ¹⁹The gods are like the wooden beams in the temple, for termites eat out their hearts from within. Even their garments are devoured, but the gods do not even notice. ²⁰Their faces are black from the smoke that rises in the temple. ²¹Bats, swallows, and other birds perch on their bodies and heads, and so do cats. ²²All this is evidence that they are not gods, so do not fear them.

²³“They may be adorned with gold, but unless someone cleans off the tarnish, they will not shine. And they felt nothing when they were being molded. ²⁴Even though they cost much money, there is no spirit in them. ²⁵Because they cannot walk, they must be carried on people’s shoulders, which proves how worthless they are. People who worship them are put to shame, ²⁶for if these idols topple over, their

worshippers must stand them up again. And even when they are set upright, they cannot move. Offering gifts to them is like offering gifts to the dead. ²⁷Everything offered as a sacrifice to these idols is taken by the priests for their own use. The wives of the priests take their share of the food, storing it for later use, but they never give even part of it to the poor or the helpless. ²⁸Even women who are ceremonially unclean because of menstruation or childbirth handle the sacrifices. Thus you can see that they are not gods; do not fear them.

²⁹“How can they even be called gods? They allow women to place offerings before these idols made of silver, gold, and wood! ³⁰The priests sit in their temples with torn clothing, with heads and beards shaved, and with their heads uncovered! ³¹The priests moan and shriek before their gods as if they were wailing for a dead person at a funeral. ³²The priests even take the clothing of the idols to give to their wives and children. ³³And whether these gods are treated well or poorly, they cannot repay in kind. They don’t have the power to appoint a king or to depose him. ³⁴Likewise, they cannot give wealth or money to anyone. If someone makes a vow to them and does not keep it, these idols cannot hold that person accountable. ³⁵They cannot prevent a person from dying or protect the weak from the strong. ³⁶They cannot restore sight to the blind or rescue a person in distress. ³⁷They cannot show concern for widows or help orphans. ³⁸These wooden idols that are overlaid with gold and silver are as powerless as a block of stone from a mountain quarry! Anyone who worships idols will be put to shame. ³⁹So how can anyone claim, or even think, that such idols are gods?

⁴⁰“Even the Babylonians themselves dishonor them. When they find a person who cannot speak, they present him to Bel, asking him for the gift of speech, as though Bel understands them! ⁴¹Yet the people fail to understand the contradiction,

for they have no common sense. So they do not abandon these gods. ⁴²Women sit in their roped-off area along the passageways, burning grain as incense. ⁴³And when one of them is selected by a man to sleep with him, she mocks the women next to her who are less attractive and were not selected. ⁴⁴Everything that takes place around these idols is false. So how can anyone claim, or even think, that these idols are gods?

⁴⁵“Made by carvers and goldsmiths, these idols can be only what the artisans want them to be. ⁴⁶And the very craftsmen who make them don’t live very long themselves. So how can the things made by mortals be gods? ⁴⁷The only legacy they leave is lies and disgrace. ⁴⁸If war comes or a disaster occurs, the priests discuss where they can hide with their gods. ⁴⁹How can anyone think these idols are gods when they cannot even save themselves from war or disaster? ⁵⁰Considering that they are only wood covered with gold or silver, it will become obvious that they are not gods; every nation and king will realize that they are merely human creations without any divine power in them. ⁵¹Don’t the people realize that these idols are not gods?

⁵²“These idols cannot appoint a king or send rain to people. ⁵³They cannot regulate their own affairs or vindicate someone who has been wronged. They are as useless as crows that fly across the sky. ⁵⁴If fire breaks out in the temple of these gods made of wood and covered with gold or silver, their priests run to safety, but the gods burn up like the temple beams. ⁵⁵They cannot stop an enemy king and his armies. ⁵⁶So why should anyone say, or even think, that they are gods?

“These wooden gods, overlaid with silver and gold, are unable to save themselves from thieves or robbers. ⁵⁷Those who steal the gold and silver and clothing of the idols are not stopped, for the gods are helpless. ⁵⁸Therefore, it is better to be a king

who shows his courage, or even a kitchen pot that is used by its owner, than to be one of these false gods. It is even better to be a door that protects a house or a wooden pillar in a palace than to be one of these false gods. ⁵⁹The sun, moon, and stars shine brightly, fulfilling the purpose for which God made them. ⁶⁰Lightning flashes across the sky and is seen by many people. The winds blow in every land. ⁶¹The clouds obey God's orders to float over all the earth. ⁶²Fire falls from the sky and burns up mountainsides and woods, just as it is commanded to do. But idols cannot compare to such glory or power. ⁶³So no one should think or say these idols are gods, for they cannot decide a case or do any good to anyone. ⁶⁴Since you know then that these idols are not gods, do not fear them.

⁶⁵"They can neither curse kings nor bless them. ⁶⁶They cannot produce signs in the heavens for nations to see. They neither shine like the sun nor give light like the moon. ⁶⁷Wild animals are better off than idols because they can flee to shelter and take care of themselves. ⁶⁸No one can produce evidence that they are gods, so do not fear them.

⁶⁹"These wooden gods, overlaid with silver and gold, are as powerless as a scarecrow in a cucumber patch. ⁷⁰They are no better than a thornbush in a garden—which birds perch on anyway! These wooden gods, overlaid with gold and silver, are like a corpse thrown out into the darkness. ⁷¹The purple robes and silk garments rot as they hang upon the idols, so you can tell that these idols are not gods. In the end they themselves will be destroyed as well and will become a disgrace to their country. ⁷²Therefore, it is better to be an upright person who has no idols; such a person will never be in danger of disgrace."

Preface to the Book of 1 Maccabees

Martin Luther, 1534



HIS is another book not to be found in the Hebrew Bible. Yet its words and speech adhere to the same style as the other books of sacred Scripture. This book would not have been unworthy of a place among them, because it is very necessary and helpful for an understanding of chapter 11 of the prophet Daniel. For the fulfillment of Daniel's prophecy in that chapter, about the abomination and misfortune which was going to befall the people of Israel, is here described—namely, Antiochus Epiphanes—and in much the same way that Daniel [11:29–35] speaks of it: a little help and great persecution by the Gentiles and by false Jews, which is what took place at the time of the Maccabees. This is why the book is good for us Christians to read and to know.

In the first place, since Antiochus is regarded as a figure or image of the Antichrist who perpetrated the abomination and desolation of the worship of God in Jerusalem and in Judea not long before the birth and first coming of Christ, we learn from this to recognize the real Antichrist who is to devastate Christendom and destroy the worship of God [sometime] before the second and final coming of Christ. Therefore we should not be terrified when we experience such things and see them happening before our very eyes. Rather, be the chaos ever so great, and the devil as angry as he knows how, we should hold fast to this and take comfort in it, that we and all Christendom must nevertheless be sustained and finally saved.

For we too see the help, though small and slight, which God the Almighty has begun to grant us. The dear and holy gospel is the sword with which God's own can nevertheless valiantly attack the Antichrist of our day and actually accomplish something—even though it cost

much suffering and bloodshed—just as God aided his people with the sword of the Maccabees in that day. Although it did not happen without persecution and great heartache, they nevertheless cleansed the temple, restored the worship of God [4:36–61], and brought the people together again under their former government. Today, in this same way, the gospel is sweeping out idolatry—as Christ says, that his angels will purge out of his kingdom all causes of offense [Matt. 13:41]—and is bringing the real Christians together again into the old true Christian faith and unto genuine good works and worship of God.

In the second place we should take heart that God helped those people not only against Antiochus and the Gentiles but also against the traitorous and disloyal Jews who had gone over to the Gentiles and were helping to persecute, kill, and torment their own people and brethren. We should be sure of [God's help] and remain unafraid even when false Christians and rabble-rousers—who have now become our betrayers—turn against us and plague and harm us as much as, if not more than, our Antiochus or Antichrist. For Daniel [11:32–34] has said it, and for our comfort proclaimed it, that things must happen this way; that the children of our people would deal treacherously with us and blithely help to persecute us. Therefore we shall not fare much better than those pious children of Israel did under their Antiochus or Antichrist, at the hands of their false brethren.

However those same enemies and traitors are amply punished by God at the end; their tyranny and treachery does not go undetected. So with a glad eye and good courage we may face our Antichrist, tyrants, and rabble-rousers, and endure their abuse, confident that they will not go on very long, much less bring matters to the point they intend, that instead (like Antiochus and those other traitors) they will soon be getting their due reward. Indeed a good deal of that punishment has already begun and is daily increasing. Hardened and blinded, though, they remain unmoved by all this. However that makes no difference to us: they will get it just as those others did. Since they do not want it any other way, may God the Almighty

Preface to 1 Maccabees

grant that it be done quickly and soon, that his name be hallowed, his kingdom advanced, and all saddened hearts, now held captive in the kingdom of the devil and of the Antichrist, be comforted. Amen.

1 Maccabees

1

Alexander and His Successors

ALEXANDER the Macedonian, the son of Philip, was king of Greece. Alexander marched from the land of Greece and conquered Darius, king of the Persians and Medes, and became king in his place. ²He fought in many campaigns, captured many fortresses, and put the local kings to death. ³He campaigned throughout the known world, plundering the nations, and all the nations of the world submitted to him. Alexander's heart was filled with pride, ⁴for he had gathered a powerful and mighty army and now ruled many nations and kingdoms, all of which paid him a tribute tax.

⁵But after all his great conquests, Alexander became very sick and was confined to his bed. When he knew he was dying, ⁶he called for his close friends—noblemen who had grown up with him—and he divided his kingdom among them while he was still alive. ⁷At his death, Alexander had reigned for twelve years. ⁸Each of his close friends took over the region assigned to him, ⁹and each one crowned himself after Alexander's death. They and their descendants ruled for many years, spreading evil throughout the earth.

Antiochus IV Epiphanes

¹⁰Antiochus Epiphanes, son of King Antiochus, was a sinful descendant of these rulers. He had been a hostage in Rome before rising to the throne in the one hundred thirty-seventh year of Greek rule.

¹¹In those days there were some ungodly Jews who tried to lead many astray. They said, "Let's make an agreement with the Gentiles around us, for since we separated ourselves from them, disaster has followed after disaster." ¹²Many thought this was good advice, ¹³so they went to the king, who authorized them to introduce Gentile

practices. ¹⁴In Jerusalem they built an education complex for promoting Greek culture, as was customarily done among the Gentiles. ¹⁵They hid the fact that they were circumcised, abandoned their holy covenant with God, and joined with the Gentiles, becoming slaves to evil.

The First Egyptian Campaign

¹⁶Once Antiochus Epiphanes consolidated his power, he decided to make himself king of Egypt as well so that he might rule over two kingdoms. ¹⁷He invaded Egypt with a massive army—chariots, elephants, and horsemen—and a large fleet. ¹⁸He attacked Ptolemy Philometor, king of Egypt, who turned and fled in terror, leaving behind many casualties. ¹⁹Antiochus captured the fortified cities of Egypt and plundered the entire land.

²⁰After conquering Egypt in the one hundred forty-third year of Greek rule, Antiochus returned to Israel ²¹with his powerful force and marched into Jerusalem. He arrogantly entered the Temple sanctuary and carried away the gold incense altar, the lampstand for light and all its accessories, ²²the table of the Bread of the Presence, the cups used for making drink offerings, the bowls, the gold incense burners, the curtain, the crowns, and the gold decoration that was on the front of the Temple. He stripped the Temple of everything of value. ²³He took the silver and gold and the precious vessels as well as all the hidden treasures he could find. ²⁴When he had gathered everything of value, he returned to his own country. He had murdered many people and arrogantly bragged about it.

²⁵Throughout Israel, people mourned deeply,

²⁶and the rulers and elders grieved.

Young women and young men grew weak,

and the beauty of women faded.

²⁷Every bridegroom began to lament,

and every bride mourned in her bridal chamber.

²⁸The land trembled for its residents,
and all Israel was filled with shame.

Construction of the Citadel

²⁹Two years later King Antiochus sent his chief tax collector to the towns of Judea, and he arrived at Jerusalem with a massive force. ³⁰He deceived the people by speaking peaceful words, thus gaining their trust. But suddenly he attacked the city and killed many of the Israelites. ³¹He plundered the city, set it on fire, and tore down its houses and walls. ³²He took women and children captive and carried away their livestock. ³³He rebuilt and fortified the City of David with a great wall and strong towers, and it became their citadel. ³⁴He manned and strengthened the fortifications with sinful and wicked men. ³⁵They stored up weapons and provisions and collected there the wealth he and his men plundered from Jerusalem. And so they became a perpetual threat to Israel.

³⁶The citadel became an ambush for the Temple,
an ever present evil in Israel.

³⁷They murdered the innocent all around the sanctuary;
they even defiled the Holy Place.

³⁸Because of them the residents of Jerusalem fled,
and the city became the home of foreigners.
Jerusalem became a stranger to her own offspring,
and her children abandoned her.

³⁹Her Temple became as barren as a desert;
her festivals were turned to mourning.
Her Sabbaths were turned to days of shame;
her honor was turned to reproach.

⁴⁰Her dishonor was as great as her former glory;

her happiness was turned to grief.

Pagan Worship Instituted

⁴¹King Antiochus issued a proclamation that his entire kingdom should be united as one people ⁴²and that each nation should renounce its own customs. ⁴³The Gentiles accepted this command of the king, and many Israelites also willingly followed his religion. They offered sacrifices to idols and no longer observed the Sabbath. ⁴⁴The king sent messengers with letters to Jerusalem and to all the towns of Judea, ordering the people to follow the foreign customs of his kingdom. ⁴⁵He banned burnt offerings, sacrifices, and drink offerings in the Temple, and he prohibited keeping the Sabbath and celebrating religious festivals. ⁴⁶He defiled the Temple and the priests. ⁴⁷He ordered altars, temples, and idols to be built and pigs and other ceremonially unclean animals to be sacrificed. ⁴⁸Their sons were not to be circumcised, and they were to practice all kinds of unclean and vile customs ⁴⁹so that they would forget to keep the law of Moses. ⁵⁰Anyone who failed to obey the king's command would be put to death.

⁵¹Antiochus sent this command to his whole kingdom. He appointed officers to enforce his policies, and he commanded all the towns of Judea to take turns offering pagan sacrifices. ⁵²Many of the people who abandoned the law of Moses joined in these sacrifices and committed evil deeds. ⁵³They forced the faithful Israelites to hide in any possible place of refuge.

The Sacrilegious Object

⁵⁴On December 6 in the one hundred forty-fifth year of Greek rule, the king and his forces set up a sacrilegious object causing desecration on top of the altar for burnt offerings, and they built pagan altars in the surrounding Judean towns. ⁵⁵They burned incense and offered

sacrifices at the doors of the houses and in the streets. ⁵⁶Whenever a copy of the Book of the Law was found, it was torn up and burned. ⁵⁷By the king's decree, they put to death anyone found with a copy of the Book of the Covenant or anyone discovered following the law of Moses. ⁵⁸Each month they punished any Israelites who were caught remaining in the towns, ⁵⁹for on the twenty-fifth day of each month they offered sacrifices on the pagan altar that stood on top of the altar of burnt offering. ⁶⁰By order of the king, women who had their sons circumcised were put to death ⁶¹with their babies hung around their necks. And all their families and everyone else who took part in the circumcisions were killed with them.

⁶²Yet there were many Israelites who refused to eat unclean food ⁶³and who welcomed death rather than be defiled by food, profaning the holy covenant. ⁶⁴So a time of great trouble had come upon Israel.

2

Mattathias and His Sons

 IN those days Mattathias son of John, son of Simeon, a priest in the line of Joarib, had left Jerusalem to make his home in the town of Modein. ²He had five sons: John, who was known as Gaddi; ³Simon, who was called Thassi; ⁴Judas, who was called Maccabeus; ⁵Eleazar, who was called Avaran; and Jonathan, who was called Apphus.

⁶When Mattathias saw the sacrilegious acts done in Judea and Jerusalem, ⁷he said,

“How terrible that I was born to see this,
the destruction of my people,
the ruin of the holy city!

How terrible to stand by while Jerusalem is given to enemies,
while the sanctuary is handed over to foreigners.

- ⁸Her Temple is like a man who has lost his honor;
⁹the glorious vessels have been carried into exile.
Her infants have been murdered in the streets,
and her young men have been killed by the enemy's sword.
¹⁰What nation has not taken its share of her realm?
What nation has not plundered her?
¹¹All her ornaments have been taken away.
No longer free, she has become a slave.
¹²Look at our sanctuary and see how our beauty
and our glory are laid waste.
They have been defiled by the Gentiles.
¹³What is left to live for?"

¹⁴To show their grief, Mattathias and his sons tore their clothing, dressed themselves in sackcloth, and mourned deeply.

Pagan Sacrifices at Modein

¹⁵Officers of the king arrived in Modein to force the people to abandon Judaism and to offer pagan sacrifices. ¹⁶Many of the Israelites went along with these men, but Mattathias and his sons refused to go near the pagan altar. ¹⁷In response, the king's officers said to Mattathias, "You are an honored leader and an important man in this town. Your sons and brothers follow you. ¹⁸Therefore, be the first in your town to obey the king's command, just as all the Gentiles and the people of Judea and those living in Jerusalem have done. Then you and your sons will be counted among the king's favored leaders and be made rich with gold, silver, and many gifts."

¹⁹But Mattathias loudly replied, "Even if every nation in the kingdom obeys the king, yielding to his decrees and forsaking their own ancestral religion, ²⁰I and my sons and my brothers will still follow the covenant of our ancestors. ²¹Heaven forbid that we should abandon the law of Moses and the commandments! ²²We will never obey the

orders of the king, nor will we stray from our religion—either to the right or to the left.”

²³As he finished speaking, a certain Jew came forward to offer sacrifices on the pagan altar in the town of Modein, according to the king’s regulations. ²⁴When Mattathias saw this, he burned with passion. Then driven by righteous fury, he ran at the man and slaughtered him on the altar. ²⁵At the same time, he killed the officer the king had sent to enforce the pagan sacrifices, and he pulled down the altar. ²⁶In his zeal for the law of Moses, he showed the spirit Phinehas had shown against Zimri son of Salu.

²⁷Mattathias then went through the town, shouting loudly, “Everyone who is zealous for the law of Moses and wants to obey the covenant, follow me!” ²⁸Then he and his sons escaped into the hills, leaving behind everything they owned.

Martyrdom in the Wilderness

²⁹Many who were committed to righteousness and justice retreated into the wilderness and lived there ³⁰with their children, their wives, and their livestock because their troubles had become so difficult to bear.

³¹The king’s officers and soldiers in Jerusalem, in the City of David, heard about these Jews who had defied the king’s commands and gone into hiding in the wilderness. ³²Soldiers were sent after them, and when they found them, they set up camp across from them and prepared to attack them on the Sabbath. ³³But first the soldiers said to them, “Enough of this! Come forward and obey the king’s command, and you will live.”

³⁴But the Jews replied, “We will not come forward, nor will we desecrate the Sabbath by obeying the king’s orders.”

³⁵Without hesitation the soldiers attacked, ³⁶but the Jews offered no resistance, refusing to throw stones at them or even to barricade their hideouts. ³⁷They said, “Let us all die in innocence. Heaven and earth will witness to the fact that you are killing us unjustly.”

³⁸So the foreigners attacked them on the Sabbath, and they were killed, together with their wives, their children, and their livestock. A thousand people died that day.

Mattathias Chooses to Fight

³⁹When Mattathias and his friends heard this news, they mourned deeply. ⁴⁰They said to one another, “If we all do as our fellow Israelites have done and refuse to fight the Gentiles for our lives and beliefs, they will quickly wipe us off the face of the earth.” ⁴¹So that day they decided, “If anyone attacks us on the Sabbath day, we will fight them. We will not die in our hiding places as our fellow Israelites did.”

⁴²They were joined at that time by a group of Hasideans, strong Israelite warriors who were deeply committed to the law of Moses. ⁴³And all those who fled from persecution joined them, giving them added support. ⁴⁴They formed an organized army and in their anger killed guilty and ungodly Jews. The survivors fled to the Gentiles for safety. ⁴⁵Mattathias and his friends went around and tore down the pagan altars, ⁴⁶and they forcibly circumcised any boys in the hill country of Israel who had not been circumcised. ⁴⁷They hunted down the arrogant and were successful in their fight. ⁴⁸They rescued the law of Moses from the control of the Gentiles and their kings, and they never gave in to those who were guilty.

The Final Words of Mattathias

⁴⁹As the time of Mattathias’ death drew near, he said to his sons, “Pride and scorn have become rampant; it is a time of violence and fury. ⁵⁰Therefore, my sons, be zealous for the law of Moses and give your lives for the covenant of your ancestors. ⁵¹If you remember the deeds our ancestors did for each of their generations, you will receive great honor and everlasting fame. ⁵²Wasn’t Abraham found faithful when he was tested? And wasn’t he declared to be righteous? ⁵³Joseph kept the law through trying times, and he became master over Egypt. ⁵⁴As

a reward for his zeal, our ancestor Phinehas was granted a covenant that his descendants would be priests for all time. ⁵⁵For fulfilling his duty, Joshua became a judge in Israel. ⁵⁶For giving a positive report to the people, Caleb received an inheritance in the land. ⁵⁷For showing mercy, David received the promise that his descendants would rule for all time. ⁵⁸Because of his zeal for the law of Moses, Elijah was taken up into heaven. ⁵⁹Because they had faith, Hananiah, Azariah, and Mishael were rescued from the flames. ⁶⁰Because he was innocent, Daniel was delivered from the lions' jaws.

⁶¹"Take notice how, in every generation, all who trust in God are strong. ⁶²Do not fear the threats of sinners, for their glory will turn to dung and worms. ⁶³Today they are exalted, but tomorrow they cannot be found, because they will return to dust, and their planning will come to nothing. ⁶⁴Therefore, my sons, be courageous and strong in keeping the law of Moses, for by obeying it you will gain glory.

⁶⁵"Your brother Simon is a wise man, so listen to him always, for he will take my place. ⁶⁶Let Judas Maccabeus, who has always been valiant and strong, be the leader of your army and direct the war against the Gentiles. ⁶⁷Gather together all who observe the law of Moses, and avenge the wrong of your people. ⁶⁸Pay back the Gentiles in full, and always obey the law of Moses."

⁶⁹Mattathias blessed his sons, and then he died ⁷⁰in the one hundred forty-sixth year of Greek rule. He was buried in the tomb of his ancestors in Modein, and all Israel mourned deeply for him.

3

Judas Maccabeus



UDAS, who was called Maccabeus, took the place of his father, Mattathias. ²His brothers and all who had joined his father helped him, and they gladly fought for Israel.

- ³Judas brought great honor to his people.
Like a giant he put on his body armor.
He armed himself with weapons of war
and protected his camps with his sword.
- ⁴He was like a lion in his actions,
like a lion's cub roaring for prey.
- ⁵He hunted down the wicked and pursued them,
and he set on fire those who harmed his people.
- ⁶The wicked fled in fear,
and all the ungodly were frightened.
The cause of liberation prospered under his planning;
⁷he bitterly angered many kings.
He brought Israel joy by his deeds;
his memory will be blessed forever.
- ⁸He went throughout the towns of Judea and destroyed the
wicked,
turning away punishment from Israel.
- ⁹He was famous even to the ends of the earth,
and he helped those facing death.

Judas Begins to Fight

¹⁰Apollonius gathered a large army of Gentiles and Samaritans to attack Israel. ¹¹When Judas heard this, he went out to meet him, and he defeated and killed him. Many were wounded and fell, and the survivors fled. ¹²Judas plundered their belongings, including the sword of Apollonius, which he used the rest of his life.

¹³When Seron, commander of the Syrian forces, heard that Judas had formed a large army of faithful men, ¹⁴he said, "I will make a reputation for myself and become famous in my kingdom by crushing Judas and his followers, who have scorned the king's command."

¹⁵So Seron organized his troops, a large number of wicked men who sought vengeance on the Israelites. ¹⁶They marched as far as

Beth-horon, where Judas went out to meet him with only a few men. ¹⁷When the Israelites saw the advancing army, they said to Judas, “How can so few of us fight against an army that is so large and strong? And we are weak, for we have eaten nothing today.”

¹⁸Judas replied, “It is easy for many to be overpowered by a few, for it makes no difference in God’s sight whether we are saved by few or many. ¹⁹Success in battle depends not on the size of the army but on strength that comes from God. ²⁰This arrogant and wicked army has come to destroy us, our wives, and our children and to take our belongings. ²¹But we will fight for our lives and our laws, ²²and the Lord himself will crush them as we watch. So don’t be afraid of them.”

²³As soon as Judas had finished speaking, he and his troops suddenly charged Seron and his army and overpowered them. ²⁴They pursued them from Beth-horon down to the plain; there they killed eight hundred soldiers, and the rest fled into Philistia.

²⁵Then the Gentiles in the area feared Judas and his brothers. ²⁶Even the king heard of his reputation, and all the Gentiles talked about his battles.

Antiochus Epiphanes Invades Persia and Judea

²⁷When King Antiochus Epiphanes heard these reports, he became angry. He formed a very strong army from the forces of his entire kingdom. ²⁸Opening his treasury, he paid his troops a year’s wages and told them to be ready for anything. ²⁹In this way he exhausted the money in his treasury. Antiochus realized that his tax revenues were small because he had antagonized and impoverished the people when he abolished the ancient laws. ³⁰He feared that he would not have enough money for all his expenses and for the gifts he liked to give. (He gave more lavishly than any of the kings who had preceded him.) ³¹He was very perplexed about this, so he decided to go to Persia to collect a large tax fund from those regions.

³²So King Antiochus left Lysias, a nobleman of the royal family, to oversee the affairs of the kingdom—from the Euphrates River to the border of Egypt. ³³Lysias was also supposed to take care of the king's son Antiochus until he returned. ³⁴The king gave Lysias half his soldiers and all his elephants and gave him orders concerning the people of Judea and Jerusalem. ³⁵Lysias was instructed to attack them in order to crush the strength of Israel and to wipe out the people left in Jerusalem. He was to erase even the memory of them from that place. ³⁶He was instructed to settle foreigners in their territory and redistribute the land to them. ³⁷Then the king took the other half of the army and left Antioch, his capital city, in the one hundred forty-seventh year of Greek rule. He crossed the Euphrates River and went through the upper provinces.

³⁸Lysias chose Ptolemy Macron son of Dorymenes along with Nicanor and Gorgias, all capable men who were among the king's favored leaders, ³⁹and sent them with forty thousand foot soldiers and seven thousand horsemen to destroy the land of Judea, as the king had ordered. ⁴⁰So the powerful army marched out and set up camp in the plain near Emmaus. ⁴¹When the merchants of the surrounding area heard about it, they brought chains and large amounts of silver and gold to the camp to buy as slaves any Israelites who might be captured. Then forces from Syria and Philistia joined the army in its camp.

⁴²Judas and his brothers saw that the situation was desperate, for the army had camped in their territory. They also knew that the king had given orders to completely destroy the Israelites. ⁴³They said to each other, "Let us fight for our people and for our Temple; let us rescue them from ruin." ⁴⁴Then they assembled the people for battle and prayed for God's mercy and compassion.

⁴⁵Jerusalem was abandoned like a wilderness;
none of her children entered or exited the city.
The Temple was trampled down.

Foreigners occupied the citadel,
and Gentiles made their homes there.
There was no joy for Israel;
the flute and harp were silent.

⁴⁶The Israelites assembled at Mizpah near Jerusalem, since it was a traditional place of prayer for them. ⁴⁷That day they fasted and dressed in sackcloth. They also put ashes on their heads and tore their clothes in grief. ⁴⁸And in contrast to the Gentiles, who search for answers from the idols of their gods, the Israelites opened the Book of the Law to find guidance. ⁴⁹They brought out the priestly garments, the gifts that represented the first portion of the harvest, and the tithes, and they summoned the Nazirites, who had completed their vows. ⁵⁰They cried loudly to heaven, "What can we do with these Nazirites? Where can we take them to fulfill the law of Moses? ⁵¹For your Temple is torn down and defiled. Your priests mourn in humiliation. ⁵²The Gentiles have gathered together to destroy us. You know what their intentions are. ⁵³How can we stand against them if you do not help us?" ⁵⁴Then they sounded the trumpets and loudly cried out.

⁵⁵After this, Judas appointed officers over the people to command groups of one thousand, one hundred, fifty, and ten. ⁵⁶(He told those who were building houses and those soon to be married, as well as those who were planting vineyards and those who were afraid, that they should go home, just as the law of Moses instructed.) ⁵⁷Then the army moved out and set up a new camp on the south side of Emmaus. ⁵⁸Judas said, "Prepare yourselves and be brave. Be ready early in the morning to fight these Gentiles, for they want to destroy us and our Temple. ⁵⁹It is better for us to die in battle than to see the ruin of our nation and our Temple. ⁶⁰May God's will be done."

The Battle at Emmaus

GORGIAS took a detachment of five thousand foot soldiers and a thousand select horsemen and moved out of the camp by night. ²Their plan was for the men of the citadel in Jerusalem to guide them to the camp of the Jews, and then they would launch a surprise attack. ³But Judas heard of their plan, so he and his soldiers prepared to attack the king's forces in Emmaus ⁴while the army was divided. ⁵When Gorgias reached Judas's camp that night, he found no one there, so he began looking for them in the hills, saying, "They ran away from us."

⁶Daybreak found Judas on the plain with three thousand men, but they lacked the armor and swords they needed. ⁷They saw that the camp of the Gentiles was well fortified, with men wearing body armor and horsemen patrolling it. These were trained soldiers. ⁸But Judas told his soldiers, "Don't be frightened by their numbers. Don't flinch at their attack. ⁹Remember how our ancestors were saved at the Red Sea when Pharaoh pursued them with his army. ¹⁰Now let us call upon God with the hope that he will think of us, remembering his covenant with our ancestors, and that he will destroy this army facing us today. ¹¹Then all the Gentiles will know that there is one who redeems and rescues Israel."

¹²The foreigners looked up and saw Judas's army advancing against them, ¹³so they rushed out of the camp to engage them in battle. The trumpet sounded for Judas's army, ¹⁴and they began fighting. The Gentiles were routed and fled across the plain, ¹⁵and their rear guard was destroyed. Judas and his army chased them as far as Gazara and even to Azotus and Jamnia and the plains of Idumea. The enemy lost about three thousand men.

¹⁶Judas stopped the pursuit and returned with his men. ¹⁷He said to the people, "Forget the plunder. We have another battle to face. ¹⁸Gorgias and his detachment are in the hills nearby. First stand firm

against our enemies and crush them. Then you may take as much plunder as you want.” ¹⁹While Judas was still speaking, the enemy was spotted coming out of the hills. ²⁰But Gorgias saw that the soldiers he left in Emmaus had fled, and the smoke rising from his camp showed that Judas’s men had set fire to it. ²¹When Gorgias’s troops saw this, they were terrified. Then they saw Judas and his army in battle formation on the plain, ²²so they all fled into Philistia.

²³Then Judas turned back to plunder the camp. He and his men carried away a great amount of gold and silver, blue and purple silks, and other valuables. ²⁴On the way home they sang hymns of praise to God, singing, “He is good, and his faithful love endures forever.” ²⁵So Israel experienced great deliverance that day.

²⁶The Gentiles who escaped reported to Lysias all that had happened. ²⁷He was shocked and upset when he heard about it, because things had not turned out as he had planned for Israel, and he had failed to fulfill the king’s command.

Lysias’s First Campaign

²⁸So the next year Lysias gathered sixty thousand select troops and five thousand horsemen in order to subdue the Jews. ²⁹This army marched into Idumea and set up camp in Beth-zur, where Judas faced them with ten thousand men.

³⁰When Judas saw their military might, he prayed, “Blessed are you, O Savior of Israel, for you stopped the giant warrior by your servant David and handed over the Philistine camp to Jonathan son of Saul and his armor bearer. ³¹Now let this army be surrounded by your people Israel, and let their many soldiers and horsemen become confused. ³²Strike them with fear, and undermine their confidence in their own strength. Give them fear for their own destruction. ³³Let those who love you strike them down with swords so that your followers may praise you with hymns.”

³⁴The opposing forces engaged in hand-to-hand combat, and five thousand men of the army of Lysias were killed. ³⁵Lysias saw his men

in retreat, and he also saw that Judas's followers were very bold and ready to live or die bravely. So he withdrew to Antioch to recruit mercenary soldiers; then he planned to return to Judea with an even larger army.

Purification of the Temple

³⁶Judas and his brothers said, "Our enemies have been utterly defeated. Now let us go up to purify the Temple and dedicate it." ³⁷So all the army was assembled, and they went up to Mount Zion. ³⁸There they saw the empty sanctuary, the desecrated altar, the gates burned down, the weeds growing in the courtyards as in a forest or on a hill, and the priests' rooms next to the Temple in ruins. ³⁹They tore their garments and mourned deeply, putting ashes on their heads ⁴⁰and falling face down on the ground. When the trumpets gave the signal, the people cried out to God.

⁴¹Then Judas sent troops to attack the defenders of the citadel while he purified the Temple. ⁴²He chose blameless priests, who were devoted to the law of Moses. ⁴³They cleansed the sanctuary, and the stones that had been defiled were carried away to an unclean place. ⁴⁴They discussed what should be done about the altar of burnt offering, for it had been defiled. ⁴⁵Someone suggested that it be torn down so it would not become a lasting shame to them, for the Gentiles had defiled it. So they pulled the altar down ⁴⁶and put the stones in a suitable place on the Temple hill until a prophet could come someday and tell them what to do with them. ⁴⁷Then they took uncut stones, as required in the law of Moses, and built a new altar like the old one. ⁴⁸They restored the sanctuary and all the things inside the Temple. Finally, they sanctified the Temple and its courtyards. ⁴⁹They made new sacred vessels and took into the Temple the lampstand, the altar of incense, and the table for the Bread of the Presence. ⁵⁰They burned incense on the altar and lit the lamps on the lampstand, which gave light in the Temple. ⁵¹Then they set the Bread of the Presence on the

table, hung up the curtains, and finished all the work they had set out to do.

⁵²On December 14 in the one hundred forty-eighth year of Greek rule, they arose early in the morning ⁵³and offered sacrifices on the new altar of burnt offering, as the law of Moses directed. ⁵⁴On the day of the month that the Gentiles regularly defiled it, the altar was dedicated anew with songs, harps, lutes, and cymbals. ⁵⁵And all the people fell face down in adoration and blessed God, who had given them success.

⁵⁶For eight days they celebrated the dedication of the altar, and they joyfully offered burnt offerings, praise, and thanksgiving for their deliverance. ⁵⁷They adorned the front of the Temple with gold crowns and shields, and they repaired the gates and restored the priests' rooms, furnishing them with doors. ⁵⁸The people were very joyful because the disgrace caused by the Gentiles had been removed. ⁵⁹Judas and his brothers and all Israel decreed that the dedication of the altar should be celebrated every year with joy and gladness for eight days, beginning on December 14.

⁶⁰They then built high walls and fortified towers around Mount Zion to stop the Gentiles from attacking and destroying it as they did before. ⁶¹Judas assigned a garrison to guard Mount Zion, and he fortified Beth-zur, so that the people would have a defense against Idumea.

5

Fighting the Idumeans and Ammonites

WHEN the surrounding Gentile peoples heard that the altar and sanctuary had been restored, they became very angry. ²Determined to destroy all of Jacob's descendants living among them, they began to persecute and kill the people.

³Judas fought against Esau's descendants at Akrabattene in Idumea because they were attacking the Israelites there. The Idumeans were

thoroughly humiliated in defeat and were stripped of their valuables and weapons. ⁴Judas also avenged the evil deeds of the sons of Baeen, who constantly threatened travelers by ambushing them along the roads. ⁵Judas chased them into their fortified towers and surrounded them. Then, calling a curse down on them, he set the towers on fire and burned them down with everyone inside.

⁶Next, Judas crossed over to attack the Ammonites and found a strong and numerous army under the command of Timothy. ⁷After fighting many battles with them, he routed them and cut them to pieces. ⁸He captured the town of Jazer and its nearby villages. Then he returned to Judea.

War with the Gentiles of Galilee and Gilead

⁹Now the Gentiles in Gilead banded together against the Israelites in their area and plotted to destroy them. But these Israelites fled to the fortress of Dathema. ¹⁰From there they sent this letter to Judas and his brothers:

“The Gentiles around us have banded together to destroy us. ¹¹They are preparing to come and capture the fortress where we have taken refuge. Timothy is the leader of their army. ¹²Please come at once and rescue us from them, for many of us have already been killed or wounded. ¹³All our fellow Israelites in the land of Tob are dead. Their wives and children have been taken captive, and their goods have been confiscated. The enemy has killed almost a thousand men there.”

¹⁴While this letter was being read, other messengers came from Galilee with their clothes torn. They had similar news: ¹⁵“Everyone in Ptolemais, Tyre, and Sidon has joined with the Gentiles of Galilee to destroy us.”

¹⁶When Judas and the people heard these reports, they held a large meeting to decide how to help their fellow Israelites who were being

attacked by their enemies. ¹⁷Judas said to his brother Simon, "Choose your men and rescue your fellow Israelites in Galilee; Jonathan and I will go to Gilead." ¹⁸He left Joseph son of Zechariah and Azariah, a leader of the people, to guard Judea with the rest of the army. ¹⁹He gave them these instructions: "Take charge of these people, but do not begin fighting the Gentiles until we return." ²⁰Three thousand men were assigned to accompany Simon into Galilee, and Judas led eight thousand men into Gilead.

²¹Simon invaded Galilee, and after fighting many battles, he completely crushed the Gentile forces there. ²²He chased them all the way to the gate of Ptolemais. Almost three thousand Gentiles were killed, and Simon captured all their belongings. ²³He led the Jews who were in Galilee and in Arbatta—together with their wives, children, and possessions—to Judea with great celebration.

²⁴Judas Maccabeus and his brother Jonathan crossed the Jordan River and marched for three days into the wilderness. ²⁵There they met the Nabateans, who received them peacefully. The Nabateans told them all that had been happening to the Israelites in Gilead. ²⁶They related that many had been trapped in Bozrah, Bosor, Alema, Chaspho, Maked, and Karnaim (all of which were large and fortified cities). ²⁷They said that Jews were also being held captive in the other towns of Gilead. The enemy planned to attack these towns the next day, and then they would capture and destroy all the Jews at once.

²⁸Judas and his army quickly marched back by the wilderness road to Bozrah and captured that town. They killed every male by the sword, carried away all their goods, and burned the town. ²⁹They left Bozrah by night and marched until they came to the fortress of Dathema. ³⁰At dawn they saw a great number of soldiers carrying ladders and battering rams to attack the fortress and capture the Jews. ³¹Judas saw that the fight had just begun and that the battle cry of the people was going up to heaven with trumpet blasts and shouts. ³²He shouted to his army, "Fight today for your fellow Israelites!" ³³Then Judas's men advanced from behind the enemy in three companies while sounding trumpets and crying aloud in prayer. ³⁴When the

men of Timothy's army realized it was Maccabeus, they fled from him. Judas's army inflicted a crushing defeat, killing about eight thousand men that day.

³⁵Judas then turned to Alema, assaulted and captured it, killed all the males, carried away all the goods, and burned it. ³⁶From there he marched on and captured Chaspho, Maked, Bosor, and the rest of the towns of Gilead.

³⁷Following his defeat, Timothy assembled another army and set up camp just across the streambed from Raphon. ³⁸Judas sent scouts to survey the enemy camp, and they returned to report, "All the Gentiles from the region have gathered to form a great army under Timothy's command; ³⁹they have also hired Arab reinforcements. They are camped on the opposite side of the streambed, ready to fight you." So Judas went forward to attack them.

⁴⁰As Judas approached, Timothy said to his officers, "If Judas comes to the streambed and crosses it, we will not be able to resist him; he will certainly get the better of us. ⁴¹But if his courage fails and he sets up camp on the other side, we will cross over and crush him."

⁴²When Judas came near the stream, he stationed the officers of the army on the bank, ordering them, "Don't let anyone stay behind to set up camp. Send everyone into battle." ⁴³Judas himself led the charge across the streambed, and his entire army followed. They routed the Gentile forces, who fled to the temple area in Karnaim, discarding their weapons as they ran. ⁴⁴But Judas captured Karnaim and burned out the temple area with everyone in it. So Karnaim was subdued, and all resistance against Judas ceased.

⁴⁵Then Judas gathered together all the Israelites who were in Gilead, from the least to the greatest—with their wives, children, and possessions—and he led this large company back to Judea. ⁴⁶Along the way they came to Ephron, a large city that was strongly fortified. They could not go around it, either to the right or left, so they had to go through it. ⁴⁷But the people in the city shut themselves in and barricaded the gates with stones. ⁴⁸Judas sent them a message of peace, saying, "Let us pass through your territory to get to our own. No one

will harm you. We will only pass through on foot.” But they refused to open the gates for him. ⁴⁹So Judas issued orders for all his troops to set up where they were. ⁵⁰His army prepared for battle and attacked the city all that day and through the night until the city fell to them. ⁵¹Judas and his men killed every male by the sword, carried away their possessions, and completely destroyed the city. Then they marched through the city over the bodies of the dead.

⁵²They crossed the Jordan River to the great plain near Beth-shan. ⁵³Judas hurried the stragglers and encouraged the people all the way until they reached Judea. ⁵⁴Then with joy and gladness they climbed Mount Zion, where they offered burnt offerings, for none of them had been killed and all had returned safely.

Tragedy at Jamnia

⁵⁵Now while Judas and Jonathan were in Gilead and their brother Simon was in Galilee outside Ptolemais, ⁵⁶Joseph son of Zechariah and Azariah, commanders of the soldiers in Judea, heard of the victories and the battles that had been fought. ⁵⁷They said, “Let’s also make a name for ourselves by fighting the Gentiles around us.” ⁵⁸So Joseph gave orders to his troops, and they marched against Jamnia. ⁵⁹Gorgias and his men came out of the town to fight them. ⁶⁰Joseph and Azariah were routed, and they were chased all the way to the borders of Judea. About two thousand Israelites were killed that day. ⁶¹This great defeat took place because they did not listen to Judas and his brothers. They thought they would do brave deeds themselves, ⁶²but they were not from the family through whom deliverance was to come to Israel.

Success at Idumea and Philistia

⁶³Valiant Judas and his brothers, however, were greatly honored by all Israel, and their fame spread among the Gentiles. ⁶⁴People rallied around and cheered for them.

⁶⁵Judas and his brothers marched out and attacked the descendants of Esau in the land to the south. They captured Hebron and its surrounding towns, destroying their fortifications and burning down their perimeter towers. ⁶⁶As Judas and his army headed for Philistia, they passed through Marisa. ⁶⁷That day some priests were killed in battle, for they had foolishly decided to make a name for themselves in battle. ⁶⁸Judas turned and marched to Azotus in Philistia. He tore down their altars, burned the statues of their gods, and carried away their possessions. Then he returned to Judea.

6

The Last Days of Antiochus Epiphanes

KING Antiochus was passing through the upper provinces when he heard that the city of Elymais in Persia was famous for its rich stores of silver and gold. ²The temple in this city was very rich, containing gold armor, shields, and weapons left there by Alexander the Macedonian, son of Philip, the first ruler of Greece. ³Antiochus came and tried to capture the city and strip it of its wealth, but he did not succeed because its citizens had learned of his plans to attack. ⁴They resisted him in battle, so he retreated and returned to Babylon greatly disappointed.

⁵While Antiochus was still in Persia, someone told him that his armies had been defeated in Judea. ⁶He was told that Lysias had attacked them with a strong force but had been defeated by the Jews. The Jews had now grown strong by capturing armor, war supplies, and stores of goods from the armies they destroyed. ⁷Antiochus was told that the Jews had thrown down the sacrilegious object he had set up on the altar in Jerusalem, had surrounded the Temple with high walls as in the past, and had fortified Beth-zur, his town.

⁸When the king heard this news, he was astounded and badly shaken. He became so sick with grief that he was confined to his bed, for things had not worked out as he had planned. ⁹He lay there for many days,

overcome with bitterness and constant grief, until finally he realized he was dying.

¹⁰The king called for his favored leaders and said to them, “I can’t sleep, and my heart has been broken with worry. ¹¹At first I said to myself, ‘How could I have come to such distress and deep sorrow? I have been kind, and my people have always loved me.’ ¹²But now I remember the wrongs I committed in Jerusalem—how I seized all the vessels of gold and silver and ordered the slaughter of the people of Judea without just cause. ¹³I know now that this is why these evils have fallen on me. Now I will die of great sorrow in a foreign land.”

Philip Is Appointed Regent

¹⁴King Antiochus then called for Philip, one of his favored leaders, and put him in command of all his kingdom. ¹⁵He gave Philip the royal crown, his robe, and his signet ring, with the understanding that Philip would be guardian to his son Antiochus and train him to become king. ¹⁶Antiochus Epiphanes died there in Persia in the one hundred forty-ninth year of Greek rule.

¹⁷Now when Lysias learned that the king was dead, he went ahead and crowned the king’s son Antiochus as the new king. Lysias had raised him from childhood and gave him the title Eupator.

Judas Attacks the Citadel

¹⁸Meanwhile, the soldiers from the garrison in the Jerusalem citadel were harassing the Israelites near the sanctuary. They tried in every way they could to harm the Jews and strengthen the Gentiles. ¹⁹Judas decided to destroy them, so he gathered all the people to besiege the citadel. ²⁰They joined together and attacked the citadel in the one hundred fiftieth year of Greek rule, using siege weapons and battering rams.

²¹Some of the people in the citadel escaped from the siege, and some ungodly Israelites joined them. ²²They went to King Antiochus

Eupator and said, "How long will you refuse to do justice and avenge the attacks on our people? ²³We were content to serve your father, doing all he ordered and obeying his commands. ²⁴But because of this, the other Israelites are angry with us and have besieged the citadel. They have killed as many of us as they could catch and have seized our inheritances. ²⁵They have opposed not only us but also people in all the surrounding territories. ²⁶Now they have besieged the citadel in Jerusalem and have fortified the Temple and the stronghold of Beth-zur. ²⁷Unless you act quickly, they will do worse things than these, and you will not be able to stop them."

The Battle at Beth-zechariah

²⁸The king became angry when he heard this. He called together all his favored leaders, the commanders of his army, and the officers over his horsemen. ²⁹He also hired mercenaries from various places, including the Mediterranean islands. ³⁰His army numbered one hundred thousand foot soldiers, twenty thousand horsemen, and thirty-two elephants trained in warfare. ³¹After marching through Idumea, they came to Beth-zur and attacked it for many days. They even used battering rams in the attack, but the Jews bravely ran out of the town and set the battering rams on fire.

³²Judas and his army left the siege of the citadel in Jerusalem and moved their camp to Beth-zechariah, opposite the camp of the king's army. ³³The king rose before daylight and marched his men toward Beth-zechariah, where they prepared for battle and sounded the trumpets. ³⁴The elephants were given grape juice and mulberry juice to provoke them to fight. ³⁵The elephants were distributed among the ranks of foot soldiers, each elephant to a thousand men, who were dressed in coats of mail and wearing bronze helmets. Five hundred select horsemen were assigned to each elephant. ³⁶These horsemen anticipated the moves of the elephants and went with them, never leaving them. ³⁷Fastened to each elephant by a harness was a sturdy wooden tower. A team of men fought from each tower while an

Indian driver directed the beast. ³⁸The rest of the horsemen were placed on either flank of the army to harass the enemy while being protected by the ranks of foot soldiers. ³⁹When the sun reflected from the shields of gold and bronze, the hills caught the glare and gleamed as if on fire. ⁴⁰Part of the king's army was deployed on the high hills, while the other part was on the plain. The soldiers advanced steadily and in solid formation. ⁴¹Everyone trembled at the noise of this great multitude, for the powerful and numerous army thundered as it marched in its clanging armor.

⁴²Judas and his army marched forward, and six hundred of the king's men were killed. ⁴³Judas's brother Eleazar, who was called Avaran, saw that one of the elephants was larger than the other beasts and was equipped with royal armor. He thought that the king was on it, ⁴⁴so he sacrificed himself to win the battle and earn everlasting fame. ⁴⁵As Eleazar fought his way boldly through the middle of the enemy ranks, killing men left and right, the troops parted as he came. ⁴⁶He got under the elephant, plunged his sword into it, and killed it; but the elephant collapsed on him and he died. ⁴⁷When the Jews saw the strength and determination of the king's army, however, they retreated.

The Siege of the Temple

⁴⁸The king's army followed them to Jerusalem, where it set up camp to blockade Judea and Mount Zion. ⁴⁹The king granted terms of peace to the people of Beth-zur, and they evacuated the town. (They had no food to withstand a siege, since it was a Sabbath year for the land.) ⁵⁰So the king captured Beth-zur and stationed a garrison there to hold it. ⁵¹Then he began a long siege of the Temple. He set up siege weapons, battering rams, machines to hurl fire and stones, machines to shoot arrows, and catapults. ⁵²The Jews also constructed weapons of war to match these, and they fought for many days. ⁵³But since it was the Sabbath year, there was no food in the town. Those who had sought refuge in Judea from the Gentiles had eaten all the stored

food. ⁵⁴Because of the food shortage, only a few men stayed in the Temple; all the others had scattered to their own homes.

⁵⁵Before he died, Antiochus Epiphanes had appointed Philip to raise his son, Antiochus Eupator, and to prepare him to be king. Lysias now heard that Philip ⁵⁶had returned from Persia and Media with the late king's army and was trying to seize control. ⁵⁷So Lysias gave orders to withdraw from attacking the Temple, and he went to King Antiochus Eupator and told him and his commanders, "We are growing weaker every day, we are short of food, and the place we are attacking is strong. Besides, the other affairs of the kingdom demand urgent attention. ⁵⁸Therefore, let us make a peace treaty with these people and their nation. ⁵⁹Let us agree that they may live according to their own laws once again. It is because we abolished their laws that they became angry and rebelled like this."

⁶⁰The proposal pleased the king and his commanders. He sent the Jews an offer of peace, and they accepted it. ⁶¹So the king and his commanders gave their word, and the defenders left the stronghold.

⁶²But when the king went up to Mount Zion, he saw that its defenses were very strong, so he broke his word and gave orders to tear down the wall around the Temple. ⁶³Then he quickly left and returned to Antioch. There he found Philip in control of the city, so he attacked the city and captured it.

7

Demetrius I Soter Becomes King



IN the one hundred fifty-first year of Greek rule, Demetrius son of Seleucus left Rome with a few men and arrived at a coastal city. There he proclaimed himself king. ²As he was entering the royal palace of his ancestors, the armies there captured Antiochus Eupator and Lysias, intending to bring them to him. ³When Demetrius heard this, he said, "I don't even want to see them!" ⁴So the army killed them, and Demetrius assumed the throne of his kingdom.

⁵Then all the ungodly and wicked Israelites came to Demetrius. They were led by Alcimus, who wanted to be made high priest. ⁶They accused their own people, saying, “Judas and his brothers have killed all your favored leaders and have driven us from our land. ⁷Therefore, send someone you trust who can survey all the damage that Judas has caused us and the king’s lands. Let him punish Judas and his men and all who help them.”

⁸So the king chose Bacchides, one of his favored leaders who governed the province west of the Euphrates River. He was a prominent figure in the kingdom and was faithful to King Demetrius. ⁹He sent Bacchides and the wicked Alcimus, whom he made high priest, to take revenge on the Israelites. ¹⁰They set out and arrived in Judea with a large army. Alcimus sent messengers to Judas and his brothers with deceitful words of peace, ¹¹but Judas did not believe them, for he saw that the enemy had come with a large army.

¹²Nevertheless, some teachers of religious law went to Alcimus and Bacchides to inquire about just terms. ¹³These Hasidean teachers were the first to seek peace from the two men. ¹⁴They reasoned, “A priest of the line of Aaron has come with the army. He will not deceive us.”

¹⁵Alcimus spoke words of peace and vowed to them, “We will do no harm to you or your friends,” ¹⁶and they believed him. But he took sixty of them in one day and killed them, as had been written in the Scriptures:

¹⁷“They have scattered the bodies of your holy ones.
Their blood has been shed all around Jerusalem,
and no one is left to bury the dead.”

¹⁸Then all the people became very fearful. They said, “They don’t know what it means to be truthful, for they have broken the agreement that they guaranteed with an oath.”

¹⁹Bacchides moved the camp from Jerusalem to Beth-zaith. He seized many of those who deserted to him and also some Jews, and he slaughtered them all and threw them into a large pit. ²⁰He entrusted the country to Alcimus and left some troops to help him. Then Bacchides went back to the king.

²¹Alcimus continually fought to maintain his position as high priest, ²²and some Jewish dissenters joined his cause. They took control of Judea and did much harm to Israel. ²³Judas saw all the evils that Alcimus and his companions did to the Israelites. They were worse than the Gentiles. ²⁴So Judas marched throughout the whole territory of Judea, taking revenge on those who had deserted and preventing them from leaving their towns. ²⁵Alcimus realized that Judas and his companions were gaining control, and he knew he could not stand against them. So he went back to the king and accused Judas and his men of many serious crimes.

The Battle at Caphar-salama

²⁶Nicanor, one of the king's most honored generals, despised Israel, so the king sent him to destroy the people there. ²⁷Nicanor came to Jerusalem with a large army, and he sent Judas and his brothers a deceitful message of peace: ²⁸"There is no need for us to fight each other. I will come with a few men to speak to you in peace." ²⁹So he came to see Judas, and they greeted each other peaceably. All the while, Nicanor's men were preparing to kidnap Judas. ³⁰But Judas learned of this deceitful plot, so he was cautious and would not meet Nicanor again. ³¹When Nicanor realized his plot had been discovered, he went out to fight against Judas near Caphar-salama. ³²But about five hundred of Nicanor's men were killed, and the survivors fled into the City of David.

Threats against the Temple

³³After this, Nicanor went up to Mount Zion. Some of the priests and elders came out to meet him peaceably. They showed him the burnt offerings that were being offered on behalf of the king. ³⁴But he mocked and derided them, cursing and spitting at them as he angrily swore, ³⁵“Unless Judas and his army are handed over to me, I will burn this house down when I return.” Then he left in a terrible rage.

³⁶The priests went into the Temple and stood facing the altar and the sanctuary. They wept and prayed,

³⁷“You have chosen this house to honor your name
and to be a house of prayer and petition for your people.

³⁸Take vengeance on this man and his army;
let them die by the sword.
Remember their blasphemies;
let them live no longer.”

Nicanor Is Defeated

³⁹Nicanor and his army left Jerusalem and set up camp near Beth-horon, where the Syrian army joined him. ⁴⁰Judas and 3,000 of his troops set up camp in Adasa. He prayed, ⁴¹“When the messengers of King Sennacherib blasphemed you, your angel went out and killed 185,000 of the Assyrians. ⁴²In the same way, utterly destroy this army before us today. Let everyone still alive know that Nicanor has blasphemed your sanctuary, and judge him as his wickedness deserves.”

⁴³The armies attacked each other on March 8. Nicanor’s army was completely defeated, and he himself was the first to fall in battle. ⁴⁴When Nicanor’s men saw that he was dead, they threw down their weapons and fled. ⁴⁵The Jews chased them for about eighteen miles, from Adasa as far as Gazara, and their trumpets kept sounding the battle call. ⁴⁶People came out of all the towns of Judea and drove the

enemy back to the pursuing Jewish army, which killed them all by the sword—not a single one was left alive. ⁴⁷The Jews carried away all the goods, and they cut off Nicanor's head and his right hand, which he had so arrogantly raised against them. They brought his head and hand to Jerusalem and put them on display for all to see. ⁴⁸The people were overjoyed and spent that day in festive celebration. ⁴⁹Judas decreed that there should be a celebration each spring to commemorate the victory. ⁵⁰So Judea enjoyed peace and quiet for a short time.

8

Rome's Fame

UDAS had heard of the Romans' famous reputation, that they were powerful and strong and good to those with whom they held alliances. They promised friendship to any who joined them, ²and they were very powerful. Judas had heard of their battles and their heroic deeds against the Gauls—how they had conquered them and forced them to pay a tribute tax. ³He had also heard of the great things they had done in Spain—how they had gained control of the silver and gold mines there ⁴and taken possession of the whole region by their wisdom and patience, even though Spain was quite far from them. In every part of the world, kings who opposed the Romans had been overthrown with great losses, while others paid them a tribute tax every year. ⁵Philip and Perseus, kings of the Macedonians, and others who had fought against the Romans had been conquered. ⁶The Romans had also defeated Antiochus the Great, king of Asia, who had fought against them with 120 elephants and with horsemen, chariots, and a very large army. ⁷The Romans took Antiochus alive and ordered that he and those who would reign after him should pay a large tribute tax and give them hostages. ⁸Antiochus was also forced to give them India, Media, and Lydia. These were then given to King Eumenes.

⁹The Greeks planned to attack and destroy the Romans, ¹⁰but the Romans heard about it and sent a single general to attack them. In the ensuing battle, many Greeks were killed or wounded, and the Romans took their wives and children captive, carried away their possessions, annexed their territory, tore down their fortresses, and made them their slaves, as they are to this day. ¹¹They destroyed and enslaved all other kingdoms and islands that resisted them. ¹²The Romans have maintained a firm friendship, however, with all their friends and allies.

So the Romans have conquered kingdoms both far and near, and all who have heard of them fear them. ¹³They make kings of anyone they wish, and they depose anyone they wish; in this way, they have become very great. ¹⁴Yet no Roman has ever crowned himself king or displayed his grandeur by wearing purple. ¹⁵They have formed a senate of 320 people, who meet daily to decide what is best for the people and how to govern them. ¹⁶Their government is directed by entrusting one man each year to rule over the whole country. They all obey him, and there is no envy or jealousy among them.

Alliance between the Jews and the Romans

¹⁷Judas chose Eupolemus son of John, son of Accos, and Jason son of Eleazar to go to Rome and establish a friendship and an alliance with the Romans. ¹⁸Judas did this so the Jews could get out from under oppression, for it was obvious that the Greeks were reducing Israel to slavery. ¹⁹Eupolemus and Jason traveled to Rome, which was a very long journey. When they arrived, they entered the senate chamber and said, ²⁰“Judas Maccabeus, his brothers, and the Jewish people have sent us to establish an alliance and a peace treaty with you. We want to be formally considered your friends and allies.” ²¹The senate was pleased to accept their proposal. ²²The senate sent a proclamation back to Jerusalem, engraved on bronze tablets so that it might be kept there as a permanent record of their peace treaty and alliance:

²³“May the Romans and the Jewish nation meet with success forever, both at sea and on land. May sword and enemy be far from them. ²⁴If war should come to the Romans or to any of their allies in all their dominion, ²⁵the Jewish nation will wholeheartedly act as their allies in whatever way the occasion requires. ²⁶If an enemy is at war with the Romans, the Jews will not supply them with grain, arms, money, or ships, just as Rome has decided. They will keep these obligations without any compensation. ²⁷Likewise, if war should come to the Jewish nation, the Romans will willingly act as their allies in whatever way the occasion requires. ²⁸If the Jews have an enemy, the Romans will not supply them with grain, arms, money, or ships, just as Rome has decided. The Romans will keep these obligations without deception. ²⁹On these terms the Romans make an agreement with the Jewish people. ³⁰If both parties agree to add or delete anything in this agreement, they may do so, and whatever changes they make will be valid.

³¹“Concerning the wrongs that King Demetrius is committing against the Jews, we have written to him as follows: ‘Why are you making things so hard for our friends and allies the Jews? ³²If they come to us again and complain about you, we will defend their rights. We will make war against you by sea and on land.’”

9

The Death of Judas Maccabeus



MEANWHILE, when Demetrius heard that Nicanor and his army had fallen in battle, he sent Bacchides and Alcimus back into Judea, along with the right wing of his army. ²They marched along the road that leads to Gilgal and set up camp at the ascent to Arbela.

They then captured the town and killed many of its people. ³In early spring during the one hundred fifty-second year of Greek rule, they set up camp outside Jerusalem. ⁴Then they marched on to Berea near Jerusalem with twenty thousand foot soldiers and two thousand horsemen.

⁵Now Judas and three thousand of his select troops had set up camp in Elasa. ⁶When they saw the size of the enemy army, they became very frightened. Many deserted the camp until no more than eight hundred men remained. ⁷Seeing that only a fraction of his army was left and that the battle was imminent, Judas became discouraged because he had no time to gather more forces. ⁸But even though he was dismayed, he said to those who remained, "Let us get up and face our enemies. We may still have the strength to fight them."

⁹His men tried to dissuade him, saying, "We don't have the strength! We should save our lives and return to fight them with more of our fellow Israelites. There are too few of us now."

¹⁰But Judas said, "I would never think of running from them. If our time has come, let us die bravely for our people and leave no blemish on our reputation."

¹¹The army of Bacchides moved out of camp and took positions for combat. The horsemen were divided into two groups, and the slingers and the archers went ahead of the army, as did the best fighters. ¹²The ranks of foot soldiers were flanked by horsemen on either side, and Bacchides was on the right flank. The army advanced as it sounded its trumpets, and Judas's soldiers sounded their trumpets as well. ¹³The earth shook at the noise of the armies, and the battle continued from morning until evening. ¹⁴Judas saw that Bacchides and the stronger part of his army was on the right, so Judas led his bravest men ¹⁵and drove back the right flank, chasing them to Mount Azotus. ¹⁶The soldiers on the left flank realized that the right flank was beaten, so they turned to chase Judas and those who were with him, attacking them from the rear. ¹⁷The fighting became very intense, and both sides lost many men. ¹⁸Then Judas was killed, and the rest of his men fled.

¹⁹Jonathan and Simon took their brother Judas and buried him in the tomb of their ancestors at Modein. ²⁰For many days, all Israel mourned deeply for him, saying, ²¹“The mighty hero—the savior of Israel—has fallen!” ²²The rest of the deeds of Judas—his battles, his heroic acts, and his great achievements—have not been recorded here, but there were many of them.

Jonathan Becomes the New Leader

²³After the death of Judas, the ungodly came out of hiding throughout Israel, and evildoers reappeared. ²⁴In those days there was a very severe famine, and the country eventually sided with the ungodly. ²⁵Bacchides chose wicked men to administer the affairs of the country. ²⁶These people searched out Judas’s friends and brought them to Bacchides, who punished and publicly humiliated them. ²⁷There had not been such distress in Israel since the day the last prophet was seen in Israel.

²⁸All Judas’s friends said to Jonathan, ²⁹“Ever since your brother Judas died, there has been no one like him to fight Bacchides and our enemies and to deal with our own people who despise us. ³⁰Therefore, we have chosen you today to succeed him as our ruler and commander, so that you can lead us into battle.” ³¹So Jonathan became leader in place of his brother Judas.

The Battle at Medeba

³²When Bacchides heard about this, he tried to kill Jonathan. ³³But Jonathan and his brother Simon and the others who were with them learned of the plot, and they fled into the wilderness of Tekoa. They set up camp by the pool of Asphar. ³⁴Bacchides learned of this on the Sabbath, so he and his army crossed the Jordan.

³⁵Jonathan sent his brother John to lead a convoy to ask their friends the Nabateans if they would store the Israelites’ sizable amount of

baggage. ³⁶The sons of Jambri, however, came from Medeba and seized John and all his possessions and took him away.

³⁷Sometime later Jonathan and his brother Simon learned that the sons of Jambri had planned a large wedding. The bride was the daughter of one of the great princes of Canaan, and they were planning to bring her from Nadabath in a splendid procession. ³⁸Remembering the bloody death of their brother John, Jonathan and Simon went up and hid themselves in the hills. ³⁹As they peered out, they saw a great crowd and a caravan loaded with possessions. The bridegroom came out with his relatives and friends to meet the procession with tambourines and musical instruments and a pompous military display. ⁴⁰Then the Israelites rushed from their ambush and began killing them, and many of them died. The survivors fled into the mountains, leaving all their possessions behind to be captured by the Jews. ⁴¹So the wedding was turned into an occasion for mourning, and the joyful music into a dirge.

Crossing the Jordan

⁴²When Jonathan and Simon had taken revenge for the death of their brother, they returned to the marshes of the Jordan. ⁴³As soon as Bacchides heard about this, he came on the Sabbath to the banks of the Jordan with a large army. ⁴⁴Jonathan said to his men, "Get up! We must fight for our lives, for this is a new and desperate situation. ⁴⁵The battle is now in front of us, the Jordan River is behind us, and marshes and woods are on either side of us. There is no escape! ⁴⁶Therefore, pray to God that you may be rescued from your enemies." ⁴⁷Then they began to fight.

Jonathan's army attacked the forces of Bacchides, but then Jonathan and his men retreated and escaped. ⁴⁸Jonathan and his men jumped into the Jordan and swam over to the other side, but the enemy did not follow. ⁴⁹That day a thousand of Bacchides' men were killed.

The Death of Alcimus

⁵⁰After returning to Jerusalem, Bacchides built strongholds throughout Judea. He built fortresses with high walls and gates and bars in Jericho, Emmaus, Beth-horon, Bethel, Timnath, Pharathon, and Tephon. ⁵¹Bacchides placed garrisons in them to harass the Israelites. ⁵²He fortified the towns of Beth-zur and Gazara and also the citadel, and he put troops in them, along with provisions. ⁵³He took as hostages the sons of the leading men of the country and imprisoned them in the citadel at Jerusalem.

⁵⁴In midspring of the one hundred fifty-third year of Greek rule, Alcimus ordered that the walls separating the Gentiles from the inner court of the Temple be torn down, thereby destroying the works of the prophets. But he had hardly started this ⁵⁵when he suffered a stroke. Paralyzed and speechless, he could no longer give commands even in his own home, so the work stopped. ⁵⁶Then Alcimus died in great agony.

⁵⁷After he learned that Alcimus had died, Bacchides returned to the king, and Judea had peace for two years.

The Battle at Bethbasi

⁵⁸Then the ungodly began to plot, saying, "Jonathan and those with him live in peace and are full of confidence. Let us bring Bacchides back, and he can capture them all in one night." ⁵⁹So they went to Bacchides and advised him to carry out this plan. ⁶⁰Bacchides set out with a large army, and he sent secret letters to his military allies in Judea, instructing them to seize Jonathan and his men. But this failed because Jonathan learned of the plot. ⁶¹His men captured about fifty people in Judea who were the ringleaders of the plot, and they killed them. ⁶²Then Jonathan, Simon, and their followers withdrew to Bethbasi in the wilderness, and they rebuilt and fortified it.

⁶³When Bacchides found out what they had done, he gathered his entire army and sent word to his allies in Judea. ⁶⁴They set up

camp outside Bethbasi, and they made siege weapons and attacked the town for many days. ⁶⁵Jonathan left his brother Simon in the town and went out into the country with a few men. ⁶⁶He struck down Odomera and his family and the sons of Phasiron in their tents. Then he attacked Bacchides' army. ⁶⁷Simon and his troops rushed out of the town and set the siege weapons on fire. ⁶⁸They fought against Bacchides and overcame him, inflicting great losses on him, and his planning and effort came to nothing.

⁶⁹Bacchides was angry with the renegades who had advised him to come into their country, so he killed many of them. Then he decided to return to his own country. ⁷⁰When Jonathan heard about this retreat, he sent ambassadors to Bacchides to offer peace and obtain release of the captives. ⁷¹Bacchides accepted the terms and kept his word, swearing that he would do Jonathan no harm as long as he lived. ⁷²Bacchides released the prisoners he had taken previously from Judea, returned to his own country, and never again set foot in Judea. ⁷³So war ended in Israel, and Jonathan settled in Michmash, where he judged the people and rooted out the wicked from Israel.

10

Jonathan Is Appointed High Priest

IN the one hundred sixtieth year of Greek rule, Alexander Epiphanes, the son of Antiochus Epiphanes, arrived and occupied Ptolemais. The people accepted him, and he began his reign there. ²When King Demetrius Soter heard of this, he gathered together a very large army and went to fight him.

³Demetrius sent Jonathan a letter containing words of peace and promises to honor him. ⁴He reasoned, "We need to make peace with him before he makes an alliance with Alexander against us. ⁵For he will remember all the harm we have done to him, to his brothers, and to his nation." ⁶So Demetrius gave Jonathan authority to recruit and

equip an army, hoping to make him a military ally. He also ordered that the hostages in the citadel should be released to Jonathan.

⁷Jonathan came to Jerusalem and read the letters to all the people and to those in the citadel. ⁸They were greatly alarmed when they heard that the king had given him authority to recruit an army, ⁹but the guards at the citadel released the hostages to Jonathan, and he returned them to their parents. ¹⁰Thereafter, Jonathan lived in Jerusalem and began to rebuild and repair the city. ¹¹He ordered workers to build walls around Mount Zion, using squared stones for better fortification. ¹²The foreigners living in the strongholds built by Bacchides fled, ¹³each one leaving his place and returning to his own country. ¹⁴Only in Beth-zur did some remain who had forsaken the law of Moses and the commandments, for this was a place of refuge for them.

¹⁵King Alexander heard of the promises that Demetrius had made to Jonathan. He was told of the battles fought and the brave deeds done by Jonathan and his brothers, as well as the hardships they had endured. ¹⁶He said, "Could we ever find another man like this? We should make him our friend and our ally." ¹⁷So the king sent Jonathan a letter that read:

¹⁸"This letter is from King Alexander to his brother Jonathan. Greetings.

¹⁹"We have heard that you are a valiant warrior who is worthy to be our friend. ²⁰Therefore, today we make you high priest of your nation, and you will be one of the king's favored leaders and will promote our interests and keep our friendship."

Alexander also sent him a purple robe and a crown of gold.

²¹So in midautumn of the one hundred sixtieth year of Greek rule, at the Festival of Shelters, Jonathan put on the holy vestments, and he recruited troops and heavily armed them.

A Letter from Demetrius Soter to Jonathan

²²When Demetrius heard about this, he was very distressed and said, ²³“What have we done that Alexander has thwarted our plans? He has gotten ahead of us and strengthened himself by gaining the friendship of the Jews. ²⁴I’ll do the same thing; I’ll send a letter of friendship to them and offer them honor and gifts so that they will help me.” ²⁵So he sent this letter to them:

“This letter is from King Demetrius to the nation of the Jews. Greetings.

²⁶“We have heard that you have kept your agreement with us and have continued our friendship and have not sided with our enemies. This makes us glad. ²⁷Now continue to keep good faith with us, and we will richly reward you for all your efforts on our behalf. ²⁸We will grant you many privileges and give you many gifts.

²⁹“I now exempt you and all the Jews from all the tribute taxes. I also release you from the tax on salt and the crown taxes. ³⁰And from this day forward, I release you from paying the standard tax of one-third of all grain and half of all fruit that is harvested. I will not collect this from Judea or from the three districts that were added to it from Samaria and Galilee from this day and forever. ³¹Jerusalem and its surrounding towns will be exempted from paying taxes on the tithes and revenues it receives. ³²I release my control of the citadel in Jerusalem and give it to the high priest so that he can station his own guards in it. ³³I am setting free, without ransom, every one of the Jews who has been brought captive from Judea into my kingdom, and all their taxes—even on their cattle—are remitted.

³⁴“I order that all festivals, Sabbaths, new moon celebrations, and appointed days, along with three days before and after

each festival, are days of immunity and freedom for all the Jews in my kingdom. ³⁵On these days, no one will have authority to take anything from the Jews or harass them.

³⁶“Thirty thousand Jews will be allowed to enroll in the king’s army; provisions will be provided for them as for all the king’s troops. ³⁷Some of them will be assigned to the great fortresses of the king. Others will be given positions of trust within the kingdom. I will allow their officers and leaders to be chosen from their own ranks, and I will let them live according to their own laws, just as the king has commanded for those in Judea. ³⁸The three districts that have been added to Judea from Samaria will be fully annexed, so that they may answer to only one authority—the high priest.

³⁹“I give Ptolemais and its adjoining lands to the Temple in Jerusalem in order to meet the expenses of public worship. ⁴⁰I grant 375 pounds of silver annually from the king’s treasury. ⁴¹All the additional funds that were denied in previous years will be given from now on for the upkeep of the Temple. ⁴²In addition, my officials will no longer collect the tribute tax of 125 pounds of silver from the income of the Temple; it will belong to the priests who minister there. ⁴³If anyone flees into the Temple in Jerusalem or into its surrounding territory because of a debt owed to the king or anyone else, that person will be released from the debt and will receive back all property taken as collateral. ⁴⁴The costs for rebuilding and restoring the Temple will be taken from the king’s revenues. ⁴⁵The king will also cover the cost of rebuilding the walls and fortifications of Jerusalem and the rest of Judea.”

The Death of Demetrius Soter

⁴⁶When Jonathan and the people heard this message, they did not believe it, because they remembered the tremendous harm that

Demetrius had done to Israel and how much he had oppressed the people. ⁴⁷They continued to side with Alexander, because he had been the first to offer them a peace treaty. So they remained his ally as long as he lived.

⁴⁸King Alexander gathered a large army and moved his camp near the army of Demetrius. ⁴⁹Then the armies of the two kings began to fight each other. The army of Demetrius fled, and Alexander's army pursued them and won the battle. ⁵⁰They continued to pursue them until sundown, and Demetrius was killed that day.

Alexander Marries Cleopatra

⁵¹Alexander sent ambassadors to Ptolemy Philometor, king of Egypt, with this message:

⁵²"I have returned to my kingdom and regained the throne of my ancestors. I have secured my reign by defeating Demetrius. I have regained control of our country ⁵³by destroying Demetrius and his army in battle, and now we have seized the throne of his kingdom. ⁵⁴Therefore, let us make a mutual pact of friendship. Give me your daughter in marriage, and I will become your son-in-law. Then I will give you and your daughter gifts that are worthy of your position."

⁵⁵King Ptolemy answered,

"It was a happy day when you returned to the land of your ancestors and regained the throne of their kingdom. ⁵⁶Now I will do what you asked, but meet me at Ptolemais so that we may see one another. Then I will give you my daughter and become your father-in-law as you requested."

⁵⁷So Ptolemy left Egypt with his daughter Cleopatra and came to Ptolemais in the one hundred sixty-second year of Greek rule. ⁵⁸King Alexander met him on friendly terms there, and Ptolemy gave Alexander his daughter Cleopatra in marriage. Ptolemy celebrated her marriage at Ptolemais with great and royal splendor.

⁵⁹King Alexander wrote to Jonathan that he should come and meet him. ⁶⁰So Jonathan went in stately ceremony to Ptolemais and met the two kings there. Jonathan gave them and their favored leaders silver, gold, and many other gifts and thereby gained their favor. ⁶¹Some ungodly troublemakers from Israel gathered together to bring accusations against him, but the king paid no attention to them. ⁶²Alexander commanded that Jonathan should be clothed with a royal purple robe instead of his ordinary clothes, and it was done. ⁶³Then the king gave him a seat of honor at his side. He said to his officers, "Escort Jonathan to the middle of the city and proclaim that no one is to bring charges against him for any reason, nor should anyone even annoy him." ⁶⁴When Jonathan's accusers saw that he was being honored and that he was clothed in a royal purple robe, they all fled. ⁶⁵So the king honored him and declared in writing that he was one of his most favored leaders, and he made him general and governor of Judea. ⁶⁶Then Jonathan returned to Jerusalem with a sense of peace and joy.

Demetrius II Nicator and Apollonius

⁶⁷In the one hundred sixty-fifth year of Greek rule, Demetrius Nicator, the son of Demetrius Soter, came from Crete to the land of his ancestors. ⁶⁸When King Alexander heard about it, he was very troubled and returned to Antioch.

⁶⁹Demetrius appointed Apollonius governor of Coelesyria. Apollonius then gathered together a large army and set up camp outside Jamnia. He sent this message to Jonathan, the high priest:

⁷⁰"You are the only one who opposes us. People laugh at me and reproach me because of you. Why should you dominate us in the hill country? ⁷¹If you are so confident in your forces, come down and meet us on the plain. There we can test each other's strength, for I have the power of the cities behind me. ⁷²Ask and learn who I am and who my allies are, and you will find that you cannot stand up to us. After all, your relatives have already been put to flight twice in their own land. ⁷³You

will not be able to defend yourselves against my horsemen and my army on the plain, where there are no rocks, or even pebbles, to hide behind or any place to which you can escape.”

⁷⁴When Jonathan heard the message from Apollonius, he was stirred to action. He chose ten thousand men and marched out from Jerusalem, and his brother Simon met him to help him. ⁷⁵They set up camp outside Joppa, for the gates of the town had been closed because a garrison of Apollonius was in Joppa. When Jonathan’s army began to attack it, ⁷⁶those in the town became terrified. So they opened the gates to him, and Jonathan captured Joppa.

⁷⁷When Apollonius heard about this, he assembled three thousand horsemen and a large army and marched to Azotus, as though he were going to pass through the area. But immediately he went out on to the plain because he had many horsemen he could rely on. ⁷⁸Jonathan pursued him to Azotus, and they fought there. ⁷⁹Apollonius had secretly left a thousand horsemen behind Jonathan’s army. ⁸⁰Jonathan realized that there was an ambush behind him, for they surrounded his army and shot arrows at his soldiers from morning until evening. ⁸¹But his men stood firm, as Jonathan had ordered them, while the enemy’s horses grew tired.

⁸²Then Simon brought his army forward and attacked the enemy’s ranks of foot soldiers, for their horsemen had become exhausted. He crushed the enemy, and they fled. ⁸³The horsemen scattered across the plain and fled to Azotus, where they took refuge in Bethdagon, the temple of their idol. ⁸⁴But Jonathan set fire to Azotus and the surrounding towns. He carried away their possessions and burned down the temple of Dagon, along with all who had fled into it. ⁸⁵Almost eight thousand people were killed, whether by sword or by fire. ⁸⁶Then Jonathan moved his army and set up camp outside Ashkelon. The people came out of the town to greet him with great ceremony. ⁸⁷After this, Jonathan returned to Jerusalem with his people and a large amount of plunder.

⁸⁸When King Alexander heard about these deeds, he honored Jonathan even more. ⁸⁹He sent him a buckle of gold, a gift that is

customarily given only to those whom the king regards as members of the royal family. He also gave Jonathan the town of Ekron and all its surrounding villages.

11

The Death of Ptolemy VI Philometor

THEN King Ptolemy Philometor of Egypt gathered together an army as innumerable as the sands of the seashore, along with many ships. He planned to seize Alexander's kingdom by treachery and add it to his own kingdom. ²He marched into Syria with peaceful words, and the people opened the gates of their cities and greeted him. They did this because King Alexander had ordered them to welcome him, since Ptolemy was his father-in-law.

³As Ptolemy entered each town, he stationed a garrison of soldiers there. ⁴When he approached Azotus, the people showed him the ruins of the temple of Dagon, which Jonathan had destroyed by fire. They also showed him the town and its surroundings, which had been leveled, and the corpses lying about. Lining the road were the charred bodies of those whom Jonathan had burned in the battle, for the people had piled them along Ptolemy's route in heaps. ⁵They told King Ptolemy that Jonathan had done these things, for they wanted the king to dislike him. But the king said nothing. ⁶Jonathan met Ptolemy at Joppa with great ceremony, and they greeted one another and spent the night there. ⁷Jonathan accompanied the king as far as the Eleutherus River; then he returned to Jerusalem.

⁸Continuing in his plot against Alexander, King Ptolemy gained control of the coastal cities, as far as Seleucia on the coast. ⁹He sent ambassadors to King Demetrius to say, "Come, let us make a pact with each other. I will give you my daughter, who is now married to Alexander, and you will reign over your father's kingdom. ¹⁰For I regret that I gave Alexander my daughter, since he has tried to kill me." ¹¹He accused Alexander because he coveted his kingdom. ¹²So he

took his daughter from Alexander and gave her to Demetrius, and it was now obvious that Ptolemy and Alexander were enemies. ¹³Then Ptolemy Philometor entered Antioch and crowned himself king of Asia; so now he wore two crowns, that of Egypt and that of Asia.

¹⁴At this time King Alexander was in Cilicia because there was a rebellion there. ¹⁵But when Alexander heard what had happened, he marched out to fight against Ptolemy, who met him with a strong force and routed Alexander's armies. ¹⁶Alexander fled to Arabia to seek protection. King Ptolemy's triumph was complete ¹⁷when Zabdiel the Arab cut off Alexander's head and sent it back to Ptolemy. ¹⁸However, King Ptolemy died three days later, and his troops in each of the strongholds were killed by the local residents. ¹⁹As a result, Demetrius Nicator became king in the one hundred sixty-seventh year of Greek rule.

Peace between Demetrius Nicator and Jonathan

²⁰In those days Jonathan gathered forces from Judea to seize the citadel in Jerusalem. They built many war machines to besiege it. ²¹But some renegades who hated their own nation went to King Demetrius Nicator and told him that Jonathan was attacking the citadel. ²²When Demetrius heard this, he was angry and set out at once for Ptolemais. He wrote to Jonathan, demanding that he end the siege and meet him for a conference in Ptolemais as soon as possible. ²³When Jonathan heard this, he ordered the siege to continue. Then, despite the danger, he set out with some of the priests and elders of Israel. ²⁴He took gold, silver, rich garments, and many other presents and went to meet the king at Ptolemais, and there he won the king's favor. ²⁵Even though certain renegades of his nation made complaints against Jonathan, ²⁶the king treated him as his predecessors had done, and he exalted Jonathan in the sight of all his favored leaders. ²⁷The king confirmed Jonathan's position as high priest and all his previous distinctions, and he declared him to be one of his most favored leaders.

²⁸Jonathan requested that the king exempt Judea and the three districts of Samaria from taxes, and he promised the king eleven tons of silver in return. ²⁹The king consented and wrote this letter to Jonathan about all these things:

³⁰“This letter is from King Demetrius to his brother Jonathan and to the nation of the Jews. Greetings.

³¹“This is a copy of a letter I am sending to our relative Lasthenes concerning you. I am sending it so that you might know the contents of the letter.

³²“This letter is from King Demetrius to his esteemed relative Lasthenes. Greetings.

³³“We are determined to do good to the nation of the Jews, for they show their goodwill toward us by being our friends and keeping their agreements with us. ³⁴We have confirmed that they possess all the territory of Judea and the three districts of Aphairema, Lydda, and Ramathaim, which were taken from Samaria and added to Judea. For all who offer sacrifices in Jerusalem, we have granted freedom from the annual royal tax and from taxes on their crops and fruit. ³⁵From this moment on, we release them from taxes on tithes, the tax on salt, and the crown tax. ³⁶Not a single one of these exemptions will ever be revoked. ³⁷See that you make a copy of these instructions and give it to Jonathan. Then post this where people can see it on the holy mountain of Zion.”

Jonathan Rescues Demetrius Nicator

³⁸King Demetrius Nicator saw that peace reigned throughout the land and that no one resisted him, so he dismissed all his troops, sending each to his own home. He retained the foreign soldiers, however,

whom he had recruited from Gentile islands. As a result, he was hated by all the dismissed troops, who had served under his predecessors.

³⁹There was a man named Trypho, who had been one of Alexander's supporters. When he saw that all the dismissed troops were grumbling against Demetrius, he went to Imalkue the Arab, who was raising Antiochus, Alexander's young son. ⁴⁰Trypho urged the Arab to let him take Antiochus and make him king in his father's place. Trypho related to him all that Demetrius had done and how his soldiers hated him. Trypho remained there for many days.

⁴¹Meanwhile, Jonathan sent word to King Demetrius, asking him to remove the soldiers from the citadel at Jerusalem and from the strongholds, because they were constantly fighting against the Israelites. ⁴²Demetrius sent this message back to Jonathan: "I will gladly do this for you and your people, and I will also greatly honor you and your nation when the opportunity arises. ⁴³Therefore, please help yourself and me by sending some of your men to support me, because my troops have revolted." ⁴⁴So Jonathan sent 3,000 seasoned troops to him at Antioch, and the king was glad at their arrival.

⁴⁵Then 120,000 people of the city gathered together to kill the king, ⁴⁶but he fled into his palace. The people seized control of the streets and began to fight, ⁴⁷so the king called the Jewish troops to his aid. They rallied to assist him and spread out through the city. They killed about 100,000 people that day ⁴⁸and set fire to the city. They also seized a large amount of plunder and saved the king's life. ⁴⁹When the citizens saw that the Jews controlled the city and could do as they pleased, their courage failed, and they cried to the king. They begged him, ⁵⁰"Grant us peace, and make the Jews stop attacking us and our city." ⁵¹Then the citizens threw down their arms and made peace. So the Jews were honored by the king and all the people of his kingdom, and they returned to Jerusalem with a large amount of plunder. ⁵²But when King Demetrius's rule was secure and the land was peaceful under his government, ⁵³he broke his promises and alienated himself to Jonathan. Instead of repaying Jonathan for the favors he had been given, the king caused him much trouble.

Jonathan Opposes Demetrius Nicator

⁵⁴After this, Trypho returned with Antiochus, Alexander's young son, who was then crowned as king. ⁵⁵All the troops that Demetrius had dismissed joined Antiochus's forces and fought against Demetrius, who was routed. ⁵⁶Trypho captured the elephants and gained control of Antioch.

⁵⁷Then young Antiochus wrote to Jonathan, saying, "I confirm your position as high priest. I appoint you as ruler over the four districts and confirm you as one of the king's favored leaders." ⁵⁸He sent him a gold plate from his table service and gave him permission to drink from a gold cup and to be clothed in purple and wear a gold buckle. ⁵⁹Antiochus appointed Jonathan's brother Simon to be governor from the borders of Tyre to the borders of Egypt.

⁶⁰Jonathan left and visited cities west of the Euphrates River, and all the armies of Syria joined forces with him. When he came to Ashkelon, the people came out to honor him. ⁶¹He went from there to Gaza, where he was denied admission, so he attacked it and burned its surrounding towns and carried away their possessions. ⁶²The people of Gaza pleaded with Jonathan, and he made peace with them. But he took the sons of their rulers as hostages and sent them to Jerusalem. Then he continued northward as far as Damascus.

⁶³Jonathan heard that the officers of Demetrius had come to Kadesh in Galilee with a large army, intending to remove him from power. ⁶⁴Jonathan went to fight them, leaving his brother Simon in Judea. ⁶⁵Simon set up camp outside Beth-zur, surrounded it, and besieged it for many days. ⁶⁶The people asked for terms of peace, and he granted them. But he removed the people from the town, took control of it, and placed a garrison in it.

⁶⁷Jonathan and his army set up camp by the Sea of Galilee. Early in the morning they marched on to the plain of Hazor. ⁶⁸The army of foreigners hid a contingent of soldiers in the mountains. Then they met Jonathan's army face to face on the plain. ⁶⁹When the soldiers in the mountains came out of hiding and joined the battle, ⁷⁰everyone

on Jonathan's side fled. The only ones who remained were Mattathias son of Absalom and Judas son of Chalphi, commanders of the army. ⁷¹Jonathan tore his clothes in grief and put dust upon his head and prayed. ⁷²Then he returned to the battle and sent the enemy running.

⁷³When Jonathan's soldiers who were fleeing saw this, they returned to the battle to help him, and together they chased the enemy all the way to the enemy camp at Kadesh. There Jonathan and his men set up their camp as well. ⁷⁴That day about three thousand enemy soldiers were killed. Then Jonathan returned to Jerusalem.

12

Jonathan's Relations with Rome and Sparta

ONATHAN saw that the time was right to confirm his friendship with the Romans, so he chose certain men and sent them to Rome with this mission. ²He also sent letters to the Spartans and to other places for the same purpose.

³When the men arrived in Rome, they entered the senate chamber and said, "Jonathan the high priest and the Jewish nation have sent us to renew our former friendship and alliance." ⁴So the Romans provided these men with letters addressed to the authorities of each place, instructing them to provide safe conduct for them as they made their way back to Judea.

⁵This is a copy of the letter Jonathan wrote to the Spartans:

⁶"This letter is from Jonathan the high priest, the high council, the priests, and the rest of the Jewish people. It is addressed to our brothers the Spartans. Greetings.

⁷"Long ago your king Arius sent a letter to our high priest Onias, stating that you are our brothers, as the attached copy shows. ⁸Onias received your ambassador with honor and accepted the letter, which declared our alliance and friendship.

⁹We do not need such alliances, since we find encouragement in our sacred books. ¹⁰Nevertheless, we have chosen to renew our family ties and friendship with you so that we don't become strangers to you, for a long time has passed since you wrote to us. ¹¹We think of you on every special occasion. At our festivals and on other special days we remember you as we offer sacrifices and prayers, for it is fitting to remember brothers at these times. ¹²We rejoice at your fame.

¹³"We have had many troubles and wars on every side because the neighboring kings have attacked us. ¹⁴We did not want to trouble you or our allies and friends during these wars, ¹⁵for our help comes from God. We have been rescued from our enemies, and they have been humbled. ¹⁶Nevertheless, we have selected Numenius son of Antiochus and Antipater son of Jason and have sent them to Rome to renew our former friendship and alliance with the Romans. ¹⁷We have also instructed them to visit you and bring our greetings and to give you this letter concerning the renewal of our family ties. ¹⁸We will be grateful for your response to it."

¹⁹Following is a copy of the letter the Spartans had previously sent to Onias:

²⁰"This letter is from Arius, king of the Spartans, to Onias the high priest. Greetings.

²¹"We have discovered a document that states that the Spartans and the Jews are brothers and that they are all descendants of Abraham. ²²Now that we have learned this, write to us and let us know how you are doing. ²³For our part, we declare to you that what is yours—your cattle and your possessions—is ours, and what is ours is yours. This is what we have ordered our envoys to report to you."

Demetrius Nicator Encounters Jonathan

²⁴Jonathan then heard that Demetrius's commanders had returned with an even larger army than before to wage war against him. ²⁵So Jonathan marched out from Jerusalem and met them in the region of Hamath, for he did not want to give them a chance to invade his own country. ²⁶He sent scouts into their camp, who returned and reported that the enemy was preparing to attack that night. ²⁷When the sun set, Jonathan commanded his men to be on guard all night and to keep their weapons at hand, and he posted sentries around the camp. ²⁸When the enemy learned that Jonathan and his men were ready for battle, they were filled with dread. They lit fires in their camp and then retreated. ²⁹But Jonathan and his army did not know until morning that the enemy had retreated, because they had seen their campfires burning. ³⁰Jonathan chased them but did not catch them because they had crossed the Eleutherus River. ³¹Jonathan then went after the Arabs called Zabadeans. He defeated them and carried away their possessions. ³²He marched on and came to Damascus and passed through all that country.

³³Simon also marched out and went as far as Ashkelon and the neighboring fortresses. Then he turned to Joppa and took possession of it, ³⁴for he heard that the people were planning to hand their stronghold over to the supporters of Demetrius. Simon then stationed a garrison there to guard it.

³⁵When Jonathan returned, he officially called together the high council and made plans with them to build fortresses in Judea. ³⁶They planned to heighten the walls of Jerusalem and erect a barrier to separate the citadel from the city, so that the soldiers in the citadel could neither buy nor sell. ³⁷So the people worked together to rebuild the city. They repaired a collapsed section of the wall that bordered the Kidron Valley on the east side of the city. Jonathan also repaired the section called Chaphenatha. ³⁸Simon built Adida in the western foothills; he fortified it and erected gates that locked with bars.

Jonathan Is Deceived and Captured

³⁹Trypho was determined to make himself king of Asia and to assume the crown and overthrow King Antiochus. ⁴⁰But he was afraid that Jonathan would prevent him and fight against him, so he marched out to Beth-shan looking for some way to capture Jonathan and kill him.

⁴¹Jonathan went with forty thousand select troops to meet Trypho in battle at Beth-shan. ⁴²When Trypho saw that Jonathan had come with a large army, he was afraid to fight against him. ⁴³So he received him with honor, commended him to all his favored leaders, and gave him presents. Trypho ordered his favored leaders and his troops to obey him as they would himself. ⁴⁴He said to Jonathan, “Why have you troubled all these people when you and I are not at war? ⁴⁵Choose a few men to stay with you and send the rest home, and then come with me to Ptolemais. I will give you that city and the rest of the fortresses, along with their garrisons and officials. Then I will go home, for that is why I came here.”

⁴⁶Jonathan believed him and did as he had suggested. He sent most of his army back to Judea, ⁴⁷keeping three thousand men with him. Then he sent two thousand of them into Galilee and kept only one thousand for himself. ⁴⁸But as soon as Jonathan entered Ptolemais, the people of the city shut the gates and captured him; then they killed everyone who had entered with him.

⁴⁹Trypho dispatched foot soldiers and horsemen to Galilee and the great plain of Esdraelon to destroy all of Jonathan’s soldiers. ⁵⁰After Jonathan’s soldiers concluded that Jonathan and his troops had been captured and killed, they encouraged one another and marched in close formation, ready for battle. ⁵¹When Trypho’s troops realized that Jonathan’s men were ready to fight for their lives, they turned back. ⁵²So Jonathan’s men returned safely to Judea. They mourned for Jonathan and those who died with him, and all Israel grieved deeply.

⁵³Then all the nations surrounding them sought to destroy them. They said, “Israel has no leader and no one to help them. Now is the time to fight against them and blot out all memory of them from the world.”

13

Simon Becomes the New Leader

IMON heard that Trypho was assembling a very large army to invade Judea and destroy it. ²Seeing that the people were trembling with fear, Simon went up to Jerusalem and assembled the people. ³He encouraged them, saying, “You know what great things my brothers and my father’s family and I have done for the laws and the Temple. You know the wars we have waged and the hardships we have experienced. ⁴For this cause—for the sake of Israel—all my brothers have lost their lives, and I alone am left. ⁵Far be it from me to spare my own life in time of trouble, for I am no better than my brothers. ⁶Nevertheless, I will avenge my nation and the Temple and your wives and children, for all the Gentiles have gathered together in hatred to destroy us.”

⁷The people were inspired once again when they heard these words. ⁸They cried out to Simon, “You are our leader in place of your brothers Judas and Jonathan. ⁹Lead us in battle, and we will obey your every word.” ¹⁰So Simon assembled the army and hurried to complete the walls of Jerusalem, fortifying it on all sides. ¹¹He sent a large force to Joppa under the command of Jonathan son of Absalom, and they drove out the residents and remained there.

Trypho Kills Jonathan

¹²Trypho and his large army left Ptolemais to invade Judea, and they took Jonathan along under guard. ¹³Simon set up camp in Adida, facing the plain. ¹⁴When Trypho learned that Simon had taken the

place of his brother Jonathan and was preparing to fight against him, he sent envoys to Simon with this message: ¹⁵“We have detained your brother Jonathan for the money that he owed the king’s treasury when he was managing the king’s affairs in Judea. ¹⁶Send 7,500 pounds of silver and two of his sons as hostages, so that when he is set free, he will not revolt against us. Then we will release him.”

¹⁷Although Simon did not believe that Trypho could be trusted, he ordered the money and the children to be sent. He did not want the people of Israel to hate him and say, ¹⁸“Jonathan died because Simon did not send the money and the children.” ¹⁹So he sent the children and the 7,500 pounds of silver. But Trypho broke his word and did not release Jonathan.

²⁰After this, Trypho entered the country to destroy it. His troops took a detour along the road that leads to Adora, but Simon and his army countered them wherever they went. ²¹The soldiers in the citadel sent envoys to Trypho, asking him to hurry to them through the wilderness to bring them food. ²²So Trypho got all his horsemen ready to leave; but that night a very heavy snow fell, and he could not go. Instead he went into Gilead. ²³As he neared Baskama, he killed Jonathan and buried him there. ²⁴Then Trypho changed course and returned to his own country.

Jonathan Is Buried

²⁵Simon sent for the remains of his brother Jonathan and buried him in Modein, the town of his ancestors. ²⁶All Israel wept loudly for him, and they mourned for him many days. ²⁷Over the tomb of his father and his brothers, Simon built a tall monument with polished stone at the front and back. ²⁸He also erected seven pyramids facing each other for his father, his mother, and his four brothers. ²⁹He surrounded these with an elaborate arrangement of large pillars, upon which he hung armor as an eternal memorial. Beside the armor he carved ships large enough to be visible to those at sea. ³⁰This tomb remains in Modein even to this day.

Demetrius Nicator Supports Simon

³¹Trypho conspired against young King Antiochus and killed him. ³²He became king in his place, assuming the crown of Asia, and brought great evils upon the kingdom. ³³But Simon strengthened the strongholds of Judea, fortifying them with high towers, massive walls, and gates locked with bars. He also stored food in the strongholds.

³⁴Simon selected ambassadors and sent them to King Demetrius Nicator, hoping to gain relief from taxes for his nation, since Trypho had plundered the land. ³⁵King Demetrius answered this request with the following letter:

³⁶“This letter is from King Demetrius to Simon, the high priest and favored leader of kings, and to the high council and the Jewish nation. Greetings.

³⁷“We have received the gold crown and the palm branch that you sent. We are ready to establish a lasting peace with you and to write to our officials, instructing them to release you from the tribute tax. ³⁸All that was previously agreed upon remains in force, and the fortresses you have built are yours to keep. ³⁹We forgive any oversights or faults you have committed to this day, and we cancel the crown tax that you owe. If there are any other taxes in Jerusalem, they are now canceled. ⁴⁰If any of you are qualified to join the royal guard, you will be allowed to enroll. Let there be peace between us.”

⁴¹In the one hundred seventieth year of Greek rule, the yoke of the Gentiles was removed from Israel. ⁴²At that time the people of Israel began to date their documents and public records in this way: “In the first year of Simon the great high priest, the commander and leader of the Jews.”

Simon Captures Gazara

⁴³In those days Simon set up camp outside Gazara and surrounded it with troops. He constructed a siege machine and directed it against the town. He attacked one tower and captured it. ⁴⁴The soldiers inside the siege machine entered the town, creating a great uproar. ⁴⁵The men in the town, together with their wives and children, went up to the wall, tore their clothes, and cried out with a loud voice, asking Simon to grant them terms of peace. ⁴⁶They said, "Do not treat us as our evil deeds deserve but according to your mercy." ⁴⁷So Simon reached an agreement with them. He did not destroy them, but he expelled them from the town and purified the houses where there had been idols. Then he entered the town, singing hymns of praise. ⁴⁸Having cleansed the town of all impurity, Simon appointed people to live there who would observe the law of Moses. He also fortified the town and built a house for himself there.

Simon Captures the Citadel

⁴⁹Then Simon prevented those who were in the citadel at Jerusalem from going in and out and from buying and selling in the countryside. So they became very hungry, and many of them died from famine. ⁵⁰They begged Simon for terms of peace, which he granted. Then he expelled them from the citadel and cleansed it from impurity. ⁵¹On June 3 in the one hundred seventy-first year of Greek rule, the Jews entered the citadel with thanksgiving, waving palm branches and playing harps and cymbals and stringed instruments. They sang hymns and songs, because Israel's great enemy had finally been destroyed. ⁵²Simon decreed that this occasion should be celebrated every year with gladness. He strengthened the fortifications of the Temple hill near the citadel, and he and his men lived there.

⁵³Since Simon's son John had now reached manhood, Simon made him commander of all the armies. John kept his residence in Gazara.

14

Simon's Success

IN the one hundred seventy-second year of Greek rule, King Demetrius assembled his army and marched into Media. He was hoping to gain support for a war against Trypho. ²When Arsaces, king of Persia and Media, heard that Demetrius had invaded his territory, he sent one of his commanders to capture him alive and bring him to him. ³The commander defeated the army of Demetrius, captured him, and brought him to Arsaces, who kept him prisoner.

- ⁴Judea was at rest as long as Simon ruled,
for he sought the good of his nation.
The people were pleased with his authority,
with the honor he received throughout his days.
⁵To crown his glory, he captured Joppa for a seaport
and opened a gateway to the Mediterranean islands.
⁶He extended the borders of his nation
and gained control of all the land.
⁷Simon captured many prisoners of war
and ruled over Gazara, Beth-zur, and the citadel.
He removed the impurities from the citadel;
no one could stand against him.
⁸The people farmed the land in peace.
The land yielded its produce,
and the trees of the plains bore fruit.
⁹Old men sat in the squares and talked of good times,
while the young men dressed in splendid military style.
¹⁰Simon provided food for the towns

and furnished them with fortresses for defense.

His name became famous, even to the ends of the earth.

¹¹He established peace in the land,

and Israel experienced great joy.

¹²The people relaxed under their own vines and fig trees.

and no one gave them reason to fear.

¹³No enemy remained in the land to fight them;

their kings were crushed in those days.

¹⁴Simon strengthened the lowly

and was zealous for the law of Moses.

He did away with the ungodly and evildoers.

¹⁵He made the sanctuary glorious

and furnished it with new utensils.

Renewed Alliances with Sparta and Rome

¹⁶News of Jonathan's death reached as far as Rome and Sparta, and they were deeply grieved. ¹⁷They heard that his brother Simon had become high priest in his place and was ruling over the nation and the cities there. ¹⁸So they wrote to Simon on bronze tablets to renew the friendship and alliance they had made with his brothers Judas and Jonathan. ¹⁹The letter from the Spartans was presented to the high council in Jerusalem. It read as follows:

²⁰"This letter is from the rulers and the people of Sparta to the high priest Simon, the high council, the priests, and the rest of the Jewish people, our brothers and sisters. Greetings.

²¹"The ambassadors you sent to us have told us of your glory and honor, and we have enjoyed their visit. ²²We have recorded their message in our public archives as follows: 'Numenius son of Antiochus and Antipater son of Jason, ambassadors of the Jews, have come to us to renew their friendship with us. ²³Our people were pleased to receive the

men with honor and to put a copy of their message in the public archives as a record for the Spartan people. We have also sent a copy of their message to Simon the high priest.”

²⁴After this, Simon confirmed the alliance with the Romans by sending Numenius to Rome with a large gold shield weighing 1,250 pounds.

²⁵When the people of Israel heard about all this, they said, “How can we thank Simon and his sons? ²⁶For he and his brothers and his father’s family have stood firm; they have repelled the enemies of Israel and established freedom for the nation.” ²⁷So they made an inscription on bronze tablets and mounted them on pillars on Mount Zion. This is a copy of what they wrote:

“On September 13 in the one hundred seventy-second year of Greek rule, which is the third year of Simon the great high priest, ²⁸in Asaramel, the following proclamations were made in the high council of the priests, the people, the rulers of the nation, and the elders of the country:

²⁹“Because of the constant warfare in our country, Simon and his brothers, sons of Mattathias, a priest in the line of Joarib, have become great leaders among us. They have put themselves in danger and resisted the enemies of their nation in order to preserve the Temple and the law of Moses. They have brought great glory to their nation.

³⁰“Jonathan rallied his nation together and became the high priest; now he is dead. ³¹When the enemies of Israel decided to invade the country and capture the Temple, ³²Simon came forward to fight for his nation. He spent much of his own money to arm the soldiers of his nation and pay them wages. ³³He fortified the towns of Judea, including Beth-zur, which lies on the border of Judea. At one time, the weapons of the

enemies were stored there, but he defeated the enemy troops and replaced them with a garrison of Jews. ³⁴Simon fortified the coastal town of Joppa and also Gazara, which borders upon Azotus, where the enemy formerly lived. He settled Jews there and furnished those towns with everything needed to restore them.

³⁵“When the people saw Simon’s faithfulness and his determination to win glory for his nation, they made him their leader and high priest. They did this in return for all the things he had done and because of the justice and loyalty he showed his nation. In every way he sought to enhance his people’s power.

³⁶“During Simon’s reign, the country prospered under his guidance. He drove the Gentiles from the land, and he also drove them from the City of David in Jerusalem. From this citadel they had gone out to defile the Temple, ruining its purity. ³⁷But Simon settled Jews in the citadel and fortified it for the safety of the country and the city. He also heightened the walls of Jerusalem.

³⁸“Because of these things, King Demetrius confirmed Simon’s position as high priest, ³⁹made him one of his favored leaders, and granted him great honor. ⁴⁰For Demetrius had heard that the Romans regarded the Jews as their friends, military allies, and brothers, and that the Romans had received Simon’s ambassadors with honor.

⁴¹“The Jews and their priests have decided that Simon should remain their leader and high priest until a true prophet should arise. ⁴²Simon should be their governor and take charge of the Temple. He should appoint officials over the Temple duties and over the country, the weapons, and the fortresses. ⁴³He should be obeyed by all, and all official documents in the country should be made in his name. And he should be clothed with purple and wear gold.

⁴⁴“None of the people or priests may nullify any of these decisions, nor may they oppose Simon’s orders. They may not gather an assembly in the country without his permission, nor may they be clothed in purple or wear a gold buckle. ⁴⁵Whoever violates or rejects any of these decisions will be liable to punishment.”

⁴⁶All the people agreed to allow Simon to act in accordance with these decisions. ⁴⁷Simon accepted this and agreed to be high priest, commander, and leader of the Jews and priests, and to exercise supreme authority over them all. ⁴⁸The people ordered that this proclamation be engraved on bronze tablets and set up where people could see it in the Temple area. ⁴⁹They also ordered that copies be deposited in the treasury so that Simon and his sons could access them.

15

A Letter from Antiochus VII Sidetes

NTIOCHUS Sidetes, the son of King Demetrius Soter, sent a letter from the Mediterranean islands to Simon, the priest and leader of the Jews, and to all the people. ²The letter read as follows:

“This letter is from King Antiochus to Simon, high priest and leader, and to the Jewish nation. Greetings.

³“Certain rebels have seized control of the kingdom of our ancestors, but I intend to reclaim it and restore it to its former state. I have recruited a large army of foreign troops and have built warships, ⁴and I plan to arrive in my country and take revenge on those who have destroyed our country and devastated many cities in my kingdom. ⁵Therefore, I confirm all tax exemptions that the kings before me granted you, along

with any other promises of release from payments. ⁶I give you permission to mint your own coins in your country. ⁷I declare Jerusalem and the Temple to be free. All the weapons you have made and the fortresses you have built and occupy are to remain yours. ⁸Any debts owed to the king, including future obligations, are canceled from this moment and for all time. ⁹When we regain control of our kingdom, we will highly honor you, your nation, and your Temple, so that your glory may be known throughout the world.”

¹⁰In the one hundred seventy-fourth year of Greek rule, Antiochus Sidetes entered the land of his ancestors. All the troops rallied to his support so that only a few people supported Trypho. ¹¹King Antiochus pursued him, and Trypho fled to the coastal town of Dor. ¹²Antiochus realized that Trypho was in deep trouble and that his troops had deserted him, ¹³so Antiochus set up camp near Dor with 120,000 soldiers and 8,000 horsemen. ¹⁴He surrounded the town, and his ships took up positions offshore. Antiochus shut off the town by land and sea so that no one could go in or out.

Alliance with Rome Proclaimed

¹⁵Meanwhile, Numenius and his companions arrived from Rome with letters to various kings and countries. The letters read as follows:

¹⁶“This letter is from Lucius, consul of the Romans, to King Ptolemy Physcon. Greetings.

¹⁷“Ambassadors of the Jews have come to us as friends and allies, and they wanted to renew our former friendship and alliance. They had been sent by the high priest Simon and by the Jewish people. ¹⁸They also brought a gold shield weighing 1,250 pounds. ¹⁹Therefore, we have decided without hesitation to send these instructions to many kings and countries: Do not harm the Jews or attack their cities or their land. Do

not make alliances with anyone who wages war against the Jews. ²⁰As a token of our friendship, we have decided to accept the shield from them. ²¹Therefore, if any troublemakers have fled to you from Judea, return them to the high priest Simon, so that he may punish them according to their law.”

²²This same message was sent to King Demetrius, Attalus, Ariarathes, and Arsaces ²³and to all the countries, including Sampsames, Sparta, Delos, Myndos, Sicyon, Caria, Samos, Pamphylia, Lycia, Haliarnassus, Rhodes, Phaselis, Cos, Side, Aradus, Gortyna, Cnidus, Cyprus, and Cyrene. ²⁴A copy of the letter was also sent to Simon the high priest.

Antiochus Sidetes Becomes Simon’s Enemy

²⁵King Antiochus Sidetes continued in his siege of Dor, assaulting it continually and building war machines to use against it. He trapped Trypho inside, and he could not escape. ²⁶Simon sent Antiochus two thousand select troops to help him, along with silver, gold, and a large amount of military equipment. ²⁷But Antiochus refused to receive them. Instead, he renounced all agreements he had made with Simon and alienated himself from him. ²⁸He sent Athenobius, one of his favored leaders, to meet with Simon and say, “You are occupying Joppa, Gazara, and the citadel in Jerusalem, which are cities of my kingdom. ²⁹You have devastated their territories, inflicted great damage on the land, and taken control of many places in my kingdom. ³⁰Therefore, give back the cities you have taken and the tribute taxes from the places you control beyond the borders of Judea. ³¹Otherwise, give me nineteen tons of silver for the destruction that you have caused, along with nineteen tons more to reimburse me for the tribute taxes of the cities. If you fail to do this, we will come and attack you.”

³²So Athenobius, the king’s favored leader, came to Jerusalem. He was astonished when he saw Simon’s splendor—his cabinet with the

gold and silver plate and his great magnificence. Then he delivered the king's message.

³³Simon responded, "We have not taken anyone else's land or property. Rather, we have taken what is the inheritance of our ancestors, which had been unjustly occupied by our enemies. ³⁴Now that we have the opportunity, we are merely recovering this inheritance. ³⁵Joppa and Gazara inflicted great harm on our people and our land, but we will give you 7,500 pounds of silver for them."

³⁶Athenobius did not answer a single word in reply. He returned angrily to the king with this message and told him about Simon's great splendor. The king was enraged.

Cendebeus Troubles Judea

³⁷Meanwhile, Trypho escaped by ship to Orthosia. ³⁸The king appointed Cendebeus commander of the coastal areas and gave him an army of foot soldiers and horsemen. ³⁹The king ordered him to set up camp outside Judea. He ordered him to build up Kedron, to fortify its gates, and to attack the Jews. But the king himself pursued Trypho.

⁴⁰So Cendebeus came to Jamnia and began to harass the people by raiding Judea, taking prisoners, and then killing them. ⁴¹He built up Kedron and stationed horsemen and foot soldiers there so that they might make raids along the highways of Judea, as the king had commanded him.

16

Simon's Sons Defeat Cendebeus



IMON's son John came up from Gazara and told his father what Cendebeus had done. ²Simon called for his two eldest sons, Judas and John, and said to them, "My brothers and my father's family and I have spent our whole lives fighting Israel's battles. Things

have gone well under our leadership, for we have rescued Israel many times. ³Now I am old, but by God's grace you have matured to manhood. You must replace me and my brother and continue fighting for our nation. May God help you."

⁴John chose twenty thousand soldiers and horsemen from Judea, and they marched out to fight Cendebeus. They camped for the night in Modein. ⁵Then they got up early in the morning and moved out on to the plain, where they faced a large army of foot soldiers and horsemen. A stream separated the two armies. ⁶As John and his troops lined up against the enemy, he saw that his troops were afraid to cross the stream. So he went over first. When his men saw him lead the way, they crossed over behind him. ⁷John divided his army, positioning the horsemen in the center of the foot soldiers, for the enemy also had a large cavalry. ⁸John's men sounded the trumpets and attacked, and Cendebeus and his army fled. Many of the enemy were wounded and fell, and the rest fled into the fortress. ⁹At the same time, John's brother Judas was wounded, but John chased the enemy as far as Kedron, which Cendebeus had built up. ¹⁰Some also fled into the towers in the fields of Azotus, but John burned these down. About two thousand enemy soldiers were killed, and John returned safely to Judea.

Simon's Tragic Death

¹¹Ptolemy son of Abubus had been appointed governor over the plain of Jericho. He had a large amount of silver and gold, ¹²for he was a son-in-law of Simon the high priest. ¹³He became overly ambitious and wanted to gain control of the whole country. So he plotted against Simon and his sons to get rid of them by treachery.

¹⁴As Simon was going through the towns of Judea and attending to their needs, he and his sons Mattathias and Judas went down to Jericho in late winter of the one hundred seventy-seventh year of Greek rule. ¹⁵At Dok, a small fortress he had built, Ptolemy welcomed them with a deceptive display of friendliness. He invited them to a

great banquet, but he hid his men in the fortress. ¹⁶When Simon and his sons were drunk, Ptolemy and his men jumped up, grabbed their weapons, and rushed into the banquet hall, killing Simon and his two sons and some of his servants. ¹⁷In this way, Ptolemy committed an act of great treachery, repaying evil for good.

Simon's Son John Becomes the New Leader

¹⁸Ptolemy wrote a report of his actions and sent it to King Antiochus Sidetes, asking him to send soldiers to help him. He also asked the king to place the towns and the country under his authority. ¹⁹Ptolemy also sent soldiers to Gazara to kill Simon's son John, and he sent letters to the army officers, asking them to come to him so he could give them silver and gold and gifts. ²⁰He sent other soldiers to capture Jerusalem and the Temple mount as well.

²¹But someone ran ahead to Gazara and told John that his father and his brothers were dead and that Ptolemy had sent men to kill him, too. ²²When John heard this, he was astounded. He captured the men that came to kill him, and he killed them instead, for he knew their intentions.

²³The rest of John's deeds, his battles, his brave accomplishments, his rebuilding of the walls, and his achievements, ²⁴are all recorded in the history of his high priesthood, beginning from the time he succeeded his father as high priest.

Preface to the Book of 2 Maccabees

Martin Luther, 1534



HIS book is called, and is supposed to be, the second book of Maccabees, as the title indicates. Yet this cannot be true, because it reports several incidents that happened before those reported in the first book, and it does not proceed any further than Judas Maccabaeus, that is, chapter 7 of the first book. It would be better to call this the first instead of the second book, unless one were to call it simply a second book and not the second book of Maccabees—another or different, certainly, but not second. But we include it anyway, for the sake of the good story of the seven Maccabean martyrs and their mother, and other things as well.

It appears, however, that the book has no single author, but was pieced together out of many books. It also presents a knotty problem in chapter 14[:41–46] where Razis commits suicide, something which also troubles St. Augustine and the ancient fathers. Such an example is good for nothing and should not be praised, even though it may be tolerated and perhaps explained. So also in chapter 1 this book describes the death of Antiochus quite differently than does First Maccabees [6:1–16].

To sum up: just as it is proper for the first book to be included among the sacred Scriptures, so it is proper that this second book should be thrown out, even though it contains some good things. However the whole thing is left and referred to the pious reader to judge and to decide.

2 Maccabees

1

First Letter to the Jews in Egypt

¹“This letter is from the Jews in Jerusalem and Judea to their fellow Jews in Egypt. Greetings and true peace to you.

²“May God be good to you and remember the covenant he made with Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, his faithful servants.

³May God give you a desire to worship him and to do his will with a loving heart and a generous spirit. ⁴May he open your heart to his law and his commandments, and may he grant you peace. ⁵May he hear your prayers and be reconciled to you, and may he never forsake you in the time of evil. ⁶We are now praying for you here.

⁷“When Demetrius Nicator reigned in the one hundred sixty-ninth year of Greek rule, we wrote to you of the trouble and intense conflict we experienced in the years after Jason defected from the holy land and from the kingdom. ⁸He burned the Temple gate and killed innocent people. So we prayed to the Lord, and our prayers were answered. We offered sacrifices and fine flour, and we lit the lamps and set the Bread of the Presence on the table. ⁹We are writing to remind you to commemorate this event by celebrating a second Festival of Shelters each year in the month of Kislev.

“This letter was written in the one hundred eighty-eighth year of Greek rule.”

Second Letter to the Jews

¹⁰“This letter is from the people of Jerusalem and Judea, from the high council, and from Judas. It is written to Aristobulus, a member of the family of anointed priests and a teacher of King Ptolemy Physcon. This letter is also written to the Jews in Egypt. Greetings and good health to you.

¹¹“Having been rescued by God from dangerous times, we give him great thanks for championing our cause against the king. ¹²God was the one who drove out those who fought against the holy city. ¹³When their leader, Antiochus, was in Persia with what seemed to be an invincible army, he and his men were killed in the temple of the goddess Nanea, for he was deceived by her priests. ¹⁴Hoping to secure large sums of money as a dowry, Antiochus led everyone to believe that he was going to marry Nanea. When he and his men arrived in Persia ¹⁵and the priests of Nanea set out the treasure, Antiochus and a few men entered the interior of the temple. The priests closed the door, trapping them inside. ¹⁶Then, opening a secret trapdoor in the ceiling, the priests threw stones down on Antiochus and his men, killing them. The priests then dismembered them, cutting off their heads and throwing the body parts outside. ¹⁷May God, who has judged the wicked, be blessed in all things!

¹⁸“Therefore, since we will be commemorating the purification of the Temple on the twenty-fifth day of the month of Kislev, we thought we should remind you also to celebrate this second Festival of Shelters, which also commemorates the day when the fire was given to Nehemiah to offer sacrifices. This fire was given to Nehemiah after he rebuilt the Temple and the altar.

¹⁹“When our ancestors were taken captive into Persia, the devout priests at that time secretly took the live coals from the altar and hid them deep in a dry cistern. There they kept the holy fire safe in a place unknown to anyone. ²⁰When many years had passed, it pleased God to send Nehemiah back to Israel by order of the king of Persia. Nehemiah sent some of the descendants of those priests who had previously hidden the fire to look for it. They reported that they found no fire but instead found a thick liquid in the cistern. Nehemiah told them to draw it up and bring it to him. ²¹Then he commanded the priests to pour this liquid over the wood and sacrifices placed on the wood. ²²This was done and sometime later, when the sun came out from behind a cloud, and a great fire broke out on the altar. Everyone was amazed, ²³and all the priests and the people prayed while the sacrifice was burning. Jonathan took the lead, and the others joined Nehemiah in a response.

²⁴“Their prayer went like this: ‘O Lord, Lord God, Creator of all things, you are awesome and strong, just and merciful. You alone are king, and you are kind; ²⁵you alone are gracious; you alone are just and almighty and eternal. It was you who saved Israel from all evil and chose our ancestors, setting them apart. ²⁶Accept this sacrifice for all your people Israel, and preserve your own inheritance and make it holy. ²⁷Gather together our scattered people. Free those who are slaves to the Gentiles. Look favorably on those who are despised and rejected, and let the Gentiles know that you are our God. ²⁸Torment our insolent oppressors. ²⁹Firmly plant your people in your Holy Place, as Moses said.’

³⁰“Then the priests sang hymns. ³¹When the sacrifice was fully burned, Nehemiah ordered the remaining liquid to be poured over large stones. ³²When this was done, flames burst forth on them, but the light that blazed from the altar was even brighter.

³³“This became a well-known event. The king of Persia heard that a thick liquid had appeared in the place where the exiled priests had hidden the fire and that Nehemiah and those with him had used the liquid to burn the sacrifices. ³⁴The king verified the matter and then enclosed the place, declaring it sacred. ³⁵The king gained a great deal of revenue from the place, and he used this money to give gifts to people he favored. ³⁶Nehemiah and his people called this liquid nephthar, which means ‘purification,’ but many call it naphtha.

2

¹“The records show that it was Jeremiah the prophet who commanded those who went into captivity to hide some of the fire of the altar. ²He also ordered them not to forget the commandments of the Lord and warned them not to be deceived in their thinking when they saw the gold and silver idols with their ornaments. ³With similar speeches he told them to keep the law of Moses in their hearts.

⁴“The same records tell us how God told the prophet to take the Tabernacle and the Ark with him until he came to the mountain where Moses had looked out over the land God had promised to give his people. ⁵When Jeremiah arrived there, he found an empty cave into which he carried the Tabernacle, the Ark, and the altar of incense. Then he blocked the entrance. ⁶Some of those who followed him wanted to mark the place, but they could not find it. ⁷When Jeremiah heard this, he rebuked them, saying, ‘The place will be hidden until God gathers his people together again and shows them his mercy. ⁸Then the Lord will reveal these things, and the glory of the Lord will appear in a cloud, as in the days of Moses and again when Solomon prayed that the Temple might be specially set apart for God.’

⁹“It is also recorded how Solomon in his wisdom offered sacrifices for the dedication and completion of the Temple. ¹⁰Just as Moses prayed to the Lord and fire came down from heaven and consumed the sacrifice, so also Solomon prayed and fire came down from heaven and consumed the sacrifice. ¹¹And Moses said, ‘Because the sin offering was not eaten, it was consumed.’ ¹²Solomon also celebrated the dedication for eight days.

¹³“These same things were written in the records and in the memoirs of Nehemiah. It is recorded that Nehemiah established a library by collecting the books about the kings and the prophets, the writings of David, and the letters of the kings concerning offerings to fulfill vows. ¹⁴Likewise, Judas collected all the books that were lost in our war, and now they are in our possession. ¹⁵If you need these things, send someone to get them for you.

¹⁶“We are writing to you because we are about to celebrate the purification of the Temple, and we would like you to celebrate this same festival. ¹⁷It is God who has saved his people and returned to us our inheritance, our kingdom, our priesthood, and our holiness, ¹⁸as he promised in the law of Moses. We trust that God will soon have mercy on us and gather us together from every land under heaven to the Holy Place. For he has saved us from great dangers and purified the Temple.”

Preface to the Story of the Maccabees

¹⁹This is the story of Judas Maccabeus and his brothers, including an account of the purification of the great Temple and the dedication of the altar. ²⁰This story recounts the wars against Antiochus Epiphanes and his son Eupator ²¹and the heavenly apparitions seen by those

heroes who fought bravely for Judaism. These heroes, though few in number, took the whole land and routed the barbarian hordes. ²²They regained the Temple renowned in all the world, liberated the city, and restored the laws of Moses, which were nearly abolished. The Lord showed great kindness and mercy to them.

²³All these things were recorded in five books by Jason of Cyrene, but we will attempt to condense them into one. ²⁴There are so many statistics—a veritable flood of material—that anyone who wants to study the narratives of history has a difficult job. ²⁵Therefore, our goal has been to make it easy for those who simply wish to read about these things and to help the studious to memorize more easily. We want all who read these things to profit. ²⁶As for ourselves, this work of condensing the records is a difficult task, yes, one of hard work and loss of sleep, ²⁷much like it is for those who prepare a banquet and try to please others. Yet we willingly undertake this labor for the sake of many. ²⁸We leave to compilers the exact handling of every detail, intending here to outline a brief digest. ²⁹The contractor of a new house must take care of the whole building, while the painter is concerned only with its decoration. So I think it is with us. ³⁰It is the historian's duty to collect all that is known, to put the events in order, and to search out and discuss every detail. ³¹But one who makes a digest is allowed to pursue brevity of speech and avoid lengthy explanations. ³²So let us begin the narrative without adding any further comment, for it would be foolish to make a long preface and then cut short the story itself!

3

The Story of Heliodorus



IN the days of Onias the high priest, the holy city of Jerusalem was at peace, and the laws of Moses were diligently observed, because Onias obeyed God and hated evil. ²So even the kings honored the sanctuary and embellished the Temple with wonderful gifts.

³Even Seleucus, king of Asia, paid from his own revenues all the expenses connected with offering the sacrifices.

⁴But a man named Simon from the tribe of Benjamin opposed the high priest because he disagreed about how the city markets should be administered. Simon had been appointed manager of the Temple. ⁵When he could not win his dispute with Onias, he went to Apollonius of Tarsus, who was governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia. ⁶Simon told him that the treasury in Jerusalem was so full of wealth that it couldn't be counted. Since this money did not belong to the account set aside for the sacrifices, Simon suggested that this money be brought under the king's control.

⁷When Apollonius saw the king, he told him about this money. Then the king called Heliodorus, who was in charge of his affairs, and ordered him to bring it back to him. ⁸So Heliodorus immediately set out on his journey, under the guise of visiting the cities of Coelesyria and Phoenicia. But his real purpose was to fulfill the king's order.

⁹When Heliodorus came to Jerusalem, the high priest received him courteously. Heliodorus told him what he had heard about this large sum of money and asked if it was true. ¹⁰The high priest told him that there were sums deposited to provide for widows and orphans. ¹¹He also stated that the rest belonged to Hyrcanus son of Tobiah, a man of prominent position. Contrary to what the wicked Simon had reported, the total amount was fifteen tons of silver and seven and a half tons of gold. ¹²The high priest said he could not touch these deposits, for they had been brought for safekeeping to the Temple—the holy and sacred place that is honored throughout the whole world. ¹³But because of the orders he had received from the king, Heliodorus said he had no choice but to take the money for the royal treasury. ¹⁴So he set a day and entered the treasury to take inventory.

The people throughout the city were very upset, ¹⁵and the priests, dressed in their special clothing, threw themselves face down before the altar. They called upon God in heaven, who had given the law concerning the deposits, asking him to preserve the money for those who had deposited it. ¹⁶Everyone who saw the high priest became

heartbroken, for his face showed the inward anguish of his soul. ¹⁷His body trembled with horror, making the sorrow in his heart clear to all who saw him. ¹⁸Many of the people hurried from their homes to join in corporate prayer because the sanctuary was about to be defiled. ¹⁹The women, dressed in sackcloth, gathered in the streets. The young women ran from their homes—some to the gates and some to the walls—while others peered out of windows. ²⁰All of them stretched their hands toward heaven in prayer. ²¹It was pitiful to see everyone lying face down in anguish and to see the high priest in his agony.

²²While the people were calling to the almighty Lord to keep the deposits safe and secure for those who had given them, ²³Heliodorus went on with his plan. ²⁴But as he arrived at the treasury with his guard, the Lord of all spirits and all authority caused such an awesome heavenly apparition that all who had boldly accompanied Heliodorus collapsed in terror, overwhelmed by God's power. ²⁵Before them appeared a horse splendidly decorated, and on the horse sat a fearsome rider clad in gold armor. The horse charged and reared fiercely, striking Heliodorus with its front hooves. ²⁶At the same time, two young men of amazing strength and striking beauty, dressed in magnificent clothing, appeared to Heliodorus. They stood on either side of him and whipped him continuously, striking him with blow after blow. ²⁷Heliodorus suddenly fell to the ground, overwhelmed by a deep darkness. His men came to his rescue. They picked him up, put him on a stretcher, ²⁸and carried him away. He had come into that treasury with a large retinue of servants and all his guard, but now he was carried away helpless. He had experienced the power of God. ²⁹Indeed, because of God's intervention, he lay speechless and without hope of recovery. ³⁰The people praised the Lord because he had marvelously honored his sanctuary. And the Temple, which a short time before had been full of fear and commotion, was filled with joy and gladness because of the almighty Lord's appearance.

³¹Because Heliodorus was dying, some of his friends urged Onias to call upon the Most High to spare his life. ³²So the high priest, fearing

that the king would suspect the Jews of foul play, offered a sacrifice for Heliodorus's recovery. ³³While the high priest was making a sacrifice for atonement, the same young men, dressed in the same clothing, appeared to Heliodorus once again. They stood before him and said, "Give thanks to Onias the high priest, because for his sake the Lord has spared your life. ³⁴And you, having been whipped by God, should tell everyone of the great works and power of God." Then they vanished.

³⁵Heliodorus offered a sacrifice to the Lord and made great vows to him, for he had spared his life. Then he said good-bye to Onias, and he and his troops returned to the king. ³⁶He told everyone about the works of the supreme God, whom he had seen with his own eyes. ³⁷Then the king asked Heliodorus what kind of person he should send to Jerusalem. Heliodorus replied, ³⁸"If you have any enemy or conspirator in your country, send him there. He will return to you whipped, if he survives at all, for there is undoubtedly a certain power of God in that place. ³⁹For the one who dwells in heaven is the guardian and protector of that place, and he strikes and destroys those who come to harm it."

⁴⁰This is the story about Heliodorus and how the treasury was saved.

4

Jason Hellenizes the Jews

PREVIOUSLY we told the story about Simon, who betrayed his country by informing about the money in the sanctuary. Then he blamed Onias for what had happened to Heliodorus, as if he had caused all the trouble. ²Simon even dared to accuse Onias of being a conspirator against the government, despite the fact that he was the benefactor of Jerusalem, the defender of his people, and a man zealous for the laws of Moses. ³When Simon's hatred got to such a point that his followers even committed murders, ⁴Onias realized the danger of this rivalry. He also could see that Apollonius son of

Menestheus, governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, was encouraging Simon in his hatred. ⁵So Onias appealed to the king, not to accuse any of his own people, but with their good in mind, both as individuals and as a nation. ⁶He saw that unless the king intervened, conditions would go from bad to worse because Simon would not stop his foolish actions.

⁷When Seleucus died and Antiochus Epiphanes became king, Onias's brother Jason became the high priest by corrupt means. ⁸He went to the king, promising him thirteen and a half tons of silver immediately and another three tons from future revenue. ⁹Besides this, he promised another five and a half tons of silver if the king would grant him a license to set up a school to promote Greek culture and a youth center and allow him to enroll people from Jerusalem as citizens of Antioch. ¹⁰When the king approved this and Jason took office, he immediately began to force the Greek lifestyle on his people. ¹¹Jason rescinded the freedoms that the kings had granted the Jews through the mediation of John, the father of Eupolemus. (Eupolemus later went to Rome as ambassador to make a treaty of peace and alliance.) Jason also prohibited the people from keeping the law of Moses and introduced customs that were contrary to God's law. ¹²He went so far as to build a Greek school near the citadel, and he made the most outstanding young men wear hats that were usually worn by Greek students.

¹³Jason was extremely successful in his efforts to introduce foreign and pagan customs, for he was a man of incredible evil who lacked every virtue to be a true high priest. ¹⁴The priests were no longer concerned with the duties of the altar. Despising the Temple and neglecting the sacrifices, they hurried off to take part in the sinful athletic events whenever there was a call for the games to begin.

¹⁵Looking down on the values of their ancestors, they held Greek customs in the highest regard. ¹⁶But disaster overtook them in the end, and the very ones whose values they desired and whose lifestyles they imitated were to become their enemies and tormentors. ¹⁷For

contempt for the laws of God does not go unpunished, a fact that time would prove.

¹⁸Now when the games that were held every four years took place at Tyre in the king's presence, ¹⁹the evil Jason sent Hellenized citizens from Jerusalem to carry three hundred silver coins for the sacrifice to Hercules. But even the envoys considered it inappropriate to use the money for the sacrifice and decided it should be used for something else. ²⁰So the money intended by Jason for the sacrifice to Hercules was contributed by the envoys for the construction of some ships.

Antiochus IV Epiphanes Welcomed in Jerusalem

²¹Apollonius son of Menestheus went to Egypt as an ambassador to attend the coronation of Ptolemy Philometor. Antiochus Epiphanes heard from Apollonius that Ptolemy was hostile toward him, so he took measures for the king's security, going first to Joppa and then on to Jerusalem. ²²In Jerusalem, Jason and the people received him in magnificent style, welcoming him with torchlights and shouts of praise. From there, Antiochus returned with his army to Phoenicia.

Menelaus Becomes High Priest

²³Three years later Jason sent Menelaus, brother of the previously mentioned Simon, to carry money to the king and bring back the king's decisions regarding certain important affairs. ²⁴But when Menelaus met with the king, he exaggerated his own authority and obtained the high priesthood for himself by offering eleven and a half tons of silver more than Jason paid.

²⁵Having received the king's authorization, Menelaus returned home, but he was not worthy to be high priest. He had the hot temper of a cruel tyrant and the rage of a savage beast. ²⁶So Jason, who had undermined his own brother Onias, was undermined himself. He fled as a fugitive into the land of Ammon.

²⁷Menelaus continued to hold the position of high priest, but he did not send the king any of the payments he had promised. ²⁸He repeatedly ignored the requests for payment made by Sostratus, the commander of the citadel and the one in charge of collecting the king's revenues. So both men were summoned by the king. ²⁹Menelaus left his brother Lysimachus as deputy high priest, and Sostratus left Crates as commander of the troops from Cyprus.

Onias III Is Murdered

³⁰Meanwhile, a revolt broke out in Tarsus and Mallus because those areas had been given as a gift to Antiochis, the king's concubine. ³¹The king went immediately to settle the problem, leaving Andronicus, one of his nobles, to act in his place.

³²Menelaus saw an opportunity to strengthen his position, so he presented Andronicus with some gold vessels he had stolen from the Temple. He also sold some other vessels in Tyre and the surrounding towns. ³³When Onias became aware of what Menelaus was doing, he publicly exposed him, but he did it from the safety of the temple of Daphne near Antioch. ³⁴So Menelaus took Andronicus aside and urged him to kill Onias. Andronicus went to Onias and deceitfully offered him his right hand as a pledge that he would not kill him. Onias had some suspicions, but Andronicus persuaded him to leave the sanctuary. Then he immediately killed Onias without any regard to justice.

³⁵Both the Jews and the other nations were angry and very saddened by the unjust murder. ³⁶When King Antiochus Epiphanes returned from Cilicia, the Jews at Antioch went to him and complained about the unjust murder of Onias. The Greeks shared the Jews' anger over this crime, ³⁷and Antiochus was deeply saddened by the news of Onias's death. He even shed tears, remembering the wisdom and noble character of the dead man. ³⁸Inflamed with anger at the injustice, Antiochus commanded that Andronicus be stripped of his purple robe and be led naked through the city to the very place he had so

shamelessly murdered Onias. There the wicked murderer was put to death. In this way the Lord repaid him with the punishment he deserved.

Lysimachus Is Killed

³⁹In Jerusalem, Lysimachus, the deputy high priest, committed many sacrilegious acts, which were planned by Menelaus. Reports of his actions spread abroad, and the people turned against Lysimachus, who had already stolen many gold items from the Temple. ⁴⁰Because the people were angry and ready to riot, Lysimachus armed about three thousand men and launched an unjust attack under the command of Auranus, a man as advanced in foolishness as he was in age. ⁴¹When the Jews saw what was happening, they attacked Lysimachus and his men with stones and blocks of wood. In wild confusion they threw ashes at the men to blind them. ⁴²As a result, many of Lysimachus's men were wounded, some were killed, and the rest fled for their lives. As for the Temple robber himself, he was killed outside the treasury.

Menelaus's Bribery

⁴³Charges about this affair were filed against Menelaus, the high priest. ⁴⁴When the king came to Tyre, the Jewish high council sent three men to plead their cause. ⁴⁵Menelaus, knowing he would be defeated, promised Ptolemy Macron son of Dorymenes a large bribe if he would persuade the king to favor him. ⁴⁶So Ptolemy, as though to get a breath of fresh air, took the king aside in a colonnade and persuaded him to change his mind. ⁴⁷Because of this, Menelaus, who was guilty of all this evil, was acquitted by the king, and those poor souls who had brought the charges were condemned to death. It was so obvious that the three men were right, however, that even barbarian Scythians would have acquitted them. ⁴⁸So those who argued the cause for Jerusalem, for the Jewish people, and for the

sacred vessels suffered unjust punishment. ⁴⁹Even some people from Tyre were indignant over the deed and buried the three men with great ceremony. ⁵⁰But Menelaus, through the greed of those in power, remained the high priest and grew even more wicked. He became the chief conspirator against his own people.

5

Second Egyptian Campaign



ABOUT this time Antiochus Epiphanes prepared for his second invasion of Egypt. ²For nearly forty days, apparitions were seen in the sky over Jerusalem. Horsemen in gold armor charged through the air, armed with lances and swords. ³Ranks of horsemen were seen with swords drawn—attacking and counterattacking, with flashing shields and numerous spears and flying arrows and shining gold armor of every sort. ⁴All the people prayed that this amazing apparition might be a good sign.

Jason's Revolt

⁵A false rumor began to circulate that Antiochus had died in Egypt, so Jason returned and assaulted Jerusalem with a force of no less than a thousand men. As the defenders on the wall were being defeated and the city was open to attack, Menelaus took refuge in the citadel. ⁶Jason killed his own people in Jerusalem without mercy, not realizing that success at the expense of relatives is the greatest of failures. He imagined that he was winning victories over his enemies rather than over his own people. ⁷But he did not gain control of the government, and in the end he was disgraced as the reward for his treachery. He was forced to flee again into the land of the Ammonites.

⁸Jason's life had a miserable end. After being imprisoned for a time by Aretas, king of the Arabians, he fled from town to town. He was pursued and hated by everyone as a despicable betrayer of the laws

of Moses, a butcher of his own country and people. Finally, he was driven into Egypt. ⁹From there he went to live with the Spartans, hoping they would give him refuge because of their family ties with the Jews. Then Jason, who had exiled so many others, died in a foreign land. ¹⁰The man who had thrown out so many corpses to lie unburied had no one to mourn his death, no funeral, and no place in the tomb of his ancestors.

The Sacrilege of Antiochus Epiphanes

¹¹When the news of fighting between Jason and the Jews in Jerusalem reached King Antiochus, he suspected that the Jews had revolted. So he left Egypt in a furious state of mind and took Jerusalem back by force. ¹²He commanded the soldiers to kill everyone they met and even to hunt down people hiding in their houses and kill them. ¹³They slaughtered young and old, women and children, young girls and infants. ¹⁴Within three days, there were eighty thousand victims—forty thousand killed and forty thousand sold into slavery.

¹⁵But this was not enough for Antiochus. He dared to enter the Temple, the most holy place in all the world. Menelaus, a traitor to the laws of Moses and to his country, was his guide. ¹⁶That filthy Antiochus seized the holy vessels; with defiled hands he took the ornaments that had been given as offerings by other kings to glorify and honor the Temple.

¹⁷Deluded by his pride, Antiochus did not realize he was successful only because the Lord was angry for a time with the sinful residents of Jerusalem. It was the Lord who permitted this contempt for the Holy Place. ¹⁸If the Jews had not been involved in many sins, Antiochus would have been immediately whipped for his presumption and turned back—as Heliodorus was when King Seleucus sent him to inspect the treasury. ¹⁹But the Lord did not choose the nation for the sake of the Holy Place; rather, he chose the Holy Place for the sake of the nation. ²⁰So the Holy Place itself suffered evils inflicted on

the people, just as later it participated in their good fortune. As it was forsaken by the Almighty in his anger, so it would be restored again with great glory when the people were reconciled to the great Lord.

²¹After Antiochus had taken at least sixty-eight tons of silver from the Temple, he hurried back to Antioch. Carried away with pride, he believed he could sail on the land and walk on the sea. ²²He left governors to oppress the people. He left Philip, a Phrygian by birth, at Jerusalem. But Philip was even more barbaric than the one who appointed him. ²³Antiochus left Andronicus at Mount Gerizim. And Menelaus remained high priest, oppressing his own people even more than the others did.

To appease his hatred of the Jews, ²⁴Antiochus sent Apollonius, the captain of the Mysians, with an army of twenty-two thousand men and commanded him to kill all the grown men and to sell the women and children into slavery. ²⁵Apollonius came to Jerusalem under the pretense of peace and waited until the holy day of the Sabbath. Then, as the Jews observed the holy day of rest, he ordered his men to parade around fully armed. ²⁶After a crowd had gathered to watch them, he killed everyone who had come there. Dashing through the city with his armed men, he destroyed many others as well.

²⁷But Judas Maccabeus and nine others escaped into the wilderness. They stayed in the hills, where they lived off the land like wild animals. They ate nothing but wild plants to avoid defiling themselves by eating forbidden animals.

6

Hellenism Enforced on the Jews

NOT long afterward the king sent an influential Athenian citizen to force the Jews to abandon the laws of God and their ancestors ²and to defile the Temple in Jerusalem. They were to call it the temple of Olympian Zeus, and the temple on Mount Gerizim was to be called the temple of Zeus the Hospitable, just as it was by

those who lived there. ³This intensification of evil was hard for everyone to bear. ⁴The Temple was filled with Gentiles getting drunk at wild parties. They took their pleasure in prostitutes and had intercourse with women in the sacred Temple area. And for sacrifices they brought in things that were prohibited by the law of Moses. ⁵The altar was covered with offerings that were strictly forbidden by the laws. ⁶The Sabbath was not allowed to be kept as a holy day, and the people were prohibited from celebrating the festivals instituted by their ancestors. They were not even allowed to identify themselves as Jews. ⁷Each month at the king's birthday celebration, they were forced to participate in the pagan sacrifices. And when the festival of Dionysus was celebrated, they were forced to wear ivy wreaths in honor of the pagan god.

⁸At the suggestion of the people of Ptolemais, a decree was sent to neighboring Greek cities that all Jews should be forced to participate in the sacrifices ⁹and that anyone who refused to conform to Gentile customs should be executed. The misery of the Jews was obvious. ¹⁰For example, two women were accused of having circumcised their children. They were seized and paraded through the city, clutching their infants to their breasts. Then they were thrown down from the city walls. ¹¹Others who met secretly in nearby caves to keep the Sabbath day were betrayed to Philip. Then, because it was the holy Sabbath, they refused to resist their attackers, and they were all burned to death.

The Reason for Persecution

¹²Now, I urge those who read this book not to be disheartened by these calamities. Look at these, not as being for the destruction, but for the correction of our people. ¹³For it is a sign of great kindness when sinners are not allowed to continue in their sin for a long time but are immediately punished. ¹⁴In the case of other nations, the Lord waits patiently to judge them so that their punishment will be based on the full measure of their sins. ¹⁵But that's not how he deals

with us. He punishes us before our sins reach their limit. ¹⁶That way he never withdraws his mercy from us. Although he chastises his people with adversity, he never abandons them. ¹⁷But let these words be sufficient warning to the readers. Now we must go on with the story.

The Martyrdom of Eleazar

¹⁸Eleazar, one of the leading teachers of religious law and an elderly man of noble appearance, was being forced to eat pork. ¹⁹But he preferred an honorable death to a defiled life, so he spit out the pork and went voluntarily to be beaten and tortured. ²⁰He acted as all people should who have the courage to refuse to eat forbidden food, even if it means ignoring their natural instincts for staying alive. ²¹The officials in charge of the pagan sacrificial meal were old friends of Eleazar. In private they urged him to secretly bring meat he was allowed to eat by the law of Moses and only pretend to eat the pork from the king's sacrificial meal. ²²In this way they were trying to be kind to Eleazar and help him save himself from death.

²³But Eleazar had firmly decided to do otherwise. He was a gray-haired old man, who had lived an honorable life since childhood. He was worthy of the distinction that comes with such age and reputation, and he wanted to obey God's holy law. So he answered immediately that they should send him to his death. ²⁴"It is not right to pretend at my age," he said. "And I don't want to give young people the idea that Eleazar, at the age of ninety, has converted to a foreign religion. ²⁵I could gain a few more days of life by pretending to eat the pork, but I would also lead young people astray and defile and disgrace my old age. ²⁶For even if I should escape human punishment, whether I live or die, I will not escape the hands of the Almighty. ²⁷Therefore, by giving up my life bravely, I show myself worthy of my old age. ²⁸I also will give the young people a good example of how to die an honorable death willingly and bravely for the revered and holy laws of Moses." Then he was immediately taken to be tortured to death.

²⁹Those who had just acted kindly toward Eleazar suddenly turned on him because what he had said seemed to them to be utter madness.

³⁰When he was about to die from the blows, he moaned, “The Lord knows all things. He knows I could have saved my life, but instead I suffer this agonizing pain. He also knows I am happy to suffer these things because I worship and fear him.”

³¹So this was how Eleazar died, leaving a memorial of virtue and courage not only for the young but also for the greater part of the nation.

7

The Martyrdom of Seven Brothers



ANOTHER time seven brothers, together with their mother, were arrested by the king. They were tortured with whips to make them violate the law of Moses by eating pork. ²One of them, speaking for all of them, asked, “What are you trying to find out from us? We are ready to die rather than sin against the laws of our ancestors.”

³The king became enraged, and he ordered that pans and cauldrons be heated. ⁴When they were hot, he ordered that the tongue of the spokesman be cut out, that he be scalped, and that his hands and feet be cut off. His brothers and his mother were forced to watch all this. ⁵When the young man was completely helpless, the king commanded that he should be fried alive in the pan. As smoke rose from the sizzling pan, his brothers and his mother strongly urged each other to die bravely. ⁶They said, “The Lord God is watching over us, and he will surely have compassion on us. As Moses declared in the hymn that he sang before the people, ‘He will have compassion on his servants.’”

⁷After the first brother died this way, they brought forward the second to continue their cruel sport. When they had scalped him, they asked him, “Will you eat pork, or do we have to tear you apart limb

from limb?” ⁸He replied in Hebrew, the language of his ancestors, “Never!” So he suffered the same torment as his brother. ⁹And with his last breath, he said, “You wicked tormentor! You may be sending us from this present life, but the King of the world will raise us up again to live forever because we have died for his laws.”

¹⁰After him the third brother was sent to the same torture. When he was ordered to do so, he quickly stuck out his tongue and courageously stretched out his hands. ¹¹Then he said with boldness, “I received these hands from God, but for his laws I will gladly give them up, for I hope to receive them again from him.” ¹²The king and his men were amazed at the young man’s courage because he regarded his suffering as nothing.

¹³After he was dead, they tortured the fourth brother in the same way. ¹⁴When he was near death, he said, “It is better to die by human hands while clinging to the hope that God will raise us up again. But for you, there will be no resurrection to life!”

¹⁵Then they brought the fifth brother and tortured him as well. But he looked at the king ¹⁶and said, “You have power among mortals, even though you are also mortal, so do whatever you want. But do not think that God has forsaken our people. ¹⁷Wait, and you will see how his great power will torment you and your descendants.”

¹⁸After him they brought the sixth brother. Just before he died, he declared, “Do not deceive yourself. It is our own fault that we suffer these things, for we have sinned against our God. Appalling things have happened to us. ¹⁹But do not think that you will escape unpunished for trying to fight against God.”

²⁰The mother was particularly admirable and worthy of honorable memory. Although she saw her seven sons killed in the space of one day, she bore it with great courage because of her hope in the Lord. ²¹She bravely encouraged each of them in Hebrew, the language of their ancestors. Joining a man’s courage to a woman’s insight, she said to them, ²²“I do not know how you were formed in my womb. I wasn’t the one who gave you breath and life, nor did I shape any part of you. ²³But the Creator of the world, who formed the human

race, devised the origin of us all. In his mercy, he will restore both breath and life to you because you are obeying his laws and showing no concern for yourselves.”

²⁴Antiochus, suspecting insult in her tone of voice, thought she was mocking him. The youngest brother was still alive, so Antiochus assured him with an oath that he would make him a rich and happy man if he would abandon the traditions of his ancestors. Antiochus said he would make him one of his favored leaders and give him a high office. ²⁵But the young man was not moved by these offers, so the king called for the mother and told her to persuade the youth to save his life. ²⁶After Antiochus had argued with her for a long time, she said that she would try to persuade her son. ²⁷Then, bending over him, she made a fool of the cruel tyrant and spoke to her son in their native language. “My son, have pity on me. I carried you nine months in my womb, nursed you three years, nourished you, and raised you to this age. ²⁸I urge you, my child, look at heaven and earth and all that is in them, and remember that God made them out of nothing. He made all human beings in this way as well. ²⁹So do not fear this butcher, but show yourself worthy of your brothers. Accept death, so that by God’s mercy I may receive you back again along with your brothers.”

³⁰While the mother was still speaking, the young man said to his tormentors, “What are you waiting for? I will not obey the king’s command but only the law that was given to our ancestors by Moses. ³¹Antiochus, you have contrived all sorts of evil against the Hebrews, but you will never escape the hand of God. ³²We are suffering for our own sins. ³³Though the living Lord is angry with us for a little while and punishes us, we, his servants, will be reconciled to him in the end. ³⁴But you are wicked and most unmerciful. Do not let your vain hopes make you proud because you have the power to torture God’s people, ³⁵for you have not yet escaped the judgment of the sovereign God who sees all things. ³⁶My brothers suffered briefly for the sake of the covenant, and now they have drunk of eternal life. But God will justly punish you for your arrogance. ³⁷But I, like my brothers,

offer my body and my life for the laws of our ancestors. And I call upon God to show mercy to our nation quickly. And may you be tormented and filled with pain until you confess that he alone is God.

³⁸Perhaps because of my brothers and myself, the just wrath of the Almighty against our nation will cease.”

³⁹This made the king extremely angry, and he tortured him more cruelly than he had the others, for he bitterly resented his ridicule.

⁴⁰So the youth died without being defiled, trusting wholly in the Lord.

⁴¹Last of all, after her sons, the mother died. ⁴²But this is enough about the eating of pagan sacrifices and of the extreme cruelties.

8

Judas Maccabeus Leads the Resistance

MEANWHILE, Judas Maccabeus and those who were with him went secretly through the towns, calling together their relatives and friends and enlisting those who continued in the Jewish faith. They gathered six thousand men. ²Then they called on the Lord to look down upon his oppressed people and to have pity on the Temple, which had been defiled by wicked men. ³They asked the Lord to have mercy on Jerusalem, which was being destroyed and was soon to be leveled to the ground, and to listen to the blood crying out to him. ⁴They begged him to remember the wicked slaughter of innocent children and the blasphemies spoken against his name and to show his hatred for evil.

⁵Once Maccabeus had organized his army, the Gentiles could not stand against him because the anger of the Lord was turned to mercy.

⁶So Maccabeus took the towns and villages by surprise and set them on fire. He captured strategic places and sent many enemies fleeing, ⁷usually making his strikes during the night. The reports of his bravery spread far and wide.

⁸Philip could see that Maccabeus was gaining ground little by little and that his victories were becoming more frequent, making him a real threat. So he wrote to Ptolemy Macron, the governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, asking him to send aid to the king's garrisons. ⁹Immediately Ptolemy sent Nicanor son of Patroclus, one of the king's most favored leaders, giving him no less than twenty thousand Gentile troops from different nations to wipe out the whole Jewish race. He also sent Gorgias, a general who was very experienced in matters of war.

¹⁰The king owed a large sum of money to the Romans, so Nicanor proposed to raise seventy-five tons of silver by selling captured Jews into slavery. ¹¹So he sent invitations to dealers in the coastal cities, offering to sell Jewish slaves at the price of ninety slaves for seventy-five pounds of silver. Little did he know that the vengeance of the Almighty was about to catch up to him.

¹²When Judas learned that Nicanor was invading, he told those who were with him that the enemy was near. ¹³Some of them were afraid and did not trust the justice of God, so they ran away. ¹⁴Others sold all their possessions and prayed to the Lord that he would save them from the wicked Nicanor, who had already sold them even before meeting them. ¹⁵They asked the Lord to do this, if not for their own sakes, then for the sake of the covenant he had made with their ancestors and for the honor of his holy and glorious name, by which they were called.

¹⁶Maccabeus called together the six thousand that were now with him, encouraging them to fight bravely and not to be afraid of the enemy or discouraged at the vast horde of Gentiles who were wickedly advancing against them. ¹⁷He vividly reminded them of the sinful and outrageous acts done to the Holy Place and of the way Jerusalem had been attacked and humiliated, not to mention the destruction of the ancestral customs. ¹⁸"They trust in their weapons and their boldness," Maccabeus said, "but we trust in almighty God, who with a single nod can completely destroy both those that fight against us and the whole world." ¹⁹He also reminded them of the help their

ancestors had received from God. Once in the days of Sennacherib, 185,000 enemy soldiers were destroyed. ²⁰Maccabeus also recalled the battle when 8,000 Jews and 4,000 Macedonians fought against the Galatians in Babylonia. When the Macedonians were in danger, the Jews received help from God and killed 120,000 of the enemy. Then they carried off many of the Galatians' possessions. ²¹The soldiers were greatly encouraged by these words and resolved even to die for their laws and country.

Maccabeus divided his army into four divisions ²²and appointed his brothers—Simon, Joseph, and Jonathan—to be captains over three of the divisions. Maccabeus assigned fifteen hundred men to each division. ²³He instructed Eleazar, another one of his brothers, to read to them from the holy book, and then he gave them their battle cry: “God is our help!” Then Maccabeus himself led the first division in an attack against Nicanor. ²⁴With the Almighty as their helper, they killed more than nine thousand of the enemy. They also wounded and disabled the greater part of Nicanor's army and forced them to flee. ²⁵They seized the money of those who had come to buy them as slaves. They also pursued the enemy for a considerable distance, but they had to call off the chase because it was getting late. ²⁶The Sabbath would begin that evening, and for that reason, they could not continue in pursuit. ²⁷When they had gathered together the weapons and captured the spoils of their enemy, they observed the Sabbath. They greatly praised and thanked the Lord, who had saved them that day and had chosen to begin showing his mercy to them. ²⁸After the Sabbath, they gave some of the spoils to those who had been tortured and to orphans and widows. The rest they took for themselves and their children. ²⁹When this was done, they all prayed together, asking the merciful Lord to be fully reconciled to his servants, the Jews.

The Defeat of Timothy and Bacchides

³⁰In confrontations with Timothy and Bacchides, the Jews killed more than twenty thousand of the enemy. They captured the high

strongholds, and then they divided a great amount of plunder among those who had been tortured and to orphans and widows and the elderly. ³¹When they had carefully gathered together the enemy's weapons, they stored them in strategic places. They carried the rest of the plunder to Jerusalem. ³²They also killed the commander of Timothy's forces, a wicked man who had harmed the Jews in many ways. ³³As they celebrated the victory in Jerusalem, the city of their ancestors, they burned Callisthenes and some others who had been hiding in a certain house. These men had set fire to the sacred gates of the Temple, so they were justly repaid for their sacrilege.

The Defeat of Nicanor

³⁴But Nicanor—that most hated man, who had brought a thousand merchants to buy the Jews as slaves—³⁵was humiliated, with the Lord's help, by the very ones he considered insignificant. He took off his brilliant uniform and fled like a runaway slave through the open country. He was fortunate to even arrive at Antioch, for his entire army had been destroyed. ³⁶He had promised to raise the tribute money for the Romans by capturing people from Jerusalem, but now he proclaimed that the Jews had a Defender and that they could not be harmed, for they were following the laws God had given them.

9

The Last Days of Antiochus Epiphanes



ABOUT that time Antiochus Epiphanes returned from Persia with his armies in disarray. ²He had entered the city of Persepolis and attempted to plunder its temples and bring the town under his control. However, the people there had rushed to arms and routed the invaders, forcing them into a humiliating defeat.

³When Antiochus arrived at Ecbatana, he received the news of what had happened to Nicanor and to Timothy's forces. ⁴He became

furious and decided to make the Jews pay for the humiliation he had just suffered. So he commanded his chariot driver to take him to Jerusalem without stopping. But God's judgment went with him because in his arrogance he had said, "When I get to Jerusalem, I will make it a mass grave for the Jews!"

⁵But the Lord, the God of Israel who sees all things, struck Antiochus with an incurable and mysterious disease. For as soon as he had said these words, a dreadful pain seized his intestines—an excruciating intestinal torture that could not be stopped. ⁶This was a very just punishment indeed, considering he had tormented the intestines of others with many barbaric tortures. ⁷But not even this stopped his arrogance; he was still filled with pride. Breathing fire in his rage against the Jews, he commanded the driver to go even faster. But as they were hurrying along, he was thrown from the chariot and fell so hard that his every limb was in agony. ⁸In his superhuman arrogance, he had thought he could command the waves of the sea and weigh tall mountains on a scale, but now he was thrown to the ground and had to be carried on a stretcher. This was a clear manifestation of God's power. ⁹Maggots swarmed out of the wicked man's body, and while he still lived in grief and pain, his flesh rotted away. The stench of his decaying flesh made his army sick. ¹⁰No one could stand to carry the stretcher of this man who had thought only a little while earlier that he could touch the stars of heaven.

¹¹As a result of God's curse, Antiochus was humbled and began to come to his senses, for his agony grew by the minute. ¹²When he himself could no longer stand his own stench, he said, "It is right to be subject to God, and mere humans should not think they are equal to God." ¹³Then this wicked man vowed to the Lord (who would not show him any mercy) ¹⁴that he would set Jerusalem free rather than level it and make it a mass grave. ¹⁵He had previously said that the Jews and their children were not worthy to be buried but only to have their bodies thrown out to be eaten by wild animals and vultures. But now he promised to grant them rights equaling those of the Athenians. ¹⁶He had previously desecrated the holy Temple,

but now he promised to decorate it with the finest gifts, to lavishly replace the holy vessels in it, and to pay from his own resources all the expenses connected with offering the sacrifices. ¹⁷He even said that he would become a Jew himself and go throughout the earth declaring the power of God.

¹⁸But his agony continued, for the just judgment of God had come upon him. Then, realizing he was going to die, he wrote a letter of request to the Jews:

¹⁹“Antiochus, king and commander, sends hearty greetings to his excellent citizens, the Jews, and wishes them health and prosperity. ²⁰If you and your children are well and everything is going as you wish, I am thankful, for my hope is in God.

²¹“As for me, I have fond memories of you. When I returned from the regions of Persia, I became seriously ill and thought it necessary to make plans for everybody’s welfare. ²²Not that I despair of my health, for I have every expectation of recovering from my illness. ²³But I noticed that my father always appointed a successor whenever he led an army into the upper provinces. ²⁴He wanted to leave everything in order in case anything unexpected happened to him. That way the kingdom would not degenerate into chaos because the people would know who was to lead the government. ²⁵And I know that the rulers of the neighboring nations watch for opportunities to take advantage of us, so I have appointed my son Antiochus Eupator to succeed me as king. When traveling in the upper provinces, I have often left him in charge. I have sent him a copy of what I have written here. ²⁶So I urge and beg you to recall the public and private favors given to you and to continue to be faithful to me and to my son. ²⁷For I am confident that he will follow my instructions to be fair and kind to you.”

²⁸So the murderer and blasphemer suffered terribly, much as he had made others suffer. And he died a miserable death in the mountains

of a foreign country. ²⁹Philip, his close friend, carried his body home. Then, fearing the son of Antiochus, Philip went to stay with King Ptolemy Philometor in Egypt.

10

Judas Maccabeus Purifies the Temple

ow Maccabeus and those who were with him, by the protection of the Lord, recovered the Temple and Jerusalem. ²They tore down the altars the Gentiles had set up in the public square and destroyed their pagan shrines. ³After they had purified the Temple, they made another altar. Striking new fire from flint, they offered the first sacrifice in two years. They burned incense, lit the lamps, and set out the Bread of the Presence. ⁴When they had done all these things, they fell face down on the ground and asked the Lord to keep them safe from any further disasters. They also asked that he punish them more gently if they did sin again and that he not hand them over to barbarians and blasphemous people.

⁵The purification of the Temple occurred on the anniversary of the day it had been polluted by foreigners—that is, on the twenty-fifth day of the month of Kislev.

⁶They celebrated with joy for eight days, as is the custom for the Festival of Shelters. They remembered how they had recently kept the Festival of Shelters when they were living in caves in the mountains like wild animals. ⁷So they carried garlanded wands, green branches, and palm branches and sang hymns to the one who had given them success in purifying his Holy Place. ⁸They voted to pass a public decree that the entire Jewish nation should observe these days every year.

The Reign of Antiochus V Eupator

⁹We have finished recounting the death of Antiochus, who was called Epiphanes. ¹⁰We will now relate the events that took place during the reign of Antiochus Eupator, the son of that wicked man. We will give a brief summary of the evils brought about by his wars.

¹¹When Eupator became king, he appointed a man named Lysias to administer the affairs of his kingdom. Before this, Lysias had succeeded Ptolemy Macron as governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia. ¹²Ptolemy was determined to act justly toward the Jews and to deal with them peacefully, especially because of the wrongs that had been done to them. ¹³But the king's favored leaders came and accused Ptolemy Macron because of his policy toward the Jews. On every side he was called a traitor because he had also left Cyprus, where King Ptolemy Philometor had put him in charge, and had defected to Antiochus Epiphanes. Since Ptolemy Macron had no support, he committed suicide by taking poison.

Confrontations between Gorgias and Maccabeus

¹⁴When Gorgias replaced Lysias as governor of Coelesyria and Phoenicia, he hired mercenaries and continually fought the Jews. ¹⁵At the same time, the Idumeans, who controlled important fortified strongholds, were also harassing the Jews. They welcomed renegade Jews from Jerusalem and did everything to keep the war going.

¹⁶After seeking God's help through prayer, Maccabeus and his troops launched an assault against the Idumean strongholds. ¹⁷They attacked vigorously and captured them, driving back those who fought on the walls and slaughtering everyone they encountered. They killed at least twenty thousand men. ¹⁸At least nine thousand men took refuge in two very strong towers with plenty of food and weapons to withstand a siege. ¹⁹So Maccabeus left Simon and Joseph, along with Zacchaeus and his troops, to command an army that was large enough to besiege them. Then he left to take care of more

urgent matters. ²⁰But some of Simon's men were greedy, and they accepted a bribe of seventy thousand silver coins to let the men in the tower escape. ²¹When Maccabeus was told what had happened, he gathered the leaders of the people and accused them of selling out their fellow Jews for money by letting their enemies escape. ²²Then he put those traitors to death and quickly captured the two towers. ²³He was successful in battle and in everything else he did, and he killed more than twenty thousand men in the two fortresses.

Maccabeus Defeats Timothy

²⁴Timothy, who had already been defeated once by the Jews, gathered a large army of mercenaries and assembled many horsemen from Asia. He approached Judea, intending to take it by force. ²⁵But Maccabeus and his men prayed to God as Timothy drew near. To show their humility, they sprinkled dust on their heads and wore sackcloth. ²⁶They lay face down at the foot of the altar and asked God to be merciful to them and to be an enemy to their enemies, an opponent to their opponents, as the law of Moses says. ²⁷After they had prayed, they took up their weapons and marched from the town until they came near their enemies. ²⁸As soon as the sun came up, the two forces attacked each other. One army had not only courage but also confidence in the Lord as its guarantee for victory and success; the other army made rage its leader in the battle. ²⁹When they were in the heat of battle, the enemy saw five men from heaven riding on brilliant horses with golden bridles. These heavenly horsemen were leading the Jews. ³⁰Two of them stood on either side of Maccabeus, shielding him with their armor and keeping him safe. They shot arrows and thunderbolts at the enemy, making them blind and confused and throwing them into chaos. ³¹The Jews killed 20,500 troops and 600 horsemen. ³²Timothy fled to Gazara, a heavily guarded stronghold where Chaereas was governor.

³³Maccabeus and his army eagerly laid siege to the fortress for four days. ³⁴Those who were inside, trusting in the strength of the place,

kept shouting blasphemies and profanities. ³⁵On the morning of the fifth day, twenty young men who were with Maccabeus became furious because of the blasphemy. They bravely stormed the wall and fiercely cut down the enemy. ³⁶Then others followed them and set fire to the towers, burning the blasphemers alive. Still others broke open the gates and let in the rest of the army so they could capture the town. ³⁷They killed Timothy, who was found hiding in a cistern, his brother Chaereas, and Apollophanes. ³⁸After their victory, they sang hymns of thanksgiving, praising the Lord who had shown great kindness to Israel and given them the victory.

11

The First Campaign of Lysias

A short time after this, Lysias became very displeased with what had happened. Lysias was the king's guardian and second-in-command, and he was a member of the royal family. ²He gathered eighty thousand soldiers and all his horsemen with the intention of capturing Jerusalem and making it a Greek settlement. ³He intended to tax the Temple, as he did the shrines of other nations, and to auction off the office of high priest every year. ⁴He had no regard for the power of God but proudly trusted in his numerous foot soldiers, thousands of horsemen, and eighty elephants.

⁵He came into Judea and approached Beth-zur, a fortified place about twenty miles from Jerusalem. He began to vigorously attack it. ⁶When Maccabeus and his men learned that the strongholds were under siege, everyone cried out to the Lord. With tears they begged him to send a good angel to rescue Israel. ⁷Maccabeus himself was the first to take up arms, and he urged the others to follow him into battle in order to help their fellow Jews. So they rushed out together. ⁸While they were still near Jerusalem, a horseman in white clothing appeared to them brandishing gold weapons. ⁹Together they praised the merciful God and took such courage that they were ready to

assault not only the men but also the fiercest beasts and walls of iron. ¹⁰So they advanced in battle formation, having a heavenly ally, the merciful Lord. ¹¹Like lions they leaped on the enemy, killing eleven thousand foot soldiers and sixteen hundred horsemen and sending all the rest fleeing for their lives. ¹²Most of those who fled were wounded and without weapons. Even Lysias was forced to flee in shame.

¹³But Lysias was not stupid. He saw the loss he had suffered and realized that the Hebrews could not be overcome, because the mighty God fought along with them. So Lysias sent a message to them, ¹⁴urging them to settle everything on just terms and promising to make the king their friend. ¹⁵Maccabeus thought about what would be best for everyone, so he accepted Lysias's offer. The king, in turn, consented to all the Jews' requests, which Maccabeus had submitted in writing to Lysias.

¹⁶Lysias wrote the following letter to the Jews:

"This letter is from Lysias to the Jewish people. Greetings.

¹⁷"John and Absalom, your messengers, have delivered your written terms and requested that I grant them. ¹⁸I have reported all the necessary details to the king, and he has granted as much as he can. ¹⁹If, therefore, you will remain loyal to the government, I will endeavor to help you from now on. ²⁰I have given verbal orders that my officials and your messengers should talk with you about the details.

²¹"Farewell. This letter was written on April 20 in the one hundred forty-eighth year of Greek rule."

²²The king had written this letter to Lysias:

"This letter is from King Antiochus to his brother Lysias. Greetings.

²³"Now that our father has taken his place among the gods, we desire that those in our realm should be left undisturbed

in caring for their own affairs. ²⁴We understand that the Jews will not accept the Greek customs of our father. They prefer to keep their own ways and have asked us to allow them to follow their own customs. ²⁵Since we desire that this nation should be at peace, we have decided that their Temple should be restored to them and that they may live according to the custom of their ancestors. ²⁶You will do well, therefore, to write to them and pledge them your friendship. When they have heard this decision, they will be able to rest easy and take care of their own business.”

²⁷The king’s letter to the Jews was as follows:

“This letter is from King Antiochus to the Jewish high council and to the Jewish people. Greetings.

²⁸“We hope you are well, as we ourselves are well. ²⁹Menelaus told us that you wish to return home and care for your own affairs. ³⁰We therefore grant safe conduct to all who go home by April 26. ³¹We also decree that the Jews may follow their own food laws, as they did before, and that none of them will be harassed in any way for things they may have done in ignorance. ³²I have sent Menelaus to reassure you.

³³“Farewell. This letter was written on April 11 in the one hundred forty-eighth year of Greek rule.”

³⁴The Romans also sent a letter to the Jews, which reads as follows:

“This letter is from Quintus Memmius and Titus Manius, ambassadors of the Romans, to the Jewish people. Greetings.

³⁵“Whatever Lysias, a member of the royal family, has granted you, we also grant. ³⁶But he thought some things should be referred to the king. So confer among yourselves on these issues, and then send someone with a message. That way we

can make good proposals on your behalf, for we are going to Antioch. ³⁷Write back immediately so that we may know what you are thinking.

³⁸“Farewell. This letter was written on April 11 in the one hundred forty-eighth year.”

12

Judas Maccabeus Continues to Fight

HEN these agreements were made, Lysias returned to the king and the Jews turned their attention to farming. ²However, some of the governors would not let them live in peace. These governors were Timothy, Apollonius son of Genneus, Hieronymus, Demophon, and Nicanor the governor of Cyprus.

³The people of Joppa also committed an evil deed. They invited the Jews who lived among them (men, women, and children) to go for a boat ride. Since this was an obvious sign of friendship, the Jews publicly voted to accept the offer. ⁴They did not suspect a thing and wanted to be on friendly terms. But when the boats were some distance from the shore, the people of Joppa drowned at least two hundred of the Jews.

⁵As soon as Judas heard about this cruelty to his fellow Jews, he assembled his men for action. ⁶After calling upon God, the just Judge, he attacked those murderers of his fellow Jews. He set the port on fire in the night, burned the boats, and killed with the sword those who had taken refuge there. ⁷Then he left, since the town's gates were closed. But he planned to return again to completely destroy all the people of Joppa.

⁸When he learned that the people of Jamnia also planned to wipe out the Jews who lived among them, ⁹he attacked Jamnia at night and set the port and its ships on fire. The light of the blaze was seen in Jerusalem twenty-eight miles away.

¹⁰When they had gone about a mile from Jamnia and were marching toward Timothy, over five thousand Arabian foot soldiers and more than five hundred horsemen attacked them. ¹¹After a hard fight and with the help of God, Judas and his men won the victory. The defeated nomads asked Judas for a peace treaty, promising to give him livestock and to help the Jews in every other way. ¹²Thinking that they might indeed be useful in many ways, Judas promised them peace. After an exchange of pledges, the Arabians returned to their tents.

¹³Judas also attacked Caspin, a certain town that was surrounded by fortifications and walls and inhabited by all sorts of Gentiles. ¹⁴Confident in the strength of the walls and their supply of food, the people there became insolent, and they taunted Judas with mockery, blasphemy, and all sorts of evil words. ¹⁵But Judas and his men called upon the great Ruler of the world, for in the time of Joshua, the Lord had crumbled the walls of Jericho without the use of battering rams or war machines. Then Judas fiercely assaulted the walls. ¹⁶By God's will Judas and his men captured the town. They slaughtered so many people—a countless number—that a nearby lake that was about a quarter of a mile wide seemed to overflow with blood.

¹⁷From there they marched eighty-seven miles to Charax, to the Jews living in the land of Tob. ¹⁸But they did not find Timothy there, for he had left the area without doing anything, except that he left a very strong garrison in a certain fortress. ¹⁹Dositheus and Sosipater, who were captains under Maccabeus, went and killed the men Timothy had left in the fortress—over ten thousand in all.

²⁰Maccabeus separated his men into divisions and appointed officers over them. He hurried after Timothy, who had with him 120,000 foot soldiers and 2,500 horsemen. ²¹When Timothy learned that Judas was coming after him, he sent the women and children and also the baggage to a fortress called Karnaim. This fortress was hard to besiege or attack because all the approaches were so narrow. ²²But when Judas's first band of soldiers came into sight, their enemies were struck with fear because of an apparition sent by the All-Seeing One. The enemies fled in such confusion that many of them were injured by

their own companions and wounded with their own swords. ²³Judas went after them vigorously, killing the sinners by the sword, and he destroyed about 30,000 men. ²⁴Timothy himself was captured by the soldiers of Dositheus and Sosipater. With great cunning, he begged them to let him live, for he held the parents and brothers of many of them, and if he died, they would also perish. ²⁵When he had solemnly promised to return them unharmed, they released him in order to save their relatives.

²⁶Judas then went to Karnaim and the temple of Atargatis. There he killed twenty-five thousand people. ²⁷After he had destroyed these and put the rest to flight, Judas led his army to Ephron, a fortified town where Lysias and many people from various nations lived. Strong young men guarding the walls made a vigorous resistance, and they had many catapults and plenty of ammunition. ²⁸But when the Jews invoked the name of the Sovereign One, whose power breaks the strength of his enemies, they captured the town and killed twenty-five thousand of those who were inside.

²⁹From there they pressed on to Scythopolis, which lies seventy miles from Jerusalem. ³⁰But the Jews who lived in Scythopolis testified that the people of the town were kind to them, especially during times of adversity. ³¹So Judas thanked the people, strongly urging them to remain friendly to Jews in the future. They arrived back at Jerusalem just before the Festival of Pentecost.

³²After the Festival of Pentecost, Judas and his men marched out to attack Gorgias, the governor of Idumea. ³³Gorgias met them with three thousand foot soldiers and four hundred horsemen. ³⁴When the battle began, a few of the Jews were killed. ³⁵Then a certain Dositheus, one of Bacenor's men and a strong horseman, caught hold of Gorgias and began to drag him by his cloak. Dositheus would have taken the accursed man alive, but a Thracian horseman rushed at him and cut off his arm, and so Gorgias escaped to Marisa. ³⁶Meanwhile, since Esdris and his men had fought a long time and were weary, Judas called upon the Lord to be their helper and their leader in battle. ³⁷After he chanted the battle cry in Hebrew, the language of their

ancestors, accompanied by hymns, they made a surprise attack on Gorgias's troops and caused them to flee. ³⁸Judas then assembled his army and went to the town of Adullam. Since the seventh day was approaching, they remained there to purify themselves according to custom and to keep the Sabbath.

³⁹By the day after the Sabbath, it had become urgent that the bodies of the Jews who had been killed be removed, so Judas and his men went to bury them with their relatives in the tombs of their ancestors. ⁴⁰But under the clothing of the dead they found some sacred amulets of the idols of Jamnia. The law forbids Jews to wear such things, so it was obvious to all that this was why these men had died. ⁴¹Then they all blessed the ways of the Lord, the just Judge, who reveals things that are hidden.

⁴²They spent time in prayer, asking the Lord to completely forgive the sin that had been committed. Then the noble Judas strongly urged the people to keep themselves free from sin, since they saw with their own eyes what happens to people who sin in the same way as those who had died. ⁴³Taking up a collection from each person, Judas sent two thousand silver coins to Jerusalem for a sacrifice to be offered for the sins of those who had died. In so doing he acted well and honorably, for he kept the resurrection in mind. ⁴⁴If he had not expected that those who had died would rise again, it would have been useless and foolish to pray for the dead. ⁴⁵But since he had in mind the splendid reward that awaits those who die a godly death, his thought in doing this was holy and devout. Therefore, he made this atoning sacrifice for the dead so that they might be released from their sin.

13

The Campaign of Antiochus Eupator



IN the one hundred forty-ninth year of Greek rule, Judas learned that Antiochus Eupator was marching with a great

army toward Judea. ²He had with him Lysias, his guardian and second-in-command, and each had an army of 110,000 foot soldiers, 5,300 horsemen, 22 elephants, and 300 chariots armed with deadly blades to cut down foot soldiers.

³Menelaus joined them, and with great pretense he urged Antiochus on. But he was not really looking out for the welfare of his country; he simply hoped to strengthen his political position. ⁴The King of kings caused Antiochus to become angry at the wicked man. So when Lysias suggested that Menelaus was the cause of all their trouble, Antiochus commanded that Menelaus be taken to Berea in Syria and executed according to their local custom. ⁵For in Berea there was a tower seventy-five feet high, with sides steeply sloping down to piles of ashes all around it. ⁶Anyone guilty of sacrilege or notorious for other crimes is taken to the top of the tower and thrown down into the ashes to die. ⁷That was the fate of sinful Menelaus, and he was not even given a decent burial. ⁸It was only fitting that he die in ashes because he had committed many sins against the altar of the Temple, the fire and ashes of which are holy.

⁹The king was consumed with savage arrogance, and he had plans, even worse than his father's, to devastate the Jews. ¹⁰When Judas learned of these plans, he ordered the people to pray to the Lord day and night, asking him to help them now more than ever. For they feared that they would be deprived of the law of Moses, their land, and the holy Temple. ¹¹They prayed that God would not let his people be overtaken again by blasphemous Gentiles, for they were only now recovering from past troubles. ¹²They all joined in this prayer and begged the Lord to be merciful. For three days they continually wept, fasted, and lay face down before the Lord, and then Judas encouraged them and ordered them to stand ready.

¹³After consulting with the high council, Judas decided not to wait for the king to lead his army into Judea to make himself master of the city. Judas decided instead to rely on the Lord to help them defeat the king's army in open warfare. ¹⁴So Judas committed everything to the Creator of the world and encouraged his troops to fight bravely,

even to death, in defense of the laws of Moses, the Temple, the city of Jerusalem, and their country and its citizens. Judas set up camp near Modein, ¹⁵and he gave his soldiers their battle cry, “God brings us victory!” Then, with a select contingent of brave young men, he attacked the king’s camp at night and killed as many as two thousand men in the camp. He also killed the lead elephant with its driver. ¹⁶Having created great fear and confusion in the enemy camp, they left with great success ¹⁷just as dawn was breaking. This all happened because the Lord helped and protected them.

¹⁸The king, having seen the daring of the Jews, resorted to making strategic attacks against their positions. ¹⁹He advanced with his army against Beth-zur, a strong fortress of the Jews, but he was held off and defeated. ²⁰Judas was able to send supplies to reinforce the defenders. ²¹And though Rhodocus, a Jewish soldier, supplied the enemy with secret information, his fellow soldiers discovered the plot, hunted him down, and took him to prison. ²²Then once more the king made a treaty with the people of Beth-zur, and they exchanged pledges of peace. When the king left them, he went to fight Judas and his men, but he was beaten again.

²³Then the king learned that Philip, who had been left in charge of the government by Antiochus Epiphanes, had rebelled at Antioch. The king was worried and made peace with the Jews, promising to honor their demands. When the peace treaty was finalized, the king offered sacrifices and honored the Temple by leaving generous gifts for the Holy Place. ²⁴He accepted Maccabeus with kindness and appointed Hegemonides as governor of the region stretching from Ptolemais in the north to Gerar in the south.

²⁵Then the king visited Ptolemais, but the people of that city were very unhappy with the peace treaty. They were so angry that they wanted to cancel its terms. ²⁶But Lysias went up to the speaker’s platform and argued in favor of the treaty the best he could. Finally, he convinced the people, and they were satisfied. Then the king returned to Antioch. This was how the king’s invasion and withdrawal turned out.

Conflict with Nicanor



THREE years later Judas and his men heard that Demetrius son of Seleucus had sailed into the port of Tripolis with a powerful army and navy. ²He had killed Antiochus Eupator and his guardian Lysias and then declared himself king.

³Now Alcimus had been the high priest, but he voluntarily participated in sinful practices during the time of the revolt. He realized he was now in danger and there was no way for him to regain his position at the holy altar. ⁴So he went to King Demetrius in the one hundred fifty-first year of Greek rule and presented him with a gold crown and a palm branch as well as a customary gift of olive branches from the Temple. On that day he kept quiet about his intentions. ⁵But Alcimus eventually found an opportunity to further his mad plans, for Demetrius called him to a meeting and asked about the attitudes and intentions of the Jews. ⁶Alcimus answered, “Those Jews called Hasideans, who are led by Judas Maccabeus, keep stirring up wars and rebellions and will not allow the country to enjoy peace. ⁷That is why I have been deprived of my ancestors’ glory—I mean the high priesthood. So now I have come here— ⁸first out of loyalty to the king’s interests but also to provide for the good of my own people. Our entire nation suffers terribly from the unreasonable conduct of those men. ⁹Since you know all these things, O king, I beg you to show kindness to our country and our people, for your generosity and kindness are known to everyone. ¹⁰As long as Judas lives, it is not possible for the country to enjoy peace.”

¹¹When he had said all this, the rest of the king’s favored leaders, who were also enemies of Judas, furthered stirred up Demetrius’s anger against Judas. ¹²Immediately the king selected Nicanor, who was commander of the elephants, and appointed him governor of Judea. ¹³He gave him orders to kill Judas, scatter his troops, and make Alcimus the high priest of the great Temple. ¹⁴The Gentiles who had

fled from Judea to escape from Judas joined Nicanor in large numbers, for they thought that defeating and harming the Jews would serve their own good.

¹⁵When the Jews heard that Nicanor was coming and that the Gentiles were assembled to attack them, they put dust on their heads to express their grief. Then they prayed to the One who established his own people forever and who always protects them by revealing his presence with them. ¹⁶Then, at the order of their leader, the Jews moved out and went to the town of Dessau to meet the enemy.

¹⁷Judas's brother Simon had once fought against Nicanor but was stopped suddenly when he saw so many enemies. ¹⁸But Nicanor had heard of the bravery of Judas and his men. He had seen their courage as they fought for their country, so he was afraid and chose not to resolve the issue in battle. ¹⁹Instead, he sent Posidonius, Theodotus, and Mattathias ahead to offer and receive pledges of peace. ²⁰After the terms of the treaty had been fully considered, both leaders informed their troops. Everyone seemed in favor of the treaty, so they consented to the agreement. ²¹Then a day was chosen when the leaders could meet together, and chariots brought them to seats of honor set up between the two armies. ²²Judas positioned armed men in strategic places to be ready for any treachery attempted by the enemy, but the conference went smoothly. ²³After this, Nicanor stayed in Jerusalem and did not cause trouble, dismissing the Gentiles who had joined him. ²⁴Nicanor kept Judas close to him because he had become warmly attached to him. ²⁵He urged Judas to marry and raise a family. So Judas married, settled down, and lived a normal life.

²⁶When Alcimus saw that the two men had become friends, he went to Demetrius with a copy of the treaty. Alcimus complained that Nicanor was being disloyal because he had appointed Judas, a conspirator against them, to succeed him as one of the king's favored leaders. ²⁷Roused by Alcimus's false accusations, the king became angry. He wrote to Nicanor saying that he was displeased with the terms of the treaty, and he ordered him to immediately send Maccabeus to Antioch as a prisoner. ²⁸Nicanor was disturbed when he

received the message, for he did not want to break his agreement with a man who had done him no wrong. ²⁹But because he could not oppose the king, he waited for an opportunity to carry out the orders by some clever scheme. ³⁰When Maccabeus saw that Nicanor was no longer friendly to him and was actually rude when they met, he sensed trouble brewing. So he gathered together many of his men and hid himself from Nicanor.

³¹When Nicanor realized that Judas had outwitted him, he went to the great and holy Temple and commanded the priests who were offering the customary sacrifices to hand Judas over to him. ³²When they swore to him that they did not know where Judas was, ³³he stretched out his right hand toward the sanctuary and swore this oath: "If you do not hand over Judas to me as a prisoner, I will level this Temple of God to the ground and tear down the altar. Then I will erect a new temple to Dionysus." ³⁴After saying this, he left.

The priests raised their hands toward heaven and called upon the One who has always defended our nation. They prayed, ³⁵"O Lord of all things, you need nothing, yet you were pleased to give us a Temple so that you could live among us. ³⁶So now, O Lord of all holiness, keep this house forever undefiled, for it has only recently been purified."

The Martyrdom of Razis

³⁷Razis, a member of the high council in Jerusalem, was a man who loved his people and was highly esteemed. Because of his kindness toward them, he was called the father of the Jews. But Razis was denounced to Nicanor. ³⁸In the early days of the revolt, Razis had been accused of practicing the traditions of the Jewish faith, for which he was ready to give body and soul. ³⁹Nicanor was determined to show his hatred for the Jews, so he sent five hundred soldiers to arrest Razis. ⁴⁰Nicanor thought that by taking him into custody he would be dealing the Jews a severe blow.

⁴¹The soldiers trapped Razis in a tower and tried to set fire to the door in order to gain entrance. But just as he was about to be captured,

Razis threw himself on his own sword. ⁴²He chose to die a noble death rather than to fall into the hands of wicked men who would abuse and humiliate him in ways that a man of his stature should never have to endure. ⁴³But in all the excitement, he failed to make his wound fatal. With the mob rushing in through the door, Razis courageously ran to the top of the wall and threw himself down on the crowd. ⁴⁴But the people quickly jumped out of his way, and he landed on the ground. ⁴⁵Then, still breathing and inflamed with rage, he got up and ran through the crowd with blood gushing from his terrible wound. ⁴⁶He climbed a steep rock and, nearly drained of blood, tore out his intestines with both hands and threw them into the crowd. He then called on the Lord of life and spirit to allow him to live again. This was how he died.

15

Nicanor's Fall

WHEN Nicanor learned that Judas was in the vicinity of Samaria, he decided to attack him on the Sabbath day, since this day of rest would give Nicanor's troops complete safety. ²The Jews who had been forced to join his army protested, "Don't destroy them in such a barbaric and savage way. Respect the Sabbath, for it has been declared holy by the One who sees all things."

³But that most hated wretch mocked, "Is there some ruler in heaven who has commanded that the Sabbath be observed as a special day?"

⁴They replied, "It is the living Lord, the Ruler in heaven, who commands the observance of the Sabbath."

⁵But Nicanor said, "Well, I am sovereign upon earth, and I command you to take up arms and carry out your duty to the king." Even so he was not able to carry out his cruel plan.

⁶Nicanor was filled with immense pride, and he thought he would erect a public monument to commemorate his victory over Judas and his army. ⁷But Maccabeus never lost his trust that the Lord would help

them. ⁸He urged his people not to fear the attack of the Gentiles but to remember the help they had previously received from God. The Almighty would surely give them victory. ⁹He encouraged them with passages from the law and the prophets and recalled the battles they had won before, so they became enthusiastic. ¹⁰Then, after he had encouraged them, he issued his orders. At the same time, he pointed out that the Gentiles had lied and broken their oaths. ¹¹He armed all his people, not so much with the protection of shields and spears, but with the inspiration of his bold speech. He inspired them even more by telling them about a dream—a vision, as it were—worthy to be believed.

¹²This was the vision: “Onias, who was formerly the high priest, was a good and virtuous man. He was modest in appearance, gentle in manner, and graceful in speech, and he had been trained in every virtue from the time he was a child. One day he was praying with lifted hands for the whole Jewish community. ¹³At that moment another man appeared whose age and dignity made him look very distinguished and whose presence conveyed a noble authority. ¹⁴When Onias saw him, he said, ‘This is a man who loves his fellow Jews. He prays often for his people and for the holy city. It is Jeremiah, the prophet of God.’ ¹⁵Then Jeremiah reached out his right hand and gave Judas a gold sword, saying, ¹⁶‘Take this holy sword, a gift from God, and use it to kill your enemies.’”

¹⁷That was all the people needed. Judas had stirred up the courage and strengthened the hearts of the young men. They now were eager to make this a quick fight and to attack bravely, deciding the matter in courageous hand-to-hand combat, for the holy city and the Temple were in danger. ¹⁸Their concern for their wives, children, brothers, and relatives paled in comparison to their first and foremost concern: the holy Temple. ¹⁹And everyone in the city was very concerned for those who were going to fight in the open country.

²⁰Everyone was ready for a decisive battle. Nearby, the enemy was set in formation, with the elephants in strategic position and the horsemen on the flanks. ²¹Maccabeus looked at the advancing army with

its many types of armor and its savage elephants. Then he raised his hands toward heaven and called upon the Lord, who works wonders and gives victory to those who deserve it. For Maccabeus knew that battles are not won merely by weapons but according to the Lord's plan. ²²In his prayer Maccabeus said, "O Lord, you sent your angel in the days of Hezekiah, king of Judah, and he killed 185,000 people in Sennacherib's camp. ²³Now, O Ruler of heaven, send a good angel to spread fear and dread before us. ²⁴With your mighty arm, strike down those who come with blasphemy against your holy people." And so he concluded his prayer.

²⁵Nicanor and his soldiers advanced with trumpets and marching songs. ²⁶Judas and his men met the enemy with prayers and cries to God. ²⁷Fighting with their hands while praying to God with their hearts, they killed at least thirty-five thousand men. They were ecstatic over this display of God's power. ²⁸And when the battle was over and they were returning with joy, they discovered Nicanor, lying dead in full armor. ²⁹With wild shouts, they blessed the Sovereign Lord in Hebrew, the language of their ancestors.

³⁰Judas had completely devoted himself, body and soul, to defending his people, and he loved his fellow Jews ever since childhood. Now he ordered that Nicanor's head and arm be cut off and carried to Jerusalem. ³¹When he arrived there, he called all the people together and stationed the priests before the altar. Then he sent for the remaining troops in the citadel. ³²He showed them the head of that evil and profane Nicanor and the arm he had raised with proud boasts against the holy Temple of the Almighty. ³³Then he cut out the tongue of the wicked Nicanor and ordered that it be fed piece by piece to the vultures. And to show what had happened to Nicanor for his foolish deeds, Judas hung Nicanor's arm in front of the sanctuary.

³⁴Then everyone looked toward heaven and blessed the Lord, who had displayed his power. They said, "Blessed is he who has kept his Temple undefiled." ³⁵Finally, Judas hung Nicanor's head from the citadel as an obvious reminder of how the Lord had helped them.

³⁶The people voted to institute an annual celebration on this day, the thirteenth day of the twelfth month, which in Aramaic is called Adar. (This is the day before Purim, the annual celebration of Mordecai's victory.)

³⁷So this is how things turned out with Nicanor. From that time until now, Jerusalem has been in the possession of the Hebrews. Now I will also make an end of my narration here. ³⁸My goal was to make it well written and concise, but if it is poorly done or just mediocre, it is the best I could do. ³⁹It is disagreeable to drink only wine or only water, but wine mixed with water is a pleasant drink that increases our enjoyment. In the same way, a story that is well written is pleasantly received by its readers. Let this, then, be the end.

Preface to The Additions to Esther and Daniel

Martin Luther, 1534

HERE follow several pieces which we did not wish to translate [and include] in the prophet Daniel and in the book of Esther. We have uprooted such cornflowers (because they do not appear in the Hebrew versions of Daniel and Esther). And yet, to keep them from perishing, we have put them here in a kind of special little spice garden or flower bed since much that is good, especially the hymn of praise, *Benedicite*, is to be found in them.

But the texts of Susanna, and of Bel, Habakkuk, and the Dragon, seem like beautiful religious fictions, such as Judith and Tobit, for their names indicate as much. For example, Susanna means a rose, that is, a nice pious land and folk, or a group of poor people among the thorns; Daniel means a judge, and so on. Be the story as it may, it can all be easily interpreted in terms of the state, the home, or the devout company of the faithful.

The Additions to Esther

The following chapters (1-6) are the Greek additions to Esther, known as Chapters A-F in Catholic editions. They are not found in the Hebrew text of Esther.

1

Mordecai's Dream

IN the second year of the reign of King Xerxes the Great, on the first day of the new year, Mordecai son of Jair, son of Shimei, son of Kish, of the tribe of Benjamin, had a dream. ²He was a Jew living in the city of Susa, and he was an important man who worked in the king's palace. ³He was a descendant of the captives whom King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon had taken from Jerusalem when he took King Jehoiachin of Judea, captive.

⁴This was Mordecai's dream: There was clamor and confusion, thunder and earthquakes, and tumult upon the earth! ⁵Two great dragons came forward, ready to fight one another. ⁶At their terrible roar, every nation prepared for war, to fight against the righteous nation. ⁷It was a day of darkness and gloom, of troubles and distress, of suffering and great confusion upon the earth. ⁸The entire righteous nation was distraught; the people feared impending evil and prepared for death. ⁹But then the people cried to God, and a great overflowing river burst forth from a tiny spring. ¹⁰Light from the rising sun burst forth, and the humble were exalted and destroyed the nobles.

¹¹When he woke up from this dream that revealed what God was going to do, Mordecai began thinking about what it might mean. He

kept turning it over in his mind, anxious to understand every detail of the dream.

¹²One time Mordecai was resting in the king's courtyard with Bigthana and Teresh, the king's eunuchs who were guards of the courtyard. ¹³He overheard them discussing a conspiracy, so he investigated their plans and discovered that they were about to kill King Xerxes. So Mordecai warned the king about the plot. ¹⁴The king had the two men interrogated, and after they confessed, he had them executed. ¹⁵The king made an official record of what had happened, and Mordecai also wrote down the events. ¹⁶The king ordered Mordecai to serve in the palace and gave him a reward. ¹⁷But Haman son of Hammedatha the Agagite, a man highly regarded by the king, sought to harm Mordecai and his people because of what had happened to the king's two eunuchs.

2

Haman's Letter



HIS is a copy of Haman's letter:

"This letter is from the great King Xerxes to the governors of his 127 provinces from India to Ethiopia and to the officials under them.

²"I rule over many nations and have brought all the world under my dominion, but in spite of my power, I have not grown arrogant. Instead, I choose to govern my subjects with fairness and kindness so that they may live quietly without any fear. Then they can travel safely throughout the kingdom and enjoy peace, as all people desire.

³"When I asked my advisers how this might be accomplished, I received excellent counsel from Haman. He is a wise, kind,

and faithful leader who is second in command of my kingdom. ⁴He told me that there is a hostile race of people scattered among all the nations and that the laws of these people are contrary to those of all nations. They despise the commands of kings and disrupt our attempt to unify our kingdom. ⁵This group constantly opposes all humanity by following strange lifestyles and laws, going against our commands, and disturbing the peace and unity of all our provinces. ⁶Therefore, we have decreed that everyone must follow the instructions given by Haman, who is in charge of the government and second in power only to the king, for we honor Haman as a second father to us. All members of this race he has identified are to be completely destroyed by their enemies, together with their wives and children, and no one is to have pity on them. This is to happen next spring on March 8. ⁷So in a single day, all these people who have been hostile for so long come to a violent end, and we will restore to our empire the peace they have disturbed.”

3

Mordecai's Prayer



ORDECAI thought about all that the Lord had done, and then he began to pray. ²He said:

“O Lord, Lord, almighty King, you rule over all things, and no one can resist your will if you decide to save Israel. ³You made heaven and earth and all the wonders under heaven. ⁴You are Lord of all, and there is none who can resist you, Lord. ⁵You know all things, and you know that it was not out of pride or contempt or desire for glory that I refused to bow down to proud Haman. ⁶For I would willingly have kissed his feet to

save Israel. ⁷But I did this so I would not place human glory before the glory of God. And I will not bow down to anyone except you, my Lord. ⁸And now, O Lord God and King, God of Abraham, spare your people, because our enemies are determined to destroy us and to wipe out the people who have been your possession from the beginning. ⁹Do not neglect us, your own people, whom you redeemed for yourself out of Egypt. ¹⁰Hear my prayer, and be merciful to us—your possession. Turn our mourning into joyful feasting so that we may live and praise your name. O Lord, do not destroy those who sing to you.”

¹¹And all Israel cried out in prayer to the Lord, for death was staring them in the face.

¹²Queen Esther, fearing the mortal danger that was at hand, also turned to the Lord for help. ¹³Taking off her royal robes, she put on garments suitable for weeping and mourning. Instead of precious ointments, she covered her head with ashes and dung. She purposely made herself unattractive and covered her beauty with her tangled and disheveled hair.

Esther's Prayer

¹⁴Esther began to pray to the Lord, the God of Israel. She said:

“O my Lord, you alone are our King. Help me, since I am alone and have no other helper but you— ¹⁵and I am about to risk my life. ¹⁶From my earliest days my family and tribe have taught me that you, O Lord, chose Israel from among all nations. You chose our ancestors from those who came before them so that they would be your special possession forever. And you have done all that you promised them. ¹⁷We have sinned in your sight. You have handed us over to our enemies ¹⁸because we have worshiped their gods. You are just, O Lord. ¹⁹But now our enemies are not content to oppress us with

bitter slavery. They have vowed ²⁰to abolish the decree you yourself made, to destroy your special possession, to close the mouths of those who praise you, and to extinguish the fire on the altar and the glory of your Temple. ²¹By doing this, they will give the Gentiles cause to praise their worthless idols and to exalt a mortal king forever.

²²“O Lord, do not surrender the scepter of your rule to gods that do not even exist. Do not let them laugh at our ruin. Turn their plan against them and destroy the man who began this attack against us. ²³Remember us, O Lord! Show yourself to us in this time of trouble, and give me boldness, O King of gods and ruler of every power. ²⁴Put eloquent words in my mouth in the presence of the lion, and cause him to hate our enemy so that he may be destroyed along with those who agree with him. ²⁵But rescue us by your hand, and help me, O Lord, for I have no other helper but you.

²⁶“You know all things. You know that I hate the splendor of the wicked, and I abhor the bed of the uncircumcised and of any foreigner. ²⁷You know what a bind I am in. I hate my crown—that sign of my proud position—yet I must wear it on my head when I appear in public. I detest it as a filthy rag and never wear it in private. ²⁸I, your servant, have never eaten at Haman’s table, nor have the king’s banquets ever pleased me, nor have I drunk wine offered to idols. ²⁹I am your servant, O Lord God of Abraham. Ever since I was brought here, I have rejoiced only in you—even to this day. ³⁰O God, whose might is greater than all, hear the voice of those in despair, rescue us from the power of the wicked, and save me from my fear!”

Esther Visits the King

N the third day of the fast, Esther ended her prayers. She took off the garments she wore for worship and put on her royal robes. ²Dressed in all her splendor, she first called upon the All-Seeing God and Savior. Then she took two maids with her. ³She leaned gently upon one of the maids for support, ⁴while the other followed behind, carrying Esther's flowing train. ⁵Her radiant and beautiful countenance made her look happy, but Esther's heart was filled with fear. ⁶She passed through all the doors of the court and stood before the king. He was sitting upon his royal throne, clothed in his royal robes, resplendent with gold and precious stones. He was awesome to behold. ⁷Looking up, his face blazed with both royal splendor and fierce anger. The queen staggered, turning pale and faint, and then leaned weakly upon the shoulder of the maid in front of her. ⁸Then God changed the king's spirit to become gentle. He hurried from his throne with concern and lifted her up in his arms until she came to. He comforted her by saying, ⁹"What is the matter, Esther? I am your husband. Don't be afraid. ¹⁰You will not die, for this law was made for others, not for you. ¹¹You may approach the throne." ¹²The king raised the gold scepter and touched her neck with it. He embraced her and said, "Speak to me."

¹³She answered, "I saw you, my lord, as an angel of God, and my heart was fearful because of your glory. ¹⁴For you are wonderful, my lord, and your face reflects such grace." ¹⁵While she was speaking, she fainted and collapsed. ¹⁶The king was very concerned, and all his servants tried to help her.

5

Mordecai's Letter



HIS is a copy of Mordecai's letter:

“This letter is from the great King Xerxes to the governors of his 127 provinces from India to Ethiopia and to our loyal subjects. Greetings.

²“For many people, the more good things they receive from their benefactors, the more proud they become. ³Not only do they seek to oppress the king’s subjects, but they are unable to enjoy the success given them. So they turn against their own benefactors. ⁴Not only do they drive out gratitude from others, but they also become proud from the flattery of those who don’t know what good really is. They think they can escape the justice of God, who sees all things and hates evil. ⁵Often higher authorities are sweet-talked into granting public offices to friends, who then use their position to kill innocent people. In this way they involve the higher authority in irreparable tragedies, ⁶for they deceive the well-meaning rulers with false trickery.

⁷“Now this is proved both from ancient records and even more by recent events, which show the kind of evil that results from the destructive behavior of unworthy rulers. ⁸In the future we must provide for the peace and quiet of all the people of the kingdom. ⁹We must change our methods and use a more just process for judging matters that are brought to our attention.

¹⁰“For example, we received Haman son of Hammedatha, a Macedonian (so he was not even Persian and did not share in our kind nature), as a guest. ¹¹He benefited from the kindness that we show toward all people—so much so that everyone called him “father” and bowed down to him, regarding him as second in power only to the king. ¹²But he was so filled with arrogance that he tried to deprive us of our kingdom and our lives. ¹³With unbelievable craftiness and deceit, he has sought the destruction of Mordecai, our constant benefactor

who saved our lives; of Esther, the blameless royal partner; and of their entire nation. ¹⁴In this way, Haman thought that he could make us defenseless and then transfer the kingdom of the Persians to the Macedonians. ¹⁵But we have found that the Jews, who were slated to be slain by that most hated man, are not evil. In fact, they have just laws, ¹⁶and they are the children of the living God, the Most High and greatest God. It is by this God's direction that the kingdom has been excellently maintained for us as well as for our ancestors.

¹⁷"Therefore, you should disregard the letters sent by Haman son of Hammedatha. ¹⁸He and all his household were impaled for this crime at the gates of Susa. God, who rules over all things, has swiftly repaid him as he deserved. ¹⁹Post a copy of this letter in all public places, and let the Jews follow their own laws. ²⁰On March 7 you must aid them in their time of hardship so that they may defend themselves against those who will attack them. ²¹For the all-powerful God has turned this day of destruction into a day of joy for his chosen people. ²²You will celebrate this day as another important festival. ²³From now on, Jews and loyal Persians will remember this day as a time of deliverance, but those who plot against us will only be reminded of their downfall. ²⁴Every single province and city that does not obey these orders will be viciously destroyed by spear and fire. Their land will become uninhabitable for human beings, and even the wild animals and birds will stay away."

6

Mordecai Interprets His Dream



ORDECAI said, "God has done these things. ²I remember the dream I had concerning these same things, and all of it has

been fulfilled. ³There was a small spring that grew into a river, and there was light and sun and plenty of water. The river is Esther, whom the king married and made queen. ⁴The two dragons are Haman and myself. ⁵The nations are those who banded together to wipe out the Jews. ⁶My nation is Israel, who cried out to God and was saved. The Lord delivered us from all these evil schemes; God has performed great signs and wonders among the Gentiles. ⁷For this reason he made two lots (called purim), one for the people of God and the other for all the Gentiles. ⁸When the appointed day, hour, and moment came for the lots to be cast as God and all the Gentiles watched, ⁹God remembered his people and vindicated his special possession. ¹⁰So people will gather together for two specified days in late winter and celebrate this day with joy and gladness before God. This festival will be celebrated from generation to generation forever among God's people, Israel."

Postscript

¹¹In the fourth year of the reign of Ptolemy Soter and Cleopatra, Dositheus and his son Ptolemy brought to Egypt the preceding letter about Purim. Dositheus said he was a priest and a Levite, and his son was a resident of Jerusalem. They asserted that the letter was authentic and that it had been translated by Lysimachus, Ptolemy's son.

Additions to Daniel

The following are the Greek additions to Daniel, not found in the Hebrew text.

Susanna

This chapter appears as Daniel 13 in Catholic editions of the Bible. It is not found in the Hebrew text of Daniel.

Susanna and the Elders

¹There was a man named Joakim who lived in Babylon. ²He married a woman named Susanna, the daughter of Hilkihah. She was very beautiful and feared the Lord. ³Susanna's parents were righteous people, so they had raised her to follow the law of Moses. ⁴Joakim was very rich and had a garden near his house, and the Jews came to him for counsel because he was the most honored member of their community.

⁵Two elders were appointed to be judges that year, but the Lord said about them: "Wickedness has come from Babylon, from the elders who were supposed to govern the people." ⁶These men came frequently to Joakim's house, and anyone who needed a dispute settled came to them.

⁷When the people left each day at noon, Susanna would go out and walk in her husband's garden. ⁸The two elders saw her going out to walk in the garden every day, and they began to lust for her. ⁹They ignored their consciences, shutting out any thoughts of God

and disregarding justice. ¹⁰So they were both overcome with passion for her, but neither one revealed his feelings to the other, ¹¹for they were ashamed to let anyone know about their desire to seduce her. ¹²Every day they eagerly waited for the opportunity to watch her.

¹³One day they said to each other, "Let's go home now. It's time for dinner." So they left and went their separate ways. ¹⁴But then they each circled back to spy on Susanna, and each discovered the other. After questioning each other, they both admitted their lust for Susanna. Then they cooked up a plan to find her alone.

¹⁵Once, as they were watching for a chance to find her alone, Susanna went out at the regular time. She was accompanied by only two servant girls, for the day was hot, and she wanted to bathe in the garden. ¹⁶No one else was there except the two elders, who had hidden in the garden and were watching her. ¹⁷Susanna said to her servants, "Bring me olive oil and ointments, and shut the gates of the garden so I can bathe in privacy." ¹⁸They did as she told them. They shut the gates of the garden and went out by a side gate to get what she had asked for. They didn't know that the elders were hiding inside.

¹⁹When the servant girls had left, the two elders ran over to Susanna and said, ²⁰"Look, the gates of the garden are shut, and no one can see us. We want to have sex with you. ²¹If you don't cooperate, we will testify against you in court and say that you sent your servants away because you had arranged to meet a young man in the garden."

²²Susanna groaned in despair and said, "I am trapped no matter what I do. If I agree to have sex with you, it is a sin punishable by death. But if I refuse, I will still not escape your power. ²³I choose not to do it! I choose to suffer innocently at your hands rather than to sin against the Lord."

²⁴With that, Susanna cried out for help, but the two elders began shouting, putting the blame on her. ²⁵Then one of the elders ran to open the front gate of the garden. ²⁶When the servants in the house heard the commotion in the garden, they rushed through the side gate to see what had happened to Susanna. ²⁷As the elders told their story,

the servants were dismayed, for no one had ever accused Susanna of such a sin.

The False Accusation

²⁸The next day the people came as usual to Joakim's house. The two elders also came, fully determined to carry out their wicked plot to have Susanna put to death. ²⁹In the presence of all the people, they said, "Send for Hilkiah's daughter Susanna, the wife of Joakim." So they sent for her at once. ³⁰And she came to the assembly with her parents, her children, and all her relatives. ³¹Now Susanna was very refined and beautiful. ³²Her face was veiled, but those wicked men commanded that she take off her veil. They did this so that they could at least feast their eyes on her beauty.

³³While all Susanna's friends and everyone else wept, ³⁴the two elders stood up before the assembly to lay hands on her head and accuse her of sin. ³⁵Through her tears, Susanna looked up toward heaven, for she trusted in the Lord. ³⁶Then the elders said: "As we walked in the garden alone, this woman came in with two servant girls and shut the gates of the garden, and then she sent the servants away. ³⁷Then a young man who was hiding there came out and had sex with her. ³⁸We were in a corner of the garden, and when we saw this crime, we ran over to them. ³⁹Although we had seen them lying together, we could not catch the young man because he was too strong for us. He opened the gates and ran off. ⁴⁰But we did catch this woman. When we asked her who the young man was, ⁴¹she would not tell us. We testify that this is what we saw."

Since the two men were elders and judges, the crowd believed them and condemned Susanna to death. ⁴²Then Susanna cried out with a loud voice: "Eternal God, you know things that are hidden, and you foresee all things. ⁴³You know that these men have testified falsely against me. And now I am going to die, even though I have done none of the things these wicked men have said about me."

Daniel Exposes the Elders' Lie

⁴⁴The Lord heard Susanna's cry, ⁴⁵so when she was being led away to her execution, God stirred up the righteous spirit of a young man named Daniel. ⁴⁶He shouted, "I will have no part in the shedding of this woman's blood!"

⁴⁷Then all the people turned to Daniel and said, "What are you talking about?"

⁴⁸So he stood before them and said, "Are you so foolish, you people of Israel, that you have condemned a daughter of Israel without a proper trial? ⁴⁹Return to the court, for these witnesses have given false testimony against her."

⁵⁰So all the people quickly returned, and the other elders said to Daniel, "Come, sit here among us, and show us your reasoning, since God has given you the wisdom of old age."

⁵¹Daniel said to them, "Separate these two witnesses, and I will cross-examine them separately." ⁵²So when they had been separated, he called for one of them and said to him, "How evil you have grown in your old age! Now the sins of your earlier days have caught up with you. ⁵³You made unjust judgments, condemned the innocent, and let the guilty go free, though the Lord said, '**Never put an innocent or honest person to death.**' ⁵⁴Now then, if you really saw what happened, tell me what kind of tree the couple was lying under when you saw them together."

The elder answered, "Under a mastic tree."

⁵⁵Then Daniel said, "Well, now, this lie has cost you your head. The angel of God has already received the sentence from God and will cut you in two."

⁵⁶Then Daniel dismissed the first elder and called for the second. He said to him, "You filthy Canaanite, beauty has deceived you, and lust has perverted your heart. ⁵⁷This is how you sinned with the daughters of Israel, and in their fear they gave in to you. But here is a daughter of Judah who would not tolerate your wickedness. ⁵⁸Now then, tell

me what kind of tree the couple was lying under when you saw them together.”

The second elder answered, “Under an oak tree.”

⁵⁹Then Daniel said to him, “Well, now, this lie has cost you your head as well. The angel of God is waiting with his sword to split you in two. Then both of you elders will be destroyed.”

⁶⁰Then the entire assembly gave a great shout and blessed God, who saves those who trust in him. ⁶¹And they rose up against the two elders, for Daniel had used their own words to convict them of giving false testimony. In keeping with the law of Moses, the elders received the same punishment they were about to inflict on their neighbor: ⁶²They were put to death. And so an innocent life was saved that day.

⁶³Hilkiah and his wife praised God for their daughter Susanna, as did her husband, Joakim, and all her relatives, because she was found innocent of a shameful crime. ⁶⁴And Daniel was greatly esteemed by the people from that day forward.

Bel and the Dragon

This chapter appears as Daniel 14 in Catholic editions of the Bible. It is not found in the Hebrew text of Daniel.

Daniel Destroys Bel the Idol

¹After King Astyages joined his ancestors in death, Cyrus the Persian took over his kingdom. ²Daniel was the king's companion and was honored above all the king's favored leaders.

³Now the Babylonians had an idol named Bel. Every day, twelve large measures of fine flour, forty sheep, and six measures of wine were offered to the idol. ⁴The king also adored it and went every day to worship it. But Daniel worshiped his own God.

⁵So the king said to Daniel: "Why don't you worship Bel?"

Daniel answered: "I do not worship idols made by human hands. I worship the living God, who created heaven and earth and rules over every living being."

⁶The king said to him, "Don't you think Bel is a living god? Don't you see how much he eats and drinks every day?"

⁷But Daniel smirked and said: "O King, don't be deceived, for that idol is only clay on the inside and bronze on the outside. It has never eaten or drunk anything."

⁸Then the king became angry, and he called for his priests and said to them, "If you do not tell me who eats all the food, you will die. ⁹But if you can show that Bel eats it, Daniel will die because he has blasphemed Bel."

And Daniel said to the king, "Let it be as you say."

Now there were seventy priests of Bel in all, besides their wives and children. ¹⁰The king went with Daniel into the temple of Bel. ¹¹The priests of Bel said, "See, we are leaving now. You yourself, O King, can set out the food and prepare the wine. Then lock the door and seal it with your own signet. ¹²If you do not find that Bel has eaten and drunk everything when you return in the morning, we will be put to death. But if Bel has eaten and drunk everything, this will prove that Daniel has lied about us and must die." ¹³They were not worried because they had made a secret entrance under the altar, and they always went in that way and ate all the food themselves.

¹⁴So after the priests had left, the king set the food before Bel. Then Daniel ordered his servants to bring ashes, and they spread them all over the temple floor while only the king watched. Then they left and shut the door, sealing it with the king's signet. ¹⁵As usual, the priests and their wives and children went in during the night and ate and drank everything.

¹⁶The king went to the temple early in the morning, and Daniel went with him. ¹⁷The king asked, "Are the seals unbroken, Daniel?" He answered, "They are unbroken, O King."

¹⁸As soon as he had opened the door, the king saw that the table was empty. Then he exclaimed, "You are great, O Bel; there is not one deceitful thing about you!"

¹⁹Daniel laughed, and he kept the king from entering. "Look at the floor," he said, "and tell me whose footprints these are."

²⁰The king said, "I see the footprints of men, women, and children." ²¹Then the king became angry and arrested the priests and their wives and children. They showed him the secret doors through which they entered to eat the food that was on the table. ²²So the king put them

to death, and he gave Daniel permission to do whatever he wanted with Bel. So Daniel destroyed both the idol and its temple.

Daniel Destroys the Dragon

²³There was also a great dragon that the Babylonians worshiped.

²⁴The king said to Daniel, "Look, you cannot deny that this is a living god. So worship it."

²⁵But Daniel said, "I worship only the Lord my God, for he is the living God. With your permission, O King, I will kill this dragon without sword or club."

²⁶The king said, "I give you permission." ²⁷So Daniel took pitch, fat, and hair, and he boiled it all together. Then he made it into cakes and fed them to the dragon. After the dragon ate them, it burst open. Then Daniel said, "Look at this one you worshiped!"

²⁸When the Babylonians heard about it, they became very angry and rebelled against the king. They said, "The king has become a Jew. He has destroyed Bel, he has killed the dragon, and he has slaughtered the priests." ²⁹So they went to the king and said, "Hand Daniel over to us, or we will destroy you and your household." ³⁰The king saw that he was in danger, so he was forced to hand Daniel over to them.

Daniel in the Lions' Den Again

³¹The people threw Daniel into the lions' den, and he was there six days. ³²In the den were seven lions that were fed each day with two human bodies and two sheep. But during this time they were not fed at all to ensure that they would devour Daniel.

³³Now there was a prophet named Habakkuk who lived in Judea. He had made some stew and put some bread in a basket. He was on his way to the fields to give the food to the harvesters. ³⁴But an angel of the Lord said to Habakkuk, "Take this food to Daniel in Babylon because he is in the lions' den."

³⁵Habakkuk responded, “Lord, I’ve never been to Babylon, and I don’t know where to find the lions’ den.” ³⁶Then the angel of the Lord grabbed him by the hair and carried him as fast as the wind all the way to Babylon. The angel of the Lord set him down just above the lions’ den. ³⁷Habakkuk called out, “Daniel, Daniel! Take the meal God has sent you.”

³⁸And Daniel said, “You have remembered me, O God. You have not abandoned those who love you.” ³⁹So Daniel got up and ate, and the angel of the Lord immediately carried Habakkuk back to his own place.

⁴⁰On the seventh day the king went to the den to mourn for Daniel. But when he arrived at the den and looked in, he saw Daniel sitting there! ⁴¹The king exclaimed, “You are great, O Lord, the God of Daniel! There is no God but you!” ⁴²Then he pulled Daniel out, and those who had tried to destroy Daniel were thrown into the den. They were devoured in a moment as the king watched.

The Prayer of Azariah and the Song of the Three Young Men

These verses (24-90) are the Greek addition to Daniel 3, known as the Prayer of Azariah and the Song of the Three Young Men in Catholic editions. They are not found in the Hebrew text of Daniel.

²⁴The three men walked around in the fire, singing hymns to God and praising the Lord. ²⁵Then Azariah stood still in the fire and prayed aloud: ²⁶“You are worthy of praise, O Lord, the God of our ancestors. Your name is glorious forever! ²⁷For you are just in everything you have done. All your works are true, your ways are right, and all your judgments reflect the truth. ²⁸You acted justly when you caused all these things to happen to us and to Jerusalem, the holy city of our ancestors. Because of our sins, you acted justly, causing all this to happen. ²⁹For we have sinned and broken your law by deserting you. We sinned greatly in everything. ³⁰We have not obeyed your commandments. We have not done what you commanded for our own good. ³¹So in everything you have brought upon us and everything you have done to us, you have acted justly. ³²You have handed us over to our enemies— lawless and detested rebels— and to an unjust king, the worst in all the world. ³³And now there is nothing we can say. We, your servants who worship you, have been shamed and disgraced.

³⁴“But for your name’s sake do not abandon us forever; do not discard your covenant. ³⁵Do not withdraw your mercy from us— for the sake of Abraham, your beloved friend; Isaac your servant; and Israel, your holy one. ³⁶For you promised them as many descendants as the stars of heaven and the sand on the seashore. ³⁷Lord, we have become the smallest of all nations, and now we are humiliated in all the world because of our sins. ³⁸We have no ruler or prophet or leader, no burnt offering, sacrifice, drink offering, or incense. We have no place to make an offering before you and find mercy. ³⁹Yet because of our contrite heart and humble spirit, please accept us ⁴⁰as if we had sacrificed burnt offerings of rams and bulls or thousands of fat lambs. Please regard our sacrifice this way today, and may we follow you completely, for those who trust in you will not be put to shame. ⁴¹And now we follow you with all our heart. We fear you and seek your presence. ⁴²Do not let us be put to shame, but deal with us in your patience and in your great mercy. ⁴³Rescue us, just as you have done many other marvelous works, and bring glory to your name, O Lord. ⁴⁴Let all who harm your servants be put to shame; let them be humbled and deprived of all power, and let their strength be broken. ⁴⁵Teach them that you alone are the Lord God, glorious over the whole world.” The Song of the Three Young Men ⁴⁶Now the king’s servants who had thrown them into the furnace continued to stoke it with oil, pitch, flax fibers, and brush, ⁴⁷and the flames shot seventy-five feet into the air above the furnace. ⁴⁸The flames also leaped out and burned some of the Babylonians who were near the furnace. ⁴⁹But the angel of the Lord went down into the furnace to be with Azariah and his friends. He drove the flames out of the furnace ⁵⁰so that the middle of the furnace was as cool as a dew-laden breeze. The fire did not touch them or even bother them, nor did it harm them in any way. ⁵¹Then the three men praised, glorified, and blessed God together in the furnace. They said, ⁵²“Blessed are you, O Lord, the God of our ancestors, and worthy to be praised and exalted above all forever. Blessed is your glorious, holy name and worthy to be praised and exalted above all forever. ⁵³Blessed are you in the Temple, where your holy glory is,

and worthy to be honored and glorified forever. ⁵⁴Blessed are you, ruling from the throne of your kingdom, and worthy to be honored and exalted above all forever. ⁵⁵Blessed are you, who looks into the depths from your throne between the cherubim, and worthy to be praised and exalted above all forever. ⁵⁶Blessed are you in the expanse of heaven and worthy to be honored and glorified forever. ⁵⁷“Bless the Lord, all you works of the Lord. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁵⁸Bless the Lord, you angels of the Lord. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁵⁹Bless the Lord, you heavens. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁰Bless the Lord, all you clouds in the sky. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶¹Bless the Lord, all you heavenly works of the Lord. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶²Bless the Lord, sun and moon. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶³Bless the Lord, stars of heaven. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁴“Bless the Lord, all rain and dew. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁵Bless the Lord, all you winds. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁶Bless the Lord, fire and heat. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁷Bless the Lord, winter cold and summer heat. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁸Bless the Lord, dew and snow. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁶⁹Bless the Lord, frost and cold. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁰Bless the Lord, ice and snow. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷¹Bless the Lord, nights and days. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷²Bless the Lord, light and darkness. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷³Bless the Lord, lightning and clouds. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁴“Let the earth bless the Lord. Let it sing praise to him and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁵Bless the Lord, you mountains and hills. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁶Bless the Lord, all that grows in the ground. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁷Bless the Lord, you springs of the earth. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁸Bless the Lord, you seas and rivers. Sing

praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁷⁹Bless the Lord, you whales and fish. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸⁰Bless the Lord, you flying birds. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸¹Bless the Lord, all you animals, wild and tame. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸²“Bless the Lord, all you people on earth. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸³Bless the Lord, you people of Israel. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸⁴Bless the Lord, you priests of the Lord. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸⁵Bless the Lord, you servants of the Lord. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸⁶Bless the Lord, you righteous ones. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸⁷Bless the Lord, you who are holy and humble of heart. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. ⁸⁸“Bless the Lord, Hananiah, Azariah, and Mishael. Sing praise to him, and exalt him above all forever. For he has rescued us from the grave and saved us from the power of death. He delivered us from the fiery furnace; from the midst of the fire he has delivered us. ⁸⁹Give thanks to the Lord, for he is good, for his mercy endures forever. ⁹⁰All you who worship the Lord, bless the God of gods. Sing praise to him, and give him thanks, for his mercy endures forever.”
The Three Young Men Are Delivered